

NEW ENGLAND

TRAVELS THROUGH THE WIND

JAMES PHILIP



BOOK 3

Annotation

It is the late spring of 1978 in a world in which the American Revolution failed in 1776 after George Washington was killed and the Continental Army was destroyed at the Battle of Long Island. The rumbling aftershocks of the Empire Day atrocities which reverberated through the pages of *Two Hundred Lost Years* are threatening to come to the boil. While in Philadelphia the politics become ever more fractious in Spain the Royal Alcazar is a citadel besieged in a country which might as well still be stuck in the nineteenth century. Preparations for war hamstrung by colonial politics begin to gather pace in New England in a climate where the Governor in his mansion and the government back in England continues to tiptoe around provocations in the Caribbean and the Borderlands of the South. In Spain, Melody Danson and Henrietta De L'Isle have performed their role as distractions, adornments to a diplomatic mission whose only purpose is to delay the moment when the truth about the Empire Day attacks finally emerge. Because, when that day comes the road to war will suddenly confront the great European powers. The Peace of Paris, the basis of the post-Great War of 1857-66 settlement, threatened by Anglo-German-Russia tensions is now hostage to the machinations of a Spanish Empire in its death throes and the failing health of Old Spain, 'the sick man of Europe'. Brothers Abe and Alex Fielding find themselves making ready for war. Melody and Henrietta discover unlikely friends in the Mountains of Madrid. Journalist Albert Stanton of the *Manhattan Globe* unwittingly stumbles into a war zone. The Governor of the Commonwealth of New England and his political masters in England wrestle with a crisis they saw coming years ago but can do little or nothing to avert. The World in which England's Georgian colonies in the Americas became the keystone of the British Empire— upon which it seemed the Sun could never set— is about to fray around the edges and our heroes and heroines are going to find themselves directly in the firing line!

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James Philip

TRAVELS THROUGH THE WIND

A.D. 1978

PROLOGUE

Chapter 1

It was announced that Isaac Putnam Fielding, the sixty-year-old New Yorker awaiting trial for his part in the Empire Day outrages of 1976, took his own life on 18th November 1977. The statement issued by the Home Office reported that he was found hanging in his cell at Wormwood Scrubs Prison, in West London, in the early hours of that morning. Attempts to revive him were made but he was declared dead on arrival at St Thomas's Hospital.

Fielding was the author of the book 'Two Hundred Lost Years', for three decades the semi-liturgical source book for a succession of obscure secessionist and anti-imperialist groups mainly based in the Crown Colonies of Massachusetts, New York, Delaware and Virginia. His history is a murky one given that he was for many years an undercover operative of the Colonial Security Service (CSS), for whom he remained a so-called 'confidential informer' until as recently as 1972. Rumours abound that Fielding was at various times used as a paid agent provocateur by more than one New England constabulary, infiltrating a group known as the 'Brothers of Liberty'. His association with the CSS appears to have terminated unhappily, coincidental with a brief mental breakdown he suffered after his wife, Rachel's, death in 1973.

By all accounts Fielding was estranged wholly or partly from each of his four children at the time of the Empire Day atrocities. Not least the most extraordinary aspect of his part in those tragedies is that he seemed, to many observers, to go out of his way to tacitly implicate his daughter, her husband and all three of his sons in the affair, a pretence he doggedly maintained for the best part of a year after his initial arrest.

I am given to understand that Fielding was confronted by his sons at Fort Crailo Prison in Albany shortly before his first, abortive trial. This was, apparently, a somewhat fraught affair during which a punch, or punches were thrown. It is telling that none of Fielding's children visited him prior to his transfer to England last September, or according to prison authorities, subsequently made any attempts to communicate with him directly, or through third (legal) parties.

Contemporary colonial historians and – I confidently say – every journalist in the Empire worth his or her salt, were eagerly looking forward to Fielding's forthcoming trial hoping against hope that previously classified details of his activities during his long career with the CSS would see the light of day in court.

Unfortunately, it now seems likely that these documents – normally embargoed for sixty years under the purview of the Official Secrets Act – will now be buried in the archives of the CSS in Virginia for the 'full term', thus denying New Englanders access to papers which might shed untold light on the true history of the First Thirteen in the second half of the twentieth century.

Notwithstanding that Fielding made what he claimed to be a full confession to the authorities in respect of his crimes and entered guilty pleas to all charges laid against him at his trial in Albany (abandoned after the attempted assassination of the head of the CSS, Brigadier Matthew Harrison) last November, his death just three months into a probable sentence of life imprisonment without the option of remission, leaves something of a bad taste in the mouth. Not least because it is now unlikely that the whole story of the 4th July 1976 outrages will ever see the light of day.

This is a most unsatisfactory outcome.

Melody Danson, the woman credited with finally persuading Isaac Fielding to confess to his heinous crimes, echoed this sentiment while she was in London when we exchanged correspondence in December, shortly before she travelled to Madrid. Ms Danson, who is currently attached to the Joint Anglo-Spanish Commission of Inquiry into the alleged involvement of rogue elements in the Empire of New Spain in the Empire Day events, was commenting upon hearing the news of Fielding's death and she kindly gave me leave to quote her words verbatim.

'I felt all along that Isaac only understood a small part of the bigger picture. Yes, he claimed responsibility for everything but when one drilled down into his confession it soon became obvious that he had had no knowledge of key elements of the conspiracy. True, he might in one sense have been the father of that conspiracy but like many fathers, what happened post-conception was largely out of his control.'

Former Detective Inspector Danson of the New York Constabulary, was the high-profile investigator brought in by the Governor's Office to

review the evidence against Isaac and his sons in June last year. She was remarkably— dare one say, refreshingly— candid with this reporter.

‘No, there was never any cover up. Frankly, the monstrosity of the outrages on the 3rd and 4th of July 1976 beggared the imagination of us all, myself included. Given the atmosphere of suspicion, public alarm and the need for the civil powers to keep good public order and to safeguard innocent third parties who might otherwise have been caught up in a violent backlash, I honestly believe that the New York authorities did all that was in their power in the extraordinary circumstances which confronted them in the days after the atrocities. My own role in this? Well, I was simply brought in to dot the ‘I’s and cross the ‘T’s, which is what professional detectives do every day of their working lives. Why me? Because I was an outsider who had not been involved in the initial investigation. I just happened to be in the right place, available at the right time and was honoured to be of service to the Office of the Governor.’

Ms Danson was rather more elliptical when questioned about her current assignment in Madrid.

‘My work here is governed by diplomatic confidence; you must speak to the head of our joint mission with our Spanish hosts.’

At the time of writing the circumstances around the death of Isaac Fielding remain the subject of an ongoing inquiry by the Metropolitan Police’s elite Criminal Investigation Department. A spokesman for Scotland Yard has refused to comment further other than to emphasise that ‘any death in custody within a high security environment’ is automatically treated as suspicious until proven otherwise.

In the meantime, the continuing silence from the Foreign and Colonial Office on the progress— if any— of the Joint Commission’s work in Spain must give rise to concerns that the involvement of Spanish nationals and sympathisers in the Empire Day abomination, may not have just been the work of a handful of fanatics operating on their own initiative but, perhaps or in part, been instigated by organs of the Spanish Government, or even by agents close to the King Emperor, Ferdinand and his court in Madrid.

The death of Isaac Fielding cannot but further unsettle the mood of many New Englanders who rightly, believe themselves to have been the victims of an outrageous, cowardly attack and that the Crown has, in the intervening twenty-one months done little to obtain satisfaction from those shadowy parties they, New Englanders, hold substantially responsible.

Isaac Fielding's daughter, Victoria and his middle son, William declined to comment on their father's death. However, Fielding's eldest and youngest sons, Major Alexander Lincoln Fielding of the Colonial Air Force and Surgeon Lieutenant Abraham Lincoln Fielding of the Royal Naval Air Service, both of whom are currently on active service were so good as to find time in their busy schedules to speak with me.

Many readers will recollect that, coincidentally, I actually flew with 'Alex' Fielding on the morning of the Empire Day attacks. Since his release from prison last year I have been privileged to get to know him, and his wife, Leonora well. At the time we spoke Alex was preparing to take his squadron down to the South West and his wife was expecting the couple's first child.

'I am not about to start crying any crocodile tears for the man,' Alex confessed to me. 'Sure, I'd rather he was still around. Going that way, well, that's too bad. But I lost a year of my life and could very well have ended up at the end of a rope myself because of him and I'm not about to forget that any time soon. Heck, this time last year I'd have pulled the lever that dropped the old monster myself! That said, at the end of the day I keep reminding myself that my brothers, Bill and Abe, got their lives back too, I got to marry an honest to God princess like in a fairy tale and here I am now back in the CAF with a long-service commission. So, I suppose anything I say about the old fool now doesn't really matter a mess of beans!'

Abraham ° – who changed his surname to Lincoln, his mother's family's name ° – last autumn, who has been subjected to a disgraceful barrage of hate mail and become the target of vituperative demonstrations outside the gates of the Norfolk Navy Base by racist *Getrennte Entwicklung* ° – separate development ° – adherents, spoke to me shortly after it was announced by the Information Office of the Atlantic Fleet, that he was to go to sea on board the light cruiser HMS Achilles as that vessel's assistant surgeon, and as a reserve or 'emergency' aviator.

I have been fortunate to have met Abraham and his charming Mohawk-born wife Kate several times, most recently when I was their guest for a meal just after New Year at their Royal Navy married quarters in Virginia. Husband and wife made it clear to me that they wished to 'cut through' the storm of misinformation which has dogged them since they returned to New England from Canada last July. Our conversation formed the substance of the lengthy feature article I wrote some weeks later under

the by-line 'Abe and Kate's Story' which Abe confided to me, less than a week after its publication, had already prompted numerous 'book offers' from houses in London and Boston and 'imploring' transatlantic phone calls from several very well-known movie producers in France.

'I and my wife have chosen to forgive Isaac,' Abe told me. 'We still mourn Elder Tsiokwaris of the Mohawk Nation, my wife's blood father and my soul father, who died on the steps of the court house in Albany so as to end the cycle of death which had enveloped my family in the years since my mother's passing. Tsiokwaris was a great and a good man: a good and a great man knows humility, Isaac knew neither, he knew only hubris.'

Having originally named their first-born Isaac Kariwase, Abe and Kate Fielding have since christened their son 'Thomas' Tsiokwaris, 'Tom' having been the anglicised name the New York authorities assigned Kate's father under the colony of New York's 'Separate Development Statute'.

'Isaac was not my blood father,' Abe freely confirmed, 'but I share with my sister and brothers my family's burden of atonement for the ills done to others by my kith and kin. To that end I will confound Isaac's legacy of shame and faithfully serve my King, the Empire and my Colony with honour so long as I shall live.'

None of the Fielding siblings intend to travel to England to visit their father's grave...

Albert Stanton, and extract from *'Isaac Putnam Fielding: a life of betrayal'* published in the *Manhattan Globe* and syndicated publications across New England and the Empire on 25th February 1978.

ACT I – BEFORE THE FALL

Chapter 2

Friday 10th March

Hacienda de los Conquistadores, Chinchón

Melody Danson and Henrietta De L'Isle followed their host out onto the terrace of the great house on the hill overlooking the ancient town of Chinchón. It was a warm evening for this time of year and the two women were, for once, comfortable in the flowing ankle-length gowns that protocol mandated they wear in public.

Alonso Pérez de Guzmán, 18th Duke of Medina Sidonia, the handsome thirty-nine-year-old castellan of the Comarca de Las Vegas in which Chinchón sat—very much as the jewel in the Medina Sidonia ducal estate—ushered his guests to comfortable chairs on the broad, terracotta-roofed veranda overlooking the town lying in the bowl of the hills some thirty miles south east of Madrid. Below them as evening drew in, the streets were coming alive as the crowds funnelled through the narrow medieval alleys to the oval Plaza Mayor— which twice a year was transformed into a temporary bull ring—at Chinchón's heart.

There was no bull 'fighting' at this time of year, a thing both women were glad of; it was the first day of the town's annual week-long wine festival, a celebration that drew merchants, connoisseurs, a random selection of the great and the good of Madrid society and over this first 'festival weekend' reputedly filled the Plaza Mayor with every other 'dissolute' and 'character' from within a fifty-mile radius. Not to put too fine a point on it the famous, or if one was being pious about it, the infamous, Chinchón Festival of the Vine, had for more years than anybody cared to remember, provided a priceless opportunity for the otherwise horribly 'buttoned up' people of the Mountains of Madrid to let off a little steam. It was just far enough away from the suffocating Inquisition-regulated protocols which governed all aspects of public life in the capital, and for the King-Emperor and all but his hardest-hearted courtiers to turn a— somewhat humourless— blind eye.

"Things can get a little lively after dark," Alonso Pérez de Guzmán apologised mischievously, patently not begrudging the gathering revellers

their pleasures. He had extended an invitation to his ‘good friends from the Americas’ to join him at his occasional ‘hacienda in the country’ the moment he had heard that the women had been attached to the British Mission.

The two women had been looking forward to this holiday-cum-adventure with no little anticipation as the second week in March drew near.

Formerly Madrid’s man in Philadelphia, de Guzman had been unceremoniously expelled from New England in the wake of last year’s explosive revelations of Spanish— albeit Spanish *colonial*— involvement in the Empire Day outrages of July 1976. ‘Alonso’ was an ancestor of the man who had once, nearly four hundred years ago, tried and failed to invade the British Isles; thus, he came from a lineage which took immense pride in taking hard knocks in its stride with élan and no little aplomb, much as he had always greeted his, very occasional, romantic rebuffs from misguided members of the fairer sex.

He was a handsome cavalry officer from one of the oldest and most distinguished Castilian houses to whom, by repute, no woman from a certain class— from pubescence to old age— was safe who had met every crisis and personal barb in his time in New England with mildly vexed, indefatigably polite bewilderment as if he really did not see what the problem was.

It was all a masterful act but Henrietta De L’Isle had, to her chagrin, not actually realised as much at the time. Alonso had seemed so perfectly representative of the apparent dissonance within the Empire of New Spain. In common with many of the senior envoys in the service of the Emperor Ferdinand and his mendacious Queen, Sophia, de Guzmán had always given the impression he was somehow above the hurly-burly of ‘colonial politics’. In fact, he often reminded interlocutors in Philadelphia that other than for a short interlude in the Philippines ended by an untimely riding accident, that prior to his appointment to New England he was proud to say he had never troubled to travel much beyond the boundaries of Europe.

His wife, Eugenia, a niece of the Emperor was, like that oddly unworldly man in the modern Royal Alcazar of Madrid, pious to a fault and had remained, presumably, blissfully unaware of her husband’s amorous adventures in the Americas. Axiomatically, that lady had not accompanied Alonzo’s party to attend the Festival of the Vine.

Melody Danson had never met the Duke of Medina Sidonia in New England; nor had she ever swallowed the idea that Old Spain's man in Philadelphia was a congenial, somewhat dim-witted nobleman. So, whereas, Henrietta had been positively speechless, and then a little angry when she encountered the 'real' Alonso Pérez de Guzmán in Madrid last autumn, Melody had very nearly allowed the dashing, marvellously well-read and informed nobleman to charm her knickers off the first night they had met. She had not, of course: allowed him to bed her that night although in retrospect, it had been a 'close run thing', as one famous admiral of the Great War had observed viewing the carnage all around him after the British Fleet had bloodily forced the Skagerrak.

In Madrid every wall had ears; little went unnoticed, unremarked and the gossip mill was brutal. It was an archaic city in a country which had never emerged from its glorious, lost past, and women were expected to conform to a rigid straightjacket of conventions that no self-respecting woman anywhere in the British Empire would put up with for a single minute.

That said, she had always known that Alonso was the sort of man who treated one rebuff as grist to the mill, and that there would surely be a second attempted seduction, probably sooner rather than later. It was that delicious thought which had, without being crass, done a lot to keep the smile on her face in recent weeks. Obviously, she was a little guilty about that; Henrietta was very precious to her and, she suspected, despite her friend's brave face, always being under scrutiny, spied upon had been an even greater trial for her. Especially lately, as their time in Spain drew to a conclusion.

Servants materialised out of the shadows and the aromatic red wine of the district was poured into exquisitely fluted crystal glasses.

"This little one is produced with grapes from my family's own vineyards," Alonso remarked with no little pride, raising his glass.

Melody Danson sipped and exchanged a glance with Henrietta De L'Isle.

Sir John Tremayne, KCB, the British co-chairman of the Joint Commission of Inquiry, an urbane career diplomat-spy who was something very senior in the Foreign and Colonial Office's Intelligence Service, had sternly abjured both women to be 'on their guard every minute of every day' they were in Chinchón.

He had not been amused when Melody had informed°— as opposed to reported°— to him that she and Henrietta had accepted an invitation to stay at the Hacienda de los Conquistadores for ten days immediately before they were scheduled to begin their overland journey to Portugal where, at Lisbon, they were due to catch an Empire Flying Boat back to Southampton on the 23rd March. Hopefully, they would not be detained overlong in London, or wherever they were to be debriefed, and they would be back in New England for the spring, a prospect which hugely bolstered both women's spirits much to Sir John Tremayne's irritation.

'Medina Sidonia is a slippery fish!' He had observed. "Dammit, by the time you go home the whole Royal Court will assume that either, more likely, *both* of you, are the bloody man's mistresses!"

'Perhaps,' Melody had suggested, 'if one, or both of us was Alonso's mistress, it might not actually be a bad idea? Pillow talk, and all that?'

The old man had been horrified but then for somebody who was supposed to be an arch professional in the dark arts of international intrigue he had seemed, from the outset, to Melody at least, to be rather a 'choir boy'.

She and Henrietta had been painstakingly discreet about their 'friendship' back in England and even more so, here in Spain but Melody guessed that Alonso had seen through their act practically from the beginning in exactly the way she had seen through him the day they met.

Melody looked to their host, smiling thinly as she met his gaze and saw the question quirking in his eyes.

"Did you bring us out here to blackmail us, Alonso?" She inquired in casually accented precise Castilian.

The man raised an eyebrow, thought about it.

"Where would be the profit in that, dear lady?"

Melody waited, some sixth sense telling her that she had read the runes correctly. Thus far, the mission to supposedly unravel the conspiracy°— allegedly fomented by extremists on the Island of Santo Domingo°— to murder the King of England and to 'set the First Thirteen' colonies ablaze from end to end had got precisely nowhere. The Intelligence Service of New Spain, the *Nacional de Inteligencia de Nuevo España* had obfuscated and basically, offered no meaningful co-operation whatsoever to the Commission's inquiries, appeals to the Royal Court had been politely deflected and the various organs of the Inquisition based in the Iberian

Peninsula had refused point blank to engage with the ‘heretics’, other than to have the ‘British’ members of the Commission of Inquiry followed wherever they went.

But then the mission had not been sent to Spain to find out what was, or might be going on— the only people who knew that were probably in Cuba or Santo Domingo— but to make it look as if something was being done because both sides were still of the view that tempers in New England needed to be kept in check, and that nobody in their right mind in Europe actually wanted to give those idiots in the Caribbean an excuse to start a new war.

Melody took another sip of her wine.

It was smooth, seductive like the man sitting between her and Henrietta on the veranda above the lights of the picturesque old town hidden away in the hills.

Back in Philadelphia Alonso had tended to make a be-line for the Governor’s daughter whenever he spied her at an official reception. They had become friends of a sort; nowadays, Henrietta mistrusted the man, feeling rightly that he had in some way been using her.

“I don’t know,” Melody confessed, allowing herself a coy smile. “Sooner or later our governments are going to decide that ‘the Commission’ has served its purpose, an anodyne report will get written and promptly buried, and we’ll be back at square one again. So, the next thing might, logically, be for each side to start discrediting the messengers rather than the bad actors who are actually responsible for the mess we’re in?”

The man pursed his lips.

“Just so,” he sighed. “But that is not why I invited you to Chinchón. Yes, I freely admit that seduction is never far from my mind, especially in the company of two such intelligent, beautiful women,” he raised a hand in self-deprecatory acknowledgement, ‘the spirit is one thing, the flesh is weak and as our noble inquisitors remind us temptation is always nearer than we care to imagine. Nevertheless, my motives were, and are, as political as they were personal. Yes, this ‘process’ will soon fail. Yes, we will soon be back at square one, regrettably with daggers drawn again. However, while there is very little that we can do about that at present, there is always hope when one knows that one has friends in the enemy camp.”

Henrietta De L’Isle opened her mouth to speak, thought better of it.

“You see,” the man continued, wryly sad for a moment, “the lesson of history is that wars start because people stop talking to each other. Oh, they talk but not to each other, but *at* each other. It is only when the shooting starts that people usually start talking *to each other* again and by then it is usually too late. I fear for my country if there is a war with the British Empire. Mostly, I fear for New England and Nuevo Granada; no matter how imperfect the peace in the border lands of the American south west, it will surely be the crucible of the coming war. If the Emperor could give away Cuba and Santo Domingo now, he would.” He shook his head. “Anguilla, too,” he added laconically, “and all those other stupid little islands that spawn so many infernal plots and coups in the Caribbean and back here in Morocco and on the mainland.”

“You speak as if war was inevitable, Alonso?” Henrietta interjected.

“Likely, not inevitable,” he replied gently.

“Melody and I are just two women. Window dressing here in Spain,” the Governor of New England’s youngest daughter objected. “How can we possibly influence things?”

The Spaniard drained his glass and waved for it to be refilled.

Presently, he answered Henrietta’s question.

“When you are recalled to England, or to wherever your fates take you, you,” he declared softly, fixing Henrietta in his grey-brown stare, “will still be the remarkably accomplished daughter of a very powerful man.” He turned his gaze towards Melody: “And you, dear lady, one day soon, will probably be the Head of the Colonial Security Service...”

“Rubbish!” Melody retorted in English.

“Is it? Lady De L’Isle’s father, an implacably honourable man has stood by Brigadier Harrison thus far— in my country he would have thrown him in prison by now— but sooner or later the branch upon which Señor Harrison sits will bend so far it must break...”

Melody shook her head, not trusting herself to speak.

“There will be a call for a replacement acceptable to a majority of the First Thirteen’s Governors,” her host continued, a note of subtle apology underlying his words, “the appointment of a woman would reassure all the colonies that the CSS’s wings have been sufficiently clipped. Honestly and truly,” Alonso said, with no little sympathy, “if you did not already exist, Lady De L’Isle’s father would have to invent you, Señora Danson.”

A servant tried to top up Melody's glass; but needing more than ever to keep her wits about her, she signalled for it to be left half-empty.

"You make a lot of assumptions, Don Alonso," she observed tartly.

The Spaniard shrugged.

"Yes, but think of the possibilities if you were Head of the CSS and I was, say, the master of the *Nacional de Inteligencia de Nuevo España*..."

Henrietta was shifting uncomfortably in her chair.

"Should I really be listening to this?"

"Oh, yes," the man chuckled. "We are, after all, just three friends, private citizens passing the time of day together before we dine. There is nothing sinister going on here." He hesitated. "Well, I suppose if this conversation became generally known to certain officers of the Inquisition, I could end up a slave in the Indies, or worse but I don't think that is likely. Our small talk becoming generally known, I mean."

Melody said nothing because she understood that the man had just placed his life in her hands.

Chapter 3

Friday 10th March

Anson Road, Royal Navy Norfolk, Virginia

Surgeon Lieutenant Abraham Lincoln, RNASR ° – Royal Naval Air Service (Reserve) ° – had kissed his one-year old son's head and hugged, and smooched like the world was going to end with his wife before, with aching reluctance, he had torn himself away and jumped into the waiting car outside the neat married quarters on Anson Road.

He and Kate had talked about how they would cope with separation, reassured each other, coupled last night as if it was for the last time. Since they had 'properly' begun their married life together on Leppe Island some twenty months ago, they had never, ever been completely apart and it scared them both.

This parting was bad enough, scheduled to last a week or perhaps up to ten days at most. Then they would be reunited, for a few days or so, before Abe's ship steamed away for a four to six-month attachment to the West Indies Squadron.

Abe tried not to mope about things; Kate was stoic in the way of her people. Stoicism was written into the soul of the native peoples of the Americas, a thing unlearned by most Europeans long before they colonised the New World all those centuries ago. The fact that Kate was approximately two months pregnant with their second child made parting even harder; that summer he was likely to be away while his wife's belly swelled and if fate so conspired, he might not even be back in Virginia in time to welcome his new offspring into the world.

Their son, Kariwase ° – *a new way of doing things* in Kanien'keháka ° – had been delivered into life by the Iroquois mothers of the Kempton community in Ontario while he watched on, his white man's medical learning treated as an unnecessary encumbrance. Although he would have stepped in if the need had arisen it had not and that was a mercy, for Kate had wanted their son born the way nature had decreed for unknown thousands of generations before her.

There was the normal desultory *Getrennte Entwicklung* separate development crowd hanging around the main gates to Royal Navy Norfolk, protesting about the one wholly multi-racial, and horror of horror, 'integrated' exemplar, in New England.

Namely, the Royal Navy.

Abe's driver, Sub-Lieutenant Robert Edward 'Ted' Forest, a blond, stocky man a year or so his junior who was still relatively new to the First Thirteen invariably shook his head and whistled a little sadly whenever he encountered 'religious nuts'. But then 'newbies' from the Old Country, these days a veritable mixing pot of humanity inter-mingled from all over the Empire, tended to be colour blind if not always very good at veiling their innate sense of moral superiority.

However, Abe was a practical man; one out of two was a good start.

The Englishman had doffed his cap, half-bowed and treated Kate like an exotic princess the first time he had called at the Lincoln household. Ted Forest had reduced Kate to tears of mirth attempting to correctly pronounce her Mohawk name, Tekonwenaharake, and been absolutely fascinated by his hosts' stories of life in the wilds of the Mohawk Valley.

That had been shortly after the Registrar of the Commonwealth of Virginia had granted the deed excising the name 'Fielding' from all official documentation.

Just so as to tidy up any possible loose ends, Abe and Kate had since had their marriage blessed anew— as Mr and Mrs Abraham Lincoln— in the Anglican Chapel at the base.

Ted Forest had been posted to HMS Achilles as the senior of the three Navigator-Observer-Air Gunners— the other two men were rated as Petty Officers — attached to the light cruiser's twelve-man Flight Division, responsible for operating the ship's two Southampton Flying Boat Corporation Sea Fox seaplanes. At the same time Abe had begun his familiarisation with the 'type'— with Ted in the 'back seat'— at the nearby Virginia Beach Royal Naval Air Station.

The two men had hit it off from the start.

'How come a bally doctor is flying kites in the RNAS?' Ted had asked within minutes of their first meeting.

'It's a long story.'

He had told that story over a beer in the Mess at Virginia Beach.

‘I was inducted straight into the Royal Naval Medical Service as soon as I got here. I assumed I’d be a junior houseman, or the Navy equivalent, for my time on shore. Anyway, as I understand it, somebody in the Personnel Section here at Norfolk saw that I was a qualified pilot with several hundred hours under my belt and the next thing I knew, I was hauled in front of a selection panel at twenty-four hours’ notice. The next day I discovered I was in the RNAS!’

Coincidentally, given that by then it had been determined that he would be posted to the Achilles, an older ship whose crew spaces had been progressively shrunk over the years by the need to incorporate more and more space-consuming modern weaponry and equipment, combining the posts of assistant surgeon and second-in-command of the ship’s Flight Division saved ‘a scarce berth’, and was therefore, an ad hoc accommodation entirely acceptable to the cruiser’s captain.

‘Apparently, that was also a major consideration,’ Abe had joked, having discovered that Achilles’s commanding officer was none other than the senior post captain in the Atlantic Fleet, the Honourable Francis Stanley Jackson. Jackson’s father had been Achilles first captain back in 1949; now the son was ending his career on the valiant old ship. The Royal Navy liked to square circles, to arrange things to be as balanced and ship-shape as possible.

During her forthcoming commission in the Caribbean the Achilles would be the senior ship on station, the flagship of the Jamaican, Windward and Leeward Flotillas. Flying his Commodore’s Pennant would be a fitting way for a distinguished officer like Francis Jackson to bookend his career. From the outset, Abe had realised that the Navy like to do things ‘the right way’.

It took about an hour to sign off all the paperwork required to fly Serial RN937-3 – a Mark IV all-metal monocoque fuselage construction with stressed-aluminium surfaced wings SFBC Sea Fox seaplane – out of the charge of No 823 Royal Naval Air (Operational Training) Squadron.

This achieved, the two officers quickly mounted up, fired up the seaplane’s Preston Rapier seven-hundred horsepower liquid-cooled V-8 engine and after a cautiously overlong run across the water took to the air for the forty-mile flight north-east to rendezvous with the Achilles.

Despite the season it was a clear, almost windless day.

The Sea Fox was typical of the seaplane types in the RNAS's inventory. It was a good, sturdy, reliable machine but aging, borderline obsolete, relatively slow with a maximum level-flight speed of around one-hundred and fifty knots and capable of carrying only a clutch of three or four two-hundred-pound bombs. There was a wheeled and a float plane version of the aircraft; the former had a forward-firing 0.5-inch belt-fed machine gun, the model Abe was flying today only had a single 0.303-inch calibre Mark IV Enfield Small Arms Factory patent drum-fed machine gun operated by the occupant of the second, rear cockpit, otherwise the Sea Fox was defenceless.

The aircraft was a throwback to before the age when big ships had all-seeing electronic marvels like ELDAR; before in fact, the original small experimental aircraft carriers— the forerunners of the giants now coming into service— were even twinkles in naval architects' eyes.

Tellingly, no ship built in the last fifteen years incorporated hangars, catapults, or any provision for carrying on board aerial reconnaissance aircraft. It was only the old ships in the Fleet, like the last surviving 1950s trade route protection cruisers and several of the more venerable big gun capital ships of the battle line that carried any kind of air arm. Once upon a time even the heftier fleet destroyers would have carried a flimsy float plane, an early death trap version of the Sea Fox or the Bristol VIIs Abe had flown in Canada.

Abe heard his navigator's voice in his ear.

The intercom on a Sea Fox was a rudimentary bundle of brittle cables still operated by crude switches inconveniently placed by the crew members' knees low in the cockpits.

"Visibility must be at least twenty miles today, skipper. We ought to catch sight of Achilles sometime in the next ten minutes if we carry on along this heading. Out."

"Roger, Ted."

The cruiser had a homing beacon and powerful transmitters which it was *not* going to use unless it had to. Captain Jackson had drummed it into his crew that '*one operates as if one is at war because that is the only way to train for war*'. Constantly broadcasting one's presence was not good practice, so HMS Achilles moved about like a wraith...

Nonetheless, Abe soon spied the tell-tale shimmering grey plume venting from the cruiser's single funnel, faintly above the horizon some

fifteen degrees to the east of his current course. He banked the sea plane and began to climb.

He hit the speak button.

“Get your camera out, Ted. Over.”

The Achilles’s executive officer, a fierce, bearded man in his forties was determined to make the ‘old man’s last commission a ‘bloody memorable one’ and one of the things he had mandated was that upon his retirement his crew would gift Captain Jackson the best possible set of aerial photographs of ‘his’ ship, one of the few tasks that a Sea Fox was actually marvellously suited to perform.

Two fixed cameras: one pointing directly below the aircraft and another to port, sited between the pilot and the observer positions, and a hand-held high-resolution 1.5-inch 6x-zoom camera operated from Ted Forest’s cockpit meant the aging workhorse was, in the right conditions, a very capable photographic aerial reconnaissance platform and today, the ‘conditions’, particularly the clarity of the atmosphere and the sunshine threatening to poke through the thinning overcast off Chesapeake Bay, were damned nearly ‘ideal’.

As to HMS Achilles, the last of the much-loved Hero class ‘trade route protection’ light cruisers, well, only a man without a heart could not fall in love with her long, elegant, somehow ‘classy’ lines. She was a real lady, every inch the perfect expression of a school of naval architecture now cruelly overtaken by the onrushing pace of technological advances.

The first ship of the Hero class of light cruisers had been launched as long ago as 1944, Achilles, the eighth and last ship of the ‘first group’, six years later as budget cuts, changing construction techniques and political wrangling had delayed practically every major building programme in the late 1940s.

Achilles had been one of the first major warships in which— to reduce weight and reduce costs— large parts of her hull had been welded rather than rivetted. This innovation had reduced her tonnage from the 7,500 ‘light’ tons of the class ‘leader’, HMS Hector, to 7,130 and shaved nearly ten percent off her original ‘in commission’ price tag. Moreover, in the long term it had ensured that unlike her six older sisters her hull had been able to accommodate a raft of modifications sufficient to ensure her retention in the Fleet well into her third decade of service.

Ironically, the radical re-design of the second group of so-called 'Improved Heroes' involving using different, supposedly higher performance lighter-weight machinery sets had ultimately doomed that whole sub-class to early appointments with the breakers during the latter 1960s, whereas, Achilles with her – essentially original 1950s – half-a-dozen 'heavy' old-fashioned Admiralty 3-drum boilers and tried and tested, more or less un-modified 1930s geared reduction turbines, had just gone on steaming, year after reliable year.

Achilles's Engineering Officer boasted that even though he had never 'got anywhere near opening up all the taps' the cruiser had 'clocked up' over thirty-one knots on high speed trials a few weeks before Abe had joined the ship.

The cruiser had been in dry-dock in January for a routine minor refit during which upgrades to her gunnery ELDAR, new breeches for her three-inch high-angle anti-aircraft auto-cannons had been installed, she had received a paint job from the keel upwards and her port inner screw had been replaced. This latter had belatedly resolved a problem first logged over five years ago which had limited the shaft to one-hundred and fifty revolutions per minute, reducing the ship's top speed to about twenty-nine-and-a-half-knots.

Drawing closer to the cruiser Abe could see that the Old Man was pouring it on. Achilles was racing south-east like a greyhound with a mighty bone in her teeth.

The plan had been to sound battle stations the moment the Sea Fox appeared on the ship's air search ELDAR, thereafter the aircraft was to mount a series of 'spoof' bombing runs so that the anti-aircraft gun crews could test their mettle acquiring and tracking the 'attacker'.

Abe had eased the seaplane up to around five thousand feet.

It was as cold as hell up here!

"TALLY-HO! TALLY-HO!" He called over the intercom.

The left wing of the Sea Fox dropped and the aircraft began to fall towards the racing cruiser.

Five hundred-and-fifty-five feet long and a few inches broader than fifty-six feet in beam, recently out of dry dock with a slick, clean bottom, with her four racing propellers each turned by up to eighteen thousand shaft horsepower, Achilles was classically 'slippery' through the water, a superb

sea boat in any weather and for a ship of her size, unreasonably agile in the turn.

Even as Abe lined up on her midships section where her boilers vented to a single long, narrow funnel ahead of the seaplane catapult and boat deck, Achilles was heeling into the turn. He tried to adjust, follow the changing angle, cursed and pulled out of the half-dive.

“What’s wrong?” Ted Forest asked in his ears.

Abe hit the talkback switch.

“She’s even more slippery than the guys in the Wardroom said!” He snapped in exasperation. “I couldn’t hold the funnel in my sights!”

For his next ‘attack’ he circled astern and slowly approached from the port quarter, this time watching for the first indication that the Old Man had put the helm over. In a way this was cheating because this sort of attack would have been suicidal in a real war situation; he would have been shot to pieces by Achilles’s battery of twin 0.8-inch cannons and or the port twin high-angle three-inch quick firing auto-cannons (capable of firing up to thirty ELDAR-predicted rounds a minute) long before he was close enough to attempt a bombing run.

He watched the cruiser’s wake.

She was turning to starboard.

He waited.

No, not a turn, maybe ten degrees of starboard wheel.

A feint...

He jinked to the right as if he was taken in, closing the range, dropped his wing-tip as if he was about to plummet on his prey like a Sea Eagle.

Achilles was suddenly swinging to port.

The Old Man had put one or both of the port screws half or possibly, hard astern and the cruiser was slowing and literally, hauling away beneath the Sea Fox’s left wing-tip.

Without hesitation Abe threw the seaplane into the dive.

In a moment the aircraft sitting on the Achilles’s catapult was filling the ring sight of his cockpit bomb aiming sight.

Abe was so exultant, so pleased with himself it was only when he was far, far too low that he realised he was an idiot.

Oh, shit...

I’m far too fucking low...

Chapter 4

Saturday 11th March

Hacienda de los Conquistadores, Chinchón

When, shortly after dawn Melody Danson crept back into her room dressed in no more than a very crumpled shift with the rest of her clothes bundled in her arms, she discovered Henrietta De L'Isle, still fully dressed, asleep in her bed. The door creaked, shutting it seemed to her, deafeningly behind her as she attempted to tiptoe to the chamber's small washroom— even grand Spanish haciendas lacked anything that a New Englander would class as an 'en suite bathroom'— guiltily intent on trying to make herself look at least a *little* presentable.

The younger woman blinked awake and sat up on the bed in the chaos of her long skirts and petty coats.

She had been crying.

Now she sniffed accusatively and her lower lip quivered as she blinked back new tears.

Melody in turn felt ashamed, replete, dirty, and yet defiantly unrepentant, as well as sore— in a half-pleasant, tingling way— in places she had not been *that* sore, or stimulated... for a while. She was also very aware that a woman is not necessarily in the best frame of mind to have a... scene with her lover the morning after she has just spent the night before being fucked every anatomically practicable which way around, by an attentive, sensitive and very, very ardent lover like Alonso Pérez de Guzmán, most recently less than twenty minutes ago.

"You look," Henrietta began, her voice trailing away as she stared at her feet.

"A mess, probably," Melody offered, in her dishevelment hugging the clothes so expertly eased off her back and recklessly discarded on the floor of Alonso's lair the previous evening.

After dinner last night, Henrietta had made her excuses and retired to her room; Melody and their host had drifted onto the veranda and talked, flirted really, as they gazed down into the festival lights of Chinchón.

‘This is a very ancient place,’ Alonso had told her, ‘although it only came into my family at the turn of this century. The previous Castellan of the Comarca de Las Vegas was an absentee landlord of the worst kind. My grandfather poured his fortune into this town and his other holdings on the plain of Tajuña, replanting the vineyards, building the modern distillery where Chinchón’s famous Anisette is now produced. He was the man who revived the ancient festivals ° – although not without resistance from the Mother Church ° – which now attract so many people from Madrid and Toledo and far beyond every year.

Melody had tasted the legendary *Anis de Chinchón* with great caution, deciding that ‘yes, I could get used to this’, notwithstanding the concoction’s vicious, mule-like alcoholic ‘kick’.

Alonso had been in no apparent hurry to seduce her.

‘The Plaza Mayor is surrounded by houses that date back to the fifteenth century, in many cases outwardly, and in many cases inwardly, they are little changed from that period other than by the introduction of rudimentary sanitary provisions which town ordinances dating to my grandfather’s time require to be out of sight and mind. You must let me escort you to our church of Nuestra Señora de la Asunción for Mass on Sunday, it too dates back to the glorious days of the First Empire of New Spain in the reign of Philip II.’

Goya’s brother had lived in Chinchón, his house was a place of pilgrimage to the faux literati of the capital, a thing Alonso had quietly mocked.

They had laughed together and Melody had allowed herself to be charmed all the way into her host’s bed chamber. But not before they had talked, and talked, sipping the local medium dry fruit-scented red wine with constant care lest they spoil their memories of what they both knew was to come.

‘People lived all across the Plain of Tajuña in olden days,’ her host had explained. ‘My House employs several archaeologists, you know. They spend every spring and summer digging up Neolithic, stone and iron age sites, the traces of long-gone Celtic tribes, and scratching over the legacy of Roman, Visigothic and Moorish occupations. La Reconquista ° – the reconquest of the Iberian Peninsula from the Muslim caliphate which was not to be finally completed until the time of Ferdinand and Isabella in the 1490s

began in these parts when a Christian monarch, Alfonso VI of Castile reclaimed Toledo for the Holy Cross way back in 1085.'

Chinchón was also renowned for its many traditional breads, its garlic and the rustic country cuisine preserved in its old tavernas and eating places. During the summer hundreds of visitors braved the twisting mountain roads to enjoy its tranquil, lost-world charms, to gorge on its surfeit of fine wine and 'peasant' food, or just to wander its narrow, unspoiled streets or to stand on the battlements of the rebuilt medieval castle, the best place to take photographs to immortalise a visit to a jewel of a Spain that was crumbling, picturesque but impoverished, its traditions turning inward, its cities stagnating in the unrelenting vice of theocratic orthodoxy, merely the stages upon which the nation's warring factions vied for advantage as if the modern world beyond the Iberian Peninsula simply did not exist...

'Most Spaniards think that the pace of change is too fast, that we have come too far too quickly and that it will all end, inevitably, very badly,' Alonso had chuckled, his gaze fixed on Melody's face and unambiguously liking everything he beheld, 'however, you and I both know that for all the talk of progress, this is a country still mired in the throes of its first industrial revolution in which innovation, imagination itself, is stifled by the dead hand of an infallible monarchy and the Inquisition. Oh, yes, I know, we no longer burn heretics, and it is hard ° – but by no means impossible ° – to see us going back to the days of the Jewish pogroms, that I suppose, is progress of a sort. But we both know that even those provinces ° – like New Granada, or as some now call it 'Mexico', Cuba, Santo Domingo, the Philippine lands, even some of the kingdoms of the Southern Americas ° – who still pay lip service to the Empire, have each developed their own systems of civilization, their own interpretations of the one true Faith and that none of them can be trusted to bend the knee, let alone bow their heads to the will of the King-Emperor.'

It had been nearly midnight by then.

Melody had been light-headed.

'I think we should stop talking now,' she had declared, suddenly nervous. Her moment of panic came and went in a blink of the eye, washed away by a rush of pure... *wanting*.

The man had walked her to his rooms on the opposite side of the house from the guest quarters. In the corridor outside his bed chamber he had

halted, and like a true gentleman, waited for a final, unambiguous sign.

That had been a nice touch.

She had placed his hands on her breasts and stretched her arms around his neck— he was three or four inches taller than her— and pulled his mouth down to hers.

After that things had taken their natural course.

Naked in his bed he had stroked, kissed and tickled her until she was practically wetting herself and then, very tenderly made love to her as if she was precious, fragile until she began to whisper the sort of things in his ear which were guaranteed to bring out the beast in any man.

She had fallen asleep in his arms sometime after their second lazy, greedy coupling as he nibbled the lobe of her left ear and only awakened when the first greyness of the pre-dawn began to spread into the bedroom.

‘How long have you been watching me?’ She had asked sleepily.

‘Not long,’ he had smiled, his left hand beginning to rove beneath the sheets as they lay facing each other. ‘I may not see you again this way for a long time. I wish to remember everything...’

Men are so full of horse manure!

Melody had pretended to play hard to get; he had enthusiastically taken her from behind and she was not about to complain. She had giggled when he thrust one last, shuddering time and collapsed upon her, briefly crushing her down into the mattress and lying on top of her gasping for breath.

The man’s wife really did not know what she was missing!

Alonso had watched her searching around for a shift to hide her modesty and gather up her other, wantonly strewn garments from all around the bed.

Presently, she had leaned across him, planting a wet kiss on his mouth, resisting the temptation to fall back into his arms.

‘Thank you,’ she had murmured.

‘The pleasure was all mine, Melody.’

She had straightened, looking down at him.

‘Thank you, anyway,’ she had said, giggling. ‘That was a truly lovely fuck, Alonso...’ And then she had fled like a thief in the night. Except it was getting light at the time...

And now she did not have the first idea what to say to Henrietta, whom she was as sure as she had ever been about anything in her whole life, she

loved...

Melody sat down on the edge of the bed.

She shrugged: "You know more about me than anybody alive," she sighed. "It just happens that the only people I have fallen in love with up to now happen to be women but I'm not any kind of nun... I'm sorry, I don't know what to say..." She groaned, her head befuddled by post-coital confusion and suddenly aware of how tired and battered she felt. "God, I must look dreadful..."

"You smell of him," Henrietta retorted, dully.

That was what you smelled like when you had been frantically exchanging body fluids with somebody most of the night.

"I'm being stupid," the younger woman muttered and made as if to rise to her feet.

Melody reached out for her arm and dragged her back down beside her. Henrietta put up only token resistance.

The women sat close yet apart.

"Don't tell me you slept with him because of politics," Henrietta hissed.

"I didn't. But I'm not about to become Alonso's mistress or anything."

The high excitement of the women's first infatuation had soon been subsumed into the reality of their lives and their primarily cosmetic part in the futile mission in Spain. They were hardly ever really alone together, always watched either by the Spanish or their own people, forever having to pretend that they, and their feelings for each other, were something other than what they were and as time had gone by it had become very nearly unbearable.

It was worse for Henrietta, whom the other members of the Commission regarded as mere 'pretty window dressing' and generally treated, albeit with exaggerated courtesy, like a brainless teenager. Melody at least, was in some sense 'on the team' and had the title of CSS Liaison Officer, thereby guaranteeing she was automatically copied into the never-ending, largely ephemeral documentation the exercise generated to keep its paymasters back in Whitehall busy.

"What if you get pregnant?" Henrietta blurted, on the verge of a flood of tears.

"I won't."

"How can you know that?"

Melody had confided most of her secrets to her friend and thus far, to her chagrin, only very occasional lover. Henrietta was very innocent in some things; and she had made allowances as one did for somebody one cared, deeply about.

“Ten years ago, I underwent a sterilization procedure,” she confessed, suspecting that she too was about to burst into tears. “That’s the little scar above my pubis that I laughed off the first time we slept together.”

“Oh...”

“I got pregnant, I planned to have an abortion in Paris— they don’t ask questions if you wave a wad of bank notes at them there, but I miscarried first. Probably, because of the stress of it all. Anyway, I decided that I was never going to go through that again and spent my money on having my tubes tied...”

“You were in a relationship?”

“Sort of, it hadn’t come to anything. He was looking for a submissive little wifey and I was never going to be that. He raped me when I told him it wasn’t going to work for me...”

“You never said...”

Melody felt the first tears wetting her cheek.

“I’ve never told anybody that before, okay. I’m not a victim and I got over it,” she insisted, her face suddenly burning hot, “and talking about it is very painful.”

Henrietta did not know what to say.

“Just because I fall in love with women doesn’t mean I hate men,” Melody stumbled on. “Last night I had an amazing fuck with Alonso and he had a really good time too, that’s as complicated as this needs to be, okay?”

She lurched to her feet, threw away her bundled dress and petty coats and skittered blindly into the washroom.

Chapter 5

Sunday 12th March

Castle Dore, Shinnecock Hills, Long Island

It was serendipitous that Leonora Coolidge had never entertained any illusions about Alexander Fielding. What you saw was what you got. He was not one of those men a good woman could mold, mellow or in any way reform. Fortunately, had he been that sort of a man she would have left him to his fate after he had done his very best to get them both killed being a hero.

‘What am I supposed to do?’ She had posed, rhetorically to her best friend, Maud Daventry-Jones. ‘I’m stupid about the guy. I love him and there’s nothing I can do about it!’

Which pretty much explained why, presently, she was the proportions of an average-sized barn door and aching for the day when she could start drinking and smoking again. She was well over seven months pregnant and about to wave goodbye to her ‘hero’ for God only knew how long!

Sure, Alex felt a little bad about leaving her in the lurch.

They had laughed about that!

In her case ‘leaving her in the lurch’ amounted to *leaving* her in the bosom of her wealthy, landed family in the luxury of the Coolidge mansion with every other private medical practitioner on Long Island on twenty-four-hour call to rush to her aid at the first sign of ‘junior’ deciding to come into the world.

Right now, junior was kicking like a mule.

Her mother said that meant ‘it’ was a boy.

Leonora had never really thought about having children until she had let herself get knocked up by her hero.

That would have been the night after their first proper date...

Alex had been in prison, out of circulation for the best part of a year by then and heck, that man had been in a hurry to make up for lost time!

Maud had quizzed her about that night a couple of days later.

‘I have never been so fucked silly in my whole life,’ she had admitted, afflicted by goose pimples all over as she recollected the experience.

Alex had proposed marriage first, of course.

That was what you got for dating an officer and a gentleman.

Leonora had not even attempted to stop her father trying to talk her out of it, he had wanted to organise the society wedding of the year, preferably sometime in 1979 or 1980; Alex was having none of that.

‘Father will cut me off!’ She had protested.

‘His loss,’ her hero had retorted, smiling that smile of his which always made her tingle in all the places a respectable girl never talked about in public.

They had spent most of the week after their chaotic registry office wedding in Brooklyn locked up in a plush room at the Ritz Hotel in Manhattan – luckily, daddy had been slow cutting off her allowance – doing what newlyweds from time immemorial have done, except more so...

Once her father discovered he was going to be a grandfather he had bitten the bullet and taken Alex to his heart, so everything had worked out just swell in the end.

Now, her hero had just landed his plane on Daddy’s lawn!

How crazy was that?

Didn’t the Air Force cashier people for things like that?

Actually, now that she looked at Alex jumping down from the old dope and fabric biplane, she reconsidered her initial impression; this was some old, very slow flying machine. Not even Alex could have got down safely in one of the new low-wing monoplanes that his squadron were scheduled to take down to the Border sometime in the next month or so.

Alex had not even bothered to don his flying leathers, he was dressed in his grey-blue day uniform, capless. Presumably, he planned to pull a suit off the rack in their rooms upstairs.

“The guy’s got style!” Maud murmured distractedly.

Leonora frowned.

Her friend got dreamier about Alex every day, if she did not do something about it, Maud would be hopelessly out of it if and when a suitable beau ever came along.

If I wasn’t so fat, I’d get straight onto that little project!

The two women watched the scene playing out on the lawn below the big house.

Alex was glad-handing his way through the assembled retainers and staff, swapping banter with other guests at that afternoon’s ‘going away’

soiree. The party was Leonora's mother's idea and even though Alex was teetotal these days he was nothing if not a party animal. Leonora had thought she was incorrigible, but Alex... Well, he took things to a whole new level!

They said there was going to be another war down in the South West and a lot of people were already asking if it was going to be a big enough war for Major Alexander Fielding!

Among other things her hero had become the instant sensation of her old set. Leastways, the members of that circle she had not completely alienated in her 'jailbird year' campaigning to get Alex out of prison, and seeking justice for all the wrongly accused bystanders swept up in the dragnet after the Empire Day outrages. Refreshingly, Alex tended to invite a lot more 'real people' to these affairs: perhaps, that was the way to go with Maud's love life?

To introduce her to mere 'real people'.

It was worth a try.

Leonora was startled out of her wool-gathering. In retrospect she had hardly known any 'real people' before her hero inadvertently enmeshed her in the Empire Day imbroglio...

Alex was hugging Maud.

"Put that woman down and start showering your wife with attention!" Leonora demanded with patrician severity.

Her husband did as he was instructed and with a dazzling smile put his arms as far around her as he could reach and held her close, pecking at her cheek preparatory to going mouth to mouth.

Leonora came up for air and realised, when she recovered her breath and her scattered wits that Alex was already shaking her father's hand and making sweet with her mother.

How on earth does he do that?

Before she met her hero, she had been engaged twice— or was it three times— and not one of her beaus had ever got her mother smiling that way! As for her succession of failed future husband's attempts to get on Daddy's good side, well, those had all been hopeless causes.

But then none of the frogs she had kissed before her prince came along to sweep her off her feet— and knock her up in no time flat— were bone fide fighter aces.

Maybe, they had just not been made of the right stuff?

“Should you be standing up, princess?” Her husband inquired earnestly, his whole being shouting that for him she was the only woman in the room.

“I’m not ill, Alex,” she snapped irritably.

He knew it was just ‘baby testiness’ and smiled proudly.

Leonora instantly forgot why she was vexed in the first place.

“I’d much rather be alone with you, that’s all,” she admitted quietly. “Rather than with all these people!”

Her husband put his arm about her shoulder.

“Give me the word and I’ll start shooting the beggars,” he offered.

“Um... What on earth is that contraption you flew over here in?” She asked, changing the subject.

“We call them Fleabags,” Alex chortled. “They’re slow old things that the Army uses as artillery spotters and so forth. You can land one of them on a sixpence and if you make a hash of it, you’re usually travelling so slowly that when you hit the ground you can dust yourself off and walk away.”

Leonora did not find that entirely reassuring.

“You flew that thing all the way from Upper Manhattan?”

“Yes, I had a following wind. I’ll get one of the new chaps to drive over from Bronx Wood Aerodrome and fly it back to base tomorrow.”

Leonora patted her husband’s chest.

“I’ll come upstairs with you,” she suggested, “you’ll want to change into something more comfortable.”

This, of course, was something of a misnomer because she well knew that Alex was never more comfortable than when he was in his Colonial Air Force tailored uniform.

Except, that was, when he was in bed with her.

They fitted together just right...

They took the recently installed lift to the second floor.

Nobody batted an eyelid when, eventually, the couple came downstairs some ninety minutes later, nor remarked at the new flush in Leonora’s cheeks, a bloom perfectly complemented by the platinum blond of her hair.

In the couple’s absence Leonora’s father’s cronies had arrived en masse, now captains of industry, merchant bankers and a host of local dignitaries rubbed shoulders as the evening drew in.

Leonora reluctantly surrendered her hero to the great men of New York who clustered about him hoping, no doubt, that a little of his magic star dust would brush off upon them.

“They’re talking about Cuba and how it will hit the stock market if there’s a blockade, or something,” Maud Daventry-Jones announced, joining her friend in comfortable chairs a little outside the jostle of the party. This was their parents’ jamboree and they both felt out of things. “Alex is being fearfully bullied to tell people what he thinks is going on down in the Gulf of Spain...”

“He’s a big boy,” Leonora smiled archly. “He can look after himself.”

“You two were upstairs an age?”

“Yes,” Leonora agreed, smugly.

Maud giggled and patted her friend’s arm.

“Alex doesn’t really know what’s going on down on the Border or in Florida,” Leonora said without prompting. “Not that he would tell me if he knew, I suppose.”

“Has he ever talked to you about what it was like when he was down in Alta California and the Rio Grande country the first time?” Maud pressed, her voice pitched lowly confidential.

“He claims it was a quote: ‘Hell of a party once or twice a month and unbelievably boring the rest of the time’,” Leonora sighed. “But I never know if he’s teasing me. All I know is that he can’t wait to get back down there. How dumb is that?”

“Men!” Maud sympathised.

“Junior’s kicking again.”

The other woman tentatively placed the fingertips of her left hand on her friend’s belly.

“Yeah, I feel it...”

Leonora held Maud’s palm against her so she could get the full ‘kicking’ experience. She tried not to get ‘sloppy’ about these things but the last year, leastways since Alex had got out of jail, had been the happiest of her life. She had got to like herself, accept she was who she was and being married to Alex was well, living the dream. Her greatest fear was that her life would— or never could be— this sweet again.

A shadow passing through her peripheral vision snapped her out of her brief introspection.

Albert Stanton bowed and offered his hand to her.

“Albert,” Leonora smiled, offering her cheek for the newcomer to bow low and kiss. “We’d almost given up on you!”

“Many apologies,” the reporter grimaced. “I was detained in Manhattan. The *Globe* is publishing more than its fair share of tittle-tattle in its evening edition and the lawyers were in a dead funk.”

Leonora and Maud Daventry-Jones had got to their feet.

They had both got to know the dapper journalist – whose evidence, had it been listened to by the New York Constabulary the morning after Empire Day would have immediately cleared Alex and Leonora of any involvement in that day’s atrocities – who had done so much to publicise the two women’s campaign for justice last year.

Truth be told, Leonora was very aware that Maud went positively ‘stupid’ whenever Albert was around. Presently, her friend was blushing and smiling and shifting nervously on her feet as if she was a teenage girl in the first flush of unreasoning infatuation.

In the aftermath of the collapse of the trial of the Fielding brothers, Albert, whose support in print for Leonora and Maud’s campaign to free Alex, had subsequently earned him access to the exclusive ‘Shinnecock Hills’ club-cabal of bankers, industrialists and colonial legislators loosely orchestrated by Sir Maxwell Coolidge, Leonora’s father, and subsequently, his journalistic career had taken off like a rocket bound for some distant stellar body.

By repute he had been the highest paid, most in demand ‘scribbler’ in the First Thirteen, even before through Alex and Leonora he had been introduced to Abe and Kate.

Albert Stanton’s eagerly expected book about Abe and Kate – formerly ‘Fielding’ now ‘Lincoln, Leonora still had not got her head around that one – was expected to go straight to the top of the bestseller lists in New England and in the Old Country when it was published, an event provisionally scheduled for the autumn.

“Is it true you are besieged by Paris movie makers these days, Albert?” Leonora asked coyly.

The man grinned.

“Not quite. Abe and Kate have the final say on everything even though they are, how can I put it,” he shook his head, guffawed wistfully, “totally disinterested in money. Which I know, in the First Thirteen must sound like something of an oxymoron!”

“I thought you’d got around that, Mr Stanton?” Maud inquired timidly, lowering her eyes as she spoke.

“Yes, sort of. Abe and Kate don’t want to earn a penny from the book or any future sale of the movie rights to their story. They’ve engaged me to write the book on the proviso that the royalties due to them should be paid directly to the Royal Navy (New England) Benevolent Fund, a Canadian Trust managed by the Elders of the Iroquois Nation which teaches native children to speak and write the English language, and the Empire Day Society which alleviates the hardship of people injured in or otherwise economically disadvantaged by the events of 1976. The same deal will apply to the sale of the film rights. I’m travelling to Paris in a week or so to see the colour of the movie men’s money.”

“Albert gets to keep fifty percent of the royalties,” Leonora explained, not entirely helpfully.

The man was urbane about it.

He removed his spectacles— steel-rimmed today— and began to wipe the left lens with a small white cloth retrieved from an inside pocket.

“For the book royalties, yes. For that I initially agreed a fifty-fifty split with Abe and Kate. The movie rights will be split thirty-three percent to sixty-seven percent in Abe and Kate’s favour. Actually, I plan to donate half of my share of both deals to the Empire Day Society. The Admiralty Dockyards have been good at supporting their own people but the EDS does a really good job looking after all the other people who got caught up in the mayhem out in the Upper Bay that day.”

“That’s incredibly generous of you,” Maud gushed.

“Actually, to be frank, I feel like a complete fraud making any money at all out of the Empire Day business,” the man frowned in self-deprecation. “Honestly, it’s not as if I’m short of a few pennies to rub together these days. Perhaps, Abe and Kate have got it right...”

He looked to Maud with no little concern.

Leonora thought her friend was about to swoon.

“Quickly, Albert,” she suggested, struggling hard to keep a straight face. “Quickly, take Maud’s arm and get a couple of stiff drinks down her neck before she faints!”

Stanton hesitated.

“Now! Can’t you see she’s absolutely besotted with you, man?”

“Leonora!” Maud complained, suddenly sobering.

Albert Stanton's response was measured.

"Oh," he murmured thoughtfully. "Is that so, Miss Daventry-Jones?"

Leonora rolled her eyes, suspecting Maud really would swoon now.

However, in the event her friend surprised her.

She blinked up ◦ – Maud was little more than five feet tall ◦ – at the Manhattan Globe's star reporter with quietly determined eyes.

"Yes, Mr Stanton," she admitted defiantly. "That would be pretty much the size of it."

The man considered this, albeit not for very long.

"Well," he sighed, "that's a very good thing to know. Perhaps, in that case we ought to find somewhere a tad quieter where we can sit and discuss *matters* further?"

Chapter 6

Monday 13th March

HMS Achilles, Chesapeake Bay

On board a Royal Navy ship when a man errs it is not initially the Captain who takes him to task it is usually the Executive Officer, or on really big vessels like battleships, battlecruisers or the new fleet carriers, the ‘First Lieutenant’, usually a senior lieutenant or a lieutenant-commander, who is specifically responsible for crew discipline and the efficient running of the ship.

Commander Peter Cowdrey-Singh, the Achilles’s Executive Officer had wasted no time summoning Abe and his co-offender, Ted Forest to his cabin. He had ripped into them the moment the cabin door shut behind them.

‘What the bloody Hell were you playing at?’ He had demanded of Lieutenant Abraham Lincoln, RNASR, whom rightly, he considered to be the primary malefactor. ‘You came within a whisker of getting yourselves, and God only knows how many of your crewmates killed and badly damaging the bloody ship!’

By then Abe seriously doubted he could possibly feel any more wretched.

He had been convinced the diving Sea Fox was going to pile into the deck somewhere aft of the funnel, probably on top of the ship’s second sea plane, stowed at the time on the midships catapult. Hauling back on the stick and closing his eyes had been the only thing he could do. Nobody had been more surprised than him— Ted Forest apart, that is— when at the last second the aircraft had, with a gut-wrenching protest that very nearly tore off the wings somehow... *missed the ship*.

In fact, technically the Sea Fox had not actually ‘missed’ Achilles; the small rudder of her port float had struck the top of the funnel and the aircraft had carved through two thin radio cables before, on the verge of a stall it had... *missed*.

Instantly, Abe had pushed the stick forward before the machine plummeted into the grey North Atlantic like a stone. Clipping the crest of a

wave the Sea Fox had struggled into the air and miraculously... *survived*.

Understandably, the Achilles's Executive Officer had been in a mood to have the two 'maniac flyers' keel-hauled.

Abe knew exactly what he had done wrong.

'It is my fault entirely, sir. Ted, I mean, Sub-Lieutenant Forest was literally just a passenger,' he had said blankly, staring to his front not daring to meet Peter Cowdrey-Singh's blazing stare. 'They warned us about 'target fixation' at Virginia Beach but the training regime on shore was never as intense as that moment... half-an-hour ago. I got so wrapped up holding the deck in my sights that I forgot everything else I had been taught, sir!'

Now, Abe was standing in front of Captain the Honourable Francis Jackson. Unnervingly, the magnificently piratical, greying man in his late fifties, the younger man concluded, ought to have been an awful lot angrier than he seemed to be that morning.

"Who told you to attack the ship the way you did that second time, young man?" The senior post captain in the Atlantic Fleet inquired, deciding he had allowed the young man before him to 'stew' long enough.

"Sir?" Abe blurted, not sure if he had heard his captain correctly.

"You made a minor, very understandable hash of your first attack but then you altered your tactics and— had we been in a real battle— you might very well have dropped a clutch of bombs down my bloody funnel," Jackson complained laconically.

Abe scrambled to recollect his thought processes on the day he had almost got himself killed.

"In the first attack I misjudged the aircraft's manoeuvrability in the dive— they never allow us to 'go in that deep' in training— and I suppose, the speed of the Achilles's turn. Again, I'd never flown anywhere near a ship operating at flank, or top speed, sir."

Captain Jackson was listening indulgently.

The two men were alone in Jackson's big stateroom near the cruiser's stern. Achilles had been built as a 'flagship' but only rarely employed in that role and 'officer country' was unusually spacious as a result even though part of it had been modified to accommodate the Petty Officers' Mess some years ago.

It was Abe's understanding that when a man stood before a Captain's Table to be disciplined for his egregious offences there were numerous other interested parties in the room. Like, for example, the Executive

Officer, his own Divisional Commander, and customarily, the Captain's Secretary minuting proceedings.

However, that morning he was alone with the great man.

"But you got it right the second time?" The older man ruminated. "Granted, by very nearly crashing into *MY* ship!"

"Yes, sir. Sorry about that, sir."

Captain Jackson grunted softly, shook his head.

"You commenced your dive before the ship began to turn. Was that a lucky guess?"

"Yes and no, sir. I don't have much, any real experience of these things but I guessed the ship's first 'jink' was probably just the rudder going over a few degrees, then I saw the port screws going astern. After that it was just a matter of following the ship deep enough into the dive to be sure of a hit... before pulling up, obviously, sir."

"Um..."

Abe swallowed, his mouth aridly dry.

In for a penny, in for a pound.

"I know hanging back that way would have got Ted and me shot down in a real battle but if it was 'for real', I'd have hung back farther away or farther astern where the medium AA cannons and the three-inch auto-cannons are blocked by the aft deckhouse. Obviously, anybody who tried to attack the ship in an old Sea Fox would be on a hiding to nothing..."

Abe realised he was getting carried away.

"In any case, I reckon that in a real fight there would be several aircraft attacking at once, splitting the ship's fire, sir."

The older man was a little... amused.

"Do you apply this same grasp of logical complexity to your work as a healer, Lieutenant Lincoln?"

Even though he was still standing rigidly to attention Abe involuntarily shrugged.

"I like to think that I am always working to be the best physician, the best flyer, and," he hesitated, "the best husband and father that I can be, sir."

Francis Jackson studied the tall, handsome dark-haired young man before him. He had had his doubts about having such a 'celebrity' aboard his ship, wondering whether a man with such a colourful recent history could ever really fit into the closely-knit, generally happy crew he had nurtured in his eighteen months in command of the old trade route cruiser.

The jury was still out on that one; in the meantime, the young man had contrived to make himself something of a ship's talisman and he was not about to take him to task for obeying his mantra of 'train for war to fight a war' to heart.

Nevertheless, something told Jackson that sooner or later, Surgeon Lieutenant Lincoln was going to outgrow this 'little' ship.

"May I speak my mind, sir?" Abe asked on an impulse, his thoughts roiling. Two days ago, the hunter in his soul, demons in the very blood coursing through his veins, had caught him unawares.

"Yes."

"I learned two things the other day. One, that I was nowhere near as good a pilot as I believed I was..."

"And the other thing?"

"That if, even in a slow old Sea Fox if I had wanted to dive straight into the deck of the Achilles, I don't think there was a single thing anybody on board could have done to stop me, sir."

"My, my," Captain Jackson guffawed ruefully. "Well, watching from the bridge I was convinced that you were going to do exactly that," he confessed, "right up to the moment you... didn't!"

"Sorry, sir."

The older man nodded and briefly his expression turned severe.

"Well, Mr Cowdrey-Singh has given you a piece of his mind. As has your Divisional Commander. To your credit you have taken full responsibility for your reckless conduct. This will be noted on your papers but otherwise I am content to consider the matter closed. That is all Lieutenant, you may resume your normal duties."

Abe had been reconciled to being disciplined, and feared being denied shore leave when Achilles returned to Norfolk to complete her final preparations for her forthcoming Caribbean cruise. He had taken it as read that he would be grounded, at least for a token period and taken solace from the fact this would allow him to become more involved in the routine work of the ship's Medical Department.

Ted Forest was loitering with intent in the passageway outside the Captain's Cabin.

"Well, what's the bad news, Abe?" He demanded anxiously.

"Er, there isn't any."

"Seriously?"

Abe nodded, still in a daze.

His friend slapped him on the back.

“If you weren’t a blasted teetotaller, I’d stand you a pink Gin!”

“I’m not a teetotaller,” Abe protested feebly, allowing the shorter man to take his arm and guide him up the steps to the quarter deck. He drank the occasional beer, it was simply that he did not like the taste, or the effect alcoholic drink had on him and he never had. He suspected part of it might be to do with the toll he had seen drink take on his brothers and sisters of the Mohawk Nation. Nonetheless, he had never been one of those inflexible, pedantic *abstainers*. He began to collect his wits. “Another time, perhaps,” he suggested.

The two men stood at the rail.

Achilles was slicing through the coastal chop at a sedate nine knots streaming minesweeping paravanes to starboard and port in her wake. The idea was to cut the cables of bottom anchored mines and for sharpshooters to detonate them when the bombs bobbed to the surface.

Realistically, nobody could imagine anybody in this day and age would actually order a cruiser to clear a minefield, that sort of stuff had gone out of the porthole with the development of sophisticated magnetic and electronic activated ‘field sensor’ mines in the 1950s which exploded only when a ship steamed over, or within killing range of one of the infernal devices. Nevertheless, since the Royal Navy had seen fit not to remove the offending ‘minesweeping’ equipment Achilles was duty-bound to employ it, like all her other weaponry, with the utmost unctiousness and this required regular drills.

“I almost got you killed the other day,” Abe said dully.

“But you didn’t, old man.”

“I’m sorry, that’s all.”

Ted Forest chuckled: “Worse things happen at sea, isn’t that what they say.” Another chuckle. “The next time I’ll know to give you a jolly good kick up the backside!”

Unaccountably, Abe’s mal-de-mere began to lift.

In the middle distance the watch bell tolled.

“I need to report to the sick bay,” Abe decided, straightening. He smiled tight-lipped at his friend. “Thanks, Ted.”

“For what?”

Abe did not know what to say to this.

“Nothing, it doesn’t matter.”

The Son of the Hunter patted Ted Forest’s arm and headed forward to report the outcome of his interview with the Old Man to Achilles’s Surgeon, forty-seven-year-old Bostonian, Commander Michael Powell Flynn.

Flynn outranked Abe’s other Divisional Commander, who was just a lieutenant like the much younger man, only with several years more seniority, and was therefore his ‘boss’ on board the cruiser.

Achilles’s Wardroom very nearly reflected the multi-national mix of the rest of the cruiser’s crew, albeit with a slightly lower representation of the coloured faces *below decks*. On a ship with an Indian Executive Officer, a half-*Red* Indian assistant surgeon-cum-seaplane flyer gave rise to precisely no comment whatsoever.

Michael Flynn was an Irish New Englander, other officers were from Australasia, the Caribbean, Africa, the ship’s Navigator was a second-generation Nigerian emigrant to the British Isles, the Engineering Officer the grandson of a lascar steward on one of the last sailing clippers carrying tea and cotton from the Indies back to the Old World. Truly, if England had become the melting pot of the Empire then the Royal Navy had become one of its primary global ‘mixing’ pots.

Which of course, was why so many Navy men found the aberration of the *Getrennte Entwicklung* movement in the First Thirteen, and increasingly in Maine and Vermont—two colonies who had considered themselves to be members of the ‘First Fifteen’ for the last century-and-a-half, although even now they were still looked down upon by the ‘originals’ — so incomprehensibly bizarre.

Especially, since it was exactly that special sense of family, of belonging to something that was so profoundly greater than the mere sum of its parts which was the real, unquenchable strength of the Senior Service.

Michael Flynn heard out Abe in wry silence.

“Dammit,” he complained when Abe finished, “I was hoping you’d at least be confined to the blasted ship, so I could hand off the next two weeks’ sick parades to you!”

Chapter 7

Thursday 16th March

Plaza Mayor, Chinchón, Comarca de Las Vegas

The two women had stayed on in Chinchón when their host, Alonso Pérez de Guzmán, 18th Duke of Medina Sidonia, had been unexpectedly called back to Madrid on Monday evening. Escorted by a pair of Ducal arms men and with their every need assiduously catered for by the devoted household of the Hacienda de los Conquistadores, Melody Danson and Henrietta De L'Isle had, after tearfully making their peace, determined to make the very best of their little 'holiday' away from the stifling tedium of the last few months.

'My Queen demands my presence at Aranjuez,' Alonso had apologised, giving every appearance of being utterly mortified to leave them.

He had assured his guests that as the Royal Palace of Aranjuez was no more than a dozen miles as the crow flies— although twice that distance by road through the mountains— he hoped to return soon, or at intervals during the 'balance of your stay in my humble house'.

Queen Sophia kept her court some thirty miles from where her husband, the King-Emperor ruled, either from the fortress-like many times rebuilt Alcazar, or as it was more commonly known, the Royal Palace of Madrid, or from his *Monasterio y Sitio de El Escorial en Madrid*, the El Escorial Palace near the town of San Lorenzo another thirty miles north west of the capital.

One thing Melody had learned since she had returned to Spain the previous year was that the two Royal Courts were rarely in step, the one often frustrating the will of the other in a ludicrous, Ruritanian farce that many foreign diplomats had condemned as 'an accident waiting to happen' for much of the last decade. The miracle was that the Queen somehow contrived to regularly produce additional princes and princesses— five to date— all of whom Ferdinand had acknowledged, and apparently, for they were seen in public very rarely, tended to actually look a little like him—

long of jaw and wide-eyed— despite the fact he and his wife seemed to be constantly at odds over, well, practically everything.

Melody had questioned Alonso on this more than once, including on the day after their coupling.

He had been maddeningly vague.

‘In your country, New England and in the British Isles there is a certain *constructive tension* between opposing political parties and organs of your governmental institutions— for example, between the Houses of Commons and of the Lords in Whitehall, and between the Office of the Governor of the Commonwealth of New England and the various colonial administrations and their internal legislative councils— which you elect to call a system of *checks and balances*. Here in Spain and throughout the Empire there is no similar separation of the judiciary from the executive branches of the Imperial Government. That would be impossible given the existence and nature of the various organs of the Inquisition, and the fact of infallible sovereign rule by the King-Emperor. However, that does not mean that the Monarchy, the Church or anybody else is actually in control of all things. Regional governors have great power and factions within both Royal Courts are supreme in some things, weak in others. Of course, a cynic might say that the *checks and balances* in the Spanish system are, like those in the British Empire, in reality closely related to who holds the real power rather than they are to any fig leaf of democracy, the fiction of a supposedly independent judiciary, or the primacy of Parliament.’

Melody had not been ready to concede that the democratic principles which had, and were continually trickling down through the fabric of the British Empire, bore any comparison with the dictatorial, theocratic chaos of its Spanish counterpart.

In fact, this was a point she had made at length and with no little indignation. Her host, and lover, had clearly found the entire debate... immensely stimulating.

‘In any event, our system,’ the man had concluded, smiling one of those smiles that had very nearly charmed her knickers off, *again*, ‘requires that the wheels of governance be oiled, lubricated in a different fashion. Which is where *neutral* go-betweens, emissaries, legates, call us what you will, who are respected by all the parties, come in. Presently, I serve Her Majesty, one day I might serve the King-Emperor, or even the colleges of

Cardinals in Seville and Toledo. We live in strange and interesting times, do we not?’

Discreetly overseen by their ever-present minders— large men dressed in the green and grey of the Medina Sidonia family— Melody and Henrietta had explored the fascinating old-world charms of Chinchón, visited vineyards and wineries on the Plain of Tajuña, and shamelessly gorged themselves on the fresh breads, cheeses, olives and cold, preserved meats of the district.

They had been a little surprised to discover that they were by no means the only ‘outsiders’ in the town. There were visitors from France and Germany, several people from England, adventurous travellers brought to the wilds of the Mountains of Madrid in search of a traditional world that was fast disappearing elsewhere in Western Europe. Unlike Melody and Henrietta, the ‘foreigners’ they encountered were careless of the alleged watchfulness of the Inquisition, and thoroughly disinterested in the medieval, positively Byzantine politics of the Spanish Empire. Instead, they were bewitched by the atmosphere and tranquility of the rural landscapes through which they moved, far removed from the hustle, bustle, noise and complexity of their lives ‘back home’.

The two women were happy to pass themselves off as fellow travellers, tourists subtly absorbing the endless contradictions of the country around them.

Most Englishmen and women, and New Englanders— if they thought about it at all— assumed that the average Spaniard lived in constant fear of the Inquisition in a society under the unrelenting merciless heel of the Catholic Church. Which, of course, was a nonsense. The majority of Spaniards were in any case religiously — Catholically, obviously — unquestioningly devout and far from viewing the Church as a burden on their backs, took immense succour and no little joy in their faith. Given that Spanish society was still over fifty percent agrarian, in most places the Church was invariably as much a welfare as a spiritual overseer; local priests, the monks and the nuns of a plethora of ancient religious orders and houses ran the hospitals, organised the soup kitchens when crops failed and lobbied local, district and national *civil* authorities to relieve hardships and to fearlessly appeal against injustices both large and small.

In the cities the Church of Rome was less concerned with the temporal, an integral major constituent of the body politic with its fingers in every

aspect of government; but out in the country an argument could be made that it was ‘the government’, albeit in its most benign ‘suffer the children to me’ incarnation.

Here in the mountains, in places like Chinchón imperial power politics and the machinations of the rival factions in the Royal Palaces of Madrid might have been happening on the surface of some alien, distant planet. Dressed in the fashion of better off local women Melody and Henrietta almost but not quite blended into the milieu of the town, unselfconsciously wandering hand in hand and sitting, as they did now, outside an old taverna which catered in the main for visitors, drinking rich coffee from Colombia, and nibbling biscuits chipped through with cocoa from the Indies.

“This must be a horrible place when they hold their twice-yearly bull fights in the square?” Henrietta remarked, enjoying the cool spring sunshine bathing her face. She had let her long hair down in the fashion of Spanish women in the country. “I suppose? You told me once that you’d been to the great bullring in Madrid?”

Melody wrinkled her nose.

“Yes, it was horrible,” she remembered, ‘yet beautiful in its tragedy. It’s really hard to describe. One side of me was disgusted, ashamed to be watching it at and the other, was, well, fascinated by the drama of it all. A lot of the ‘bull fight’ was really like an intricate, very dangerous ballet played out in a huge sandy arena, scene after scene until in the final acts the matadors’ swords stab and the gladiatorial circus comes to a tumultuous end...”

Melody still felt conflicted, guilty and defiant about sleeping with Alonso. She wondered if she would have felt half so conflicted if she had fallen into his bed on an impulse, suffered some kind of rush of blood. That she had planned to be seduced, or to seduce him – she had no idea which clause applied even in hindsight – for several weeks before the event, tugged persistently at her conscience even though Henrietta had forgiven her.

The last two nights they had abandoned pretence, wrapped each other in their arms and slept curled, clinging together in Henrietta’s room, slowly healing.

“Do you think Alonso is one of the Queen’s lovers?” The younger woman asked, so lowly that Melody had to piece together the interrogative before she could consider it.

“I wouldn’t put it past him,” she whispered, quirking a very wan smile. And then, spontaneously, giggling like a girl and almost spilling her coffee.

Among other dissonances within the ‘Madrid bubble’ at the nexus of the dysfunctional Empire of New Spain was the *tension* between the ‘modernisers’ of the Aranjuez Court and the ‘traditionalists’ of the El Escorial. While it would be a gross misrepresentation to claim that one faction was in any way anti-Catholic—such a thing was unthinkable in the Spanish Imperial establishment— the Holy See in Rome periodically castigated those ‘who would overturn *the tradition* in the name of progress’, and now and then had backed up this with bulls of ex-communication against several of Queen Sophia’s advisors in recent years. Moreover, the Cardinal of Madrid, a man in his eighties whom many considered a living anachronism had once famously bemoaned ‘the feebleness of the modern-day Inquisition.’ Apparently, he was still a ‘burning’ cardinal!

One of the main tasks assigned to ‘British’ members of the impotent Joint Commission to which Melody and Henrietta had been appointed last year, had been to probe both Royal Courts to identify people—men, if one was being picky because there were few women of influence, courtesans apart within either court—with whom London might ‘do business.’

Melody had actually been a little shocked to discover that Imperial Intelligence had so singularly failed to penetrate the apparatus of the Empire’s *only* serious transatlantic rival. The reasons for this had soon become crystal clear. Belatedly, she had come to understand that the closer to the top of Spanish society one moved the more profoundly opaque things became until by the time one tried to peer into the workings of the Royal Courts, all was veiled, smoke and mirrors and scores, possibly hundreds or thousands of lies, schemes and subterfuges obscured any glimpse of reality.

Consequently, the very fact that outside observers could see even slim shafts of murky daylight between the Courts of the El Escorial and Aranjuez was the real litmus test of how much trouble the Empire of Spain was in, and the likely ramifications for New Spain overseas. It was almost as if what everybody had known for decades but been afraid to talk about, was now the least-best kept secret in Christendom.

Even in Old Spain, there were factions who understood that the Empire of New Spain was dying, disintegrating around them and with it the century’s old dominion of an infallible monarchy.

Old Spain was not a country, it was an empire within an empire: Castile and Leon, Aragon, Galicia, Asturias, La Mancha, Catalonia, Extremadura, Andalusia, Navarre and all the other lands of the Iberian Peninsula might be nominally 'Spanish' but each had their own language, culture, histories and communal identities buried beneath 'Spain' but not extinguished, waiting to find new expression if and when the burden of the upstart Castilian, or Aragonese, or Asturian, or whichever royal blood line, which temporarily sat upon the throne in Madrid stood aside, or was... *over-thrown*.

However, for the moment Melody was content to forget all the wearisome 'background noise' and enjoy being with Henrietta, safe in this rural backwater many miles from the harsh realities of a once great nation in sad, irreversible decline.

The two women finished their drinks and walked slowly back up the gently rising cobbled street to the *Hacienda de los Conquistadores*, where, asking not to be disturbed until a few minutes before the evening meal was served, they retired to their bed chambers— or rather, Henrietta's bed— to enjoy a lazy, playful siesta little knowing that the great storm long-predicted by an army of 'Spanish experts', few of whom had ever stepped foot on the soil of Old Spain, was about to break over the Mountains of Madrid.

It seemed odd that evening, eating alone together at the big table where Alonso had regaled them with witty asides, pithy word plays and gossip, both scurrilous and ironic about the goings on in his time in Philadelphia.

The women ate sparingly having excelled themselves in their wanderings around the town that morning, enjoying a long, browsing lunch in the Plaza Mayor and subsequently, done little to burn off the calories they had taken on board during their post-prandial perambulations and naps that afternoon. They savoured small glasses of wine, talked awhile on the veranda until a light, spotting rain began to fall in the darkness and the wind, as if on cue, chilled several degrees, quickly driving them inside.

"I could get used to this," Melody admitted. "But I think we'd both grow quite plump in no time at all living the easy life!"

They laughed as they shut the door to Henrietta's bed chamber at their backs, disrobed, trooped into the small washroom to wipe away a little of the day's dust, brushed their teeth, and discarding their shifts, slipped beneath the blankets together.

“I’m sorry,” Melody whispered in the Stygian gloom. “I do thoughtless things sometimes, that’s who I am.”

Henrietta kissed her as their limbs tangled together.

“I’m sure I will do something bad one day,” the younger woman gasped, breathlessly.

Melody laughed softly.

“I shall look forward to that!”

It was all the prompting her lover needed to roll on top of her and straddle her.

Melody stretched and pressed against her, her hands gently kneading Henrietta’s breasts; presently her lover lowered herself onto her elbows, began to plant small, moist kisses on and around her mouth, moaning as Melody’s fingers began to explore between her thighs. Suddenly she wanted to lick and suck every inch of her partner’s flesh, touch her with every part of her being.

Much, much later the two women slept.

Their sleep was dreamless, sated, both utterly comfortable, safe in their own skins in the warm blanket of the Spanish night far, far from the troubles of the age.

Chapter 8

Friday 17th March
Government House, Philadelphia

The Governor of the Crown Colonies of the Commonwealth of New England, Edward Philip Cornwallis Sidney, 7th Viscount De L'Isle, who only usually used his full title 'The Lord De L'Isle, Dudley and Northampton' in his annual, summer appearances in the House of Lords to make his customary report on the year just completed in the Americas, was a much pre-occupied man that morning. Not least because he had felt it necessary to dissemble when, some minutes ago, his wife Diana had inquired, with horrible pertinacity, whether the 'commotion in Spain' was 'likely to effect Henrietta and Miss Danson?'

'Hen and the others will be as safe as houses in the Embassy, my love. It'll all turn out to be a storm in a tea cup. You know how volatile the Latin temperament can be!'

The Governor of New England's wife had been very ill in the last few days and although he justified his white lie – in reality only an embellishment of the truth because nobody seemed to know anything about the situation in Madrid or anywhere else in Old Spain at the moment – he felt damnably guilty.

Not to say more than a little worried about his daughter.

"Excuse me, My Lord," a Government House staffer, a subaltern in the uniform of the 20th/21st Hussars murmured, reluctant to interrupt the great man mid-stream in the consideration of whatever mighty matters of state were demanding his immediate attention, 'Brigadier Harrison has asked to speak to you at your earliest convenience. Should I put the call through to you, My Lord?'

"Yes, if you'd be so good. Thank you."

De L'Isle settled behind his broad, uncluttered desk and waited a few seconds for the phone to ring. He had asked London if they had any idea what was going on in Spain, only to be informed that the Foreign and Colonial Secretary was in a meeting with 'Cabinet colleagues', which did not bode well.

“I apologise for not getting through to you earlier, sir,” the Head of the Colonial Security Service apologised, his Virginian drawl belying the fears both men shared. “I’ve only just landed in New Orleans.”

Although the Mississippi Delta had been border-country in the two men’s youth, successive dirty little wars had since pushed the frontier all the way into the badlands of West Texas and Coahuila since the 1950s. The lands west of the vast Louisiana Territories had been a harsh, windswept desert wilderness in those days, a terrible place to fight any kind of war. However, the most recent – 1971 – ceasefire in the borderlands had held, more or less intact. Not so much because the regime in Mexico City was any less acquisitive or embittered than any of its predecessors but because it understood that it could not win – other than at immense cost – a ‘long war’ in the South West.

Successive New England governors had driven railheads and a network of broad, arrow-straight highways across the coastal flats of the Gulf of Spain and the rolling plains west of the Mississippi. New boom towns had been founded and now dotted the previously empty landscape, and factories had moved into ‘tax and tariff free’ zones. Lately, the fast-expanding gulf ports of Pelican Island and Buffalo Bayou west of the Delta had accelerated the rush to claim and develop the new territories opened up to settlers and immigrants from the East.

In retrospect, had the same policy of incentives – free land grants and Imperial agricultural subsidies been made available in the south as had been promoted in the north back in the 1930s, it might not even have been necessary to fight the border wars of the mid-years of the century. But that was hindsight and little use to man nor beast...

The ‘land rush’ – essentially, loosely regulated ‘land-grabbing’ and settlement right up to the borders with New Granada – had gone into overdrive in the last few years. Huge ranges had been opened up to cattle farmers and in the last two or three years the small garrisons stationed, much in the fashion of trip-wire, or deterrent outposts, close to the contested border line had been mainly pre-occupied keeping the peace between the newcomers and the indigenous Apaches and Cherokees.

De L’Isle hoped above hope that memories of how those railroads and highways had enabled Empire forces to win the logistics war and eventually, to crush the last foray of an invading army onto New England soil, were still fresh in the mind of his counterpart in Mexico City. In the

last big 'border war' in the late 1960s the enemy, reliant for all his supplies on a few narrow un-metalled roads and tracks across the deserts and through the mountain passes that guarded Nuevo Mexico, Chihuahua and Coahuila had swiftly run out of ammunition, fuel and food once it moved into New England territory.

He hoped they remembered that because right now, all those recently planted towns and villages, cattle and sheep stations lost in the wilderness of the South West, were potentially in the firing line and if things went badly, there was nothing he could do to protect them in the short-term.

Worryingly, what was going on in Old Spain had the look and the feel about it of a madman lighting the fuse to...

God only knew what!

"How are things down there, Matt?" The Governor of New England inquired urbanely.

"Calm enough for the moment. The party started when the Navy came up the river a couple of days ago and people are still getting over their hangovers!"

Philip De L'Isle guffawed at this.

New Orleans was over a hundred miles from the Gulf of Spain but the Mississippi was easily navigable for even very big ships, as had been proven by the despatch of the forty-two thousand ton, eight-hundred-and-fifty feet-long battlecruiser HMS Indomitable and a squadron of fleet destroyers 'up river' to reassert that neither he, nor the Royal Navy had forgotten the people of the city or of the vast, poorly mapped and still relatively sparsely populated country to the west between it and the rapidly expanding Pelican Island-Buffalo Bayou port complex, the opening of which had prompted a rush of fresh private investment into the express development of the oilfields of West Texas.

The light cruiser HMS Devonshire and two more destroyers, detached from Indomitable's squadron, had steamed west to Pelican Island with orders to 'make their presence felt' in international waters along the coast of the Spanish province of Coahuila.

Every war plan the Governor had ever seen predicted, that in the event of a general war with the Empire of New Spain two things would happen: firstly, the Royal Navy would blockade the Gulf of Spain, Cuba and Santo Domingo and destroy 'enemy' maritime assets in detail at its leisure; and secondly, that the Army of Nuevo Granada would make mechanised

thrusts— in strength, possibly with columns simultaneously emerging from Nuevo Mexico and Coahuila — into West Texas, or east into the unincorporated protectorate of Sequoyah, or conceivably, north into the mountainous Colorado Valley concession. In this scenario, Pelican Island would be an obvious early objective for the invaders, possibly opening up a deep-water port he might employ as a bridgehead, thereby bypassing the virtually impassable terrain of much of the borderland and obviating the supply issues which had hamstrung every previous attempt to push the boundaries of New Granada farther to the north and east.

Thirty years ago, a Spanish column had advanced along the Gulf coast before bogging down in swamp land only a few miles short of being able to bring long-range artillery fire down upon New Orleans...

That fiasco had led to the summary dismissal of the then Governor. But every Governor in the Empire understood that the one indefensible, unforgivable sin of a man in his position, was to allow events to make his masters back in London look silly. That was invariably the sort of thing which sent a fellow into the sort of retirement from which there was no resurrection!

Unfortunately, with the best will in the world there were an awful lot of things beyond the control of even a pro-consul as mighty as the man who sat in Government House in Philadelphia.

For example, even though Colonial forces in the South West had been beefed up in recent months, albeit from a 'skeleton level', well short of a general mobilisation New England land and air resources *might*, if the Spanish really grasped the nettle — which they had never done before, admittedly — and exploited *their* problematic but undeniably much shorter lines of communication, and took advantage of the fact that well over half their standing army and air force was already stationed within a hundred miles of the border, there would be very little that *his* forces could do to seriously inconvenience the invaders in the opening days of the campaign. The enemy had a huge numerical superiority in men — easily ten-to-one or greater in manpower — and a four or five-to-one advantage in armoured and other vehicles. Likewise, although their aircraft tended to be older, and less capable than those operated by the small number of scout and reconnaissance CAF squadrons permanently based within range of the border, the Spanish had perhaps, twenty aircraft to every operational machine on the New England side. Put bluntly, if the Spanish attacked with

everything they had, they would simply roll over the 'trip wire' Colonial units, and rag-tag civilian militias theoretically barring their path.

Granted, colonial land cruisers were markedly harder nuts to crack and carried far deadlier high-velocity long-range rifles in comparison to their Spanish counterparts, and the latest CAF scouts were formidable aircraft but if the worst came to the worst, they would inevitably be 'mobbed under' by sheer weight of numbers.

Some had called Philip De L'Isle's 'border policy' *appeasement*; personally, he had always regarded a new war as being, sooner or later, inevitable but had inherited a mandate requiring him to do nothing to risk provoking 'Spanish aggression in the South West'.

Besides, drastic reductions in manning and equipment levels, and the consequent budgetary savings arising from his policy had been universally welcomed throughout New England, not least on the East Coast, many of whose legislatures were filled with people who did not see why they ought to be paying to 'defend the Border', some two thousand miles away, in the first place.

West Texas, Sequoyah, the highlands of the Colorado Valley, and the barely mapped parcels of designated Indian Country scattered in a disorderly patchwork all across the South West into the foothills of the Sierra Madre and the Rocky Mountains, were after all, foreign countries, deserts and wildernesses to most of the citizens of the First Thirteen. So, the establishment of notional de-militarized zones either side of the border and the draw-down of colonial forces had been welcomed practically everywhere, except in the still relatively sparsely populated South West. Inevitably, with the influx of settlers and industry to the borderlands that had been beginning to change; nevertheless, it remained a fact that less than five percent of all New Englanders lived within two hundred and fifty miles of the border with Nuevo Granada.

The Borderlands of the South West remained country of which most New Englanders knew little and sadly, cared less...

Moreover, even if De L'Isle had wanted to substantially alter the military balance in the region his hands were tied by what he, as a military man, well understood to be 'the facts on the ground'.

The problem was that while many colonies had been persuaded to call up the majority of their reservists to spring camps, aircraft had been taken out of mothballs and one of the four mechanised infantry divisions stationed

in the British Isles— the 52nd Highlanders— had been warned to embark for New England in the coming days, there was no magic wand that Philip De L'Isle or his military advisors could wave to remedy overnight the 'peacetime' status of the forces down on the Border.

They were where they were...

The policy mandated from London had been one of watchful vigilance; so, the avoidance of unnecessary incidents and provocations had been the guiding order of the day while the men in the Old Country tried to work out what to do about the 'Spanish Problem'.

The mission to Madrid was supposed to have been a fig leaf behind which preparations might be made and which hopefully, would gain a little more time to resolve the conundrum of whether or not there was any such thing any more as the 'Empire of New Spain'. The assumption had been— complacently, in De L'Isle and Matthew Harrison's opinions— was that the Spanish provinces ringing the Caribbean and dominating the central Americas were so many disarticulated, uncoordinated entities incapable of acting in concert to bring their truly massive combined military clout, and latent economic power to bear against their northern neighbour and or to challenge British imperial hegemony over North America.

Which was all very well if one ignored the five-ton rogue African bull Elephant in the 'room' of global realpolitik, the German Empire. Frustrated by the British Empire's command of practically all the international trade routes, Germany had been investing heavily in Spain's colonies in both the East and the West Indies, and attempting, with varying degrees of success to increase its influence in Africa, Latin America and the Far East, at the same time modernising and increasing the size, capabilities and reach of the *Deutsches Heer* (the Imperial Army), the *Kaiserliche Marine* (the Imperial Navy) and the *Deutsche Luftstreitkräfte* (the German Air Force). At the same time the Abwehr, the combined military intelligence service of the three arms of the forces, and the Foreign Intelligence Service controlled by the Wilhelmstrasse, the German Foreign Office, had also massively extended their tentacles in the last decade.

Nowadays, everything that happened in Old Spain and elsewhere needed to be viewed through the prism of a thus far militarily peaceful, yet otherwise hostile and antagonistic German strategy which could only be designed to erode British global hegemony.

There were those who accused British ministers of appeasement; of criminal inaction in the face of German intimidation. Whatever his critics in New England accused him of, De L'Isle was not a man in *that* camp.

In any event, he recognised that his view of the 'big picture' was restricted, which was just as well because he had quite enough on his plate already. He planned to carry on working within the policy framework handed down to him by his principals in the Foreign and Colonial Office in Whitehall.

Historically, whatever one thought of the state of Old Spain sandwiched between long-time British ally Portugal to the west and the Mediterranean— a Royal Navy 'pond'— to the east, with British occupied France to its north, separated from the Americas by an ocean ruled by Britannia, and with every passing year that little bit more impoverished in comparison with its own colonies and all the other major European powers, it was assumed that the King-Emperor in Madrid at least exerted a restraining hand on the ambitions of his most unruly 'subjects' abroad. It was taken as read that Ferdinand was not about to become a meek vassal to the Kaiser's Germany, no matter how much treasure in the form of military, economic and straightforward humanitarian aid the Germans dispersed in the distant colonies.

This 'foundation' presumption was pretty much an article of faith in the corridors of the FCO whose wise denizens argued, persuasively, that if Spanish colonies unwisely fomented war with British Imperial interests then inevitably, the old country back on the Iberian Peninsula would 'get it in the neck' from just about every quarter, regardless of what happened elsewhere in the subsequent conflagration. Therefore, the wise men in Whitehall prognosticated, it was in nobody's interest in Madrid to play that particular game.

Therefore, the Peace of Paris remained inviolate.

For the moment, at least.

This had seemed a safe basis for the ongoing conduct of international affairs, given that there was no intelligence that the government in Madrid had, for example, even attempted to build an atomic bomb and it was generally assumed that not even the Kaiser would contemplate handing over any of the dreadful things to the Spanish in the Americas or the Pacific.

The rationale was reasonable; unfortunately, it pre-supposed that other first, second and third rank powers would view the 'Spanish Problem' through the same prism as the Foreign and Commonwealth Office. Such an assumption had suited successive recent governments much in the fashion of turning a blind eye to a signal one does not wish to receive.

Right now, Philip De L'Isle and Matthew Harrison were confronting a developing situation which might, very easily, turn into the sort of nightmare they had discussed, many times in recent years and tried, and repeatedly failed to get Whitehall to take seriously.

"All the lines to Madrid have gone down," the Governor reported tersely. "Just before it happened there were several reports of troop movements and heavy gunfire. Other big cities appear to have gone off 'the grid' in the last few hours."

"Could it be a coup?" Harrison mused, thinking aloud. In a moment he clicked his thoughts into gear. "Henrietta and Melody Danson are not in Madrid at present. My information is that they were the guests of the Duke of Medina Sidonia out in the country somewhere. They weren't due back at the Embassy until the coming weekend at the earliest."

De L'Isle breathed a sigh of heartfelt relief.

"That's something," he said grimly.

"Do you want me back in Philadelphia?"

"Yes, that would be for the best."

"If it is a coup of some kind going on in Spain that might not be the worst thing," the Governor's spy master remarked, uncharacteristically surprised by the trend of recent world events.

"Why not?"

"The current regime is sclerotic and ineffective, unable to enforce its writ abroad and incompetent at home. If, say, the Army or a Navy or an Air Force faction was to take charge a few heads might get knocked together..."

The Governor of New England gently disagreed.

"What if the Inquisition or one of the opposing Royal factions takes over and wages a reign of terror against its enemies?"

"Yes," Matthew Harrison conceded, "there is that!"

One thing Philip De L'Isle had always agreed about with his old friend, Sir George Walpole, the eminent historian reluctantly turned politician who had ruled the FCO for most of the last decade, was that 'Old

Spain' was best understood within a frame of reference based on a Byzantine, rather than a contemporary model of governance.

Basically, there was no telling what might emerge from a coup in Madrid, whoever was responsible, or whomsoever eventually ended up wielding the levers of power in the Royal Alcázar, the El Escorial or in Aranjuez.

There was a knock at the door.

"Admiral Lord Collingwood is here, My Lord."

"I'll let you go about your business, Matthew," the Governor of New England decided, "the C-in-C of the Atlantic Fleet has just arrived at Government House."

Chapter 9

Saturday 18th March

Hacienda de los Conquistadores, Chinchón

Henrietta De L'Isle thought she was dreaming even after she blinked awake in the cool darkness of the spring mountain morning. Melody's breath fell on her cheek, the women's hair was crazily tangled, strands of her lover's burning red mane and her own, girlishly long auburn locks seemingly intertwined like their warm, relaxed limbs.

Was that fireworks in the distance?

Henrietta imagined she heard movement in the corridor outside the bedroom, and distantly, doors opening as she sleepily nuzzled Melody's brow with her nose and mouth, sucking in the scent of her, luxuriating in the tingling pleasure of it as it suffused her whole being.

Melody had finally opened her heart to her; allowed her into her secret world and that had made moving on from the events of last weekend if not painless, then easier and in some ways made them the sisters Henrietta had always hoped they might one day become. She had known from the outset that there were no fairy tales, especially not involving two princesses – conventional wisdom being that there had to be a prince in the deal somewhere along the line – and perversely, it had probably not helped that initially, she had been both infatuated and a little in awe of Melody, who had had no real idea exactly how much Henrietta had set her on a pedestal.

Melody had been a heroine to her and ought to have been to all other young women with aspirations to be the best that they could possibly be in a man's world!

Well, to those of her sisters who cared a fig for an Empire in which the contributions of women were valued...

Ha...

That was a joke!

What use was female suffrage in societies which refused to even acknowledge women's suffering or gumption? Let alone 'valued' it in most places where the map was painted Imperial Pink!

Anyway, sisters like Melody were very special, outriders who had by dint of sheer will power, and in her case a native intelligence which allowed her to run rings around most men, achieving firsts or near firsts in two separate careers.

She had been called to the Virginia Bar at just twenty-four years of age, practiced criminal law as a Colonial Prosecutor for two well-publicised and middlingly controversial years and without warning, applied for and gained admittance to the Colonial Police Academy at Boston, emerging top of the intake in 1967 and been subsequently inducted into the pilot 'fast track' program of the New York Constabulary, a short-lived initiative abandoned by the current Governor of the Colony. Nevertheless, she had still become the youngest Detective Inspector in New England at the age of thirty-two, albeit hitting the glass ceiling thereafter, her brilliant career idiotically becalmed by a Constabulary which had come to regard her as an embarrassment, something of an inadvertent celebrity in some liberal Manhattan-Long Island circles.

Back in the British Isles where clever, ambitious women routinely infiltrated the 'old boys' club', and one by one the professions were opening their doors on the basis of merit, not exclusively on gender, birth or wealth or colour, reading about how Melody was 'bucking the trend' in New England had been an inspiration to an untold number of young women like Henrietta.

It was pure happenstance that Henrietta had not met, or contrived to 'bump into' her personal exemplar-heroine until last year. She could honestly say— cross her heart and hope to die if she fibbed— that had the Colonial Security Service not passed Melody's file to her father when a high-profile detective-auditor familiar with but not obviously beholden to any of the political factions within the New York Constabulary, had been required to quickly, efficiently 'look into the case against the Fieldings'— she might never have got to know the woman she now loved too, and sometimes, a little beyond reason.

Henrietta had been unashamedly fascinated with Melody on first sight. Love had come along a little later, although thinking about it, very fast on the heels of infatuation. Melody had only caught up with her later but then for all Henrietta's experience at Government House and the privileges of her upbringing— in private she called the King 'Uncle Bertie' and the Queen 'Aunt Eleanor', after all— she had not understood how gauche and

frankly, a tad shallow, or how over-protected she had been until she had been around Melody for a while.

Not that Melody had ever belaboured the point. All things considered she had let Henrietta down very, very gently. As for the ‘Alonso incident’, Henrietta would have forgiven her lover even faster had not Melody steadfastly refused to concede that she had anything to be forgiven for, or in fact, that she had actually done anything wrong. However, moving on, it was as if having learned the important lesson— that sometimes one simply could not account for one’s feelings and physiological drives— that they could finally both be genuinely ‘grown up’ about their commitment one to the other.

‘Sometimes I like it sweet,’ Melody had quirked self-deprecatingly, ‘mostly, actually, but sometimes, very occasionally, I like it sour...’ She had added: ‘You’re the *sweet* side of that, just so you know.’

Henrietta shrugged closer to her partner; Melody stirred but did not awaken, half sighing, half moaning as she lay, loose-limbed in the nest of blankets blissfully unaware of the sudden commotion somewhere within the big house.

“What...” The older woman muttered.

Instantly, Henrietta was electrically awake, alert without knowing why and for a moment paralysing alarm coursed through her veins.

Melody propped herself on an unsteady elbow.

There was a hammering at the door.

Quickly followed by the dazzle of a torch and the loom of one, then another person entering the bed chamber.

“Forgive me, My Ladies,” a man apologised with urgent, perfunctory gruffness.

The women recognised the voice of Don Rafael, the senior Arm’s Man that Alonso, Duke of Medina Sidonia had left behind in Chinchón to chaperone and to safeguard his guests.

The Spaniard was a man in his late fifties, a life-long family retainer with whom Alonso invariably conversed with quiet, patrician respect. The man had served Alonso’s father for half his life and although Henrietta had not been introduced to him, or had the occasion to speak with him in Philadelphia, he had never been far from Alonso’s side, bodyguard and she had since learned, now and then, his wise counsellor.

The Hacienda's middle-aged housekeeper had accompanied the man into the bed chamber.

"Time is short," Don Rafael declared in a tone which brooked no dissent.

"Put on these clothes!" His companion ordered. "Forget about your toilet and your hair. Just get dressed. Now!"

Don Rafael may or may not have turned his back as the woman threw back the blankets revealing Melody and Henrietta's shocked pale nakedness. However, because he was a gentleman, he had turned the torch away.

Henrietta began to protest.

"What is happening?" She demanded.

"Do what they say, sweetheart," Melody snapped, pushing her out of the bed ahead of her.

That was when Henrietta belatedly realised that there was a sharp tang of immediate peril in the air and that both Don Rafael and the housekeeper were on the tightest of tight reins.

The women began to pull on the shifts and dresses pressed into their arms; plain linen, ungainly, heavy, coarse woollen ankle-length robes— that stank of the earth— like those worn by peasant women out in the country.

Boots clunked onto the floor.

"They won't fit you but put them on anyway," the housekeeper pleaded desperately as if time had already run out. "Quickly! Quickly!"

Henrietta dumped herself down on the side of the bed next to Melody as they frantically did as they were ordered to do, pulling on the horrible, stiff boots, and glimpsing the flash of steel in the reflected light of the torch.

Don Rafael had unsheathed the Castilian steel of his old-fashioned ceremonial sword.

"What is going on, Don Rafael?" Melody asked calmly, her voice barely a whisper.

Henrietta, who was so rattled, so caught up in the moment, that she had not thought to utter a word since her previous panicky complaint, froze. The 'fireworks' had got a lot louder in the last minute or so and seemed to be much closer. Belatedly, she worked out that what she was actually hearing was gunfire interspersed with the crack of grenades.

"We must leave," the man replied abruptly.

“What about our...” Henrietta began, the words dying in her throat as the house seemed to flinch beneath her feet.

There was the faint stench of smoke.

A clamour in the street below.

And a long, magazine-emptying burst of automatic gunfire.

“Forget your jewellery and trinkets, girl!” The housekeeper spat, grabbing Henrietta’s arm and dragging her to the door.

“Follow me,” Don Rafael commanded. “Whatever happens, stay close to me!”

The women trotted after him, down to the ground floor of the hacienda and thence to the wine cellars. There were other Arms Men, all brandishing cutlass-like swords or old-fashioned six-shooter revolvers.

Breathing heavily the party burst out into a narrow alleyway behind the Ducal residence.

Henrietta could already feel her feet rubbing, blistering in the ill-fitting, painful boots but right then none of that mattered. She was running— she knew not why or to where— for her life and the only thing that stopped her completely going to pieces was Melody’s hand in hers and the broad back of the old, sword-wielding man leading them through the warren of the ancient town’s medieval streets in the now pre-dawn greyness.

Behind them the rattle of gunfire seemed unbroken.

Fires had been lit, buildings were burning, their flickering glow periodically lighting their way along cobbled, twisting alleys. More than once Henrietta felt herself falling, tumbling to her knees, and being picked up as if she was a rag doll and impelled forward. Even in the cool of the morning she was sweating heavily, her hair plastered to her face and every breath came in ragged, lung-hurting gasps.

They halted, leaning against a low wall on the edge of the town. At their back the whole of Chinchón was an angry hornet nest, a battlefield.

“What?” Melody demanded breathlessly. “What is going on, Don Rafael?”

The old man motioned for the women to get down below the level of the top of the wall, lowered himself onto his haunches and viewed them with rheumy, oddly untroubled eyes.

“The world has gone mad,” he said sadly. “As my master, the Duke, warned me it might when he was summoned to Aranjuez.” He coughed,

took unhurried looks to his left and his right, like the old soldier he was, making absolutely sure that his men were in the right place. “It is too dangerous to take you back to Madrid, or to any place where the rebels might respect diplomatic soil. So, I must take you to sanctuary until plans can be laid to smuggle you safely out of Spain.”

Melody detected the shame accenting every word the proud Castilian knight said.

“You must trust me, My Ladies,” the man concluded. “You are under the protection of my Duke. You have my word as a gentleman and an Arms Man of the House of Medina Sidonia that no man will lay his hand upon you while I and my men live.”

Chapter 10

*Saturday 18th March
Île de la Cité, Paris*

Albert Stanton had felt a little creased and travel-weary last night when he had finally arrived in the ‘City of Peace’. When he was a boy the text books had called the French capital the ‘City of Peace and Reconciliation’ but that latter appellation had been quietly dropped over the last twenty years. It was as if the politicians and diplomats had known all along a thing the rest of civilisation had not. The flight across the Atlantic had seemed to last an eternity despite the normal following winds, with interminable delays at each stop for fuel in Nova Scotia and Belfast Loch and then, when the CEREBUS – one of the oldest flying boats in the Imperial Airways fleet – had finally touched down on Southampton Water he had had to wait six hours for the next ferry to Le Havre.

That said, it would have been churlish to have complained overmuch about his first-class, luxurious no expenses spared journey paid for out of the fat wallet of the Versailles Studio Collective. His hosts and ardent suitors for the film rights of Abe and Kate’s story, planned to send him back to New England in a week or so on the flagship of the Blue Star Line, the year-old sixty thousand ton, thousand feet long leviathan Titanic.

In an upper deck penthouse with his own team of stewards, would you believe? Mr and Mrs Stanton’s little boy had, it seemed, made the big time!

That he had arrived in Paris a little bit emotionally conflicted had not been anticipated; that was not at all like him. Having built his career upon his ability to keep his eye unerringly on the ball he had to admit that the last few months had been more than a tad... distracting. And as for his brilliant career, well, that had really only taken off after the acquittal of the Fielding brothers last August. And then only because he had happened to have flown with Alex on the morning of that fateful day in July two years ago. In retrospect, everything had flowed from that – at the time – middlingly unremarkable flight.

Leonora Coolidge had courted him, journalistically, after he wrote a sympathetic article about the unjust fate of women like her who had been

swept up in the New York Constabulary dragnet in the weeks following the atrocities in Brooklyn and the Upper Bay. Later, he and Alex had hit it off, just a random thing, the first time they met after his release from prison; and the connection with Abe and Kate had flowed from that because Abe trusted and basically, liked his older half-brother.

Looking back, it had been Kate who had really given him the theme for the feature he had published in the *Manhattan Globe* that had so caught the public imagination, and swiftly attracted an unstoppable avalanche of interest in New England, and, it now seemed, practically everywhere that the map was painted Imperial Pink!

People ran away with the idea that Kate was some kind of latter-day Pocahontas. She was nothing of the sort yet in her down to earth practicality, stoicism and devotion to her husband and son she had somehow ceased to be ‘a squaw’ – he loathed that term – adrift in the ‘white’ world of the First Thirteen and become a kind of ‘every-woman’ with whom few New England housewives could fail to identify. Kate herself, did not think she was in any way remarkable, or any different from other women. She had spoken of her love for her husband – they had been childhood sweethearts and teenage lovers, married under tribal law before they were twenty, a secret Abe had kept from his family for nearly four years – their life together and their hopes for the future with a simple frankness which spoke straight from the page of the first draft of ‘Abe and Kate’, the working title for what was promising to be the English language publishing sensation of 1978.

Abe and Kate – Stanton did not think for a moment that would be the actual title by the time the interminable haggling with publishers was concluded – was already well on the way to burying the now fading notoriety of that other bestseller, *Two Hundred Lost Years*.

And it might not even be published for another six months!

Perversely, now that he was finally in Paris – a city he had always wanted to visit – a part of him wanted to be on the boat home as soon as possible.

Maud Daventry-Jones had been hanging, literally hanging, on his arm by the end of that soiree at Castle Dore, the great bastion of the Coolidge dynasty in the Shinnecock Hills of Long Island.

She had been hanging on his arm and he had felt like he was eight feet tall!

A dinner at the Ritz in Manhattan the evening before he boarded the CEREBUS for the journey across ‘the pond’ had *flown* by in a blur and in retrospect he could not make up his mind who had been more fascinated, utterly infatuated with whom. With any other girl that meal might have concluded with a steamy night in an impetuously booked hotel room, or perhaps, in his cramped Brooklyn apartment.

That was a thought which had not even occurred to him until much later, lying awake in the dark trying to make sense of his feelings, having kissed his date goodnight on the steps of the Ritz before putting her in a taxi back to her West Side studio overlooking the Hudson River.

He had bent his face to hers, intending to respectfully peck her cheek. She had shyly raised her mouth to meet his. Just for a fleeting second and then... bizarrely he was recollecting, he knew not why, a meeting with Melody Danson— heck, she was a one off!— when they had both agreed that they were not each other’s ‘type’. There was absolutely nothing about Maud that was not ‘his type’ and it was pretty clear that she felt the same way about him. The serendipity of it all left him stunned. And right now, he was a little home sick, out of sorts in a strange city a long way from the only woman in the world he had ever loved...

Yet it had not even occurred to him to ‘take liberties’ with Maud the other night because she was just so much better than that. She deserved more, only the best and he could not help but wonder if he was, in his heart of hearts, worthy of her.

Albert Stanton had first encountered Maud in prison.

She had been locked up in the Massapequa Prison for Women after one of her protest stunts with Leonora Coolidge had gone wrong, or right, depending upon one’s viewpoint. Maud had been sitting beside her friend; both women’s hair still streaked purple-pink— the after-effect of a botched attempt to deluge the Chief Magistrate of New York with purple dye and butter acid bombs outside his office on Clinton Street— and they were both in a mood to pick a fight with any man who crossed their bows.

Notwithstanding, Leonora was the willowy beauty she could not help being, a woman like Helen of yore, whose face might inadvertently launch a thousand ships and turn countless strong men’s souls to mush. Maud had seemed round-shouldered, a little dumpy and vaguely tomboyish, except even that day her brown eyes had twinkled when she spoke...

I must have been blind the last year!

Of course, Maud was the equivalent of Long Island aristocracy and he was a guy from the back of nowhere who, at that time, was still working hard to make something of himself. Women like Leonora and Maud had seemed like exotic creatures from another world, unattainable, untouchable.

Maud was over-conscious that she was no statuesque Venus de Milo exemplar of womankind like her friend.

‘I’m short, curvy, buxom and liable to plumpness if my mother is anything to go by...’

Stanton had observed: ‘It takes all sorts. Wouldn’t it be terrible if we were all the same?’

That had come out all wrong.

What he had meant to say was: ‘I adore you exactly the way you are!’

However, from the smile on Maud’s face he got the general impression that regardless of what he had actually said, that was what she had heard spill from his lips.

He sighed.

He tried to read the papers while he waited for his hosts to make an appearance. He had arrived early at the plush boulevard café almost but not quite in the shadow of Notre Dame Cathedral— the great Gothic monument flattened by German artillery in the 1860s and still, in places, undergoing restoration to its former glory over a century later— taking an inside table due to the cool breeze threatening rain sweeping up the Seine.

Like all newspaper men he was an avid consumer of newsprint. Practically every major daily newspaper printed in the World had a Paris edition produced in an English, German or French translation, and he had worked his way through half-a-dozen papers that morning.

He had not realised that the Germans and the Russians, traditional enemies, had been so hugger-mugger of late. Apparently, Crown Prince Frederick had just got back to Berlin from a State Visit to Moscow. The son of the German Emperor was reputedly a huge fan of Wagner, Tchaikovsky and the Opera— and of loud music in general, and the Tsar had taken Frederick and his wife, Kristina, a placid Danish princess with a smile fit to melt an ogre’s heart, to the ballet before he and his new friend ‘Freddy’— a second cousin, all the royal families of Europe were variously inbred— off to play toy soldiers.

It seemed the Russians were going to buy over a thousand warplanes from the concern of Messers BMK— the Berlin, Munich and Kassel

Aircraft Works°— in the next couple of years. Payment was to be made in oil, rather than specie, shipped directly from the Caucasus.

There had been fleet manoeuvres between the *Kaiserliche Marine* and the Russian Fleet in the Baltic and the Far East...

Okay, that sort of thing never got reported back in New York!

The Paris Stock Market was down again...

Breaking news in the *Times of Paris*: ‘Disturbances in the streets of Madrid for the second day running. Troops fired warning shots over the heads of *the mob* outside the Royal Palace of Aranjuez...’

Um...

It was a big ask expecting a New Englander to entertain so much as a scintilla of sympathy for the House of Hapsburg!

But even so...

The journalist sighed, put down his paper.

There was a jovial commotion at the door to the café signifying that Albert Stanton’s suitors had arrived!

Chapter 11

Saturday 18th March

Sierra de Guadarrama, North of Madrid

The two old cars had rumbled and jolted over narrow twisting mountain roads and then tracks before finding still more precipitous, barely maintained, ribbons of crumbling, ice-ruptured tarmac still deeper into the high country most of the day before finally giving up the unequal struggle and discharging Don Rafael, a pair of young toughs hefting hunting rifles and the two women in a narrow canyon leading still higher between grey, sun-dappled looming peaks.

They watched the vehicles coughing and wheezing away and then, at Don Rafael's signal began to march, wearily— well, Henrietta and Melody, at least— into the rubble-field of fallen rocks and alpine-type shrubs— which almost immediately hid them from the dusty track the cars had, with no little difficulty, just traversed.

After perhaps, thirty minutes— although it seemed like hours to the exhausted women— the group halted to rest beneath an outcrop of granite. The three men were all carrying heavy packs, from which canteens of brackish water, biscuits and dried fruit were forthcoming.

“We ought to be carrying our share of the load,” Melody remarked, pointing at the over-burdened rucksacks.

The younger men thought this was hugely amusing.

Don Rafael, who seemed the freshest of them all despite his years, shook his head and grimaced whimsically.

“My Lord would never allow of that,” he retorted gently, proudly, in that marvellous intonation of pure old-fashioned Castilian which Melody had decided as a teenage girl had the capacity to make the best love poetry of that ancient language so exquisitely... erotic. “I am honoured in my duty to you both,” Don Rafael continued. “It is the greatest tribute that My Lord could bestow upon me, and,” he eyed the two younger men, “my sons.”

Melody felt very silly, and not a little unworthy.

“Besides,” the man guffawed softly, “if the worst happens you Ladies must run like the very wind. That is not a thing to be done with a soldier's

baggage upon your fair backs!”

Don Rafael’s sons chuckled, the women smiled and blushed.

“Where are you taking us, Don Rafael?” Henrietta asked quietly.

“A place that has been in the debt of the House of Medina Sidonia for a hundred years...”

Melody raised an eyebrow.

“Won’t the authorities, or whoever is looking for us,” she had worked out a lot of things as the journey had progressed. She was, after all, a professional detective and therefore, deductive reasoning was what she had been doing for a living for many years now. “Head straight for Ducal houses and lands?”

“Yes. And no. Remember, Señora Danson, that this is Spain,” Don Rafael re-joined. “There are places that are barred even to the Inquisition.”

Melody absorbed this.

“Okay, so you’re not going to tell us where we are going?”

“Regretfully, no,” the man apologised. “However, from the moment we arrive you must cease to be Lady Henrietta De L’Isle and Special Emissary Melody Danson. I respectfully suggest you become Señorita Marija,” he put to Henrietta, “and perhaps, Señorita Carmen.”

“Okay...”

“Actually, the names do not matter it is just that you cannot be who you are while you are *en santuario*.”

In sanctuary...

Melody threw a glance at Henrietta which in other circumstances might have been mischievous.

“I might have been wrong about what I said about being a nun,” she observed ruefully.

“A nun?” Don Rafael echoed, shaking his head. “No, that is not our intention although much will be at the discretion of the Mother Superior, a most redoubtable woman...”

The man thought his thoughts for several seconds.

“Please, I mean nothing that I say now with malice. I am an old man who has had my day, I have seen many things and witnessed things better not witnessed, but I must speak without dissembling to you both, My Ladies.”

Henrietta did not think that sounded like good news but then she and Melody were, apparently, fugitives on the run for their very lives so it was

hard to tell what exactly constituted good news on a day like this.

She opened her mouth to speak only to think better of it when Melody shook her head. That was spooky the way Melody could read her...

"Your names *en santuario* mean little because those into whose hands I shall be entrusting you think you to be," Don Rafael hesitated, distaste twisting at the corners of his mouth, 'women of the lowest kind. Harlots, or rather, courtesans fleeing from the troubles in Madrid, Segovia and Toledo. The majority of your custodians will assume that you are favourites of my master..."

"I suppose being a mistress is better than being a whore," Melody decided dryly.

"Inevitably, it may be that your custodians will treat you with little dignity. They will almost certainly require you to serve penance. I apologise in advance but..."

Melody shrugged.

"If we're going to do this thing it has to be done properly."

Okay, Don Rafael planned to hide them in more or less plain sight and if that was going to work it was going to have to look as good as they could make it look.

"I believe you speak French, My Ladies?" Don Rafael checked.

"Yes," Henrietta confirmed. "And other languages..."

"French will suffice. I advise you to affect to be hard of hearing or unfamiliar with any Spanish tongue, except perhaps, Catalan because French 'ladies' who find their way into the Royal Courts of Madrid often previously frequented the, er, fleshpots of Barcelona and the towns close to the border..."

"So, we're high-class girls from Paris?" Melody inquired, rhetorically.

"Yes, just so, My Lady."

"What sort of penance, Don Rafael?" Henrietta inquired.

Melody smiled philosophically: "We shall find out soon enough, Hen."

They walked, stumbled, groped up the canyon and then hiked across a grassy, otherwise barren rocky plain for some miles before with nightfall the men erected a low canvas awning and laid blankets on the ground for the two women before the group settled to sip from their half-drained canteens and munch more biscuits and dried fruit.

Returning from relieving herself behind some rocks Melody discovered Don Rafael's sons were nowhere to be seen.

“There are only two paths by which our enemies can approach this place unseen,” the old man explained phlegmatically. “My boys watch each.” Involuntarily, he glanced to the sky which was dark and cold all the way to the stars filling the heavens. “I was afraid we might be hiding all day long from eyes in the sky. Perhaps, the Air Force is not involved in the coup.”

Melody had a hundred questions.

The old man shook his head.

“I know very little other than that my Duke’s sword stands at the service of his Queen in Aranjuez. I know that there is fighting in Madrid, that probably the Army is behind the conspirators, and that the Inquisition must be involved. It is involved in all things in Spain, therefore it must be at the heart of this thing, whatever it is. Because this is Spain, to be a foreigner caught outside ‘protected’, or diplomatic grounds, will be a dangerous thing particularly for those associated with whoever loses this contest for the soul of my country. That is all I know. All that I would swear to, My Lady.”

“I am no lady, Don Rafael,” Melody smiled. “I am a lawyer turned detective turned spy, none of those things make me ‘a lady’.”

Amusement glinted in the old man’s eyes by moonlight.

There was no question of lighting a fire despite the ever-more biting fingers of the cold up here over four thousand feet above sea level.

Henrietta and Melody had collected up all the blankets they could find, tempted to huddle together but inhibited by the presence of their protector.

“Forgive me,” Don Rafael chuckled. “I make no judgement, you understand. My Lady De L’Isle is of an ancient and honourable family. While you,” he met Melody’s curious gaze, “are in My Lord’s regard, every inch as much ‘a lady’ as any of those fine ‘ladies’ who are the bane of his life in Madrid.” He grinned, shook his head and added: “My Lady.”

The old man sighed and looked to the nearby awning.

“You should try to sleep. We have a long way to walk tomorrow. You will be safe, I shall be nearby.”

The women clung together for warmth as the unyielding lumps and bumps in the ground beneath them dug into them. Unfortunately, not being able to ever be entirely comfortable was only a minor distraction from the cold which quickly got into their feet and began to attack their every extremity.

“I hate being dirty,” Henrietta confessed. “And being cold.”

Melody shivered, kissed the younger woman's nose.

This, she knew, was going to get a lot worse before it got better but tonight, she would spare her lover that 'little insight' into the depth of the big black bottomless pit into which they had unknowingly plunged.

Chapter 12

Sunday 19th March

Idlewild Beach Field, Long Island

Major Alexander Lincoln Fielding walked cursorily around his Gloucester Goshawk Mark II radial-engined low-wing monoplane scout with the relaxed air of a man without a worry in the world. He kicked at the big undercarriage tyres, patted the lowest of the three wicked blades of the machine's huge propeller and unhurriedly chatted with the veteran Sergeant fitter in command of the crew that kept his personal warhorse in tip top fighting trim.

The Goshawk had been cutting edge technology when it first took to the skies over a decade ago; it was still a formidable beast even though the coming generation of jet scouts would soon render it, and every other prop-powered 'puller' or 'pusher' obsolete. Notwithstanding, capable of around three hundred and fifty miles an hour in level flight with a 0.8-inch cannon and a brace of 0.5-inch machine guns in each wing, all the way up to twenty thousand feet it was the equal of anything the Spanish had down on the Border. True, it was a real beast to fly and when it first came into service it had acquired an evil reputation as a 'sprog killer' but modifications to the Mark II had since taken the sting out of the Goshawk's unforgiving low-speed – that is, take-off and particularly, landing – characteristics and consequently, accidents were a lot less frequent these days.

On the down side it took two or three times as long to train a man to safely fly, let alone fight, a Goshawk in comparison to the old Bristol biplanes Alex had flown the first time he served down in the South West.

This morning the commander of No 7 (New York) Squadron of the Colonial Air Force was still chewing over the news that he and his boys were likely to be posted down to St Augustine in Florida, not West Texas or Alta California. Moreover, he had no idea what to make of the additional news that 'the Squadron might be required to conduct affiliation drills with the Navy down there!'

It seemed that Headquarters had no real feel for how 'hot' or 'cold' the situation actually was down south or in the South West. In fact, there was a

suggestion that the current ‘tension’ was simply more of the ‘usual nonsense’ that flares up when the Spanish screw up on Santo Domingo, Cuba or in Mexico City!

Alex was no historian, and ‘geopolitics’ was just a word to him but from what he was reading in the papers and what he had seen of the preparations being made on Long Island – parts of which resembled a military camp – by the Army, the sudden urgency with which the Air Force was looking to get things done, and the number of big grey warships he saw exercising in Nantucket Sound and the approaches to the Lower Bay, he was starting to get the distinct impression that ‘something’ had to give, sooner or later.

That said, nobody would tell him when his Squadron was likely to get its movement orders. It was as if the big wigs had not made up their minds what to worry about first!

Not that he was complaining.

He got to spend lots of time with his very pregnant, somewhat cranky, utterly bewitching and forever delicious wife, and in the last month or so he was beginning to feel as if he was knocking his old timers’ heads together and bringing his ‘newbies’ up to speed. That his experienced men were starting to do things his way and that his ‘sprogs’ had now graduated to being combat-green ‘newbies’ was real progress. If he got a few more weeks grace he was going to have a top line squadron behind him if and or when he led his merry men into battle.

The other thing all the delays and changes of plan had achieved was to bring 7(NY) up to full strength. A CAF Scout – *Interceptor* seemed to be the latest terminology but Alex was old school – Squadron had a ‘book roster’ of eighteen aircraft and twenty-six pilots, enabling damned nearly continuous operations over short periods by two flights of six aircraft each, or squadron sorties by at least a dozen machines. Not that it had ever actually worked out that way in any of his tours down on the Border; nevertheless, it transpired that since he had been away, five or six years without a major flare-up with New Spain had allowed the CAF to build up its fighting strength, phase out all the older types – like the Bristol VIs, VIIIs and IXs – and replace them with aircraft like the Goshawk and other more modern high-performance attack and bomber aircraft.

Alex elected not to contemplate the logical corollary to this: namely, that the Spanish, presumably surreptitiously aided and abetted by agents of

the German Empire would also have used the intervening years to ‘make and mend’ on their side of the Border.

As any pilot will tell you ‘things can always get worse’ so there was not really much point worrying about it in the meantime!

One thing which had not changed from his earlier sojourns in the military was the rent-a-mob gang of scruffy ‘peaceniks’ who sometimes gathered outside the gates of the bigger military bases. From what Abe had told him the problem down in Virginia was with the *Getrennte Entwicklung* crowd. Those people did not mind about warmongering they just did not like ‘others’, particularly native Americans or the coloured descendants of the slaves brought to New England by *their* forefathers!

Up here in the ‘middle colonies’ the protestors, demonstrators, whatever, were often student dropouts, draft dodgers and poor rich kids. His late father used to crow about the minor acts of vandalism he and his cronies had carried out in ‘the good old days’, like that was something to be proud of! Since the Empire Day atrocities there had been a rash of attacks against men and women in uniform, usually when they had been out drinking on the town, less frequently bricks and stones had been thrown at servicemen’s houses or cars, and their families abused on the street by foul-mouthed youths. Back in the day nobody in uniform would have even thought about carrying a firearm while off base, nowadays, it was becoming de rigor, which Alex thought was a really sad comment on civil society in the First Thirteen.

Satisfied that there was no vital component of his Goshawk unscrewed, damaged or otherwise lying on the ground underneath the aircraft, Alex stepped up onto the port wing root and held his arm aloft signalling to the other five pilots of the training flight to mount up.

He scrawled his initials on Flight Form 100, officially transferring the aircraft— Serial 7114S— from the hands of his ground crew into his charge, and waited patiently while his straps were adjusted. He tried to get comfortable in his seat; not an easy thing when a man was sitting on his parachute pack.

In the big picture his passing discomfort was a blessing in disguise. Goshawks had been built to be flown by six-feet-six-inch tall muscular athletes— by men with the physique of a mature male gorilla— not fellows of average height with a musculature to match so the couple of inches of ‘seated height’ he got from perching on his chute gave him a much taller

man's visibility out of the cockpit, if not the longer legs ideally required to fly a Mark I. Fortunately, the Mark II had moved all the levers, pedals, buttons and switches that little bit closer to the pilot, as if in silent acknowledgement of the fact so many low-speed accidents were probably caused by a man's foot slipping off a pedal or his not quite being able to reach a vital toggle in time.

The brainier types on the CAF Staff was speculating about something called 'fly by wire' whereby servos and hydraulics controlled by something called a 'central processing unit' which was completely separated physically from the actual flying controls, moved the flaps, ailerons and rudder and kept the aircraft in perfect trim all the time, thereby allowing the pilot to throw a bird all over the sky with a minimum of muscle-power and a much-reduced risk of inadvertently getting himself killed. That sounded literally like 'pie in the sky' to Alex.

Everything on a Goshawk was directly connected to something in the cockpit, every control surface and throttle adjustment was controlled one hundred percent directly by the pilot's hand and feet. That could be challenging sometimes, like for example trying to persuade the aircraft to pull out of a steep dive...

He waved away the battery cart as soon as the big Derby-Royce 1,350 horse-power radial ran smoothly. The Goshawk was a tail-dragger like earlier biplanes which meant one had to look out of the side of the cockpit to see where one was going until the bird was up to speed. Alex had no idea what was fifty to a hundred yards in front of him as the chocks were pulled away.

One last look at the wind cock in the near distance.

Brakes off.

A blast of throttle and the scout lurched forward.

Over to his left construction teams were building a three-mile long runway. Whatever needed a runway that long was going to be worth seeing!

The Goshawk picked up speed.

With little more than a threat to touch the brakes the tail came up and suddenly he could see where he was going, albeit through the great blur of the auto-speed propeller.

More bumps, the machine wanted to leap into the air.

More throttle.

Then the fighter was free of the ground climbing like she was hitching a lift on an express elevator to the clouds ten thousand feet above New York's Lower Bay.

A check in his mirrors, stupidly tiny little things that it took a man forever to get used to; followed by a veteran scout pilot's neck roll to see as much as possible of what was around him and over behind his shoulders.

Where the fuck are the other kites?

He touched the speak button on his throat mike.

"BLUE LEADER TO CHILDREN!" He drawled laconically. "DOES EVERYBODY STILL HAVE ME IN SIGHT, OVER!"

The others obediently checked in.

Apparently, the ground controller had held back the last two Goshawks because the control tower had warned him a big transport was incoming. As per protocol he had acquired a visual— 'a sighting' in layman's terms— on the distant transatlantic shuttle, before clearing the last two scouts to take-off.

Circling over Hell's Gate Alex had awaited his missing 'children' before leading the flight east along the coast of Long Island. Today, ABLE Section would dogfight with BAKER Section over Long Island Sound midway between Bridgeport on the Connecticut northern shore and Smithtown Bay on the opposite, southern coast, and later over the Shinnecock Hills, because Leonora deserved only the best entertainment her colony could serve up.

First, he planned to slew off three aircraft as 'singletons', just to see if his newbies were up to navigating to the dogfight on their own. How a fellow performed in a fight was a moot point until he learned how to find his way to it!

Chapter 13

*Sunday 19th March
Royal Navy Norfolk, Virginia*

The Governor of New England had been able to report to the Prime Minister that morning by transatlantic telephone on a link scrambled at both ends – a thing he could easily believe given the appalling quality of the line – that there had been no new significant developments in the Gulf of Spain, Florida or in the Border lands of the South West in the previous twenty-four hours. However, that had been the beginning and the end of the good news communicated between the two men that morning.

It seemed that the Foreign Secretary had travelled to Paris to speak to the German Minister and his Portuguese counterparts. The Kaiser's Chancellor, a wily Rhinelander who as his Emperor's surrogate had largely been responsible for the renewed squabble over *Germany's legitimate unresolved colonial prerogatives* – the settlement of which had been piggy-backed onto the subsequent seemingly unrelated Submarine Treaty over ten years ago, probably narrowly averting the risk of a general war – had vetoed any censure or intervention in Old Spain by the Great Powers under the remit of the Treaty of Paris protocols.

This suited Berlin but nobody else: Spain might be the sick man of Europe but its ongoing existence – sick or not – as an independent, unaligned polity with an avowed policy of neutrality between the British and the German Empires had, in hindsight, been the one thing which had kept Anglo-German rivalries in check for decades.

It was also the determining factor in successive British Governments turning a blind eye to German interference in the affairs of New Granada, which Berlin had always regarded as a counterweight to British power in North America. Diplomacy was all about checks and balances, uncertainty by design, so that nobody could ever be wholly confident that they would win a future war.

To the Germans the presence of significant British forces in France – at any one time between 120,000 and 150,000 personnel – had become an itch they could not scratch, and year on year the economic and cultural

renaissance of the French°— the vanquished enemy of 1866°— simply added insult to injury. A few colonial scraps from the British table; surrendered or passed over on ‘protectorate’ terms in Africa, the West Indies and the Chinese Far East in 1966 had failed to sate the Kaiser’s appetite for the Reich, and singularly failed to acknowledge the German Empire’s status as a global titan.

Now Spain appeared to be dissolving into civil war and even if one discounted the most gratuitous tales of the blood-letting going on in some of the big cities, of Army and Navy units in open rebellion fighting for different sides and the blood-curdling prognostications of the Catholic Church and its Inquisition, it was plain that the situation was completely out of hand.

Still, in extremis, the least an imperial pro-consul could do was to exhibit the stiffest of stiff upper lips which was exactly what Philip De L’Isle the Governor of the Commonwealth of New England planned to do that morning.

There had been no news overnight from Spain about his daughter, and he was not the sort of man who treated no news as good news when the principal object of his concern was pretty much the light of his and his dear wife’s life these days. He liked to think he loved, and had treated all his offspring fairly, equally with the devotion and care that they were due but Henrietta had always been different. Perhaps, it was because she was the youngest, born around the time that his wife, Diana, had first been diagnosed with the early symptoms of the rheumatoid arthritis which had so cruelly blighted her days these last few years.

Henrietta had been their last, not accidental although certainly unplanned child and they had forever cherished and protected her in ways her elder brothers and sisters had probably occasionally resented, possibly misunderstood because in retrospect they had never been quite as close to the others as they had been, briefly with Hen, especially since she returned from University in England three years ago.

It sounded so sentimental, so gushing when put that way; it was no less the truth for that. There was something special about their daughter that he and his wife had nurtured, wondering how that vital spark might express itself in later life. Now their precious treasure might already be dead, or in the murderous hands of some madman inquisitor...

The Royal Marine Band of the Atlantic Fleet struck up the first notes of God Save the King, rescuing De L'Isle from his darkest fears.

But for his presence the dockside church parade would have long been over and done with and the crew of HMS Achilles would have been getting on with its duties. Instead, over five hundred officers and men were still standing in the bloody rain!

Just to honour him...

He hoped to be able to board the cruiser and wish her Captain, Francis Jackson, a man he had first met nearly forty years ago leading a contingent of Naval Volunteers in Alexandria in a short, sharp, bloody little action that no historian would remember in fifty years' time. Their paths had crossed a dozen or more times over the years and their wives were regular correspondents. He had made a point of commending the C-in-C Atlantic Fleet on the Navy's 'style' in so ordering affairs that his old friend might conclude his career flying his own flag in command of the Jamaica Station.

'If Francis hadn't been having such a jolly good time at sea, he could have been First Sea Lord just like his old mater!' Admiral Lord Collingwood had retorted.

Jackson had spent most of the last twenty years in command of ships the Lords of Admiralty considered otherwise 'problematic', specifically, vessels often serving on foreign stations with a history of poor morale or low efficiency. In this respect Achilles was a notable exception, re-commissioned eighteen months ago, after a major refit with a new crew by Francis Jackson. Without exception, Jackson had earned a reputation as the best man in the Fleet to 'turn around' any ship. To be rewarded with his commodore's pennant upon the day Achilles docked in Kingston, Jamaica, was the least a grateful service could do to reward him.

The C-in-C had had a covered saluting platform erected when the weather had turned bad; De L'Isle had led his grumbling entourage out of it onto the wet concrete of the dockside when the rain had set in. The King might occasionally avoid the weather when he was with Queen Eleanor, Bertie worried terribly—albeit with very little real cause—about his wife's constitution, but Philip Sidney had no intention hiding away in the dry when so many good men were getting a soaking just *because* he was there!

His aide-de-camp, a nephew of Sir George Walpole, quickly took his dripping coat and hat as soon as the party retired into the sheltered warmth of the Operations Complex.

Lord Collingwood and Rear Admiral Sir Anthony Parkinson, Flag Officer, Task Force 5.1, had been deep in conversation when the Governor arrived. De L'Isle had not had the opportunity to renew acquaintance with Parkinson in the weeks since his appointment in January.

Task Force 5.1 had been created as part of the Royal Navy's root and branch battlefleet re-organisation necessitated by the commissioning of the new Ulysses class of fleet carriers.

The days of the line of battle were numbered.

Going forward, instead of 'battle fleets' there would be 'task forces' assigned to specific roles in peace and in war. Henceforth, the 'task' would determine the 'composition' of each 'force'.

Parkinson flew his flag on HMS Princess Royal, one of the fifty thousand-ton battleships attacked on Empire Day 1976. Together with the new fleet carrier Ulysses, two heavy and two light cruisers, half-a-dozen destroyers and a fleet train of auxiliaries, Task Force 5.1 was focused not around the guns of the Princess Royal and the cruisers but the seventy to eighty aircraft and in due course, up to eight helicopters, carried by the Ulysses.

The coming of the new generation of big— forty thousand ton plus nearly one thousand feet long— carriers had prompted the most radical re-think of the tactics of naval warfare for a generation. In the mid-years of the century the introduction of ELDAR and of new long-range communication technologies had revised the calculus of global fleet operations; now, the advent of the new, so-called 'strike carriers' meant that future battles could be fought at ranges of hundreds of miles. The Fleet's reach was no longer determined by the effective range of its biggest guns— around twenty-five miles— but by the range of its seaborne Combat Air Wing (CAW).

Task Force 5.2 was presently forming, working up to combat worthiness, around the Princess Royal's sister ship HMS Tiger and the second of the Brooklyn-built Ulysses class ships, HMS Perseus, while in British waters the Home Fleet would soon be forming the first three of five such Task Force's with one Canadian, and two Scottish-built Ulysses class ships.

Inevitably, when last year the Admiralty had proposed to de-commission and to place in reserve as many as five, six or seven of the older battleships and battlecruisers— nearly a quarter of the big gun battle

fleet – to crew the giant, manpower hungry carriers, there had been an unholy storm of protest.

The wind of change often blew cold...

Philip De L'Isle was unlikely to have been the only colonial governor who wondered how the commissioning of the new carriers and the radical re-design of the Royal Navy's age-old Fighting Instructions and deployments would be received in Germany, whose admirals had doggedly resisted the latent, now very real, possibilities of naval air power because they well understood that their aging, ailing Kaiser – and more importantly, his rambunctious son Prince Frederick – was a confirmed 'big gun man'.

The Governor stood over the situation table of the New England, and the Jamaica and Gulf of Spain Stations with the two admirals, each man nursing a cup and saucer in his hands. If Englishmen abroad ever started to neglect the proprieties, the Empire would surely fall and more important, in times of trial there was nothing quite so guaranteed to sooth a fevered brow than a nice cup of tea taken in convivial company.

"I'm worried about our dispositions in the Caribbean," Lord Collingwood admitted. "Achilles is a damned good ship but when all is said and done a single light cruiser armed with eight 6-inch guns is really here nor there in the bigger picture. All this loose talk about the Germans pushing the Spanish in Cuba, Santo Domingo and New Granada into declaring some kind of *Triple Alliance* gives me pause. I'm damned if I know how that would work in practice but if it did, at any level, with von Reuter's ships in the region it might well embolden the hotheads in Havana, Port au Prince and in Mexico City. If that happens my ships down there on the Jamaica Station will suddenly be out on a limb!"

The C-in-C had in mind the modern cruisers of the so-called Vera Cruz Squadron of the *Kaiserliche Marine*, supposedly on an extended 'good will' cruise in the Caribbean and the South Atlantic was, to put it mildly, a loose cannon which now skewed every debate about naval policy south of the Gulf of Spain, which was presently through to be exercising with units of the *Armadas* of both Cuba and New Granada.

Fifty-five-year-old David Cuthbert Horatio, 9th Baron Collingwood was the direct descendent of the great admiral of the French Wars of the latter eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, the man who had smashed a Franco-French Fleet nearly twice the size of his own at the Battle of the Channel after that other legendary hero of the period, Admiral Lord

Nelson's flagship, the *Temeraire*, had suddenly blown up early in the action. Uncannily, people who cared to study, even momentarily, portraits of the 1st Baron invariably remarked upon the fact that he was the spitting image of his illustrious ancestor.

Like his illustrious forbearer he was also famous for his dour, no nonsense, methodically cautious approach to his duties. His peers called him the 'Navy's voice of common sense', implacably unswayable when he had decided that the good of the Navy demanded a certain course of action. Oddly, it was this very trait which had allowed him, a career gunnery specialist, to appreciate much earlier than many of his contemporaries that the days of the big gun ship of the battle line, were numbered. In fact, he had been the man who, as Director of Naval Planning, had written the key directive cancelling the construction of four new 'super' *Vanguards* – the latest most formidable, fifty thousand ton-plus battleships – and placing, some six years ago, the orders for the first *Ulysses* class aircraft carriers; having spent the previous four years of his time as DNP fighting a bitter, thankless battle against the 'battleship' men who still, truth be known, were under the mistaken impression that they dominated the Board of Admiralty.

So, when he said he was worried about something it was usually as well to take note.

"Indomitable is at New Orleans," Collingwood reminded the Governor of New England. "Invincible is about to come out of dry dock at Halifax after a routine period out of the water; I have drawn up provisional orders for her to steam south to the St John's River anchorage in Florida. She can work up to full fighting trim down there. HMS *Lion*, as you know is undergoing a major refit and partial modernisation in Nova Scotia which is not due to complete until this coming autumn. The *Queen Mary* is currently based in Vancouver, at some stage thought may have to be given to reinforcing her squadron, especially, if the Russians start sabre rattling from their bases farther up the coast."

Actually, 'farther up the coast' was Novo-Archangelsk – New Archangel – the capital of the Russian province of *Russkaya Amerika*, a huge almost entirely uninhabited tract of land in the north-western extremity of the continent which included the Aleutian Islands, the base of the Tsar's Eastern Pacific Fleet. Other than at Novo-Archangelsk the only other significant 'Russo-European' settlements of any size were on Kodiak

and Unalaska Islands, both garrisoned by Russian troops and the home to small naval flotillas.

“I think we can defer decisions on that score a little while yet,” Philip De L’Isle suggested wryly.

The C-in-C of Atlantic Fleet guffawed.

“True, whatever happens we’re hardly likely to be at odds with both the Kaiser and the Tsar at the same time.” Cuthbert Collingwood re-focused on more immediate matters. “Our only other available capital ship, Indefatigable, was to return to England in the coming months to pay off into the Reserve Fleet. As you know, she has been operating as Atlantic Fleet’s combined seagoing Gunnery School and Midshipmen’s ‘cruise ship’. At this time, she is perhaps, somewhat less than fifty percent operational. Her aft main battery is, effectively, de-activated and her electronics suite is minimal, stripped back to her 1950s rig. In her present state, even von Reuter’s cruisers might give the old girl a severe handling.”

Rear Admiral Parkinson grunted his displeasure at this juncture.

“If they came upon her unescorted, they’d *mob her under* in the most likely scenarios I can foresee,” he remarked.

The Governor of New England thought that sort of ‘scenario’ was straight out of a bad dream. That said, the one thing practically everybody agreed was that whatever the Germans were up to, sending a powerful cruiser squadron to the Caribbean under the command of Rear Admiral Edwin von Reuter, a favourite of the Kaiser and a close friend of Crown Prince Frederick – they had been naval cadets together at Kiel in their youth – no ship flying a German flag was going to deliberately fire on a British ship.

Because, if that happened there would be another general war...

No, the question at the moment was how big the ‘small war’ in the Caribbean and the borderlands of the South West was going to be? Or at least, De L’Isle hoped that was still *the question*.

If it was not, they were all in big trouble.

Collingwood was still unhurriedly contemplating his subordinate’s remark about the capabilities of the *Kaiserliche Marine* cruisers in the Caribbean, presently thought to be visiting the port of Vera Cruz, thankfully some fifteen hundred miles – some four to five days cruising time – from Jamaica, by dint of its proximity to Cuba and Santo Domingo effectively

cut off from direct support from the north, the least defensible of all the Empire's major Caribbean colonies.

"Two heavy cruisers, three light cruisers and a pack of destroyers would," he conceded ruminatively, "be a bit of a handful for Indefatigable. If we sent her back to sea in earnest she'd be in company with escorts of her own, mind you. I'm sure they'd have something to say about the issue, Tony."

"I'm sure things won't come to that, sir," Parkinson decided.

Even with two of its four modern fast battleships unavailable for operations in the Gulf of Spain-Caribbean theatre of operations and discounting Indefatigable, that still left the two Lion class ships and the two Indomitable class battlecruisers, each vessel boasting a main battery of eight 15-inch guns 'in play'. Including the anti-aircraft cruiser Cassandra, the present Jamaica Station guardship and Achilles, soon to join her at Kingston, the C-in-C had eleven operational cruisers— five heavy and six light— several others which could be rushed back into service in short order if necessary, over fifty fleet destroyers and trade route protection frigates and corvettes, not to mention about two hundred other vessels, everything from tugs to fast motor gunboats to ammunition ships and fleet oilers with which to counter any threat posed by Spanish colonial naval forces.

Moreover, this accounting did not take account of the two new aircraft carriers joining the fleet: Ulysses, within days of being declared fully operational, and Perseus possibly only weeks behind her, albeit probably joining the fleet with a much smaller air group than the name ship of her class.

The problematic availability of 'carrier-adapted' modern aircraft and the crying shortage of qualified naval aviators was another matter altogether, one nobody seemed to have thought about until the two carriers were undergoing trials when, obviously, it was far too late to do much about it this side of the coming six to twelve months.

But for the present crisis the 'air group' question— which had been 'parked' temporarily by the decision to fully crew Ulysses and then 'make and mend' to get Perseus to sea— would never have raised its ugly head. It was no comfort to know that the Home Fleet was having similar problems putting together the CAWs for its newly commissioned carriers. The right aircraft had been ordered and the training programs to supply the necessary

flow of 'deck qualified' aviators had been launched as long ago as last autumn; unfortunately, nobody in the Navy had been told that the politicians were going to let the international situation get out of hand so damned fast!

If this or any other vexation was presently costing Lord Collingwood to lose sleep there was little in his calm, unruffled demeanour to betray it. If nothing else a career in the Navy inured a man to setbacks and frustrations; a captain at sea often had to choose between the lesser of two evils so it paid to be mindful of what remained on the credit side of the ledger regardless of the down side of the naval balance sheet.

On paper, and in reality, he knew that the Atlantic Fleet remained nothing less than formidable, of itself the equal of any other Navy on the planet with the obvious exception of the Kaiser's High Seas Fleet, and the rapidly modernising Imperial Japanese Navy. The Spanish colonies in the Americas had no centralised command system, no modern battleships, no aircraft carriers, an antique collection of ironclads, a dozen variously modern cruisers but perhaps as many as thirty or forty notionally operational destroyers and frigates of varying vintages and utility.

"If this goes badly," Rear Admiral Parkinson observed, daring to mention the dog in the manger which had be-devilled planning. The big unknown was the quality of enemy *air*. "Frankly, nobody seems to have the remotest idea whether the Spanish, be it on Santo Domingo, Cuba, or New Spain or in Colombia or Venezuela, are capable of projecting meaningful air power over any or all of the Caribbean or the Gulf of Spain. Goodness, we don't even know if the beggars are capable of bombing southern Florida!"

What with one thing and another the presence of the modern German 'Vera Cruz Squadron' inconveniently muddled the tactical situation. In much the same way that a similar, more powerful German East Asia Squadron at Tsingtao, flying the flag of Rear Admiral Reinhard von Trotha in the battlecruiser Goeben, was complicating the strategic calculus in the Far East where, in comparison, the Royal Navy was spread somewhat thinly.

Other *Kaiserliche Marine* squadrons and flotillas, and a number of lone vessels were currently abroad conducting 'good will visits' and suchlike. There was nothing remotely unusual about this: the Kaiser was as enthusiastic about flag-waving as anybody. Some analysts speculated that

perhaps, one in four 'active' units in the Imperial Navy was presently engaged on such 'flag-waving' missions outside European waters. This was important because the last time there had been so many German warships 'showing the flag' in foreign parts had been at the height of the Submarine Crisis in the mid-1960s.

That had turned out all right in the end...

Collingwood stepped back into the conversation, electing to defer further, unprofitable discussion of the intentions of Edwin von Reuter's cruiser squadron, for another time.

"Achilles is going south with the latest covert electronic listening gear on board," he reported, for the Governor's information. "She may be able to answer one or two of the questions we have concerning, particularly, the Dominicans' electronic warfare capabilities along the north coast of Santo Domingo. Frankly, the thing which worries me at the moment is not if the Spanish come out looking for a rough-house fight with my ships but if they attempt to fight an asymmetric campaign of attrition."

Philip De L'Isle frowned, said nothing.

"For example," Collingwood continued, "the blighters could secretly mine shallow water channels in the Floridian Keys, or ports in the south, the entrance to the Mississippi Delta say. Or make sneak hit and run attacks using their fastest units against undefended or lightly-defended coastal targets in the Gulf or as far north as the Carolinas."

"Is that likely?"

Parkinson shrugged: "It is very hard to say, sir," he admitted. "But one has to try to visualise how they, knowing they are outgunned, might view things. If I was in my counterpart's place in Havana I'd seriously think about a range of well, basically, underhand options. One of which might be to convert several merchantmen into disguised commerce raiders..."

De L'Isle was lost now.

"Sorry, sir. If you'd bear with me," Parkinson apologised. "You'd take an ordinary motor ship, install as many heavy guns, torpedo tubes, too, on it and then hide everything away behind hinged hull panels and so forth. The idea being that you would creep up on one of our unsuspecting merchantmen, or even a small warship, probably swapping friendly, jovial signals and mega-phone hails all the way and then when the two ships were next to each other unmask one's guns..."

"Is that even legal?"

“Er, yes, sir. I’m afraid it is. We, er, vetoed resolutions at Paris a decade or so ago, which would have outlawed that kind of thing because we wanted to be able to legally employ so-called ‘decoy’ ships to sink submarines.”

“Submarines are banned,” the Governor of New England growled, eyes narrowing. “Are you telling me that the Spanish might have submarines too?”

The Commander-in-Chief of the Atlantic Fleet sighed.

“We don’t know, sir. If one discounts the normal rumours about the *Kaiserliche Marine* exercising covertly built submersibles in the Baltic, there are credible reports that the Cubans might have attempted to construct several small ‘submersibles’ in big sheds at their Guantanamo Bay shipbuilding facility but honestly and truly, we just don’t know what they were up to there or anywhere else.”

Philip De L’Isle would have despaired but that would never have done. So, instead, he thoughtfully sipped his tea.

ACT II – THE MADNESS OF PRINCES

Chapter 14

Sunday 19th March

Hotel Atlantique, Boulevard du Wellington, Paris

The news from Spain had fallen upon the city's diplomatic community like a tsunami that nobody had seen coming. Not that most Parisians or the thousands of British, German, Scandinavian and Mediterranean visitors to the cultural capital of western civilisation would have known it as they strolled the grand boulevards, or emerged from their religious observances in chapels, churches and cathedrals into the blissful spring sunshine.

Notwithstanding, the background burbling of radios followed one wherever one went. Suddenly, the news was closer to home, at the very borders of the country with the most sensitive and bloodily fought over borderlands on the planet. There remained an angst written into the souls of the French nation, an acknowledgement that the 'great peace' was not a thing within its sovereign control and that an equilibrium maintained for so long must, one day, come to an end. The Grand Alliance had brought not peace, rather an absence of war to an utterly shattered, broken country in 1866. A peace not unlike that the Romans had brought to Gaul two millennia ago. Although Tacitus had not been writing of the downfall of Vercingetorix before Julius Caesar's legions, all French school children learned of the ancient histories that were still achingly relevant to their modern situation.

Auferre, trucidare, rapere, falsis nominibus imperium; atque, ubi solitudinem faciunt, pacem appellant... To ravage, to slaughter, to usurp under false titles, they call empire; and where they make a desert, they call it peace...

That was what had happened to the French in the 1860s and what could happen once, could happen again...

Albert Stanton's business with the movie moguls had been surreal.

One gang had offered him an obscene amount of money, then another had done the same and later in the day a third, somewhat apologetic group had, shamefaced, submitted a bid for slightly less than either of the other two *production alliances*.

He had initialled heads of agreement with this third combine: they seemed to be the ones with their heads screwed on the right way around and had made no attempt to bamboozle him with legal jargon, movie double-speak or to ply him with vast quantities of stupidly expensive Champagne.

The ‘clinch’ for Stanton had been that the third ‘gang’ wanted to film the movie ‘on location’ in New England and that he – as Abe and Kate’s representative – would have the final say on the script.

It was probably too good to be true but as soon as he got home, he had planned to cash the cheque for £100,000 – a down payment on the £375,000 to be paid when filming commenced and a further payment of £325,000 when the movie opened simultaneously in the United Kingdom, New England and probably, throughout the Empire – he had in his pocket and hand over all the paperwork to the lawyers. A part of him still did not believe Abe and Kate – people back home did not get it that they had quite deliberately been married under tribal law first and that therefore, they were equals in their union in ways few ‘white’ men and women could even begin to understand in the First Thirteen – had foresworn his earnest advice to seek their own representation and to all intents, given him carte blanche to cut whatever deal he saw fit.

For all they knew, or cared, he could be robbing them blind!

It helped that neither of his friends – Abe and Kate were friends first and business associates a very distant second – attached any importance to money. For them their ‘story’ was already history and only the here and the now and what fate had in store for them really mattered. They just lived their life, enjoyed it, and each other, and so far as they were concerned that was as complicated as it needed to be.

Albert Stanton dropped the telephone onto its rests.

He swore silently.

The rumour was true!

The Spanish Embassy in Paris was not issuing entry visas or authorising any travel documents today. Further, the French-Spanish border was closed and nobody knew when it would re-open.

It was maddening!

He was less than a day’s travel from what might be the biggest story of the century and everybody, and he meant *everybody*, was pretending that nothing was going on in Madrid and that even if there was something going on, the Spanish were not going to let anybody go down there and report it.

Well, he would see about that!

The border was mountainous and he was no kind of outdoors, countryman. There were no flights to the south of France, it was Sunday, but the trains were still running down to the south coast. How hard could it be to bribe a fisherman or yachtsman from say, Narbonne, Montpellier or Perpignan to sneak him onto some Spanish beach in the middle of the night?

“Your taxi is here, sir,” a bellhop reported.

Stanton unconsciously tipped the kid a shilling. He had no idea if that was being cheapskate in this town and besides, his mind was elsewhere.

He had dashed off a telegram to Maud Daventry-Jones.

APOLOGIES. I WILL NOT BE ON THE TITANIC WHEN SHE DOCKS ON 27TH INSTANT. SOMETHING HAS COME UP. SPAIN. I WOULD BE NO KIND OF JOURNALIST IF I SAT ON MY HANDS WHILE THE STORY OF THE CENTURY IS HAPPENING A FEW HUNDRED MILES AWAY. I CANNOT WAIT TO SEE YOU AGAIN. WE HAVE SO MUCH TO DISCUSS. WITH ALL MY LOVE. ALBERT.

‘I am an idiot,’ he told himself as he had handed over the message form. There’s a beautiful girl waiting for me back in New York and I am heading off in the opposite direction towards what has the makings of a full-blown civil war.

Sunday, no banks open.

There were more delays while he had written a letter of authority to accompany the movie men’s cheque so it could be paid into the nearby branch of the Westminster Private Bank for transfer to his account in the Broad Street Branch of that banking house in Manhattan, all of which would take five to seven days.

Another telegram had flown across the North Atlantic to his Editor at the *Manhattan Globe*.

He was off to the wars and would file copy as and when he could.

Grabbing an armful of the latest papers off the stand at the Gare-de-Lyon Railway Terminal he threw his travelling bag, a ridiculously bulky over-sized hold-all— he had no idea what a war reporter was supposed to carry with him so he had stuffed in everything from borrowed binoculars to

plus fours and a pair of stout walking shoes— ahead of him and boarded the express service to Lyon. Some minutes later he found his reserved seat in the first-class compartment two coaches back from the thrumming diesel engine starting to drag the train out of the station.

The devastation of the Great War had permitted the rebuilding of the French railways system very nearly from scratch. Express routes were long straight drags with hardly a bend or even much of a curve in the permanent way for tens, sometimes scores of miles enabling trains to rocket along in excess of one hundred and twenty-five miles an hour.

If only the East Coast railroads of the First Thirteen had been constructed with such wisdom!

Soon, the train was roaring out of the Paris suburbs.

“Mind if I join you, old man,” a broad shouldered, athletic-looking man of about Stanton’s own age inquired pleasantly.

“By all means,” the journalist waved.

“How far south are you planning to go?” His companion inquired, making conversation.

Or, so it seemed.

“All the way, if I can.”

The newcomer chuckled. His eyes were grey, agate hard, belying the smile twitching at his lips.

“That makes two of us, then!”

Something in the way he said it engaged Albert Stanton’s reporter’s threat antennae.

“Oh...”

“You’re off to find a war, Mr Stanton,” the other man remarked, smiling a predatory smile, “and funnily enough, I’m on my way to join in the fun too.”

“How do you know my name?”

“It’s on the label on your baggage.”

“No, it’s not.”

“Oh, well, it ought to be. That’s how luggage gets to be lost, old man.”

Now that Stanton had had an opportunity to study his companion, he had worked out that this was not, under any circumstances, a man he wanted to embroil in a rough house.

“Paul Nash,” the stranger said, extending his hand to the New Englander.

Stanton shook the proffered hand. Then retrieved it pleasantly surprised the stranger had not crushed every bone in it, a thing he could clearly have done had he so wished.

“I can’t place your accent, friend?”

“I tend not to stay in one place overlong.”

Nash had only placed a single small attaché case into the overhead racks.

“I travel light as a rule.” He shook his head, a little amused. “I’m with the British Embassy in Madrid. We’re all on our best behaviour ‘in country’, the Spanish are a bit po-faced about our libertarian ways in the Old Country and New England. So, we escape across the border to enjoy the fleshpots and the too numerous to be listed right now, attractions of la belle France. How did *you* find the ‘entertainments’ available in Paris?”

Stanton coloured.

“I’m over here on business. Besides, I...”

“Ah, you’ve got a girl back home! Good for you!”

Stanton was rarely speechless.

He opened his mouth to snap a retort, thought better of it.

“She must be quite something if you’ve voluntarily foregone the pleasures of the City of Peace?”

“Yes,” the New England muttered.

“Especially,” the other man chuckled, “when the movie people you’ve been hob-knobbing with would have been picking up the tab every inch of the way!”

Albert Stanton just stared at Paul Nash.

“They won’t let you cross the border,” his very well-informed companion went on, cheerfully. “Our people, I mean. The French gendarmerie won’t either. The Spanish might shoot you, just for the Hell of it. But you’ve probably worked all that out for yourself. Presumably, you can afford to bribe somebody to drop you upon Catalonia’s middlingly rocky shores?”

“What’s your game?” Albert Stanton demanded angrily.

“No game,” the man who called himself Paul Nash growled, suddenly dropping the forced bonhomie. “I’m going to Spain looking for two women whose lives are probably, at this moment, in the sort of mortal peril I seriously doubt that you, cynical old scribbler that you are, can even imagine.”

The New Englander opened his mouth; no sound emerged.

He had never been so flummoxed in his whole life. Well, other than when Maud Daventry-Jones had gone out of her way the other night to make damned sure he kissed her flush on the mouth...

Paul Nash was silent.

Watchful, waiting, waiting...

"Two women," Stanton said eventually in a low, confidential murmur.

"Yes."

Now Albert Stanton waited. The train was rattling and rocking along, picking up speed almost like a runaway. The first time New Englanders travelled on a French Express they always thought they were on board a runaway...

"You are well-acquainted with one of the women, and know of the other," Nash declared. "The file I was given indicated you might have met her in passing. But that's by the way."

The *Manhattan Globe's* star investigative reporter had regained his composure. He was thinking straight again. The impatience playing in his green-grey eyes prompted a nod from the other man.

"For reasons beyond my ken," Paul Nash groaned, a scowl twisting at the corners of his mouth above a square jaw that jutted momentarily, "the powers that be elected to allow the two ladies to be put at risk. To wit, they ought to have been called home a month ago, but the idiots in London vetoed my recommendation. In fact, I had only just got back to Paris from Whitehall – where I'd received something of a telling off for carping on about the danger of what seems to have just happened in Spain, *happening* – when the news arrived that the balloon had gone up in Madrid."

Albert Stanton could only think of two women of his acquaintance, the one he had spoken to on a couple of occasions, the other, not really at all who so far as he knew might be in Spain at the moment.

"Are you talking about Melody Danson?" He inquired tentatively. "And perhaps, Lady Henrietta de L'Isle."

"I knew you'd get there in the end, old man! Obviously, the Official Secrets Act stops me naming names but as you've already mentioned them there's no reason we can't get down to business!"

"Business?"

“Yes, I need you to tell me absolutely everything you know about the two ladies. Absolutely everything. About them, their careers, education, antecedents, the colour of their eyes, their mannerisms, anything they are afraid of, *everything*.”

“I hardly know them...”

“You’re the *Manhattan Globe*’s man on the case! Nobody’s closer than you to several of the leading actors in the Empire Day affair. If you’re anywhere near as good at your job as people say you are, you’ll have had your ear so close to the ground for the last couple of years you know the *dramatis personae* better than their own mothers do!”

Stanton raised an eyebrow.

“What if I don’t want to tell you a damned thing?”

“Well, I suppose I could threaten to throw you out of the carriage somewhere between here and Lyon. But,” he held up a hand, “that’s normally the sort of thing I reserve for people who try to do me physical harm and I’ve not got you down as a homicidal maniac. So, if you were, hypothetically, to try to give me the *hear no evil see no evil, think no evil blind monkey number*, I’d probably just mark your card with the local gendarmerie in Lyon. Nothing malicious, you understand but I can guarantee that you’ll spend the next couple of months in a cell with a latrine bucket for company. The choice is yours but if you want to fly to Portugal with me to see what we can do to rescue our two damsels in distress, I’d suggest you start spilling the beans like your life depends upon it!”

Albert Stanton swallowed hard: “Presumably, because one day soon my life might depend on it?”

“Man-to-man,” Nash murmured, leaning closer, “yes, that’s about the size of it, my friend.”

Chapter 15

*Sunday 19th March
Royal Navy Norfolk, Virginia*

The thing that had really struck Kate Lincoln the first time she had stepped aboard HMS Achilles to, not without immense trepidation, attend a ‘family open day’ a month or so ago shortly after Abe had joined the cruiser, was that the great ship had seemed ‘alive’. Abe had explained away the illusion by saying that there was always machinery running, and at least one of the ship’s six boilers ‘lit’ which was why there was the constant low background rushing of the ‘blowers’ ventilating the bowels of the leviathan. It had never occurred to Kate that the Achilles was actually quite a small ship until she had seen two huge walls of steel, floating castles bigger than any man-made structure she had ever seen or imagined slowly cruise into Hampton Roads while she was aboard Achilles that magical afternoon in February.

‘The white man’s magic is powerful strong,’ Abe had whispered in her ear as the couple had stood on the rear end— the ‘quarterdeck’— of his ship watching the battleship HMS Princess Royal and the brand-new fleet aircraft carrier HMS Ulysses stately progress to their moorings out in the roads. A group of husbands and wives, friends and family members including any number of scampering, noisy children had surrounded the couple witnessing the leviathans anchor.

‘Captain Jackson likes to throw these parties every month,’ Abe had confided to his wife. ‘Achilles is a family ship. Besides, keeping everybody in touch with their families is good for morale and discipline, it keeps everybody’s feet firmly on the ground.’

Kate did not know about that!

For a month or so after her husband had donned his Navy blues she had very nearly swooned every time she laid eyes on him. He was so handsome...

The Captain had particularly asked to be introduced to Kate that afternoon last month. In fact, she had learned that he particularly asked to

be ‘properly introduced’ to each and every one of his men’s wives upon their initial introduction to the ship’s ‘family’.

‘I am honoured to present my wife, Tekonwenaharake, daughter of Tsiokwaris, sir.’

Captain the Honourable Francis Jackson had smiled indulgently, very much in the fashion of a proudly indulgent uncle, a question in his grey eyes.

‘Kate, sir,’ she had blurted, a bundle of nerves as the great man extended his hand in greeting, his smile ◦ – of the patriarchally kindly variety ◦ – slowly broadening all the while. ‘In my birth language my Mohawk name means,’ she had struggled with the words, scrunched up her face in momentary concentration, *‘travels through the wind...’*

Captain Jackson had chortled.

‘Which is exactly what your husband does all the time, dear lady!’

Kate had not thought about it that way until then, now she thought about it often. Life was full of circles within circles, experiences lived again and again in infinite variations.

‘What goes around comes around,’ was a saying she had heard several of her new Navy wife friends murmur. The society of the married quarters tended to be phlegmatic, practical, its optimism tempered by the knowledge that both good and sometimes bad, things happened at sea.

That day she and her son, Tom, and the other ‘Wardroom’ wives and their offspring had been bussed in for the ‘family day’ party. Now the ship was crowded with ‘civilians making the deck untidy’ but nobody minded about that because this time tomorrow Achilles would be gone.

Abe had bought an old atlas from a second-hand bookshop in the old town of Norfolk opposite the sprawling Portsmouth Naval Dockyards so that he could show Kate where he was headed.

It was a beautiful book with colourful relief maps of all the continents and a marvellous two-page spread of the Gulf of Spain and the Caribbean. Measuring the distance between Norfolk and Kingston, Jamaica she had discovered that it was around one thousand three hundred miles.

Abe had teased her about that.

‘Unfortunately, we can’t go straight there, we’d run aground half-a-dozen times!’

Other officers had greeted Kate with tiny nods of the head, shaken her hand as if she was made of glass, tried far too hard to make her feel

welcome and that had deeply touched her. Two men had actually apologised that she had had to pass by those ‘good for nothing GW idiots at the gates...’

Becoming a Navy wife had been an education, one she was still absorbing. Stepping on board the Achilles had been a rough and ready finishing class of sorts.

Those *Getrennte Entwicklung* ‘idiots’ at the gate pasted billboards around Norfolk protesting about the ‘polyglot’ scandal of the Royal Navy’s historic— well, near century-old explicitly mixed-race crewing practices— and yet standing in the crowd on the quarterdeck of HMS Achilles she was surrounded by many coloured faces and everybody seemed to be getting along just fine!

Basically, very few people in the Navy had a lot of time for the *GW idiots*, the majority of whom claimed ‘religious exemption’ from military service the moment colonial enrolment— ‘Draft Notices’— landed on their doormats.

Abe had taken their son in his arms as soon as she stepped aboard the ship, transparently eager not to waste a single second with him before he sailed away.

He had taken her forward to show her the aircraft he flew.

There were two flying machines atop the cruiser’s amidships catapult, both with bulbous floats like the Bristol seaplanes Abe had flown in Ontario. Below the boom of the heavy-duty crane which recovered returning aircraft and lowered the ship’s larger ‘small boats’ into the water, there was a third aircraft, almost but not quite identical to the seaplanes stowed high on the catapult rails.

Kate had stared at this flying machine not immediately knowing what was ‘wrong’ with it. Her husband had followed her gaze. He had laughed gently as their son gurgled with pleasure at being raised to his father’s shoulders.

The third Sea Fox had its wings folded inward along the length of its all-metal monocoque fuselage and seemed to have *lost* its floats...

Abe stepped closer and kicked at the nearest fixed undercarriage wheel.

“I only get to fly this one *off* the ship,” he grinned. “Well, me or one of the other fellows.”

He elected not to tell his wife that the ‘wheeled’ Sea Fox had had its single defensive machine gun removed, likewise its bomb racks and heavy cameras and once the ship was at sea two technicians from the Headquarters Electronic Warfare Division would go to work filling the rear cockpit with top secret equipment.

“We’ll fly her ashore as soon as we are in Jamaican waters,” Abe said, leaving it at that.

Since moving into married quarters Kate had made a point of dressing as her neighbours dressed, albeit she had soon become aware that she was, in comparison with many of her new friends, something of a make and mend obsessive. In the house she still wore a pair of comfortable moccasins, a gift from one of her aunts, otherwise she was a very ‘modern’ woman. That said she found the ‘lingerie’ her friends talked about fiddly and uncomfortable, and as for stockings and suspenders, that was just ridiculous and other than on the coldest of days—when she wore leggings or slacks under her calf-length frock or skirts—she preferred to go bare-legged. One day she hoped her feet would get used to the impractical half-heeled lightweight leather shoes that were all the rage in New England; but nobody minded her sticking to flat heels even though it emphasised that she was not the tallest of women.

Although spots of moisture still pattered on the deck the rain of the morning had passed over as the farewells began.

“Be safe, husband,” Kate asked. She had heard about his ‘close shave’ from one of the other wives. Everybody thought she was married to a daredevil! She patted his chest, bowed her head to rest her brow against him, hiding her face.

“That’s what I plan to do,” he promised, the words catching in his throat.

They hugged, kissed and then the family day was over with the women and children reluctantly disembarking as the cruiser’s five-man Royal Marine Band serenaded the departing guests.

Abe walked back to the ship, distractedly saluting the officer at the head of the gangway.

“Permission to come on board, sir?”

Sub-Lieutenant Ted Forest, unmarried and presently romantically unentangled, as he bemoaned cheerfully to anybody who would listen, grinned broadly.

“Permission granted, sir!” Forest had had the deck watch that afternoon. “Tom seems to have grown every time I lay eyes on him, Abe,” he remarked as the two friends turned to watch the last of the busses drive off.

“He’ll be taller than you the next time I see him,” Abe complained ruefully.

Chapter 16

Sunday 19th March

Monasterio de Nuestra Señora de la Asunción

La Superiora Isabella had been rudely disturbed from her prayers by the arrival of her half-brother's Arms Man, Don Rafael and his two whores. She was not a happy woman.

That her much younger sibling° – he was twenty-six years her junior, the only male issue of her father's second marriage to an Aragonese gold-digger young enough to be his daughter° – should impose upon her, yet again, at a time like this was very nearly beyond belief...

However, when her initial ire subsided, she allowed herself a few minutes for reflection. If Don Rafael, that most honourable of her father's swords should have allowed himself to be embroiled in this farrago was a strange, dissonant thing which gave her pause for thought. Although, why he or her brother should imagine that she was remotely interested in the goings on in Madrid or the other cities° – each and every one Babylon-reincarnated and deserving of the cleansing fire of God° – still defeated her comprehension.

Up here, hidden away at an elevation of some five thousand feet in the Sierra Guadarrama Mountains, her community made no effort to keep abreast of, and rarely inquired, into the affairs of the world beyond the adjacent peaks and valleys of the harsh, unforgiving land upon which their great monastery had sat, like God's last citadel since the time of Ferdinand and Isabelle, a monument in living stone to the glory of *la Reconquista*, the re-conquest of the whole of the Iberian Peninsula from the Moors in 1492.

From what she could gather from Don Rafael, that most discreet of Arms Men, it seemed that her brother° – presumably in a fit of Quixotic idealism, a dangerous thing that he had always been prone to° – had placed his sword at the disposal of Queen Sophia, another Aragonese usurper, at Aranjuez because 'the Christian soul of Spain' was imperilled by traitors to the best interests of the Mother Church and the State.

Even her third-party conversations with Alonso tended to be conflicted, unsatisfactory affairs; as had this most recent encounter with

Don Rafael, conducted at the main gates to the *Monasterio de Nuestra Señora de la Asunción* by the flickering light of shielded candles in the rising wind and spitting rain of the coming storm. Up here in what foreigners lazily ° – incorrectly if one was being pedantic ° – called ‘the Mountains of Madrid’ in their verse and songs, winter was still upon them and often, it delivered one last frigid blast before it surrendered, coldly to the inevitable spring.

Alonso knew that she could not refuse sanctuary.

Isabella de Guzman, born the daughter of the House of Medina Sidonia, had renounced her titles, wealth and earthly privileges of her birth in mid-life. She had not come to Christ as a virgin supplicant but originally to make sense of the grief and despair of losing her husband, Miguel, to a stupid hunting accident and her son, Carlos, to a dreadful, inherited wasting illness. She had loved Miguel, they had abjured the customary civil restraints upon marriage between first cousins, turning to the Mother Church to bless their union. And in the end God had sundered them, as if to mock the happiness of their time on earth together. Her life had become a penance, an atonement to ensure her husband’s and her dear son’s souls rested easy in the arms of their Lord. That she had eventually become Sister Isabella, La Superiora of the sublime house consecrated in the time of *la Reconquista*, had followed with the inevitability of night following day.

That evening the two bedraggled, dirty, footsore, near-exhausted, hungry, thirsty New Englanders swaying unsteadily on the cold stone floor of Sister Isabella’s bare-walled, dungeon-like unwelcoming ‘day room’ found themselves under the relentless, hard-eyed scrutiny of a woman who customarily had no patience whatsoever for human frailty.

“You,” the old woman said eventually after a long, horrible silence as she appraised the newcomers, “are self-evidently *not* what Don Rafael or my well-meaning but feckless brother claim that you are?”

Melody had hissed at Henrietta: ‘Leave the talking to me,’ as they had stood, shivering outside the monastery while La Superiora berated Don Rafael in clipped, mightily vexed Castilian before that dignified, but harshly chastened gentleman was finally dismissed.

Don Rafael had departed without a sidelong glance at them.

“I beg your pardon,” Melody had begun in French. Smiled apologetically, re-started in halting Catalan, “my Spanish is,” she shrugged

and held out her arms in what she hoped might pass for Gallic confusion.
'Not good, I...'

"SILENCIO!"

Melody swallowed hard.

Okay, that did not go as well as I had hoped...

"You," the old woman spat at her, "you, I can see could be one of my brother's mistresses. You're his type."

Melody recoiled, opened her mouth to defend the accusation that she was anybody's 'type', but thought better of it the next moment.

The other woman had already turned her piercing, hawk-like stare onto Henrietta who was doing her best, and failing, not to wilt under its merciless glare.

"Whereas, you, are not Alonso's type. Whatever else, he is no ravisher of virgins!"

Henrietta took offense to this.

"I'm not a..."

"Silencio!" Sister Isabella moved around the ancient, less than flat and much knotted table at the centre of the room and stood directly before the women. "My brother rarely asks me for anything. Now he sends me you two. Marija," she looked to Henrietta, "and Carmen," this to Melody. "So, although you cannot possibly be what you seem to be, yet my brother has assumed a debt of honour to you both."

The silence deepened.

"What do you expect us to say, La Superiora?" Melody inquired, too tired to hide her irritation. She had spoken in Spanish, deliberately mimicking the accent and subtle dialect of the peoples of the mountains separating the Community of Madrid from neighbouring La Mancha. "We are strangers in this land who must trust our lives to the kindness of," she shrugged, "other strangers."

The old woman appeared not to have heard her then relented, shaking her head.

"Yes," she sighed, letting down her guard momentarily, "are definitely my brother's *type*."

Melody quirked a grimace of acknowledgement.

Alonso's sister probably had a point but this was hardly the time to be discussing the complicated—actually, messy—ins and outs of her sexuality.

Sister Isabella was stone-faced again.

“Has Alonso’s infatuation with that harlot in the Royal Palace of Aranjuez caused,” she gestured with an angry hand, “all this?”

Melody hesitated.

“I don’t think so. Or rather, I’d be very surprised if it had anything to do with... well, whatever is going on... I know nothing of Alonso’s influence in Queen Sophia’s Court but whatever seems to be going on in Madrid, or elsewhere, is much bigger than just court gossip or intrigue. Men came to Chinchón to capture or kill us, I don’t know which. Alonso went away, we think to Aranjuez several days ago. Otherwise, like you, we know only what Don Rafael was able to tell us, La Superiora.”

“So, who are you?”

“I’m nobody. Not in the big picture of things,” Melody replied.

“Nobody but my brother’s favoured mistress?”

Why were nuns always so obsessed with sex?

“That is none of your business, My Lady,” Melody retorted, baring her claws Minx-like, replying as if she was speaking to the woman as an aristocrat not a maid of God.

“So, are you nothing?” The old woman snapped at Henrietta.

“Hen,” Melody pleaded.

Too late.

“I am Lady Henrietta De L’Isle, the daughter of the Governor of the Commonwealth of New England...”

She might have added ‘oh, bother’ or something more descriptive of her sudden foolishness in allowing herself to be so easily provoked. However, by then Henrietta had worked out that she should not have risen to the bait and it was already far too late to take anything back.

“We are both fully accredited members of the British Diplomatic Mission. Unfortunately, that does not seem to count for anything in this country anymore.”

Sister Isabella’s eyes had widened a fraction.

She folded her arms across her chest.

She sighed.

“Listen to me very carefully,” she declared quietly, “you are the harlot Marija, and your friend is your partner in shame, Carmen. As such you will be treated accordingly by this House. You will live like my lowliest noviciates, you will eat, work, dress and deport yourselves in atonement

without complaint and obey every instruction you are given without protest.”

Melody had no idea if this was good or bad news.

Luckily, she was beyond caring.

“I will leave you for a few minutes. There are things I must arrange if you are to be inducted into our community. You will not be with us very long but it is important that you do nothing to betray your true identities. When I return you will speak only in French or Catalan, the latter badly, I think...”

The door clunked shut.

Melody listened but heard no key turn in the lock.

She opened her arms and Henrietta fell into them.

They clung together until Sister Isabella returned.

“You will be separated. Together you will be too conspicuous. You may not associate again while you are under the protection of the *Monasterio de Nuestra Señora de la Asunción*.”

The women stared at her.

“Is that clear?”

Melody and Henrietta nodded dazedly.

“Good. Come with me.”

Chapter 17

*Monday 20th March
Government House, Philadelphia*

The Governor of New England had not returned to Philadelphia until the early hours of that morning. Going straight to his wife's chambers he had found her heavily sedated and sleeping, mercifully, peacefully. Sitting by her bed in the gloom protectively, tenderly holding her left, slightly less twisted, hand he had attempted and failed to parse, to draw any hard and fast conclusions from the meetings, inspections and abbreviated public engagements which had filled the last seventy-two hours in Norfolk and the surrounding military bases.

London had decided that if the worse came to the worse – a general war with the Spanish – then New England and the Atlantic Fleet would 'ride out the first blow'. There would be no 'provocation offered'; the view being that nothing mattered more than that 'the Empire stands astride and commands the moral high ground.'

Personally, De L'Isle thought this was a strategy of despair, tantamount to an admission that the Empire's policy in the America's was holed below the waterline.

But... And it was a big but; nobody had fired the first shot yet and peace, albeit of the uneasy, fragile kind was a lot better than a real shooting war. Moreover, putting to one side the pronouncements of leading colonial politicians and opinion-makers in the more bellicose middle and upper colonies – the one's farthest away from where any fighting might actually happen – nobody in Government House honestly believed a wholesale military mobilisation was a thing likely to find widespread support throughout the rest of New England.

Problematically, he suspected the majority of the men and women in the street, if they thought about it at all were quite happy to convince themselves that the Border Wars were things of the past and that the South West was an 'old issue', and anyway, if anything went awry in the Gulf of Mexico or the Caribbean that the Royal Navy would sort it out in five minutes flat!

Of course, the man in the street was blissfully unaware of the troubling undercurrents in international affairs, or that since the middle of the last decade the two great European Empires°— those of Britain and Germany°— had been vying for ascendancy and advantage around the margins of their respective imperial spheres and increasingly, trespassing on each other's prerogatives through the agency of proxies. Diplomacy was, indeed, war by other means and Whitehall's perspective was that the Kaiser's men had taken far too many 'liberties' of late. There were many places in the World where there was if not a lot, then at least some 'wiggle room', scope for accommodations and negotiations: unfortunately, there was no such scope in New England, or for the Governor of that Commonwealth.

If Philip De L'Isle ordered a general mobilisation before the war actually began, he would be pilloried for scaremongering; whereas, if he waited until Spanish boots were on New England soil before hitting the button, he would be pilloried for vacillation.

Heads he lost, tails the other fellow won...

Sooner or later most Governors of the Commonwealth of New England came to understand that nothing was black and white and there were often, especially in great matters of state, no 'good options.'

You have only got yourself to blame, old man...

Nobody had held a gun to his temple and ordered him to pick up the poisoned chalice. Thus far, his time in Government House had coincided with one of the longest periods of peace for several decades, the people had got used to the absence of war and welcomed the gradual run-down of both the colonial militias and the CAF. The complacent mantra that whatever the Spanish do we have the Royal Navy had taken root. Under his administration everybody's number one priority had been to do nothing to slow down or to impede the runaway economic boom which was making New Englander's more prosperous and supposedly, happier with every passing year. Even the Empire Day outrages of July 1976 had just been a blip on the horizon; nobody could have predicted that the 'blow back', or knock on effect of last year's revelations about the disaster would have their most malign, world-shaking consequences not in New England but hundreds and thousands of miles away in the Gulf of Mexico and back in old Spain.

There was still no news of Henrietta...

The latest cables from London reported that communications with the British Embassy in Madrid were ‘up and down’ and that fighting in the city had intensified in the last twenty-four hours with the Army shelling several neighbourhoods and possibly the grounds of one, or all of the Royal Palaces.

Troublingly, the provinces of New Granada, Cuba and Santo Domingo had yet to publicly, formally pledge their allegiance to the King-Emperor. In fact, hardly anybody had said anything about events in Spain other than the Pope in Rome, who had demanded the warring parties lay down their weapons and accept the intercession of the Papal Legate to the Spanish Church, Cardinal Vincente Coretta, formerly Bishop of Milan and latterly hardly ever absent from the side of Pius IX, the doddering, eighty-seven-year-old near blind incumbent sitting ◦ – stupefied most of the time, some claimed◦ – on the throne of the Vatican.

Unlike the Pope◦ – premature rumours of whose death had leaked out of Rome twice in the last six months◦ – Coretta was an arch conservative who preached ‘God’s will that we roll back the territorial and theological adjustments of recent times.’ Specifically, this was usually interpreted as advocating a stronger hand on the helm in Madrid, a resumption of the Church’s historic missionary role in Spain’s overseas provinces and a global renewal of the battle against the march of heresy and apostasy.

De L’Isle had snatched three hours sleep, risen, completed his toilet, breakfasted and was at his desk at nine o’clock, diligently working through his papers and dictating letters to his secretary.

He broke for a cup of tea at eleven o’clock, chatting briefly with his Chief of Staff, Sir Henry Rawlinson about the meetings he had scheduled for that afternoon with the Governors of the Carolinas, Georgia and the Governor-designate of Florida, which was about to be incorporated into the Commonwealth of New England as its newest Crown Colony.

The race was now on to incorporate all possible viable protectorates, concessions and as much as possible of the ‘wild west’ beyond the Mississippi as full colonies. This was always a thing the First Thirteen and their two ‘Johnny-come-lately’ allies◦ – Maine and Vermont◦ – had resisted for over, in several cases, a hundred years before, more recently, grudgingly caving in to the reality of the global marketplace. That none of the ‘unincorporated’ or so-called ‘un-organised’ territories had yet gained full Crown Colony status simply reflected the determination of the First

Thirteen's rear-guard action. Ironically, as the crisis worsened in the south, practically every delaying tactic had run its natural course and in the coming years De L'Isle confidently expected the map of his immense bailiwick to start changing in a big way.

Politics was one thing but business was business.

Florida was about to become the sixteenth Crown Colony, joining, in order of their Royal Grants of full Colonial status: Pennsylvania, Delaware, New Jersey, New Hampshire, New York, Massachusetts, Connecticut, Maryland, Virginia, South Carolina, Georgia, North Carolina, Rhode Island, Vermont and Maine.

De L'Isle had been disconcerted by how little real push back there had been when, early in his administration he had spoken to New Englanders of his mandate to complete the 'process of colonisation' from 'shore to shore' of this mighty land. In many instances granting full crown colonial status and rights was long overdue. In the cases of the Ohio, Indiana, Tennessee, Louisiana and Illinois territories it was going to be a matter of simply rubber-stamping long-established realities on the ground. Over forty million of the King's subjects lived in those lands and had enjoyed what amounted in reality to a semi-colonial settlement dating back to the early days of the century.

The *prima facie* case for full colonisation was less clear cut for the other eight parcels of 'real estate' and their growing mining, industrial, farming and settler populations. In many of them there were unresolved questions as to what to do with the minority but still large indigenous populations, although it was recognised – with no little discomfort in Government House – that as time went by European diseases, the diminishment of their traditional hunting grounds and emigration to the industrial cities of the interior was gradually winnowing the extant populations of the native nations.

That said, around half of all native Americans – some six or seven million souls – lived east of the Great Lakes and the Mississippi on the great plains of the interior and it remained unclear how exactly, they might be humanely accommodated in the final regularisation of the disparate polities living in the areas designated on maps of New England bearing labels such as: the Minnesota Farmland, the Dakotas, the Missouri Valley and Basin, the Mississippi Plain, and the Oregon Country.

The railways had rolled across the hunting grounds of the Lakota Sioux and the other clans of the Great Plains a hundred years ago, punching through the towering continental divide of the Rocky Mountains and driven north and north west to link into the railroad system of the Canadian colonies by the turn of the present century, connecting the Eastern economic power house of New England to the great Pacific port cities of Vancouver and Sammanish and opening up the Oregon country.

Last but by no means least, was the fate of West Texas, Texas, Sequoyah and the highlands of the Colorado Valley, contested lands located along the vulnerable South Western borderlands running from the Gulf of Spain in a ragged line all the way across Alta California to the Pacific at a place called Port Orford, notwithstanding that to this day nobody had ever comprehensively mapped that border.

Throughout these territories the gathering 'land rush' of the last decade was constantly changing the facts on the ground, populating former Indian land. Change was happening so fast that the maps drawn by the mandarins in Whitehall were out of date before they ever saw the light of day in Philadelphia.

Watching those 'facts on the ground' changing virtually before their eyes it was, in one way, hardly surprising that the rulers of New Granada, seething angrily in the corridors of power in Mexico City, should be chomping at the bit and beginning to plan for one new, possibly last war to turn back what to them must seem to be an unstoppable tide of 'English', protestant invaders into provinces that in living memory, had actually been 'Spanish' buffer zones between the further expansion of the British Empire and *their* sovereign realm...

That was the trouble with the bloody Spanish.

One could not have a straightforward war with them; everything was stained, usually, blood-stained with them...

The telephone by his right hand rang.

More bad news?

"The Lieutenant-Governor of New York is requesting to speak to you urgently, My Lord," a prim female secretary informed him.

"Put him through, please." De L'Isle waited. "Hello, John," he welcomed his caller the moment the line connection crackled in the earpiece of the handset. He knew Sir John Waverley from his time in the Cape and had been happy to recommend him for the sinecure he now held,

with immense charm and dignity on Long Island. “Always good to hear your voice, what can I do for you, old chap?”

There was a crackle of static down the line.

“I’m afraid I am the bearer of bad tidings, Philip,” the other man apologised.

De L’Isle waited patiently, bracing himself.

“There was an incident outside the Governor’s mansion this morning,” Sir John Waverley explained, his tone very grim. “The Governor’s official car was rammed by another vehicle and there was a large explosion. The Governor and his wife were both declared dead at the scene. I fear there will be news of many other fatalities and serious injuries as the day progresses.”

De L’Isle and Lord Cumberbatch, the Governor of New York, had been at daggers drawn – very politely, of course – ever since he had appointed Melody Danson to look into the apparent discrepancies in the prosecution files of Isaac Fielding and his sons in respect of the Empire Day atrocities. Subsequently, Cumberbatch’s regime had come in for something of a roasting in the New England press and he had been a somewhat reclusive figure in recent months.

“Damn,” the Governor of New England muttered. “Thank you for giving me a warning that the story was about to break, John. It goes without saying that my office will render all assistance to you up there in New York.”

“Thank you...”

“I’ll let you get about your business,” De L’Isle concluded.

No sooner had he put the phone down Sir Henry Rawlinson knocked on the door and entered his room. He had been listening in on the call in his own office.

“We’re also getting reports of an incident outside the law courts in Albany,” De L’Isle’s Chief of Staff announced grimly. “At least one, perhaps two suicide car bombers. There are many casualties in Temple Gardens.”

Two attacks...

How many more were to come?

Chapter 18

*Maundy Thursday 23rd March
North Atlantic, 25 Miles east of Sandy Hook*

Major Alexander Lincoln had done a lot of crazy things in his barnstorming days but flying through a prematurely initiated firework display— set off by an imbecile he had punched out the night before who had accused him of ‘hitting on’ his girl in a bar— while looping the loop in a souped-up Bristol VI with two buxom wing walkers strutting their stuff on the old kite’s top wing had pretty much taken the biscuit... *until now.*

That said, veterans like Alex who had survived four tours down on the Border in those years when peace had been— more or less— unofficially declared everywhere except in the skies above the disputed territories, got inured to being handed the shit end of the stick. So, when he had finally discovered why 7NY’s transfer out of Colony had been delayed not once but three times in the last month he had been uncharacteristically phlegmatic. Of course, breaking the news to his pilots had been... *challenging.*

‘Look, I’d sugar-coat this, chaps,’ he had apologised, trying to be as pugnacious as a British bulldog, ‘but the sooner you know what’s going down the sooner we can start getting our heads around it.’

That had got the boys’ attention!

‘We’re swapping our Mark II Goshawk’s for Mark IVs.’ His pilots’ eyes had been as wide as his had been when he had first choked down the implications of this. ‘Then we’re going to learn, very quickly, how to operate them off the Navy’s biggest flight deck!’

The Gloucester Aircraft Corporation had re-designed and extensively modified the Mark II Goshawk for a longer-range ground-based fleet protection role some years ago. More recently, as an expedient to cover the period— as little as three and as many as six years— before the first generation of jet interceptors was likely to come into general squadron service, the Mark III, a heavier, slightly slower and less nimble version of the Mark II but with approximately twice the operational range, had been given a significantly more robust undercarriage and structurally

strengthened to enable it to fly off, and the hard bit, *land* on the pitching deck of an aircraft carrier at sea.

On the plus side, the Mark IV's 1,475 horse-power power plant made it the Mark II's match for speed, if not manoeuvrability and because of its bull-like construction on land at least, serious take-off and landing 'incidents' were statistically speaking, occasionally 'survivable'. The problem was that the Goshawk Mark IV was the Royal Navy's principal sea-borne scout-interceptor and each of the new Ulysses class ships were listed to carry at least two squadrons of them and there were not enough naval pilots to fly the aircraft now rolling off the production lines.

Old hands like Alex had been asking themselves how on earth the Navy was going to find the pilots to fly so many Mark IVs. Now he knew and putting a good spin on it was not going to be straightforward. It was this which had impelled him to commandeer the first three Goshawk IVs delivered to Idlewild Field and to lead his best two jockeys on this little 'proving flight'.

The base's Royal Navy Liaison Officer (RNLO) had tried to give them a pep talk last night, and— give him credit, he was a persistent cove— that morning before the off.

'There's nothing to it,' he had explained. 'You crank down the hook and let the birds glide onto the after part of the flight deck. The 'sweet spot' is marked by a big cross and smaller markings indicate less ideal but still safe touch-down points where you are still likely to *catch* a wire...'

Obviously, it was not that simple.

A Mark IV's stalling speed was around seventy-eight or nine knots— about ninety miles per hour — at sea level which normally meant a minimum safe landing speed was going to be in excess of a hundred miles an hour, maybe as high as one hundred and twenty. Any faster and the kite would squash down on its under-cart, breaking something, or 'bounce' back into the air, either way a pilot was liable to lose control and it was going to hurt. In a nutshell, landing on a carrier's flight deck entailed putting down on a moving runway— one-fiftieth the size of the target on land— steaming into the wind at around twenty-five knots. Moreover, to avoid bouncing over the four evenly spaced 'traps'— tensioned steel hawsers raised off the deck just high enough to catch a plane's tail hook— a Goshawk Mark IV had to hit the deck at a closing speed of around a hundred knots.

Four 'traps' sounded reassuring... sort of.

However, there was a reason the Navy called the fourth ‘trap’ the ‘FOR CHRIST-SAKE’S WIRE’: because even if your hook caught it the odds were that the best one could hope for was a crash with°– or without°– the aircraft nosing forward onto its propeller or worse, slewing over the side of the ship...

The RNLO had briefed Alex about the advanced ‘mirror landing system’ installed on all the big carriers; the CO of 7NY had been more interested in the Landing Officer’s ‘light board’, visible for two to three miles distant.

Two reds°– too high, abort.

One red°– too high, adjust.

Green°– on glide path.

Green and red°– left of the glide path.

Green and yellow°– right of the glide path.

‘Watch for the WAVE OFF officers standing in the small sponsons either side of the fantail of the ship. Watch their bats very hard during the final approach...’

In extremis these latter ‘bat men’ had been known to fire flares directly in front of, or directly *at* aircraft that looked as if they were going to crash into the stern or the wake of a carrier.

‘Look, don’t be upset if only one of you gets down successfully and the others have to return to Idlewild,’ the RNLO, a Naval Air Service pilot of Alex’s vintage who comported himself with the exaggerated care of a man who had taken one knock too many. “That’s par for the course. Give your chaps a couple of goes at this. The third attempt is usually the stickiest if a fellow has had to abort a couple of times.’

HMS Perseus looked like a floating wall of steel from the quayside but right now as Alex began his approach from the north-east, she looked like a tiny grey speck in the distance.

He was still too far out to be worrying about mirrors and light boards. To either side of him his wingmen, both old-timers°– real old lags°– like him, had taken up formation three or four wingspans away, attempting to conform to his every move. They would peel off at about eight hundred yards from the carrier, hopefully, if he got down in one piece, they would have got a feel for the right glide path and throttle settings by then, giving them a better chance at lining up for their own landings on the postage stamp size crosses on the deck of the Perseus when their turn came.

TWO REDS!

Jesus, those lights were bright!

No, not going to abort this far out...

He chopped back on the power and the Goshawk sank towards the grey, white horse-flecked North Atlantic.

ONE RED!

Still over three miles out but suddenly closing horribly fast.

Maximum flaps!

GREEN AND YELLOW!

How the fuck did I drift left?

Perhaps, the wind had shifted?

Once a carrier was landing aircraft it would not change course unless the wind backed or it was under attack.

Alex had no excess mental capacity to check to see if his wingmen were still clinging to his coat tails. This was one of those scout pilot's classic every man for himself moments. He blinked, sweat stinging his eyes, a spasm of cramp shot up his right arm.

Try not to grip the stick so bloody hard, old man...

GREEN!

Shit I'm almost on top of the bloody ship!

He glimpsed the Landing Officer flattening his big paddles across his chest.

The Goshawk hit the deck with a jarring crunch.

Alex was brutally snapped forward in his straps.

The engine was roaring but the aircraft was stationary.

Without conscious thought he cut the throttle to idle.

There was a man already pulling back his cockpit hood.

"UNHOOKED!" The man in the greasy yellow dungarees of a flight deck crewman yelled in his ear. He reached in and thumped Alex's right shoulder. "Gun the engine, sir!" He said into the pilot's face as if cognisant that he was still in a state of shock. "Hit the WINGS FOLD switch and taxi STRAIGHT AHEAD! We're parking you forward of the island."

Presently, he was ordered to kill the engine.

Strong arms helped him out and manhandled him clear of his aircraft as a gang of men in yellow, black and red dungarees pushed his Goshawk so close to the edge of the deck he thought for a moment they were going to pitch her over the side. Then he was being escorted through a door into the

quiet of the 'Island', HMS Perseus's bridge superstructure located approximately half-way down the vessel's starboard flank.

It was not until he stepped into Flight Control, the fiefdom of the Commander, Carrier Air Wing (CAW), that Alex truly started to get his faculties back into gear.

"That was a gutsy landing!" A large, bearded, piratical figure of a man some years Alex's senior declaimed heartily as he crushed the newcomer's right hand in a bear-like calloused paw. "Come and join me at the best seat in the house!"

Alex found himself leaning on the back of a chair high up in the Island with an unobstructed view of the entire massive— it looked very, very big down at this level— flight deck of the brand-new carrier. In addition to his Mark IV there were several Bristol torpedo bombers neatly parked near the bow and to his surprise two of the experimental small helicopters — machines clouded in real rather than perfunctory secrecy — he had been starting to hear so many good things about. One of them was slowly spooling up its small tail-mounted stabiliser and twenty-foot diameter main lift rotors.

"I've ordered your chaps to try a couple of trial approaches while we get our little friend," the Perseus's CAW intimated, "into the air. Just in case we have to pull anybody out of the sea in the next few minutes."

Alex sobered, gave the man a very hard look.

The big man grinned.

"Those whirlybirds are still very much works in progress," he confessed. "I'd hoped to have one in the air for your landing but we're having to learn as we go along."

The other man became more serious.

He gestured to the thickening overcast.

"You've made your point," he said, breathing respect. "You've shown what can be done. Are those two chaps out there up to this work?"

Heck, that was honest!

"Up to it and up for it," he retorted briskly.

"Good. We'll give the whirlybird a couple of minutes to get onto station then we'll call your chaps in again."

Alex watched the fragile-looking helicopter lift effortlessly off the deck and swing away to port, its main rotor a blur in the greyness. Three or

four miles away the indistinct silhouette of a sleek fleet destroyer kept pace with the Perseus.

“When we go to sea with Task Force 5.2 there will be a battlewagon, cruisers and a pack of destroyers like the Campbeltown°— out there°— all around us, not to mention oilers, ammunition and general stores auxiliaries in company,” the Perseus’s CAW remarked cheerfully. With our Goshawks, torpedo and dive bombers we will be able to make mincemeat of any battlefleet that ever sailed the seven seas at a range of two to two hundred-and-fifty miles.”

“That’s quite a thought, sir,” Alex grimaced. “You’ll forgive me if I worry more about the mechanics of taking-off and landing on this boat rather than grand strategy for the next few minutes.”

The older man laughed heartily.

“I can see that you and I are going to be a damned good team, Major!”

Chapter 19

*Maundy Thursday 23rd March
Bridge Street, Manhattan, New York*

Brigadier Matthew Harrison tried not to dwell on the news he had received two days ago, about the tumour discovered last year in the x-rays taken after his admittance to the Accident and Emergency Department of the Queen Eleanor Hospital in the wake of the Temple Gardens shooting. It seemed that the surgery he had undergone last August, had only delayed the inevitable and that his present, oddly rude health was simply the precursor to a sudden terminal decline which might set in any day without warning.

Rather than dwell upon his own troubles, he had begun to reflect on the many regrets he would be relieved to be leaving behind sometime later that year.

Last night he had visited the Brooklyn Admiralty Dockyards to walk down the now repaired slipway where so many people had died on Empire Day two years ago, and a great ship had been wrecked. The death of John Watson, an innocent man in the confusion some hours later was a thing that would be on his conscience forever; few days passed when he did not think of the man's poor widow and his orphaned children.

In comparison, the news of his boyhood friend, Isaac Fielding's death had left him cold. The man who had been his oldest friend had become his most implacable enemy and the shame of it would cling to him like a bad smell, an itch it was far, far too late to scratch. Isaac had won in the end: in the last few years everything he touched turned to dust, went bad on him.

Harrison still had no idea why the Spanish had had Sarah Arnold assassinated, or even if she, not Melody Danson had been the real target...

He should never have let *that* woman go to Spain on *that* fool's errand. Now she, and almost as bad, Henrietta De L'Isle had disappeared into the chaos of what had every manifestation of a civil war, a war to the knife for the soul of Spain.

What made it ten times worse was that he could and should have called her back two or three months ago. Those idiots in Madrid hated having such an intelligent, perceptive— and strong— woman in their midst in a position

of authority. That was why they had progressively cut her and the Governor's daughter out of the main work of 'the Commission', and probably why so little had been achieved other than to delay the moment the men in London had to take action against the Spanish for turning a blind eye to the Empire Day plot.

Although, in that respect, that time had been coming soon anyway; and the current disorder, probably a botched coup attempt in Madrid and other major regional capitals in the Iberian Peninsula, had merely pre-empted matters.

At least Melody and Henrietta had contrived to make contact with one or two of the saner players on the undercast of the ongoing Spanish tragedy. Moreover, they had managed to travel around the country last year, collecting a wealth of 'soft' intelligence before the *Mission's* senior men—dolts one and all—had succeeded in clipping their wings.

Melody Danson's acutely observed, detailed reports of what the two women had seen, and heard being said, in several of the big cities and their conclusions on the actual, not the theoretical, workings of Old Spain had been remarkably illuminating. On their own initiative they had moved around—in the guise of Melody escorting Henrietta around the landscape of her childhood in Spain, gaining access to what was essentially, the last 'closed' society in Western Europe—and with nothing more potent in their armoury of subterfuges than their charm, quiet persistence and their nascent curiosity had set about overturning a raft of long-held misconceptions about the relative modernity and stability of Spanish society, and partially debunked a slew of brainless assumptions about the real nature and virulence of the Inquisition.

The two women had ruthlessly exploited their hosts' notion—shared by the male hierarchy of the 'Joint Commission'—that they were just a pair of exotic adornments, window-dressing. Therefore, the Spanish had let them roam about at will just like two wide-eyed tourists on some kind of old-fashioned Grand Tour. The great families of the cities they had visited had been only too eager to welcome 'Lady Henrietta' and her quaint, New England 'friend' into their houses, and now and then, to talk with what seemed like reckless abandon about the issues confronting their fiefdoms, and their country.

There was no single Inquisition in Spain in exactly the same way there was no controlling Mafia family in the affairs of Italy or Sicily or anywhere

else in the Mediterranean world. Everything was a lot more complicated than people imagined and Old Spain was simply an umbrella nomenclature under which Castile, Asturias, Galicia, Catalonia, Aragon, the Basque lands and all the other fiercely independent 'nations' of the Iberian Peninsula, without the borders of Portugal, co-existed in a constant state of flux. Seville and Cadiz, Granada, Toledo, Salamanca, Segovia, Barcelona and a score of other communes and communities were each in permanent low-level opposition to the writs of the Royal Palaces of Madrid. To many Spaniards the King-Emperor was an irrelevant lapdog of the Mother Church locked away in his bunker in the Mountains of Madrid...

Harrison glanced at his wristwatch.

Sighed, knowing he needed to be on the next ferry across to Elizabethtown if he was to catch the 14:11 train down to Philadelphia. After that the next express service did not leave until after four o'clock and he needed to confer with the Governor this evening.

His best guess about the 'Spanish situation' was that a cadre of officers within the military—possibly both the Army and the Navy, the Air Force tended to keep out of politics—had sided with one or other of the Court factions, there were several of those in both Ferdinand and Sophia's palaces, and possibly with a coalition of the more 'traditional' Inquisitions but at the end of the day all that was pure guesswork.

He looked out of the window of the tea rooms where he had taken shelter from the morning's showers. Out on the street everybody was going about their business as usual.

Ignorance was indeed, bliss!

The Empire Day outrages had somehow let a terrible genie out of his bottle and soon, he feared, they were all going to have to pay the price.

Matthew Harrison had come to New York the day after the murder of the Governor and his wife and the Temple Gardens bombings. There were twenty-seven dead, another one hundred-and-five people, men, women, children, two of them babes in arms still in hospital, many of them critically ill and yet here in Manhattan all was calm and few of the uniformed police on the streets carried fire arms.

He had immediately offered the full resources of the Colonial Security Service to assist 'in any way required' by the Colony's constabulary, and as he had anticipated, had his offer politely, curtly rejected notwithstanding the locals were obviously desperately chasing shadows again with little or no

idea how to begin to uncover the support networks which had to have existed, and had to have left significant evidential trails, given that the three suicide car bombers had contrived to wreak such havoc.

Of course, the idiots did not have the first idea what they were actually looking for, and he had little or no confidence that even if they stumbled over what they were looking for, they had the expertise or the native wit to recognise it for what it was!

It was Empire Day 1976 all over again...

I should have had Melody Danson recalled from Spain!

Honestly and truly, I was stupid to let her go in the first place!

Problematically, no amount of wishful thinking or retrospective existential angst was going to change a single damned thing; he was dying and the woman he had first floated as his long-term successor shortly after the smoke in the Upper Bay had cleared twenty months ago was, for all he knew, dead.

He paid his bill, collected his hat and coat and ventured out into the street. Threatening rain drops splashed heavily on the pavement even though the nearest bank of grey-black storm clouds was retreating to the east.

He had no idea if Melody Danson would have accepted the role that he still envisioned for her; for all he knew she might have laughed in his face. Nevertheless, *that* would have been the sort of conversation a man would pay good money to have a ring-side seat at!

He forced himself to focus on his contemporaneous mistakes and misapprehensions. Specifically, were there still terrorist attacks to come and if so, where and directed against whom?

He began to walk west down Bridge Street towards the ferry port on the Hudson bank.

Bridge Street...

The road had been carved through late nineteenth century Manhattan at much cost and against huge public opposition—on account of so many private buildings having to be demolished to make way for it—because the colonies of New York and New Jersey had briefly agreed that a bridge on the model of the King Edward VI, already spanning the East River linking Long Island to Manhattan should be built across the Hudson River. That concordat had only survived a couple of years and by then Bridge Street and the footings for two rail tracks had already been substantially

constructed most of the way across Manhattan. Nowadays, the magnificent straight road across the city was regarded as a salutary epitaph to inter-colonial non-cooperation and misunderstanding, a folly worthy of comparison with any of those ridiculous aristocratic landscape jokes of yesteryear back in the Old Country.

A depressing aspect of the current crisis was that the complacency he witnessed everywhere in the First Thirteen had its roots in the misconception that somehow, if war came, the greater part of the burden would be borne not by the East Coast but by the Old Country and the peoples of the trackless western hinterlands. The general view on the East Coast was that not only would the war industries of the Ohio and the Monongahela Valleys and the vast sprawling cities around the Great Lakes take much of the economic strain, but that the sons of other parts of the Empire and of the anonymous factory workers of the interior would largely populate the regiments, man the ships and fly the aeroplanes which would enable life in the First Thirteen— and of course Maine and Vermont— to go on ‘as normal’ until such time as the unpleasantness was concluded.

As in all previous ‘conflicts’ with the rump of New Spain the exchequer back in England would take the strain while in New England it would be ‘business as usual’.

In any event, nobody in the middle or upper colonies took the notion of the supposedly ‘raggedy’ despotic Spanish colonies of the Caribbean, the Central Americas and the northern shores of the Latin Southern continent ever ‘getting their act together’ and uniting in common cause very seriously.

Heck that was as unthinkable as the First Thirteen ever agreeing about anything other than that they deserved preferential treatment within the Empire!

As for talk of a ‘Triple Alliance’, comprised, according to who one listened to, of New Granada, Cuba and Santo Domingo or any number of the other estranged Spanish provinces like Panama, or Colombia or one or other of the fractured colonies of Nuevo Valencia, Maracaibo, Caracas or Barquisimeto, that seemed almost too incredible to be true. Likewise, few people were aware that the German Empire’s so-called ‘1966 Concessions’, among them Aruba and Curacao, and the ports of Cumana and La Cruz in the South and San Juan, the original Spanish ‘rich port’ or Puerto Rica in

the Americas, had been conduits through which the Germans had injected unknown treasure and technological assistance to their allies in the region.

In the last half-a-dozen years the German Navy had been granted facilities in Cuba at Guantanamo Bay, at the city of Santa Domingo and at Port au Prince by the Dominicans and perhaps, most significantly, at Vera Cruz on the Caribbean shore of New Granada. Nor was it commonly recognised that trade between the Empire of Germany and the Spanish colonies they had 'befriended' in and around the Caribbean had expanded exponentially in those years from a nett worth of a few tens of millions of pounds sterling— the currency of all international transactions— thirty-fold or more just since the mid-1960s.

The World was changing but the mindset of New Englanders was not. Several Colonial Legislatures had already cavilled at the increased military expenditures *suggested* for the financial years 1979-80 and 1980-81 by the Governor's Office in Philadelphia, increases designed to ensure that there was a realistic, working recruiting and supply administration, and that planning for a future expansion of military capabilities was carried out on a continual basis in every colony and protectorate in the Commonwealth of New England.

There would be Hell to pay when the Governor was forced to insist that for the first time in a generation the Colonial Exchequers re-introduce the direct taxation of personal rather than just commercial income. In peace time levies on raw materials and manufactured goods entering the Commonwealth from outside the Imperial Preference Zone, duties on household goods other than foodstuffs and taxes on petrol and heating oil when supplemented by local tariffs imposed by Colonial Legislatures were usually sufficient to fund basic public services, universal health provision free at the point of contact to all persons as per the original 'British model', the Constabulary, urban sanitation and waste disposal, the maintaining of the road system and so forth. The railroad combines were privately owned, as were the river and canal conservancies who kept the waterways in operation. Historically, the colonial militias— part-timers or as the English termed them 'Territorials' — were the responsibility of individual 'home colonies', whereas, regular troops were paid for directly by the British taxpayer, although many argued the profits, dues and taxes the Chancellor in Whitehall collected abroad were as much Empire as solely British taxes.

The Colonial Air Force had always been a different kind of animal; funded directly by the colonies themselves. In the beginning the quid pro quo had been that all the CAF's aircraft would be built under licence in New England, bringing skilled employment and guaranteeing routine technology transfers, mainly to the benefit of the economies of the middle and upper First Thirteen. That had become contentious as the complexity and cost of modern aircraft had rocketed through the roof; currently, London paid for approximately sixty percent of every airframe flown by the CAF.

The Royal Navy, of course, had always been wholly 'owned' and funded by the British Government.

However, all that was going to have to change if there was another war. If that war turned into a general conflagration the privileged, comparatively wealthy citizens of the First Thirteen would have to be squeezed until the pips started to squeal. As historians quipped: 'It would be 1857 all over again!'

Matthew Harrison knew that his friend, Philip De L'Isle and his principals in London shivered at the likely implications of *that* scenario.

Personally, Matthew Harrison was agnostic about it while accepting that nobody could deny that the imposition of possibly penal 'war taxation' upon the First Thirteen was a thing likely to have long-lasting political implications.

Isaac Fielding had always maintained that if and when the 'English'—for whatever reason—'came calling' for the wealth of the Virginia planters, the New York and Boston money-changers, and looked to claim a meaningful tythe from the industrial robber-barons of the Great Lakes territories, that would be the *cause célèbre* that finally ignited 'the spirit of the Boston Tea Party' and that then, 'they would really be in trouble' because 'old George Washington's ghost would surely rise again from the cold ground of Long Island!'

Two Hundred Lost Years had a lot to answer for.

Personally, the Head of the Colonial Security Service thought that the jury was out on the question of whether even a punitive 'war tax' burden might be sufficient, of itself, to begin to unite the fiercely independent East Coast colonies against their Imperial overlords...

Basically, New Yorkers had little time for Virginians, the two Carolinas would be at war with each other anyway were it not for 'the

English', Bostonians looked down on the rude country folk of Vermont and Maine, and so on.

One had to be sceptical that anything would ever change that!

Matthew Harrison never saw the Morris speedster coupe which suddenly accelerated, mounted the curb and hit him at a speed later calculated to have been in excess of sixty miles per hour.

He was already dead before his broken body hit the ground.

Chapter 20

Good Friday 24th March

Monasterio de Nuestra Señora de la Asunción

Melody Danson had begun to lose track of time, of days passing and even though she knew that today was Good Friday it felt as if she had been at the monastery weeks rather than just five long, cold miserable days.

On the first morning after she and Henrietta De L'Isle had arrived two nuns ° – 'sisters' or whatever ° – had roused her from her bed, a straw palliasse on the stone floor of her 'cell', more a dungeon, that would have had any right thinking-colonist up in arms back home had it been located in say, a New England police station or prison, ordered her to strip naked and then cut her hair. Well 'cut' was being a little generous, it had seemed to her that they were 'shearing' her with a lot less care and attention than they would have paid had she been a sheep!

Thereafter she had been dunked in a very cold bath ° – one of her 'helpers' had pushed her head under the water several times while muttering an angry prayer in what she later decided was a demotic, or at least a very rural, Asturian dialect ° – and left to stand naked and shivering uncontrollably for some minutes before being allowed to dry herself with a towel so coarse it actually scratched her, before being instructed to get dressed. Thereupon, she had been required to don a white linen surplus tailored to fit a woman of twice her breadth, and a faded brown, horribly itchy ° – it might have been horsehair ° – habit with a hood that she was specifically commanded to always employ to cover her head when she was 'outside'.

With her teeth still chattering, feeling literally like death warmed up she had been frog-marched barefoot to a small, damp chapel and forced to kneel on the floor, just frigid flagstones, for an interminable period while all manner of chanting, praying of the silent and communal kind and various incantations were, it seemed ° – she was feeling so ill by then she did not care ° – directed at her.

Next, she had found herself back in her cell.

‘Found herself’ because she must have fainted or passed out at some stage because a different nun with none of the righteous hutzpah of her former ‘escorts’ had sat her up and was trying to get her to eat what looked like lumpy vomit dripping from a rudimentary wooden spoon.

Actually, to be fair, ‘the food’ turned out to be some kind of watery gruel made from crushed maize which only tasted like vomit.

‘Our ways will be strange to start with,’ the other woman, who might have been Melody’s age but it was hard to tell when she could only see a part of her face in the gloom of the cell, assured her without malice.

Melody had been so hungry she did her best to keep her ‘breakfast’ down, notwithstanding how just the smell of it made her gag. Thinking about that morning she realised now that at one point she must have been borderline hypothermic, so cold that her body was starting to shut down and the gruel, in addition to the blankets her gentle saviour had wrapped about her shoulders had probably been all that kept her going.

For all she remembered they could have locked her away for the rest of that first day. She had slept fitfully as if in the throes of a fever, awakened only with the sharp pain of her bladder protesting. There was a large terracotta-type bowl by the door which she used to relieve herself before collapsing back onto the lumpy palliasse again, not waking again until it was dark.

Her cell door was wedged open the next morning.

Cold gruel was placed on the floor, an earthenware jug with brackish water next to it and a chunk of bread so black and hard she initially thought it was a rock of some kind. She had had to soak the bread in the gruel to soften it sufficiently to attempt to eat it.

“Wash!” Yet another nun had demanded, standing in the door.

Melody had followed her down two corridors afraid she was going to be subjected to another ice bath treatment and was pleasantly surprised, not to say, relieved, to be ushered into what was obviously a communal washroom with two real latrines in open brick cubicles at one end. There was tepid water in a bowl, and some kind of carbolic soap.

It was all she could do not to yelp: “Hallelujah!”

It seemed that cleanliness was definitely adjacent to godliness and it was the custom of the sisters to discard most or all of their garments so as to ensure this much to be desired state was achieved on a whole-body basis at least once a day.

Running her fingers through her raggedly massacred now very short hair was an experience, as was eying the bumps and bruises on her legs and knees acquired hiking over the mountains. The bruises were coming out nicely...

She felt positively scrawny, beaten up and was glad that there were no mirrors to hand.

She had asked her companion about that in halting Catalan.

‘Pride goeth before a fall,’ the other woman had replied stoically.

Sometime later that morning she was handed a broom.

‘Sweep the corridors and the courtyard. A sister will bring you food later.’

So, she had swept the floors and ventured out into a claustrophobic yard, got a little distracted by the faded, cracked possibly formerly magically coloured tiles underfoot. She wearied very quickly, tried to carry on, eventually slumped in a corner and started to cry.

That was the low point.

Not that the days since had been exactly a barrel of laughs.

She hated feeling like a victim, being helpless and after a while, as she had always done in the past she began to fight back. However bad things get a woman can always get angry!

Fighting back, even in small ways was not tolerated.

They had marched her off to see the Mother Superior that evening.

“You must work,” Sister Isabella informed her tersely, waving for her to be taken away again. Then the old woman had had a second thought. “No, take her to Sister Elvira. She looks feverish.”

Sister Elvira was even older than La Superiora.

Mercifully, it transpired that she was cut from a different cloth.

She had put her hand to Melody’s forehead.

Looked placidly into her eyes.

Taken her left hand between her hands.

“We are an order that welcomes any who will contribute to the common good under the sight of Our Lord,” Sister Elvira decided, her voice maternal. “We will keep you, and your friend, another day from fully joining our community. That is our way. You are both exhausted still. You both have much to get used to.”

Since the old woman had made no attempt to communicate in any language other than Castilian, Melody assumed that she too had been let

into the secret about the monastery's two new guests.

Melody had obediently drunk the potion° – some kind of cold herbal tea, she guessed° – from the cup that Sister Elvira had pressed into her hands. Later she had slept a deep, dreamless sleep.

Okay, so they drugged me...

A few of the other nuns had given her curious looks when she was escorted through the building to the refectory the next morning, others had watched her as she choked down more of the foul gruel and slaked her thirst. Apparently, all the other sisters had completed their toilet hours ago and she had missed her turn. Breakfast concluded, it had been straight to a larger chapel than before where she glimpsed Henrietta, like her, with her hood drawn half over her face several rock-hard cold pews away. Both women had minders, or perhaps, 'watchers' would be a better word, assigned to them for the first couple of days they were allowed out of their cells. In between periods of kneeling supplication wherever one was at a given hour, or attendances at, initially, meaningless religious observances in the chapel, Melody's days rotated between the kitchen, sweeping floors and working in the walled garden on the southern side of the castle-like complex.

She began to yearn to look over and beyond the walls, to chaff at commandments restricting 'noviciates' such as her to the ground floor and the 'under croft' spaces of the *Monasterio de Nuestra Señora de la Asunción*.

The morning gruel and hard bread was a thing to be endured; in the evening the bread was fresher and some nights the warm, steaming broth, tasted like manna from heaven to stomachs cramped with hunger.

Everybody was hungry practically all the time; in that the communion was united and despite herself, Melody quickly started to find common cause with other sisters, many of whom began to quirk smiles, or occasionally giggled at her deliberately butchered Catalan. Several of the nuns spoke passable French, although it took a while to get used to the fact that nobody was remotely interested in her life prior to the day she had 'entered' the monastery.

That had confused Melody.

It was as if when a woman arrived in this other little world within a world locked away in the seclusion of the high Mountains of Madrid that the slate was wiped clean, that one began anew.

Melody worried about Henrietta.

If the adjustment to life here was hard for her then what must it be like for her younger friend, lover...

Three times they had exchanged inscrutable, unreadable brief looks in the gloom of the chapel, or across tables at opposite ends of the refectory, once they had passed each other in a corridor almost without knowing it.

Melody would have given anything just to know that Henrietta was... *okay*.

There was rain in the air that morning as Melody hoed and weeded the 'sunny corner' of the kitchen garden. The sisters grew root vegetables elsewhere because this bright spot was reserved for bean stalks which climbed wooden frames and chives, and mint and rosemary struggled to gain a foothold in the tilled dun-coloured earth. She was a total ignoramus when it came to gardening, horticulture or agriculture. Back home she would have rued her broken finger nails, the soreness of her pale, previously soft hands and the stink of the manure in the earth beneath her feet. Such things had swiftly ceased to matter as she went about her work with a mind oddly emptied of clutter and distractions.

I had had no idea how one behaved in a place like this...

Already, she had picked up the basic do's and don'ts of the sisterhood, accepted that she was an inconsequential junior member of the community whom the others viewed as a clumsy child in their midst.

Today was Good Friday but the chores still had to be done.

There were dishes to be scrubbed and washed, the laundry pummelled in the kitchen's big tubs and the garden tended, God's work to be accomplished in the intervals between abasement and worship, and devotions to be lived and to be celebrated.

In a funny sort of way, she half-suspected that she could be happy here...

"Come inside!"

That was when Melody became aware of the distant drone of an approaching aircraft.

Chapter 21

*Easter Saturday Friday 24th March
HMS Achilles, approaching Bermuda*

Surgeon Lieutenant Abraham Lincoln of the Royal Naval Air Service had assumed, wrongly as it turned out, that the ship would cruise straight down to the Gulf of Spain before transiting the Windward Passage to make port at Kingston, Jamaica within the week. However, it transpired that this had never been the plan.

‘This is the Captain!’ The Old Man had announced over the Tannoy about an hour or so out of Norfolk. ‘In the morning we shall be rendezvousing with units of the Atlantic Fleet to conduct gunnery, anti-aircraft and anti-submarine evolutions. Thereafter, we will steam directly for Bermuda where we will top-off our bunkers, and take on fresh produce before steaming for the Caribbean. Divisional Commanders will be authorised to issue six-hour shore passes to their people while we are at Bermuda. That is all!’

The next day Achilles had joined a second, albeit modern^o— only half-a-dozen years in commission^o— light cruiser, HMS Culloden, a couple of miles astern of the battleship Tiger, which in company with the heavy cruiser Naiad had conducted a ‘full-bore shoot’.

Even at that distance the battleship’s broadsides had torn the air asunder like thunderclaps. Each time she unleashed a salvo the great ship had disappeared behind billowing clouds of smoke. It had been the most remarkable and the most sobering thing Abe had ever seen in his whole life.

Later that day Achilles had ranged up alongside the behemoth and delivered despatches from Norfolk via breeches buoy. A passive observer from the unobscured elevation of the catapult rails, Abe had stared in mute wonder at the castle of steel surging effortlessly through the rising Atlantic swell at fourteen knots, asking himself, not for the first time, what on earth those lunatics had thought was going to happen when they crashed speed boats and flimsy old aircraft into a thing like that!

Achilles and Culloden had had their own ‘shooting match’, engaging each other at a range of nearly thirteen thousand yards at speeds of up to

twenty-eight knots, their respective gun directors configured to shoot with a six-degree targeting offset.

There had been a frissance of excitement through the ship when one of the Culloden's broadsides fell only two hundred yards astern of the Achilles half-way through the exercise, otherwise both ships had fired with 'commendable accuracy and near optimal rates of fire' throughout the eighteen-minute-long exercise. According to the 'umpires', who subsequently analysed the 'gun plots' adjusting for the mandatory offsets, Achilles would have been bracketed seven times and hit at least three; Culloden bracketed nine times and, because she was a bigger ship, probably hit five or six times.

Needless to say, Captain Jackson authorised a second tot of Grog for the entire crew that evening!

This was also a Navy tradition: when one division or department excelled their triumph belonged to the whole ship. Culloden was not just the bigger ship—by at least three-and-a-half thousand tons—with twelve to Achilles's eight main battery rifles but her turrets were much more highly automated, and therefore, theoretically able to put approximately twice the weight of metal in the air at any one time. To have performed so well against a newer, larger vessel which also had a marginally superior 'ELDAR suite' was the highest possible compliment to Achilles's combat readiness.

But then, allegedly, every captain in the Atlantic Fleet blanched at going up against—one on one—a ship under the command of Captain the Honourable Francis Jackson, RN.

On the third day out from Virginia the weather had been too stormy for safe flying operations and Abe had spent the day conducting the morning sick parade, and later signing off the ship's registry of medical supplies.

Yesterday, the ship had turned south and worked up to twenty-three knots to be in position to make Bermuda in the middle of the calm spell forecast for the following day.

Twenty minutes ago, Abe's CO's Sea Fox had launched off Achilles's catapult. Now, after much 'messaging about' to hoist his own aircraft onto the launching rails and a short delay loading the firing charge to the aging, somewhat temperamental assembly, his charabanc was ready to launch.

Abe had never actually launched off a moving ship. In fact, this was his first catapult launch and he was not entirely sure what to expect.

Both Sea Fox seaplanes were being ‘jettisoned’ before the cruiser began to pick her way through the reefs and shoals protecting the superb natural anchorage within the elongated half-circle of the one hundred and eighty or so islands◦– the remnants of ancient volcanoes◦– of Bermuda. Apparently, the wheeled, land-plane Sea Fox was going to be stored on the catapult while the ship was in harbour and more equipment◦– depending on who one asked◦– was going to be installed therein, or removed, meaning that one of the float planes was going to have to be part-mothballed, its wings folded back, fuel tanks and lubricant reservoirs drained, its gun unloaded for safety before they could be re-hoisted onto Achilles as ‘deck cargo’ for the journey south.

To Abe it seemed like an unnecessarily complicated way of doing things.

‘Yes, of course we could just unload the kites alongside the dock in Bermuda,’ Ted Forest had agreed, ‘but then this way the deck crew, the Section Commander *and you*, get the experience of a catapult launch while the ship’s under way. The Old Man is a tartar for using every opportunity to train his people.”

Now Abe was waiting to be shot off the Achilles as she idled along in the thankfully benign Atlantic swell. His eyes were rivetted to the launch officer standing below the right-hand end of the catapult rails.

‘Look, there’s nothing to it,’ Ted Forest had assured him. ‘We make sure the kite is locked down, run up the engine to full power, wait a few seconds to check that everything is hunky dory, the launch officer gives you the nod,’ a chopping down of both arms like a linesman at Wimbledon signifying that a close line call was *good*, ‘then the crew releases the brake, we wiz forward and a second later the impellor charge goes off firing a blast of compressed air into the back of the sled and the next thing you know we’ve gone from nought to sixty knots in no time flat and we’re in the air!’

Abe held the throttle up against the stops.

The Sea Fox thrummed and vibrated, desperate to surge ahead.

Before him there was nothing between the blur of the propeller and the shores of the Iberian Peninsula thousands of miles away. He raised his right hand, thumbs up and quickly grabbed the control stick, bracing himself.

The launch officer’s arms came down in the approved manner.

The ball is good...

The aircraft began to move.

There was a popping BANG, Abe was pressed back in his seat and in the blink of an eye the Sea Fox was airborne. Gentle pressure on the stick and they were climbing away from the cruiser.

“I told you it was a piece of cake!” The man in the rear cockpit chortled over the intercom.

Climbing to fifteen hundred feet Abe circled the cruiser once, then again before wagging his wings and turning south towards the long, low sprawl of the archipelago protecting the finest natural anchorage for hundreds of miles in any direction.

Achilles’s two float planes had taken off with only about thirty minutes fuel in their tanks so there was no real scope for ‘sightseeing’ or the usual ‘malarkey’ that ‘RNAS types got up to’.

Abe throttled back and tried to detect the navigable channels between the reefs through which the cruiser would have to tiptoe to get into the deep water of the Great Sound at the south-western expanse of the archipelago. He was struck by how crystal clear the blue water was and how easily he could see every lurking shoal just beneath the surface.

There were two destroyers tied up in the inner basin of the Navy Dockyard, and a big tanker – presumably off-loading its cargo – at the oiling jetty refilling the ‘tank park’ on Ireland Island. Achilles’s first Sea Fox had already put down and was taxiing through the gap in the breakwater between Cross Island and the isthmus to its north.

Abe circled, making absolutely certain he had his bearings and that he had got his nerves under control again, before lining up and putting down, rather more bumpily than he had planned. The wind was gusting a little despite the cloudless skies and the waters of the Great Sound were nowhere near as millpond flat as he had expected. Nevertheless, soon he pointed the aircraft’s nose towards Cross Island.

Achilles was only just beginning to pick her way through the shoals by the time the Sea Fox was safely moored to a floating jetty directly astern of the Section CO’s seaplane.

It seemed that Achilles was due to berth alongside the main quay, well over a mile away as a bird might fly but two or three by land. It was early afternoon and the sun burned down on the naval aviators who quickly began to divest themselves of their heavy leather flying accoutrements. Goggles, helmets, fur-lined jackets, essential to survival at ten thousand feet were somewhat superfluous in the tropical heat of Bermuda.

Ted Forest looked around.

He sniffed, and when he spoke his voice was a little vexed.

"I'd expected dancing girls, or suchlike!" He complained.

"I don't think this is *that* sort of tropical island, Ted," Abe chuckled wryly, thinking about his very own 'dancing girl' he had left behind in Norfolk. He had been away less than a week and already he felt disconnected from things, incomplete without his precious... Tekonwenaharake.

Belatedly, he remembered the folded papers he had stuffed inside his jacket before clambering up onto the catapult and dropping into the cockpit of his Sea Fox half-an-hour ago.

"I reckon the fort must be over there," he decided, pointing across the basin to the barracks and what looked like white bastion walls in the middle distance.

Surgeon-Commander Flynn, Abe's medical superior had asked him to visit his opposite number on Bermuda.

'I plan to keep out of his way, ancient history, you understand,' the older man had explained, for him somewhat tersely, for reasons he soon clarified. "There was a member of the fair sex involved, I'll say no more. Other than Ralph" the officer Abe was charged to visit, "and I don't get on with each other. We've managed to avoid each other for the last fifteen years, be a pity to come to blows again at our advanced ages, what?"

Achilles had sailed with a regulation medicine 'cupboard' fully stocked but Flynn wanted to 'cadge whatever tropical medicaments' could be begged, borrowed or stolen from the Fleet Stores on Bermuda.

Guardships on the Caribbean and other distant stations were de facto floating hospitals, their crews often deployed ashore as good Samaritans mending infrastructure and 'mucking in' on local construction projects. Yes, they were there to keep good order, to knock heads together if it came to it, and occasionally, to hunt pirates and such like but wherever the Navy went it looked first to make friends, influence people and to preserve the King's Peace any way it could. That was why most ships returned from their stations with their drugs lockers emptied; so, Abe's chief wanted as much 'therapeutic ammunition' as he could get his hands on before Achilles 'shot' the Windward Passage into the Caribbean.

Ted Forest had offered to accompany Abe on his delicate mission and he was grateful of his moral support. They had begun on foot, hitching a lift

from a passing Military Police patrol. Soon they were outside the gates of the base hospital. Chatting to their driver Abe had learned that the main hospital was located across the other side of the Great Sound in the town of Hamilton, which was where all the ‘bigwigs’ hung out and the location of all the best bars and ‘fleshpots’ of Bermuda were to be found.

Achilles’s Surgeon had informed Abe that his counterpart on Bermuda was ‘not a fellow who approved of such things’ and therefore confined himself to the Naval Base most of the time.

For a man he claimed to have fallen out with and to not, like very much, Abe thought his chief seemed to know an awful lot about Surgeon Captain Ralph McNab.

Thinking about it later he realised he ought not to have been totally surprised when he was ushered into an airy office and greeted by a man who was the spitting image of Michael Powell Flynn.

It transpired that McNab was older, by five years, than his half-brother, Achilles’s avuncular surgeon, Michael. McNab’s mother had remarried a Bostonian physician a year after his father’s death. As is often the case the two brothers ° – albeit half-brothers ° – had been broken from radically different temperamental templates and this was self-evident from the moment Captain McNab opened his mouth.

“The damned philanderer doesn’t have the courage to face me man to man!”

Abe did not care to disagree with a four-ringer.

Especially as he was half in-uniform as a pilot and half out of uniform as a surgeon-lieutenant and he got the distinct impression that Captain McNab was the sort of man who put men on charges for a lot less. The most disarming aspect of the meeting was that the elder brother had exactly the same Boston-Irish accent of his sibling, not to mention several of his mannerisms.

“I suppose Michael has sent you to raid my medical lockers?”

Abe saw no good reason to lie.

“Yes, sir. Surgeon-Commander Flynn has spoken to me of the exigencies of service especially on the Leeward Islands Station and Trinidad.”

Captain McNab had re-taken his seat and now viewed the young man before him with thoughtful eyes.

“Are you a competent surgeon, Lieutenant?”

“Not yet, sir. I plan to be one day.”

The older man reviewed Abe’s relative dishevelment.

“I never knew my father,” he said, astonishing the younger man. “You and I have that in common. That and the contagion that is my brother.”

Abe kept his mouth firmly shut.

Albert Stanton had observed that ‘being famous cuts two ways and not invariably in the ways you’d like it to.’ Thus far, the Navy had shielded Abe from the worst of that.

“That was unfair,” McNab apologised punctiliously. “Often it is best to separate family and service matters. Never the twain shall meet, and all that. I take it Michael sent you over with a list?”

“Yes, sir.”

“Leave it with my secretary,” the older man decided, indicating that the interview was concluded.

Chapter 22

Easter Saturday 25th March

Hacienda de Cortés, Navalperal de Tormes, Avila

Albert Stanton had initially feared he had broken three or four bones—important ones—after he had finally come to rest against the bowl of a gnarled olive tree in the fading light of yesterday afternoon. In retrospect he was to reflect that it was a miracle his spectacles had survived undamaged, stowed at the last minute in an inside pocket of his jacket before he had fallen into the void. He had lain very still for some minutes before the pain started to ease and air slowly, gaspingly, re-filled his lungs as his parachute billowed around, and eventually over his prostrate form.

He had taken Paul Nash's—the man had to be a spy or some kind of special forces soldier whom he hoped, fervently, was actually on *his* side but would have been hard-pressed to testify under oath that he was entirely convinced he was—talk about Portugal with a pinch of salt. It would not have been the first, or the last big lie the man had told him.

Portugal was a friendly country: why on earth would they be parachuting into it like thieves in the night (and heavily-armed ones at that)?

'Bend your knees and roll when you hit the ground,' had been another lie. For one, it pre-supposed you knew you were about to 'hit' the ground, when in fact, 'the ground' had 'hit' him first!

The unmarked Blenheim twin-engine transport aircraft had been waiting for them outside Perpignan, its very military, RAF-looking crew, clearly feeling somewhat out of sorts in their grubby civilian flying kit.

'The container with all the stuff we're going to need once I get the ladies to Navalperal de Tormes will follow you out of the door,' Paul Nash had explained airily to Stanton, who, in retrospect had taken in very little of the advice or the pseudo-information he was given before or during the long, very bumpy 'terrain-hugging' flight south. 'The static line will automatically spring your chute a couple of hundred feet after you jump', actually he had frozen in the open hatch and had to be pushed, 'so, all you

have to do is find and secure the supplies in the container before you make contact...’

None of which took account of him bashing his head when he landed, or his being so badly concussed that by the time he had stopped throwing up and his eyes were starting to focus it was pitch black inside the olive grove he had come down in.

This is insane...

And now there were people in the grove nearby.

He could hear his parachute, somehow detached from him rustling and cracking in the branches. He knew he was never going to find the container and its precious supplies. The whole thing was hare-brained; how the Devil was Nash going to find ‘the ladies’ in the bloody mountains in the first place? Let alone get from there to here— God only knew how many miles separated their jump positions— and find him again?

No, this is beyond insane...

Nash claimed to know where Melody Danson and the Governor of New England’s daughter had been ‘parked’ for quote: ‘safe keeping’.

Not that Stanton needed to know this, or really, anything about anything in particular.

‘We can’t have you blabbing the first time they snip off one of your fingers, old man,” Nash had guffawed cheerfully.

There had been a bright light in Stanton’s face.

That must have been when the man from the *Manhattan Globe* passed out...

Now, he blinked into muzzy-headed consciousness.

Somebody was swinging a hammer against the inside of his skull as if he had the worst hangover in human history and he was half-afraid to open his eyes in case he bled to death.

A cool, damp cloth was placed on his brow.

He did not understand what was being said to him, registering only that the woman’s voice was soothing, unthreatening.

He groaned, attempted to sit up.

Bad mistake; he collapsed back into the warm, soft pillows.

Okay, the Inquisition have not got me yet...

“Rest easy, Señor,” the woman said in awkward, heavily accented English. “The Alcalde has been called...”

Albert Stanton squinted myopically at the woman, a large lady with a heavily tanned complexion and dark eyes, who was smiling stoically.

“Where am I?” The man croaked. He had no Spanish, other than pigeon.

“You are among friends and my husband’s men have buried your,” she hesitated, “goods in the hills. Even if they look the militia will find nothing. But they will not look...”

The woman pressed a cup to his lips and cool liquid slipped like nectar across his parched palate and down his throat.

“Little at a time,” he was cautioned. Then: “You do a very brave thing. These are bad times...”

Stanton slept after that and when he awakened the nausea and the worst of his pain was gone. He reached around for his glasses, found them on a table by the bed, crammed them on his face. His head remained sore, his thoughts muzzy but he felt stronger, strong enough to swing his feet over the side of the bed and scan the room for a suitable pot or bowl in which to relieve his bursting bladder.

Hearing movement a man entered the room.

“Bathroom?” Stanton muttered.

“Of course. This way.”

Presently, the New Englander looked at himself in the mirror.

Not a pretty sight!

His left cheek, which seemed about twice its normal size, was stitched— it was hard to tell if that was one or two gashes— and he was going to have the mother and father of all black eyes. His nose felt... wrong, and his spectacles would not quite sit normally atop it. His ribs hurt and his right knee was swollen, hardly mobile.

What was it they said: ‘Worse things happen at sea?’

The Alcalde, Don Jose de Cortés, was a broad, magnificently moustachioed man in his sixties who insisted that Stanton “lie down again before you fall over” in heavily accented English, and drew up a chair by his bedside before sobering, albeit only by a degree before offering to fill him in on one or two little things that “my good friend el Escorpion will have neglected to share with you!”

“The Scorpion?”

Don Jose grimaced and slapped his right thigh.

“My Duke’s name for Señor Nash. But,” he chortled and shook his head, “but it is apt.”

Don Jose’s ‘lord’ was Alonso Pérez de Guzmán, 18th Duke of Medina Sidonia, whom Albert Stanton had never met but heard a lot of conflicting things about during the two years that the man was his country’s Consul General in Philadelphia. The consensus had been that he was a charming, somewhat dim-witted buffoon, an aristocratic place man a little out of his depth in New England who was most famous for his legendary philandering.

Stanton got confused at this point. Well, if he was being honest, *even more confused*, and because he was so beaten up, he must have allowed his bewilderment to show.

He compounded this when he admitted: “Nash told me to hide the ‘equipment’— I haven’t a clue what was in that big box— I dropped with and that he would rendezvous with me here, and then...”

Actually, he realised he had no idea what was supposed to, or likely, to happen *then*.

“Are you a soldier?”

“I did my militia service several years ago. I know which end of a rifle to hold, but...”

Don Jose smiled sympathetically.

“What?” Stanton blurted.

“Perhaps, your pen will be mightier in our cause than any sword we might put in your hands, Señor Stanton.”

The reporter did not care to contemplate the thought that Paul Nash— or whoever the man he had met on the Express train to Lyon was— had played him like a fish on the end of a very short line, flattering and bamboozling him into jumping out of a bloody aeroplane, for goodness sake!

The older man had turned deadly serious.

“If all goes well, we shall be reunited with his excellency, the Duke of Medina Sidonia and our Catholic Monarch Sophia Louise in Portugal. In the meantime, we await the arrival of the Scorpion and his charges, then, if necessary, we shall fight our way to the border.”

Chapter 23

*Wednesday 29th March
Government House, Philadelphia*

The Chairman of the Virginia Colonial Legislative Council, Roger Emerson Lee III, who liked to tell anybody so foolish as to hang on his words that he was distantly related to Light Horse Lee, an obscure minor figure in the revolt of 1776, whom, in their wisdom the English had ‘graciously rehabilitated’, thus founding his most ‘loyal’ of ‘loyal families’. Basically, he was a man so full of his own importance that it never occurred to him that even his political allies regarded him as a self-serving buffoon. Nevertheless, owing to his innate ruthlessness and absolute belief in his own right to speak for ‘his people’ he had inexorably risen up the greasy pole of colonial politics to not only lead the majority faction in his own Colony’s legislature but had recently been appointed Director of the Organisation of Chairmen of the Fifteen, the mouthpiece of the East Coast crown colonies.

Fifty-seven years old, handsome in that fleshy Virginian planter fashion and the son of perhaps, one of the five wealthiest dynasties in New England, he was vain, thin-skinned and unfussy about letting the truth, or the unimpeachable facts about a given matter get in the way of his take on reality.

His favourite sound bite was: ‘They would say that, wouldn’t they?’

Or: ‘I thought you were too clever to be taken in that easily!’

Lee made Philip De L’Isle’s— for his many egregious sins in previous lives, he could think of no other rational explanation, by the Grace of God and the Great Seal of England wielded by his Majesty, King George V, Governor of the Commonwealth of New England— blood boil. Whereas, he too was a man born to extraordinary privilege, he had spent his whole adult life in the service of his Monarch, doing his duty; whereas, Lee had never stopped sucking at the teat of wealth and power, never once thinking to actually serve anybody but himself.

Obviously, the Governor betrayed none of this as he rose to greet his visitor that morning.

“What a pleasant surprise, Roger,” he smiled. “I trust Elizabeth and the children are well?”

Lee’s wife was a semi-recluse on the family’s vast Arlington Estate and ‘the children’ – idle, spoiled brats aged between sixteen and thirty-four – the eldest of whom, now an independently wealthy merchant banker, had had very little to do with the patriarch of the Lee clan for years.

“Fine, fine,” the Virginian said curtly.

De L’Isle waved his visitor towards comfortable chairs with a view through the veranda windows of his office to the gardens beyond.

“Always good to see you, of course,” he remarked as the men took their seats, “but your secretary did not give us any indication what you wanted to talk about, Roger?”

As if Philip De L’Isle did not know exactly what the puffed-up overbearing oaf wanted to talk about!

The other man parried the question.

He was accustomed to doing things only in his own good time and that, he determined was not quite yet.

“You must be dreadfully worried about Lady Henrietta?”

“She’s a resourceful young woman. I am sure she will emerge, sooner or later from the imbroglio in Spain.”

“It goes without saying that I and my colleagues in the Virginia Colonial Legislature share your *hopes* for her safety.”

“Thank you. My wife and I draw great strength from the loyal support of *all* New Englanders in these trying times.”

It was not as if both men knew that the other would rather be having this conversation in a boxing ring than the urbane, gentrified setting of Government House. Although, in all things involving risk to his person or dignity Roger E. Lee III usually preferred to nominate a second to do his dirty work, take the hard knocks, and if necessary, sacrifice himself to the greater good of the Lee dynasty.

The Governor of New England, a man who had survived any number of ‘close shaves’ in his long and distinguished career as an officer in the Grenadier Guards and bore the scars to prove it, had never sent another man into harm’s way alone and had a truly heroic contempt for moral cowards like the politician sitting smugly before him.

“As distasteful as it is at such a sad time,” Lee prefaced, with every appearance of a troubling existential angst he did not feel, shifting uneasily

in his chair more on account of his piles than any qualms of his conscience, “but you will be aware that against my own wishes, the VCL has again voted in favour of the abolition of the Colonial Security Service...”

Matthew Harrison was not even cold in the ground and the bastards were raking over his life’s legacy!

“Yes,” the Governor of New England agreed blankly, “it is *distasteful*, Roger.”

“I would have preferred to have delayed this interview until after Matthew’s interment...”

“Why didn’t you?” Philip De L’Isle inquired, pleasantly as if he was genuinely curious to know the answer. “Defer this interview until after tomorrow’s funeral?”

“We live in an age when decisions must be made regardless of the sensibilities...”

“That is not my approach to colonial governance, Roger. Nor will it be while I sit in this chair.”

Once, as a very young man De L’Isle had fought a duel against an arrogant, unprincipled charlatan like Lee. Although the blaggard had fired at him before the umpire had dropped his handkerchief, no harm had been done as each party’s seconds had handed their unknowing principals revolvers loaded with blanks. De L’Isle had not exercised his right to – notionally – gun the bounder down; a man like that was not worth the cost of a single bullet!

“Surely, you cannot consider rejecting a vote of the VCL out of hand, Governor?”

“The VCL speaks for Virginia, not New England, Roger.”

“The VCL is speaking for the rest of the Fifteen...”

The Chairmen of the other fourteen Colonial Legislatures had backed Lee to be their spokesperson not because they thought he was the best man for the job, rather because most of them realised that the job was of that particularly ruinous type whereby any applicant was best advised to drink poison before accepting it.

“You will be aware that the position of Director of the Organisation of Chairmen of the Fifteen has no constitutional under-pinning, Roger,” the Governor reminded his guest urbanely.

He would not normally have cut to the chase so artlessly but it was not as if Roger Lee’s motives were anything but transparent.

“A colony’s rights are inalienable,” he went on benignly, a sympathetic smile playing on his lips, “until such time as it formally surrenders those rights and privileges in combination to a third party. So, if you want to engage me in a conversation about Virginia’s rights after the abrogation of its colonial status well, we probably ought to call in a constitutional lawyer right now.”

The other man objected before he engaged his brain.

“The Fifteen have a legitimate right to seek common ground and to petition the Governor’s Office in respect of its demands...”

Roger Lee flinched the moment he had said it, knowing he had been provoked into intemperance.

“*Demands*, Roger?”

“I misspoke. *Concerns*. Yes, that’s the word. *Concerns*...”

Philip De L’Isle eyed the other man for several long, silent seconds.

“One is always duty-bound to listen to the ‘concerns’ of senior members of the colonial establishment with the due deference they deserve, Roger. That has always been the case. My door is always open to the Governors of His Majesty’s Colonies and the senior representatives of their peoples. In fact, I can confidently claim, that no Governor of the Commonwealth has ever been as willing to listen to the voice of the peoples of New England as I, or the officers of my administration.”

Right from the outset of his time in Philadelphia, De L’Isle had operated under the assumption that while the Colonies had responsibilities to the Old Country, the Old Country had even more responsibilities in the New World. In his father’s day the mandarins at the Foreign and Colonial Office still talked about the ‘White Man’s Burden’, well, nowadays, across an Empire in which at least twice as many of its people were coloured than white, the burden was a profoundly multi-racial, mixed-culture, increasingly less-European-centric contract and he could not see for the life of him how it could be that here, in New England, so many well-educated, otherwise intelligent and hard-working people who liked to believe they were Christians, could be so bloody pig-headed!

Not that a single scintilla of his frustration got past his well-constructed imperial pro-consul’s mask.

“Sorry, are you threatening to intervene directly in my colony’s affairs?” Roger Lee blurted.

“No,” De L’Isle retorted patiently. “That would only occur in the most extreme, frankly, unimaginable circumstances, as you well know, Roger. You should also know me well enough by now to know that I would never allow anybody else to interfere in Virginian, or in any other colony’s affairs without just, constitutional cause. My opposition to the improper usage of that power would be of the ‘over my dead body’ variety!”

“Oh...”

“All that is hypothetical, anyway,” the Governor went on smoothly. “You know how I hate hypotheticals.”

“The Fifteen have a number of ‘concerns’,” Lee said cautiously.

The Chairmen of several of the Colonial Legislatures were notorious gossipers and leakers, gregarious to a fault as befitted men who oversaw what were, essentially over-blown talking shops. The big in-colony decisions rested with the Governors, and the status of the legislative councils was other than in colony-specific areas, consultative rather than strictly ‘legislative’. The *Legislative Assembly Acts of 1872, 1903 and 1954* had been very careful not to transfer too much power, or budgetary control, from Governors to elected politicians. The reason behind this had been that every colony in New England and Canada was already represented by at least two directly elected Members in the House of Commons, therefore the question of a so-called ‘democratic deficit’ simply did not arise.

De L’Isle raised an eyebrow.

“By all means share them with me, Roger,” he invited his guest.

“In the event of war...”

“Ah, so we are talking *hypothetically* after all?”

“We have a right to expect the Empire to defend our territory and our economic interests.”

“Yes.”

“In the Great War the Empire treated New England like a huge cash cow. It took us decades to recover from that.”

It took the whole Empire a generation to recover from the war of 1857-66. De L’Isle would have given the Virginian a history lesson if he had thought the man would listen to a single word he said.

“Virginia will not again be bled white to defend *British* interests, Governor!”

Philip De L’Isle blinked at this. Of all the colonies none would be so enriched by a major war as Virginia. The naval base at Norfolk alone was,

to use Lee's own words, a giant 'cash cow' for the colony.

"British interests, Roger? I am confused. In any likely scenario that I can foresee the object of imperial policy in this hemisphere would be the defence of New England..."

"The cost of which ought to be borne by the British taxpayer."

"And presumably," the Governor murmured angrily, and for once, inexcusably he was to reflect, losing his temper, "English blood, too?"

"I didn't say that."

The Governor of New England rose to his feet.

"Forgive me, I have another appointment shortly, Roger. Please give my regards to Elizabeth."

The Virginian looked at him as if he thought he had misheard.

"Sorry, I..."

"Good day to you, sir," De L'Isle smiled, grim-faced.

A few minutes later he went upstairs to have tea with his wife, Lady Diana, whom he found propped up in a chair in the window of her chambers. He bent his head to kiss her cheek.

"My, my, what was that for, darling?"

The husband sighed, pulled up a chair beside her. His wife was having one of her 'better days' and this knowledge was immensely curative. He shook his head.

"I was just unspeakable terse with Roger Lee," he confessed. "That man is a disgrace. If I had had a gun, I would have shot him!"

"No, you wouldn't have, darling. You don't have it in you to shoot a defenceless man."

Presently, the better angels of De L'Isle's nature were not wholly in the ascendant.

"Trust me, my dear," he grimaced. "I'd certainly have winged the bloody man!"

"I'd have understood perfectly if you'd given him a good kick up the backside, darling," his wife commiserated. Neither of them was quite themselves. Matthew Harrison's death— a brutal assassination more likely, since the car involved had sped off— was too fresh, too painful and they were worried all the time about Henrietta...

"Honestly, my love," her husband groaned, "the people over here don't know how lucky they are. They pay half the tax a citizen of the British Isles pays and get two-thirds of the bill for defending New England defrayed by

the Exchequer in London. It's hardly surprising that the average family in the First Thirteen is thirty or forty percent better off than their counterparts in the Old Country!"

"Oh, dear," Lady Diana smiled bravely, "if you're talking about economics you must still be really angry!"

"I'm sorry," he guffawed. "I know I shouldn't let little weasels like Roger Lee get under my skin. But..."

His wife patted his arm.

"You mustn't be too hard on Roger, darling. Wasn't it one of his ancestors who fortified Manhattan so ineptly that our boys were able to just walk in unopposed after the Battle of Long Island?"

"Good old *Light Horse*, you mean?"

"Yes, dear."

Philip De L'Isle visibly relaxed, the tension draining out of his face.

"Mind you," he guffawed quietly, "another of his ancestors fought with no little distinction in Flanders in the early 1860s."

"Oh, I was forgetting all about *Robert Lee*," his wife conceded. "It only goes to show, I suppose. He travelled to France as the Colonel of the Virginian Brigade and at the time of his death he was in command of," she paused, unable to recall the details.

"British Third Army during the successful advance to the Moltke Line." The Governor of New England involuntarily ran his left forefinger across his moustache. "If he had lived, he might have gone all the way to Berlin and finished the war in 1865. Instead, the old fellow is just a footnote to history, his campaigns one of the great 'what ifs?' endlessly discussed and war-gamed at staff colleges around the world ever since. Yet he is still a man largely forgotten by his own countrymen back here in Virginia, like so many of his fellow 'Imperial Virginians' because he won his fame exclusively on foreign battlefields."

"All historical memory is selective," his wife sympathised. "But if I've learned one thing since we arrived in Philadelphia, there is no gainsaying that *they* can be an awfully insular lot over here."

Chapter 24

Thursday 30th March

Monasterio de Nuestra Señora de la Asunción

‘You look terrible,’ Henrietta De L’Isle had blurted as her escorts bundled her into the small cold room high in the northern wall of the ancient monastery and she found herself face to face with Melody Danson.

Both women had been literally grabbed by gangs of sisters and hurried, at a stumbling run down gloomy corridors and up several flights of steps smoothed and partially worn away by generations of nuns’ feet since the late fifteenth century and arrived breathless, disorientated and on the verge of panic.

‘Be very quiet. Do not attempt to look out of the window...’

And then they had been alone listening to the iron tenon of the heavyweight very old and rusty, lock settle into the deep mortice in the granite frame of the door.

The women had looked at each other for a moment.

‘So, do you,’ Melody had returned, unable to stop a crooked smile spreading infectiously across her face and filling her suddenly twinkling green eyes.

In truth, they were both very nearly unrecognisable from the coiffured, expensively dressed women who, a fortnight ago, had luxuriated in the hospitality of the Hacienda de las Conquistadores, been winned and charmed by the Duke of Medina Sidonia, and wandered the streets of Chinchón like two fairy princesses.

Most obviously, their long hair had been crudely shorn off their heads. Now their hair was raggedly cut short as if they were boys, in places the ‘cut’ had been so close to the scalp that from a distance an observer might surmise they were Alopecia sufferers. In the flight from Chinchón and since they had both lost weight although probably no more than a few pounds but in places which now gave each a much leaner look, and eyes which were suggestively, rather than actually a little hollowed out. Melody’s fair skin had started to acquire a wind-burnt tan; while Henrietta’s fading girlhood freckles seemed somehow pronounced.

They had stared at each other for some seconds before falling into a clinging, sobbing embrace which had lasted many minutes. Eventually, they had begun to absorb their new surroundings. The grubby leaded glass of the small not quite square window situated above head height allowed in very little light and their vision slowly adjusted to the murk.

A palliasse lay in the corner of the cell farthest from the door, on it were two folded blankets. Under the window was a small, knobbly table upon which there was a single, small candle-holder but no candle. The nuns had placed a large earthenware jug— perhaps holding as much as two pints of water — and a pewter plate with several lumps of black bread and, wrapped in a white linen rag, a wedge of very hard cheese on it. Upon inspection they discovered that somebody had, thoughtfully, scraped a little of the mould off the cheese. There was the normal crudely fired bowl-cum-chamber pot beneath the rickety table under the window.

“Home sweet home,” Melody murmured.

The two women had not been able to exchange a single word after that first morning at the monastery. Now they did not know what to say.

“I was working in the kitchen garden when the panic started a few days ago,” Melody offered.

“I was in the chapel,” Henrietta returned. “The only time they don’t have me working is when I’m on my knees praying!”

The older woman smiled and the Governor of New England’s youngest daughter giggled involuntarily.

‘The panic’ had quickly evaporated only to recur again, and again, with the women being ushered hurriedly to their cells at regular intervals over the last few days. Today, ‘the panic’ was of a self-evidently different intensity, not just the appearance of a stranger or a passing pilgrim at the gate of the monastery.

“I never really paid much attention to my Latin classes at school,” Melody confessed, “but I seem to be getting a crash course here!”

Her grasp of Latin had been well-honed during her training for the Bar; however, she too was out of practice and in any event, had never really taken to the language as a tool of spoken communication. It did not help that many of the nuns casually employed positively archaic forms of Biblical and other liturgical texts. What had impressed her was that practically all the nuns she had come into contact with, many of whom seemed to be from peasant or labouring classes where traditionally, girls in

Spain had not been taught to read and write, were significantly more fluent in Latin than either she, or she suspected, Henrietta were.

“They’ve been keeping us away from the East Cloister,” Henrietta speculated, that’s where the monastery school is. I’ve heard children’s voices several times in the mornings. The younger woman spoke in a whisper. “Do you have any idea where this place is?”

“Somewhere north of Madrid. At least twenty, twenty-five miles to the north judging by the country we trekked through with Don Rafael.” Melody sighed. “That already seems like an age ago...” She had collected her wits again now. “I thought I heard an aeroplane before they called me inside that first time?”

“I heard a commotion in the gatehouse later that day.”

Melody was tight-lipped.

“It didn’t take them very long to find us, did it?” Henrietta went on, chewing her lower lip.

“No, it might not be that,” Melody said tartly, relenting immediately. “The whole country is in turmoil, so far as we know. At a time like this, old scores get settled. Old debts called in. Places like this might look like easy meat for deserters, chancers, local bigwigs who think the Mother Church or the Medina Sidonia family have lost their grip on things. Besides, up here in the mountains we’re an awfully long way from anything you or I would recognise as civilisation, or the rule of law.”

“Oh, I hadn’t thought about it like that,” Henrietta admitted sheepishly, badly wanting to be reassured.

“This place might be a closed book to the local Inquisition, for example,” Melody explained, deciding the best thing to quell her own fears was to carry on talking. “As for that aeroplane, well, there’s nowhere for it to land around here.”

“Bandits could just take over,” Henrietta posited. “What’s to stop them?”

“God,” Melody replied, with greater confidence than she felt. “The Mother Church is the one constant and we both know that the Catholic hierarchy tends to revert to an eye for an eye interpretation of Holy Scripture when somebody treads on its turf.”

“That’s true...”

“We’ve forgotten something,” Melody grinned.

“Oh, what?”

“This,” Melody breathed, kissing her lover open-mouthed as the women renewed their embrace.

Later they lay together, entwined for mutual warmth and mental solace, listening to the faint, distant sounds of the great citadel-like religious house.

No hue and cry came to their ears.

There were no heavy— or in fact, any— footsteps in the corridor on the other side of the impregnably locked door to their cell. Presently, evening drew on: they rose to nibble bread and pick at the cheese, which tasted bitter and stank unpleasantly as they broke through its crust, slaked their thirst with caution not knowing when the water jug might be re-charged and hurriedly crept back beneath the blankets to keep out the chill which quickly radiated from the thick walls of the castle keep when night fell.

Eventually, they slept.

Much later Henrietta blinked awake.

Candles burned nearby on the floor and on the table below the window, and a dark form loomed over the women, seated unmoving in a chair.

“Do not be alarmed,” the man said in a gently amused, unthreatening low baritone. He had spoken in English with a vaguely Canadian twang which might have originated anywhere in the Maritime Provinces or the upper colonies— Maine, Vermont or New Hampshire as easily— as in New Brunswick or Nova Scotia.

“Melody,” Henrietta hissed.

“I’m awake,” the older woman muttered, trying to prop herself on an unsteady elbow as she peered into the gloom. She did not ask the man who he was.

She already knew that.

As to what he was doing here in the Mountains of Madrid...

Well, that was the mother and father of all conundrums!

The last time she had spoken to Captain Paul Nash, an aide-de-camp to the Military Attaché of the United Kingdom Embassy in Madrid, he had struck her as a typical upper-class dimwit. The man had made a clumsy pass at her at that Embassy reception soon after she got to Madrid, and she had rebuffed him with barely veiled contempt. Which, she had assumed, was why they had not had a lot to do with each other since. During that first encounter and the others when their paths had crossed, he had affected a

positively effete hoity-toity upper-class accent which was so over the top it would have embarrassed a member of the Royal Household at Buckingham Palace!

She had naturally concluded that he was a spook.

Now, in the darkness his voice rang with confident authority.

“If I asked you who you really are would you tell me?” She asked, stifling a shivering yawn.

“Melody?” Henrietta asked, not yet recognising the stranger but cognisant that nothing about the mysterious interloper had panicked her partner.

“Brigadier Harrison and Lady Henrietta’s father wasn’t prepared to allow you, either of you, to go out and about without,” the man paused, chuckled lowly, “a safety net. Besides, in the beginning we didn’t trust Alonso.” He grunted ruefully at this juncture. “That was another mistake. If it wasn’t for him you two would almost certainly be enjoying the hospitality of the *Nacional de Inteligencia de Nuevo España*, or,” he reconsidered, “one or other of the various flavours of the Inquisition vying for position in Madrid.”

This was a classic case of too much disjointed information all in one mouthful for the women to quickly assimilate.

“Is Alonso all right?” Melody asked.

“Yes. The last time I heard. But that was a few days ago, now.”

Both women, still clutching the blankets close had sat up.

The man leaned forward, viewing them by the faint illumination of the candles.

He chuckled ruefully.

“Well, I don’t think there is anything I can suggest to improve your disguises, ladies!”

“Very funny!” Melody retorted.

“Sorry, but your own Mums wouldn’t recognise you and in the circumstances that’s all to the good. It’s pretty chaotic out there and we need to take advantage of that. Sooner or later the Generals,” he shrugged, “or it may be the Colonels, who tend to be better at insurrection than the old guard, will get themselves organised, wheel out the King-Emperor, or the most senior surviving member of the Royal Family, kiss the ring of the Cardinal of Madrid and turn a blind eye to the excesses of the Inquisition, then it will only be a matter of time— not long, I’d guess— before the towns

and the cities, and the borders, I daresay, get locked down tighter than a duck's arse."

"The Army mounted the coup?" Melody demanded.

"Maybe. Maybe, they just stepped in when the Court factions kicked off, or when the *Nacional de Inteligencia de Nuevo España* and the *Guardia Nacional* tried to move against the Cardinal of Madrid's personal inquisitors. All that stuff's way beyond my pay grade. Nobody on our side has the vaguest idea who organised the mass protests outside the Royal Alcazar that seem to have been the trigger, or the starting gun, for the craziness. Coups always work better in a climate of chaos when nobody has a clue what's really going on."

It was a lot to digest.

Neither woman spoke.

"Anyway, once Alonso had got word to us that he'd locked you two ladies away in a monastery," the man guffawed laconically, "that was a nice touch coming from a chap like the Duke," another chortle, "then it was the work of another couple of days to find somebody to fly the aeroplane and voila, here I am!"

Melody frowned.

"There's nowhere within ten or fifteen miles of here that a plane could land?"

"Well, not in one piece," the man whom she knew as Paul Nash agreed affably.

"That's why I had to parachute into the valley. It took me bloody hours to retrieve all my kit and then to climb all the way back up to the monastery!" He sniffed. "I'd hoped to be with you a couple of days ago. Sorry about that. I'd have been here a lot earlier if I hadn't bumped into those scoundrels La Superiora has been keeping at bay the last few days."

"Scoundrels?" Henrietta murmured.

"Their officer confided to me that his superiors wanted to get their hands on 'the Duke's whores' but that Sister Isabella had sent him away with a flea in his ear and a threat of ex-communication ringing in his ears..."

"There are people looking for us even up here in the mountains?" Melody checked, trying to figure out what the man had meant when he said 'bumped into'.

The man smiled, barring his teeth in the gloom.

“No, not anymore,” he said blankly.

Chapter 25

Friday 31st March

HMS Perseus, off St Margaret's Bay, Nova Scotia

Alex Fielding did not know how he felt about having been peremptorily transferred – temporarily, he hoped – from the Colonial Air Force to the Royal Naval Air Service.

Technically, this was a thing his home colony – New York – could have vetoed but given that by transferring Alex, and his whole squadron, to the Royal Navy, the ever-parsimonious bean counters back in the Defence Department in Albany got to defray the entire cost of operating 7NY Squadron to the British Exchequer, the people in the colonial capital had probably bitten off the Navy's hand when the transfer was first mooted.

Not that Alex had that much to complain about. He had been bounced to the rank of substantive Commander, with that rank's pay and prestige, while actually serving as only a Lieutenant-Commander aboard HMS Perseus. Basically, the three navy-rings on his sleeve seriously trumped his major's pips in the world of short-term CAF commissions. Heck, it almost made him 'respectable'!

Whoever would have seen that coming?

Not that any of that guff pre-occupied him that morning.

He had lost two of his guys already: one dead and another banged up so badly he was not going to be in uniform again, if ever, any time soon. That was in addition to the three men who had not cut it as naval aviators and a fourth who had decided that this new game – operating the Squadron's Goshawk Mark IVs off the deck of an aircraft carrier – was not for him. That was fair enough, none of them had signed up for the *Navy lark*!

The yardstick by which a man was certified 'deck qualified' was six successful landings on a carrier at sea. There was no time limit within which this had to be achieved, not officially. Unofficially, the Navy had wanted it done in a screaming hurry.

Land, take-off a minute later, climb back into the circuit, take your turn and come in to land again, and so on until a man had the magic six

‘survived’ deck landings.

Alex and sixteen of his nineteen remaining pilots— including a couple he had offered to transfer back to land-based operations because he had mistakenly thought they would get themselves killed on ‘this lark’ — had already qualified over two fraught days.

The last week had been brutal, not least because the Navy believed it was only a matter of time before it was right in the middle of a shooting war. Back on land the politicians, generals, legislators and media people could complacently pussy-foot around reality; out at sea the Navy had already activated War Plan Alpha-1978.

In the absence of specific guidance from the mandarins in London the Senior Service was doing what it always did in times of crisis, it prepared for the worst and hoped for the best. Which was why the huge aircraft carrier was gliding through the slowly lifting fog in the wake of two pilot boats to dock alongside Gun Wharf— a complex of quays linked to the magazines on the northern shore of the Naval Base which these days, virtually encircled St Margaret’s Bay. Perseus was at best half-worked-up, in no condition to punch even a proportion of her substantial weight but even a half-strength Combat Air Wing of some thirty-five aircraft, with a flight room filled with still raw, green ‘carrier airmen’ she was, to quote her CAW Commander: ‘One Hell of a beast!’

Alex had climbed up to the flight deck from his cabin in the bowels of the leviathan to get a bit of fresh air and untypically, to clear his head of some of the jangling contradictions he had rarely experienced down on the Border as a singleton ‘hot-shot scout jockey’. Much to his surprise the responsibilities of squadron command had washed off his shoulders like water off a proverbial duck’s back; right up to the moment they had told him about Perseus.

To have only had three bad crashes was near miraculous...

‘A testament to how well you’ve brought your chaps on,” the CAW had declared.

Alex thanked the fates that he had been lucky enough to have inherited half-a-dozen real fighter pilots, men who had served on the Border, survived enough scrapes to know that blinking twice was never going to cut it. Those experienced men had carried the ‘newbies’ and the ‘sprogs’ along in their wake, and to the credit of the CAF’s peacetime flight training programs— which old hands tended to regard as overlong and fussy— once

they had got over their terrors many of the junior men had soon got the hang of ‘catching a wire’.

Not that landing on the *Perseus* was ever going to be routine. If take-off and landing were the two most dangerous times on land then at sea, the perils were positively extreme. It was with good reason that the most hazardous place on any ship in the Royal Navy was the flight deck of an operational carrier.

Worse, the Navy was still only just beginning to get used to operating high-performance low-wing monoplanes like the Goshawk off the decks of the big new carriers. Previous experience flying string-bag, hundred-mile-an-hour machines too fragile to ‘catch a trap’ off the much smaller decks of the first carriers – often converted merchantmen or cruisers from the Reserve Fleet – significantly less than half the size of the *Ulysses* class ships, had proven useless and many of the attempts to transfer the ‘lessons’ learned in that previous era had ended up killing too many brave men.

Perseus was scheduled to be at St Margaret’s Bay for seventy-two hours. Insofar as the giant base was practically in the middle of nowhere and literally miles from what New Englanders – particularly from Alex’s neck of the wood – tended to call ‘civilisation’, its main attractions were a couple of big cinemas, and some of the most notorious bars in the Empire.

The gentrified civilian settlements where the wives and families of Navy personnel and the permanent civilian employees of the dockyards lived – regimented streets of detached and semi-detached married quarters up and down the coast and around Halifax to the north – were a world apart from Royal Navy St Margaret’s Bay.

The fleshpots of St Margaret’s Bay, wet and chilly, arctic for two to three seasons of each year were the exclusive preserve of the crews of visiting ships. Alex planned to take his boys on a monumental pub crawl they would remember the rest of their lives before *Perseus* sailed again. There was nothing like a party to blow away the cobwebs and besides, the Squadron’s fallen deserved a bloody good wake!

The carrier’s fog horn blared deafeningly.

Cynics claimed that the Empire had invested so heavily in the St Margaret’s Bay-Halifax shipbuilding, maintenance, stores and base infrastructure in the first half of the twentieth century, primarily in furtherance of a concerted attempt to shrug off the dead hand of organised labour back in the Old Country. However, if that had been the case the

Crown would hardly have developed Norfolk into the largest naval base in the World outside of Europe, nor would it have continually modernised and kept busy, the Admiralty yards at Brooklyn, given that the civilian workers employed in any Empire facility in either New England or Canada had— by statute— enjoyed the same workers' rights as their 'British' counterparts since as long ago as 1916.

People said the days of St Margaret's Bay were numbered. However, while it was true that none of the contracts for the new fleet carriers had been allocated to its yards, it was also true that the era in which the Navy mandated that its big ships be constructed in secret, far from the prying eyes of potential enemy agents, were long gone. The Ulysses class was being built as visibly as possible just so that *everybody* knew that the Royal Navy was acquiring and enthusiastically embracing, a new and formidable technological edge on its rivals.

Leonora had looked at Alex as if he was pulling her leg when he told her he was 'joining the Navy'; at the time he had rather been hoping that somebody was indeed pulling his leg! It had been a lot harder to leave her that last time, especially as he had no idea— nor did anybody else— when he would be back. Everybody assumed Perseus's home port was going to be Norfolk but in reality, that was no more than scuttlebutt. Other rumoured home ports had been Gibraltar, or Alexandria in Egypt, although it was said that Malta was unlikely because the dry docks there were too small.

The notion that he might be hundreds or thousands of miles away when his first— so far as he knew, he had been drunk a lot in the latter half of the 1960s and the first half-decade of the 1970s — son or daughter emerged squalling into the world, preyed on Alex's mind.

I must be getting old...

Either that or his twenty-one deck landings on and twenty take-offs from the deck of the Perseus to date, had reminded him of his own mortality.

In the middle distance the armoured flank of HMS Tiger was emerging from the mists, her fighting tops proudly grey, glistening in the damp air above the murk. The rumbling of the ammunition wagons carrying pallets of one-ton, 15-inch main battery rounds from the subterranean bunkers in the surrounding hills to the dockside reverberated across the dark waters.

Even in port the battleship's air search ELDAR aerials rotated slowly, ceaselessly and a translucent plume of light grey exhaust fumes rose from

her forward, raked funnel.

Although the Atlantic Fleet was not quite at war yet, every ship not in dockyard hands had at least one boiler lit, a watch closed up and several of her guns manned. On the forward flight deck Perseus had turned out a hundred men to salute the Admiral's flag flying from Tiger's main mast halyards.

A small saluting gun popped.

The men on deck came to attention.

Chapter 26

Friday 31st March

Monasterio de Nuestra Señora de la Asunción

Melody guessed Captain Paul Nash, allegedly of the Seaforth Highlanders – she took his stated rank, name and regimental affiliations with a particularly suspicious and very large pinch of salt – was in his early to mid-thirties with a build that might have been designed for trekking across one hundred and seventy miles of mountains, valleys and forests along the spine of the Sierra de Guadarrama, Sierra del Norte and the Sierra de Gredos all the way to the Portuguese border. Unfortunately, Melody had no illusions that her and Henrietta's bodies were in any way 'up to it', and this she had pointed out to their would-be rescuer in no uncertain terms.

The man had listened respectfully.

He was stocky, quite obviously without an ounce of extraneous flesh on his teak-hard muscled skeleton, an inch or so taller than Henrietta which made him about five feet ten in height, and moved with an almost cat-like grace and purpose.

What he had neglected to tell the two women last night prior to advising them to try to get as much sleep as possible, was that when, several days ago, he had thrown himself out of the light plane several thousand feet above the *Monasterio de Nuestra Señora de la Asunción*, he had jumped with a cannister containing weapons, lightweight camping equipment, iron rations, packs of dried ready-cook meals, a first aid kit, several courses of anti-biotics – because you never knew if you might need them – and his 'personal' weapons: an automatic assault rifle, a .45-inch calibre semi-automatic pistol, enough ammunition to start a small war and a wicked, hunting knife with a nine-inch blade, razor-sharp on one side and serrated on the other which he carried strapped to his left shin.

In total he had carried a load of some eighty plus pounds three miles up the mountain from his 'drop site' in the valley below the monastery. And somehow, he had dealt with or got past the – presumably heavily armed – men La Superiora had turned away from the doors of the monastery yesterday afternoon.

Melody had no doubt that ‘Paul Nash’ had secreted other nefarious and very deadly weapons about his person.

He had also lugged up the mountain camouflaged cold-weather smocks and trousers, several pairs of thick woollen socks and of all things, fur-lined caps for Melody and Henrietta. And wonder of wonders, the kit actually fitted them!

The women were astonished when they were presented with well-worn but comfortable calf-length walking boots, items Sister Isabella had instructed to be recovered from the monastery’s storeroom of items surrendered, possibly decades ago, by women who had ‘entered our house’, thereby renouncing all property.

While Melody and Henrietta had been trying to sleep and not really succeeding, ‘Nash’ had been busy investigating what the monastery’s resources had to offer, apparently without demur from La Superiora. Whether this was because Sista Isabella was looking forward to having her step-brother’s ‘whores’ off her hands, or she was relishing the opportunity to thumb her nose at ‘those idiots in Madrid’, watching Melody and Henrietta don the clothes their presumptive rescuer had brought them, the old woman had almost threatened to smile.

La Superiora’s relatively good humour even survived the news that Nash had decided to delay setting off another day. Ostensibly, this was to give ‘the ladies’ another few hours to take in as many calories as possible and rest up a little longer.

Several of the dried ◦ – desiccated would be a more precise description ◦ – ready meals, high protein stews were cooked up, filling Melody’s and Henrietta’s bellies for the first time in a fortnight, inducing an afternoon siesta from which they later awakened marginally refreshed and temporarily, a little less afraid of the ordeal to come.

It was Henrietta who asked the obvious question: “Why isn’t it safe here anymore?”

“It was never safe here,” La Superiora informed her in suddenly clipped, very received British Broadcasting Corporation English which had both younger women blinking at her. “My brother has worked very hard to remain unaligned, a so-called honest broker between the King-Emperor’s El Escorial conservative faction and the Queen’s Aranjuez modernisers. Unfortunately, gossip ties him to Sophia’s,” she shrugged, “petty coats. I have no idea if the rumours are true but our families ◦ – that of the Queen

when she was one of several young girls mooted for marriage into the Royal Family— were very close and Alonso even as a very young man, was a very hard boy to not fall in love with.” A flicker of unlikely fond remembrance was instantly extinguished. “The Mother Church will afford this house some small protection but only at a cost, namely, its expropriation from the family’s hands. It depends how confident the Holy See in Rome is in its agents in Madrid as to whether I find myself the object of a bull of anathema. This is a matter of no importance to me. I am too old to accompany you on your journey to freedom; and in any case, I refuse to flee from the cowards of the false Inquisitions that plague the Empire. I shall stay and fight.”

Outside the rain was sleeting down driven nearly to the horizontal by the wind which howled through the mountains.

“We shall depart when the gale abates,” Paul Nash declared. “At whatever hour that may be.”

Both Melody and Henrietta would be carrying old canvas knapsacks, taking the edge— but little more— off the load their muscular guardian angel planned to hump across the Mountains of Madrid. Each woman would heft extra blankets, and between them much of the food including hard tack biscuits from the monastery’s stores. The man would be transporting a lightweight tent, ground sheets, a stove and two small gas bottles, all the medical supplies bar the anti-biotics which he had donated to Sister Elvira, the order’s carer for the sick. It went without saying that he planned to— very personally— carry all the weaponry he had brought with him from...

“Where exactly did you come from, Paul?” Melody asked waspishly.

“From the sky, dear lady.”

Okay, military types tended to be paranoid about secrecy. She got that. Not that it was going to stop her asking questions.

“Alonso sent you?”

“Yes and no.”

“That’s no answer at all!” She complained.

“True,” he retorted blandly. “For all you know I could be working for the Spanish Government. I might be about to kidnap you for ransom or to deliver you into the hands of the Inquisition.”

Henrietta had quirked askance at Melody.

Whose impatience was almost tangible: “If that was your game you’d have turned up with a small army and you’d already have whisked us away to your lair in the mountains!”

“I might not have?”

Melody had frowned even harder.

“Okay, but that’s what I’d probably have done.”

The man had started cleaning his Martini Henry assault rifle, a wickedly compact weapon capable of a rate of fire of nearly six hundred rounds per minute in full-automatic mode. Three spare thirty-round magazines were packed into his body webbing. The clips for his pistol, which he had laid on the floor beside him as he worked, each contained eight soft-nosed .45 BSA – Birmingham Small Arms – factory patent bullets. From the slickly choreographed, precisely executed way he disassembled and re-assembled both weapons, Melody guessed he could do it blindfold, or in the dark of the night, or under fire faultlessly, nervelessly.

“According to your New York Constabulary file you refused to undergo fire arms training or to carry a gun on duty, Ms Danson?” The man inquired, idly.

“I was terrified I’d shoot my foot off.”

“That’s why you do the training, to stop that sort of thing happening.”

“I don’t think I could ever shoot anybody.”

The man thought about this.

“No? You’d be surprised,” he sighed. “Maybe, you just haven’t met enough people who’d be better off dead yet.”

Melody recoiled with a horror which was unfeigned.

“Seriously,” the man smiled wanly. “Trust me on this one. Some people you can’t argue with, the only thing you can do is kill them before they kill you.”

Melody and Henrietta were alone in the room with the man.

“Who sent you?”

“Brigadier Harrison,” she was informed wryly. “The day after he and Alonso proposed your name for the Joint Commission in Madrid.”

“Alonso?” Henrietta De L’Isle queried in disbelief.

“He was the one who proposed the Commission to ‘take the sting’ out of the revelations about the Empire Day outrages that *you*,” he looked to Melody, “so adroitly brought into the public domain last year that the Governor was, against all expectations, able to exert some small influence

over the excesses of what I believe in New England is called the ‘news cycle’. We’d known for some time, years in fact, that there were a large number of bad actors here in Old Spain and out in the islands of the Caribbean, not to mention within that nest of vipers in New Granada. Needless, we didn’t want the blighters stirring up war-fever in Madrid or the Gulf of Spain, or anywhere else until we were in some kind of position to defuse it. So, Alonso fell on his sword in Philadelphia, and returned home to try to talk a little sanity into the Royal Court, or rather, ‘courts’, plural. As ever, diplomacy is the art of the possible and sometimes things don’t turn out the way we hoped. This is one such occasion.”

He contemplated this, snapping together three separate components of his assault rifle before continuing.

“We don’t usually cock things up quite this badly but then when you a dealing with a bunch of religious maniacs, and with a hereditary monarchy that belongs more to the sixteenth than the latter twentieth century, I suppose we ought not to have been anywhere near as surprised by the way things have gone,” he sighed, “as they have.”

Melody said nothing.

The man grimaced apologetically.

“Alonso was confident that he could protect you two ladies but obviously, events rather overtook us all. Anyway, I’m here because I was ‘it’, HMG’s last ‘standing’ asset in-country with half-a-chance of extricating you two.”

“What about all the other people at the Embassy?” Henrietta asked, her curiosity aflame.

“As you see, I’m the only one here with you on top of this mountain.” He decided he had talked enough about himself. “Is it true that you’re Alonso’s mistress?” He put to Melody, genuinely and in no way salaciously curious.

Henrietta giggled at her friend’s unease.

“Yes, and no!” Melody replied, recovering fast. “It’s complicated...”

“Ah, that explains it. He gave me the distinct impression that if I didn’t escort you – and of course, Lady Henrietta – safely to the border that I would regret it. Which is odd, because Alonso has always been such a level-headed fellow about members of the fair sex before.”

Melody refused to be distracted again.

“Okay, you’re telling us that you’re CSS?”

“Sorry, I thought I’d made that clear. I work for Matthew Harrison, and I suppose, for Lady Henrietta’s father.” Nash completed re-assembling his Martini Henry, he snapped back the breech.

A round clicked into the chamber.

Locked and loaded.

“I really do suggest you ladies try to get a little bit of shut eye before we set off. Don’t mind me.”

The women hesitated.

“I’ll be just outside the door,” he promised, rising to his feet, holstering his pistol at his waist and hefting the matt black assault rifle in his arms.

“You’re guarding us even in this place?” Henrietta blurted.

“We live in strange times, My Lady,” Paul Nash grinned. “Better safe than sorry, what!”

ACT III – THE VIEW FROM THE EDGE

Chapter 27

Saturday 1st April

Palace of the Nations, Place de la Concorde, Paris

Sir George Walpole, His Majesty's Secretary of State for Foreign and Colonial Affairs, smiled sternly for the massed cameras of the press and at the last moment, remembered to nod – several times, with appropriate gravitas – in acknowledgement of the live TV coverage of his arrival in the Place de la Concorde. Not that he was in any mood to smile overmuch at anything in particular as he walked stiffly into the regal, cathedral-like reception hall of the Palace of the Nations, the great neo-classical complex built upon the ruins between the Seine to the south, the Champs-Élysées to its west and the gardens of the ruined, never re-built Tuileries to the east.

On another day the most respected – by friends, allies and enemies alike – historian-politician manipulator of World affairs of his generation, a man one Russian minister had once, in perplexed exasperation called 'Machiavelli in a frock coat', might have paused to enjoy and to marvel at the great buildings ringing the octagonal Place de la Concorde, of which the Palace of the Nations was the magnificent jewel. Today, he was pre-occupied, having spent the whole of the five-hour journey from London to Paris via the Channel Tunnel, deep in conference with his bevy of aides and advisors, afraid of what new disasters might be presaged by the telegrams he knew would surely have accumulated awaiting his arrival at the Gare du Nord Terminus.

He was still struggling to absorb the alarming implications of the latest updates from Spain and the bellicose pronouncements – not unexpected but unwelcome nevertheless – of the Governor of the Spanish Royal Province of Cuba.

It was hardly surprising that the Foreign Ministers of 'the powers' were rapidly coalescing in Paris that afternoon several days in advance of their scheduled monthly 'get together' customarily attended only by junior representatives briefed to discuss predominantly 'technical' matters relating to the routine 'fine tuning' of international relations.

Sir George Walpole's mood was not improved when he was kept waiting in the British Rooms of the western wing of the Palace by his counterpart, and co-chair of the Council of the Nations, Count Lothar von Bismarck of Hesse-Kassel.

The German Legation had apologised profusely for its principal's 'unavoidable delay' but Walpole suspected it boded ill for the conversation he was about to have with his old friend.

He and Lothar were of an age, nearer sixty years old than fifty and had sparred, in academia in their younger days and off and on in the less amenable, dangerous sphere of realpolitik for the last, ever-more troubling decade. On Walpole's part, their political encounters had been interrupted now and then by the vagaries of the workings of democracy in the United Kingdom, not a cross that von Bismarck, whose family had been as near as dammit, Walpole had written many years ago under the Germanic Imperial system, 'the hereditary custodians of the Empire's foreign affairs for the last century.'

In preparation for his life-long role, first as a junior secretary in the Kaiser's Colonial Office ahead of a succession of increasingly senior posts until eventually, he had succeeded his father at the Wilhelmstrasse, the German Foreign Office on the Unter den Linden in Berlin, Lothar had spent two years at Harrow, and studied Classics and Medieval History at Balliol College, Oxford, where he had met many of the men with whom, it was anticipated, he would work with, and sometimes against, in pursuance of his Kaiser's policies in later life.

In comparison with the large, fierce, somewhat over-bearing persona of his illustrious forebear at least, in his depictions in portraits of the period and those early still photographs of him in old age, who was the acknowledged guiding hand behind the Treaty of Paris, the man German children were taught was the 'saviour of the First Reich' Lothar was a man constructed on slighter, dapper lines belying the fact he was the 'Iron Man's' great-great grandson.

His mother was the sister of Her Majesty the Duchess of Windsor, the Queen Consort of the King, George V of England, which made the King and Queen his aunt and uncle. Nobody had designed that particular match, royalty having been bestowed upon it by assassination and fate rather than by any reach of imperial match-making. Nevertheless, by a strange accident

of history Lothar von Bismarck presently found himself nineteenth in line of succession to the English throne.

At one stage back in the late 1950s he had actually been seventh in line but since then – much to his relief – the present King of England's offspring had been loyally, dutifully and with no little gusto producing new royal princes and princesses at a rate which far outstripped the rate older members of the Royal Family were passing away.

Back in Germany the left-leaning papers sometimes teased Lothar about his 'British antecedents'. Cartoons of him hob-knobbing with the Royal Family referring to the King as 'Bertie' and the Queen calling him 'Bissi', appeared in the press every time he was accused of being 'soft on the Brits'.

Sometimes, George Walpole felt as if he and his friend had outgrown their relevance in a World increasingly dominated by proletarian ambition and the crying need for faster economic development. They were men of empire and now and then, just occasionally, he looked in the mirror and glimpsed... *a dinosaur*.

When the King and Queen had returned from their post-Empire Day World tour, Walpole had spent a long weekend with the Royal Household at Balmoral in company with the Prime Minister and other senior members of the current administration discussing, in the main, how the Empire was going to ride out the storms to come. Nobody, least of all the King, honestly believed that the current 'imperial model' was sustainable and that talk of full 'Dominion Status', self-rule by any other name albeit under the flag of the British Commonwealth, even in the cases of Australia, New Zealand, the Canadian Provinces and although this was probably a pipe dream, India, could give the Empire more than a 'few short decades' breathing space, grace, some kind of buffer against the rising demands for self-determination.

Now, it seemed to Walpole, that the crisis they all feared years hence – hopefully, when men of their generation were all retired or dead, basically – might be upon them already.

For much of the twentieth century the ruling classes of both Germany and the British Isles had cultivated and by and large, enjoyed, cordial and mutually respectful relations. Unfortunately, like many old couples whose marriages seem rock solid from the outside, both parties had concluded that their union had never been more than one of convenience. Obviously, this

was not a thing the hundreds of thousands of Anglo-German families inextricably linked by matrimony over the last century, had been in a hurry to come to terms with and their existence, as a minority but significant influential polity in both Empires had to some extent, provided a societal brake, a bridge of sorts over the years, which thus far had frustrated open talk of divorce.

Walpole was afraid that things had gone too far to halt the inevitable parting of the ways. The Submarine Treaty of the mid-1960s had, in retrospect, marked the end of informal co-operation and ushered in an era of co-existence in which the protocols of the century-old Treaty of Paris were increasingly, little better than a fig leaf.

“I’m dreadfully sorry to keep you waiting, old man,” Lothar von Bismarck apologised profusely as he led his aides into the room. His English was clipped, precise and tripped off his tongue with the same native fluency as his Saxon-accented German.

Today, he spoke in English and beneath his normal *savoir-faire* he was clearly a little flustered. Angry, in fact, that circumstances had delayed him. There was absolutely nothing forced or false about his apology— he was clearly mortified by the discourtesy of having kept his old friend waiting—and he smiled with tight-lipped relief when Walpole grimaced and assured him that he, too, had been unexpectedly detained by the exigencies of his own administrative duties.

Each man, in common with all members of each country’s professional diplomatic corps was as at home speaking or writing the other man’s language, for such was a basic qualification for all men in their profession. Normally, every diplomat posted to Paris was also expected to be at least, passably proficient in French, an invaluable skill since every second member of the secretariat of the Palace of the Nations these days was a French man or woman.

He was attired as he invariably was of late when he visited the Palace of the Nations, in the immaculate uniform of a Colonel of the 7th Regiment of Foot, Hesse-Kassel, into which he had been commissioned as a cadet at the age of twenty-four, being of that class whose sons’ education was incomplete without a mandatory period of military service of not less than four years between the ages of eighteen and twenty-nine.

“I was hoping we might have a little chat alone before we started the main meeting, Lothar,” Walpole suggested urbanely as the two men shook

hands.

“Yes, that would be most agreeable,” the German Minister concurred.

They soon retreated to chairs by the windows commanding a view across the gardens of the Champs-Élysées, at this season bursting into leaf and adorned by the first blooms of spring for as far as the eye could see between the Palace of the Nations and the monumental, three hundred and fifty-foot high marble, granite and terracotta L'arc de la Victoire nearly a mile away.

The Arch of Victory...

Walpole had often wondered how it might have altered the perspectives of generations of British statesmen who had walked through the portals of the Palace of the Nations since its completion in 1875, had they looked out not on the L'arc de la Victoire but upon the overgrown ruins of the Tuileries, ploughed under by the merciless artillery of the Kaiser's Army in the 1860s, the view allocated to Lothar von Bismarck and his predecessors for the last one hundred and three years...

The Foreign and Colonial Secretary forced himself to focus on the here and the now. Unbidden, his aides had placed crystal tumblers and a bottle of twenty-year old Balvenie single malt whisky on the coffee table between the two men.

“Can I tempt you, old friend?” Walpole murmured. Both men shared true connoisseurs' appreciations of fine whiskies.

“Thank you, yes,” von Bismarck guffawed, allowing himself a thoughtful sigh. “You will be hearing the same news that I am hearing from Spain, George?”

The two men nursed their drinks.

Sipped reflectively.

“Yes.” The Englishman nodded, staring into the mid-distance.

“I am assured that our agents had nothing to do with the *timing* or the ongoing *blood-letting*,” Lothar von Bismarck said tersely, picking his words and meanings with exaggerated care even for a career diplomat.

Sir George Walpole had taken it as read that the Kaiser's surrogates would have been making mischief in Madrid, had Whitehall had the same opportunities as the Wilhelmstrasse, it would have played the same shady game down the years. That said, Lisbon, rather than the Spanish capital, had always been the hotbed of British imperial intrigue in the Iberian Peninsula,

a deficiency he had done what he could to address; in hindsight it amounted to too little too late.

“My Kaiser wishes it to be made known to you that he deplores, with all his heart, the desecration of diplomatic property and the abominable treatment of foreign nationals caught in the ‘crossfire’ in Spain.”

One of the telegrams which had been awaiting Walpole at the Gare de Nord Terminus had confirmed that the German and the Russian Embassies in Madrid had not been stormed and ransacked like every other embassy, consulate and foreign commercial concern in Madrid, a pattern repeated in practically all the big cities of Old Spain. The situation in the Caribbean and the Gulf of Spain was less immediately dire but no less threatening: in Mexico City, Havana and elsewhere British Embassies and Consulates, as yet unmolested by the mobs ranging the streets were ringed by – essentially, besieged – by large, heavily armed police and militia ‘protection’ detachments.

“That is good to know,” Walpole nodded, unconsciously running a hand through his thinning still dark hair, secretly wondering how much it cost his old friend to deal in such transparently false commiserations.

If the FCO’s intelligence was half-right, anywhere remotely near the mark, the coup in Madrid had probably been fomented by a cadre of middle-ranking Spanish Army and Navy officers trained in Germany with close links to the Imperial Army, the *Deutsches Heer* and the Navy, the *Kaiserliche Marine*.

The Germans privately called this generation of Spanish brigadiers, colonels and majors, naval captains and commanders *das junge blut* – the young bloods – men who were schooled in Prussian military thinking and tactics. The Spanish had sent many of their best and brightest officers to Germany since the mid-1950s in a belated attempt to meaningfully modernise, intellectually and technologically, its ‘home’ armed forces, a move subsequently mirrored by the governors of Nuevo Spain (New Granada), Cuba, Santo Domingo and several of the South American provinces.

Sir George Walpole and his predecessors had always viewed the ‘Germanisation’ of elements within the Old and New – colonial – Spanish military establishments, and the supply of German weaponry, everything from state-of-the-art medium-sized warships to infantry small arms although as yet, it seemed, no advanced guided munitions, to the King-

Emperor's Iberian forces and worryingly, to several of Spain's far-flung, disobedient colonies, particularly those closest to New England, with immense suspicion. Yet, keen to avoid provoking an international crisis at virtually any cost, successive British governments had restricted its protests to quiet, behind the scenes 'conversations'.

There were men in Walpole's own Progressive Tory coalition who privately called the policy of 'quiet diplomacy' *appeasement* but they had always been in the minority.

"You will understand that my colleagues in London are concerned that while *our* diplomatic missions in Spain have been mercilessly targeted that German, and to a degree, Russian interests have escaped the attention of the mobs, Lothar?"

The German minister did not flinch.

"Our influence with the factions vying for control in Spain is not, perhaps, what some of your colleagues might imagine it to be, George."

The Englishman smiled, his eyes cold.

"I am informed that Admiral von Reuter's squadron may have departed Vera Cruz?"

"I'm sorry. I have no knowledge of that."

The two 8-inch gunned heavy cruisers, the Lützen and the Breitenfeld, three 5.9-inch armed light cruisers, Karlsruhe, Emden and Breslau, and as many as eight fleet destroyers of the C-79 and D-111 classes armed with 4.1-inch 55-calibre guns and fitted with between six and eight 20-inch torpedo tubes had been scattered about the Caribbean and the ports of the Gulf of Spain until about a fortnight ago when they, their oilers and supply ships had rendezvoused at the Spanish port of Vera Cruz. Even with the recent deployment of the mighty old warhorse HMS Indomitable and her screening destroyers at New Orleans, the handful of other Royal Navy ships, just one cruiser until HMS Achilles arrived on the Jamaica Station, a few older destroyers and a handful of gunboats, were hugely outnumbered by von Reuter's powerful modern squadron, the oldest ship of which was the sixteen-thousand-ton heavy cruiser Seiner Majestät Schiff Lützen commissioned in 1969.

"You must be concerned for the safety of your advisors in the Caribbean?" The British Foreign Secretary prompted.

Actually, von Bismarck was extremely worried about the thousands of dependents of the small but very significant regiment of German diplomats,

soldiers and sailors, resident in Cuba and Santo Domingo, although not so much about the even larger German presence in New Granada.

Potentially, Santo Domingo was a nightmare with various theocratic movements constantly calling for the persecution of foreign apostates regardless of their own government's crying need for outside help – exclusively German in the last twenty years – to run its poverty-stricken territory's basic infrastructure and to maintain its mainly early twentieth century military equipment in something like good fighting order.

The situation on Cuba was different, the civil population – over fifty percent slaves – was largely quiescent under a colonial regime which had ceased to pay anything other than lip-service to Madrid for decades, and had formed increasingly intimate military and commercial links with the regime in Mexico City in the wake of the loss of its Floridian lands in the late 1950s.

“Look, Lothar,” Walpole went on, not having expected his friend to have responded to his previous, essentially rhetorical question. “I am very worried that it would not take much for things to get completely out of hand...”

“So, am I.” The Kaiser's Foreign Minister sipped his Balvenie, enjoying the warmth of the spring sun on his face.

Back in Berlin, the General Staff parroted out the mantra that ‘we are ready for anything, Your Majesty’ but actually, that was a misnomer. Whereas, the British Empire spread its fleet around the World and committed relatively small land forces – relying on locally raised units in the main – the German Empire had several armies distributed around its borders and whole divisions deployed abroad, at ruinous expense to the Berlin Treasury, already engaged in three or four low-level, enervating ‘bush-fire wars’. In the West, it had maintained active force levels at two to three times that of the British Army of the Rhine occupying France and in the east, three further German Armies confronted the Russian bear and its potentially bottomless pit of manpower. Likewise, another whole Army Group held down the Balkan remnants of the old Austro-Hungarian Empire, deterring the militaristic ambitions of the resurgent Caliphate in Istanbul. The spiralling cost of it all – yearly exacerbated by the steadily rising developmental and procurement costs of increasingly more sophisticated armaments – had been the bane of all German civil administrations for a generation.

Ironically, the Kaiser— unlike his son, Crown Prince Frederick— was not really a very warlike man who listened to his generals' and admirals' prognostications with a complacent ear, allowing himself to be comforted by statistics: men under arms, reserves standing ready for mobilization, ships ready for action, etcetera ad infinitum.

Basically, the Kaiser liked to style himself as the 'Hadrian of the Reich'. The 'Empire is big enough, what we have we hold, in perpetuity' and until recent years his mainly Prussian, military establishment, had fortified the borders of his Reich with immense purpose and professionalism. Consequently, regardless of the changing winds of international affairs, Germany was superbly placed to defend itself; but as to progressing its imperial ambitions abroad, well, that was another matter. The Royal Navy and the North Sea bottled up this Kaiser's— as with all Kaisers since the turn of the century— pride and joy, the High Seas Fleet, in its Baltic lair; and its presence other than in the Caribbean and on the Asia Station, remained globally insignificant.

Unfortunately, with the Kaiser's withdrawal from public life in recent years, a disconnect had emerged within the higher echelons of the Imperial body politic. The old Kaiser was failing fast and the Crown Prince had long been an advocate of a 'less apologetic' approach to the 'shackles of the 1866 Treaty', which he and his clique, regarded as an outdated, borderline irrelevant straightjacket denying the German Empire its 'rightful place in the sun'.

Nevertheless, the reality on the ground was that the Imperial General Staff had, for as long as anybody could remember, always planned on the basis that there would be no general war in the next five years, or a major conflict overseas— that is, with a second, or a third-rate power, because a 'European war' with the British was too unimaginable as to be not worth planning for— within the next two years. This was still the General Staff's assumption despite the messages Bismarck had been trying to get the idiots to listen to; ever since the ripples of the explosions of those speedboats crashing into the side of those British battleships on Empire Day had begun to fan out around the globe.

The German Foreign Minister felt sick to his stomach.

Nobody in the German government wanted a war for which it was neither prepared militarily, logistically, politically or psychologically. The problem was that elements close to the Crown Prince in the Wilhelmstrasse

and to a degree, a few like-minded hotheads in the Navy, had given their friends and clients in the Spanish Empire the impression that German policy was something it patently, was not. Worse, unknown to the British a little over a month ago, the Kaiser had been persuaded to put his signature to an Imperial edict transferring Rear Admiral Erwin von Reuter's squadron to the *Armada de las Americas*, the Navy of *Nuevo Granada*.

Nobody at the Wilhelmstrasse had been informed of this 'development' until yesterday, by which time the first of the men sent ashore from von Reuter's ships— which in the interim were to remain under the tactical command of von Reuter and his officers retaining over half their existing German crews but operating under the orders of the Commander-in-Chief of the *Armada de las Americas*, which of course, was insane— had cabled back to Germany complaining about having to hand over their ships to a quote: 'Bunch of bloody amateurs who don't know the bow from the stern,' and complained volubly that some of the vessels were already 'real shit-holes...'

The Kaiser had been in decline for some years, everybody knew that: this latest *madness* had spawned an outcry for the Crown Prince to step in and in effect, become Regent...

Lothar von Bismarck leaned forward.

The situation was so unthinkable bad that he had no choice but to tell his English friend the truth, the whole truth and nothing but...

"This can never be admitted beyond these walls," he said in a near whisper, imploring confidentiality. "But my Kaiser," he hesitated, shaking his head, "has placed von Reuter's ships at the disposal of the Triple Alliance..."

The German Foreign Minister explained further, sharing his analysis that the 're-flagging' of the German squadron 'might' conceivably convince the regimes in Mexico City, Havana and on Santo Domingo, as well as 'unstable entities' on the northern coast of the Southern continent, that they have 'carte blanche' to aggressively challenge British Imperial interests in the Gulf of Spain and the Caribbean. There was also the personality of von Reuter himself to be considered; he was an old friend of the Crown Prince and within the *Kaiserliche Marine* something of an outspoken 'Anglophobe', who had long advocated a 'more assertive policy against British domination of the world's sea routes.' The fact that he had been left in command of the so-called 'Vera Cruz Squadron' and, according to some

reports, been promoted Vice-Admiral in the *Armada de las Americas* and given command of the naval forces of the putative Triple Alliance, was currently giving rise to ‘serious unhappiness’ in the High Command of the Ministry of War in Berlin.

As Sir George Walpole listened, he was sorely tempted to drain his glass and pour himself another drink.

A big one...

His friend might have been reading his thoughts.

“Nobody knows what is in the mind of the Triple Alliance, or what von Reuter will do next, George.”

“Can’t your Admiralty recall the bloody man?” Walpole demanded quietly.

The German shook his head.

“The Crown Prince will not countenance that,” he sighed, placing his empty tumbler on the table.

The two friends viewed each other for some moments, too distraught to say another word.

Presently, as one they rose to their feet and went to the window to stare at the great monolith of the L'arc de la Victoire.

“Sometimes,” Lothar von Bismarck confessed, wearily, “a fellow must admit, to himself if nobody else, that things might turn out as badly as one first feared.”

Chapter 28

Sunday 2nd April

HMS Achilles, 40 miles south of the Turks and Caicos Islands

Neither of the cruiser's other pilots had the foggiest idea what they were 'playing at' taking their aircraft, each 'loaded up to the gills' with the 'hush hush' equipment the boffins had installed back on Bermuda, up to their maximum service ceiling of about twelve or thirteen thousand feet—on a good day— and stooging around within twenty miles of the ship until they got low on fuel. Some of the zigzag courses they had been asked to navigate added a little interest to the flying but not a lot, otherwise the two crews involved, had found the whole thing 'tiresome'.

Meanwhile, Surgeon Lieutenant Abraham Lincoln had temporarily been removed from the flight roster because three days earlier his superior, Surgeon Commander Flynn had been flown to Cockburn Town, the capital of the Turks and Caicos Islands where the Governor had been taken ill with what now seemed to have turned out to be a straightforward case of a ruptured appendix. Abe had not even tried to get to the bottom of why a passing Royal Naval ship should have been ordered to fly its surgeon ashore to a protectorate that had its own fully-staffed garrison medical corps.

Ours is not to question why...

In any event, he had enjoyed being HMS Achilles's surgeon the last three days and knew he was going to miss the responsibility, and the feeling of being 'useful', when his chief came back on board either later that afternoon or sometime tomorrow morning. Not that he had had a lot to do: the normal daily sick parade, rarely more than two or three malingerers or fellows testing if the 'new man' was a soft touch, the periodic health checks that every man had to undergo once every few weeks in tropical waters, this latter a regimen commenced the first day out of Norfolk en route south with no reference to when the ship was actually expected to cross the Tropic of Cancer, a thing it had not done until the day after she sailed south from Bermuda.

However, unlike his fellow pilots he had sought out an opportunity to chat with 'the boffins' who had come on board at Bermuda. Apparently, the

two pilots had thought this was an underhand approach to discover what they were *playing at*.

“Well, the thing is we haven’t got a clue what sort of ELDAR coverage the Spanish have in these parts,” Abe was told. “We know they have radar stations on the northern coast of Cuba but this far east, well, nobody’s ever even looked before now. The equipment on your planes will tell us if anybody is broadcasting electronic pulses, and their wavelengths, from the south. If we pick up any signals it will tell us a lot, and if and when we compare the plots from the various flights, we ought to be able to triangulate the approximate position, perhaps to within a mile or so, of any Spanish ELDAR ground stations near to the coast. We need you chaps to fly as high as you can, so that any ELDAR activity on Santo Domingo, about seventy or eighty miles to the south isn’t blocked by the curve of the horizon. Achilles, this far north of Spanish territory will be invisible to any ELDARs on land hopefully, and in the unlikely event the Dominicans detect the Sea Foxes, they won’t think anything untoward of it!”

Abe had processed this information a lot slower than the talkative boffin, Jack Muir— a Scot from the Imperial Radio Research Laboratory in Edinburgh, the top secret government establishment which had pioneered the development of cathode ray tubes and beaten the Germans to producing the prototype black and white television broadcast and reception system back in the 1930s— a man in his middle years with a shiny, perspiring pate and quick grey eyes who clearly loved his work, had explained it.

“The thing is we have no idea how much advanced electronic technology the Germans might have transferred to the buggers on those islands down there.”

Once Surgeon Commander Flynn was safely back aboard, Achilles was to steam farther east and test the electronic defences of Puerto Rico Island, a war-torn sub-territory of the Santo Domingo colony and Anguilla, a supposedly de-militarised German protectorate under the terms of the Submarine Treaty.

In relation to its western neighbours Anguilla was an oasis of calm prosperity, visited regularly by the big cruise ships of the Hamburg-Atlantic Line, something of a must-visit destination for the wealthy of the German Empire. Once her electronic spying missions were completed the cruiser would steer to the west, running much closer inshore along the twelve-mile — self-declared by all the Spanish New World provinces in

contravention of the internationally recognised three-mile territorial limit—line before making passage to Jamaica. During that part of the cruise the detection equipment would be completely removed from, and the Achilles's Sea Foxes returned to their former state, so as to allow the precious sophisticated equipment to be mounted on the cruiser's main and anti-aircraft directors as high as possible on the bridge and in the aft superstructure.

"I think the original idea of bringing along the extra 'wheeled' Sea Fox was that the Admiralty wanted the raw data flown straight back to Florida, via a fuel stop somewhere in the Bahamas, obviously, so that it can be analysed as soon as possible by the Electronic Warfare Staff at St John's River."

Abe had never heard of that facility.

He suspected that this was probably because it was so secret that he was not supposed to know.

"I think the Navy and my boss got their wires crossed," the boffin, who invited everybody to call him 'Jack' speculated. "One of your sea planes could as easily bring our findings back to base. But, I suppose, at least this way Achilles gets to keep both sea planes, which you'll need if you're going on farther south and we are still going to get our preliminary findings back to Florida pretty damned quick. So, I suppose, everybody is happy at the end of the day!"

A few minutes later the manoeuvring bell rang insistently and the ship began to pick up speed.

"THIS IS THE BRIDGE. ALL SEA DUTY MEN TO THEIR STATIONS! REPEAT. ALL SEA DUTY MEN TO THEIR STATIONS. THE SHIP IS INVESTIGATING A MERCHANTMAN WHICH HAS REFUSED TO REPLY TO OUR HAIL. THAT IS ALL."

Achilles was at Air Defence Station Three, its lowest alert level with only one main battery turret manned, 'A' turret, and two of the 0.8-inch anti-aircraft cannon mounts locked and loaded. That was standard operating procedure when one of the ship's aircraft was in the air.

Abe explained this to his pet boffin.

"The normal drill would be to send a Sea Fox to investigate but the Old Man doesn't want to muck up your, er..."

"We call it electronic surveillance," Jack Muir retorted. "Spying by any other name!"

“Anyway, what we’ll do is close to hailing range of the merchantman. If the Old Man doesn’t like anything he hears, or the attitude of the ship’s master, he’ll send over a boat so that an officer can check the ship’s manifest and routing papers. Standard commerce protection work, really,” he had concluded as if he was a grizzled old hand not the greenest seagoing member of the cruiser’s wardroom.

Jack Muir was suddenly very thoughtful.

“Do you think I might inveigle myself into the Achilles’s ELDAR room, Abe?”

They had got onto first name terms soon after they started to chat.

Abe was at a loose end.

“Follow me.”

The ELDAR Officer, a scrawny sub-lieutenant fresh out of the Royal Naval College at Dartmouth, after which he had passed a crash course at the Electronic Warfare Establishment at Fort Nelson, near Portsmouth, who had only arrived at Norfolk two days before the cruiser sailed for Bermuda, waved the newcomers into his cramped domain at the back of the bridge on the deck below the compass platform.

“We’re getting a fair bit of interference,” the youngster complained distractedly.

“Try tweaking the frequency down a tad,” Jack suggested.

“Seriously?”

The green repeater screens cleared.

“Somebody else is operating a search ELDAR,” the boffin declared. “Probably that ship we’re approaching.”

“But he’s only a merchie?” The youngster objected.

“There’s nothing else on the screen except distant ground clutter from the nearest land,” the civilian remarked gently.

The ELDAR officer called the bridge and reported this.

Shortly afterwards the Achilles’s Executive Officer entered the compartment, glancing askance at Abe.

“Er, Mister Muir, asked if he could visit the compartment, sir. He’s the ELDAR expert, so I thought...”

The older man grinned conspiratorially and looked to the boffin.

“Do you think that beggar may be attempting to jam our ELDAR?”

“Possibly. He’s obviously got modern, fairly powerful equipment. He certainly knows we’re here. I’m surprised he hasn’t acknowledged your

radio hails?”

The Executive Officer pursed his lips.

“We may be stepping up to ADC One in a minute or two, Mr Lincoln. You may wish to make tracks back to the sick bay.”

“Aye, aye, sir.”

In the event, nothing happened for some ten minutes after Abe returned to the sick bay to find that his attendants – men trained in battlefield first aid, who were otherwise the equivalent of regular naval nurses ashore who had completed the first year of their training – had worked out for themselves what was likely to happen next and had reported to their ‘action stations’ in the aft superstructure where they were already prepping to receive casualties.

“THE SHIP WILL COME TO ADC ONE!”

Abe was struck by the subtle differences between the real thing and the drills he had gone through as Michael Flynn’s number two. For one, he was nobody’s deputy today.

Achilles, having closed the range to her ‘target’ had slowed to a crawl, taking the swells on her starboard flank, rolling gently.

“The Old Man will keep the ship bow-on to the merchie,” Abe’s senior man, a petty officer who still wore the torpedo division badge of his former trade – he had been crushed in an accident some years ago and transferred to his current specialisation in order to remain at sea – on his left bicep, remarked respectfully. “This close to Santo Domingo the merchie could be anything,” the man grinned ruefully, “or nothing.”

“Bow-on?” Abe queried, curious.

“Captain Jackson is old-school, sir,” the other man said with affection and no little respect. “You never show the other fellow your flank unless you’re about to trade broadsides with him.”

“Oh, I see.”

After that they just waited, and waited.

Nothing happened.

Over an hour passed, the cruiser no more than holding her position and then, as if a switch had been flicked, the boredom dissolved.

“This is the Captain. We have stopped a German registered freighter, the SS Horst Lorenz. She’s one of those new refrigerator-cargo-passenger motor vessels the Mexico-Berlin Line has been introducing lately. About eighteen thousand tons deadweight. A glorified banana boat, really. Her

master claims his WT room is out of action; I just think the fellow was being awkward. I had one of our planes buzz him to persuade him to stop so that he and I could have a jolly little chat via signal lamp. There is no reason to board the Horst Lorenz, so, in a few minutes we shall be letting her go on her way. Remain at your stations and stay alert until the stand down bell rings. That is all.”

A little later Abe felt and heard the catapult impellor fling one of the ship’s Sea Foxes into the air. Five minutes later the Tannoy blared.

“STANDOWN FROM ADC ONE. THE SHIP WILL RESUME ADC THREE.”

“Panic over, sir,” Abe’s senior sick bay rating murmured.

Abe stood back while his men began to square away the compartment, re-storing and re-packing the equipment they had swiftly, efficiently broken out of lockers and adjoining spaces, and laid out ready to receive casualties. The emergency medical kits which in extremis could be distributed around the ship were meticulously logged back into the sick bay inventory. It took over an hour to restore normality.

Such were the ways of the peacetime Royal Navy.

Everything had its place...

Chapter 29

Sunday 2nd April

Villanueva de Ávila, Castile and León, Spain

Both women had been out on their feet as they followed their infuriatingly tireless guide and protector into the woods in the darkness and waited, faint and swaying as he swiftly, efficiently hung a canvas awning between two trees and spread blankets on the ground.

“Take the weight off your feet,” Captain Paul Nash commanded softly. “Drink some water, I’ll dissolve a couple of ready meals. I’m sorry, we can’t risk a fire but you must eat and drink before you try to sleep. I know your feet must be hurting like blazes. Sorry, I’ll look at them in the morning. We can’t risk a light. The village is only a few hundred yards away.”

Neither Melody Danson nor Henrietta De L’Isle even contemplated a protest. They had walked all of the last two nights and all of that long, gruelling day. They had no idea where they were, and for the moment cared less. For most of the last few hours they had been like sleep-walkers, unconsciously putting one foot in front of the other and for periods, because of the unforgiving nature of the terrain—often with sheer drops to one side of rocky, twisting mountain paths, they had been roped together with their inexhaustible guide-protector.

Henrietta and Melody choked down the mush in the billy cans pressed into their hands, and swigged water from the canteen the man held out. Despite their thirst the sour reek of the purification tablets almost made them gag as they drank.

Melody tried to give the canteen back to Nash, guiltily realising she was about to drain it dry.

“You finish it. We passed a stream about half-a-mile back, I’ll re-fill the canteens overnight.”

“Where are we?” She asked.

“The town on the next hill is Villanueva de Ávila.”

“Castile and Leon,” Melody groaned. “I thought we’d be farther west.”

The man chuckled in the darkness.

“We’re about sixty miles from Madrid. Tomorrow we’ll lose ourselves in the Sierra de Gredos. I’d expected there to be more militia and busybodies in the hills,” he added with a suggestion of irritation as if he had been looking forward to the prospect of shooting or knifing somebody.

Henrietta’s head lolled against Melody’s shoulder, instinctively, she put her arm around the younger woman’s shoulders and kissed the top of her head. The women had made no secret of their intimacy, careless of what their soldier knight-errant guardian made of it.

Melody started doing the math— how far they had come, how far they had to go to reach the Portuguese border?— and she hated the numbers that she was coming up with.

“How far are we from the border?” She prompted wearily. “A hundred-and-ten, maybe one hundred-and-twenty miles?”

“Something like that,” the man conceded, vaguely. “We’ve come over fifteen hundred feet down the mountains. We must be at around three thousand feet hereabouts, the weather’s warmed up and dried up a bit which ought to make it easier...”

“Unless it rains again tomorrow,” Melody objected feebly.

“It won’t,” Paul Nash retorted. “Trust me, it’ll be sunshine and light winds all the way from here.”

Henrietta was fast asleep sitting beside Melody, dead to the world.

“And I’m the Queen of England!” Melody snorted derisively.

The man had rested his assault rifle against the bowl of a nearby tree as he squatted down opposite her. The whites of his eyes fixed on her.

“I need you two ladies to stay strong,” he said. “You stay strong and I’ll do the rest...”

“For all we know there are thousands of people looking for us?”

“I doubt it. There really aren’t that many people who give a damn about us. A lot of locals will have seen us in the last couple of days; most of them will have just shrugged and got on with their lives. The telephone system in the mountains is spotty at the best of times, right now I doubt if it is functioning at all. It’ll take a while for people to work out who is in charge in Madrid and then, it’ll be a whole mess of beans for them to try to work out who is on whose side. No, we could easily just stroll to the border from here in a week or so...”

“Seriously?”

As if to emphasise her scepticism big, cold drops of rain began to filter through the branches over their head. The man ushered the women under the shelter of the awning, pulled a poncho over his shoulders as the rain became heavier, persistent.

Henrietta lay asleep again in moments, her head in Melody's lap. The older woman ached all over. Nonetheless, she was getting her second wind, possibly the effect of the food and water she had forced down a few minutes earlier.

"I always knew this whole 'mission' of ours was a complete nonsense from the outset," she confessed. "If my head hadn't been so turned by working for the Governor and Matthew Harrison, I'd never have allowed myself to be talked into it."

Nash's eye flicked at Henrietta's sleeping form.

"Yeah, that complicates things in a," Melody hesitated, "really nice way and I think Hen needed to spread her wings a little. We both did, I suppose."

"Life's complicated sometimes."

"That's no lie!"

The man smiled, his teeth flashing briefly in the gloom.

Melody was aware again that there was something profoundly predatory in that smile, and a hunter's glint in the man's eyes.

"You seem to know everything there is to know about us. What's your story?" She asked, not really expecting an answer.

"I suppose I'm one of those guys every Empire needs to oil the wheels. Now and then that involves doing things nobody is ever going to own up to in public. I'm your man for that sort of thing. That's my story."

Melody's eyes narrowed.

Until last year she had been the only female detective inspector in the New York Constabulary, and moreover, at the time of her promotion youngest woman *or man*, to ever hold that rank. She had not stopped being a detective just because she had been attached to a pointless diplomatic mission to a country where she had lived, blissfully happily, for several years as a child.

Of course, as a young girl she had been blind to the grinding poverty of the peasant population, and to each and every iniquity of the Inquisition, the privileged daughter of two feted and acclaimed classical musicians at the court of the old King-Emperor, Carlos VI. Unlike in the overseas

provinces the institution of slavery had been officially abandoned at Royal Command thirty years ago: although it had never been specifically outlawed by statute in the *Cortes Generales*, the so-called legislature of the Empire of New Spain, essentially a collection of aristocrats, courtiers, old soldiers and place men whose sole purpose was to rubber-stamp royal edicts. Instead of crude slavery the ruling classes had inflicted serfdom on the old Russian model upon the peoples of the agrarian countryside, and a heavily regulated wage slavery upon the inhabitants of the urban landscape.

Nowhere in Europe had feudalism survived so robustly, and nowhere in the post-renaissance 'West' had so many factors combined to limit, in many cases suffocate and actively snuff out, the spark of innovation and ambition vital to any nation seeking to maximise the opportunities of industrialisation. Old Spain had been left behind by the rest of the World, become an impoverished backwater in which six or seven out of every ten of its citizens might as well have still been living in the middle of the nineteenth century for all the good 'modernisation' had done them. There was no national electrical grid or even a proper road system in the mountains north of Madrid, in winter starvation often stalked the villagers on the hillsides who still lived in semi-fortress communities largely ignorant of the marvels taken for granted in some of the big towns and cities, forever the voiceless vassals of the princes who lived in golden splendour in their great palaces.

All this had disgusted her on her return as an adult to Spain but right now it lent persuasive credence to what Paul Nash had said to her. She was stuck in a mindset alien to the majority of the peoples of the country around them. She was thinking like a latter-twentieth century, very independently-minded woman; she might speak Spanish like a native but there was no way she could put herself in the place of somebody who had only ever lived in these mountains, and if they were lucky, attended a church school for half-a-dozen years during their childhood. To most people they encountered she and Henrietta and their guardian would be strangers, no threat, of no interest once they had moved on by and passed out of sight. An armed man accompanied by two women was just a man guarding his chattels in these hills where the writ of princes and absentee landlords was a tenuous, infrequently exercised prerogative.

"I don't think you work for the CSS," Melody decided, thinking aloud.

"Does it matter who I work for?" This the man posed, amused.

She shrugged, suddenly weary beyond measure again.

“Who do you really work for?”

“Ah... I think you’ve worked that out already.”

The rain was falling so hard that the branches and leaf cover above their heads made little or no difference.

“Stay dry,” the man sighed, rising to his feet.

“Where are you going?”

“Like I said, to re-fill the canteens and to reconnoitre ahead. I’ll leave my backpack here with you in the dry under the awning. Try to sleep, we’re as safe up here as anywhere. Especially, if the weather sets in for the next few hours. It rains a lot in the night at this time of year, hopefully we’ll have another dry day tomorrow. The going gets a lot better until we climb into the Gredos Mountains so we ought to make good progress. But right now, just try to sleep.”

With that he was gone, ghosting into the night.

Melody tried to track him, it was useless.

He disappeared into the darkness like a wraith.

Chapter 30

Monday 3rd April

Cliveden House, Buckinghamshire

Sir George Walpole had requested one, last meeting with Lothar von Bismarck, the Russian Minister and the Papal Legate, Cardinal Manzini before returning to England. The Royal Air Force had sent a Marlborough twin-engine transport aircraft to hasten his journey, landing him and his small entourage at Northolt where cars had been waiting to whisk him the fifteen or so miles out into the country to the Prime Minister's country retreat in the heart of the Home Counties.

Normally, the Foreign and Colonial Secretary relaxed when he walked through the portals of the magnificent old Italianate mansion in the Chiltern Hills. Today, his customary public insouciance, what people who ought to have known better persisted in describing as 'grace under pressure' was a somewhat porous mask which might slip without warning at any time.

"Oh, dear, George," Lady Emily Hamilton smiled sympathetically as she appeared from a side room to intercept her visitor as he divested himself of his hat and coat, "surely, things can't be that bad," she remarked cheerfully as she studied her old friend. "It is bad enough that misery-guts old *Primus inter pares* is walking around with a permanently long face without you joining him in a double act!"

"Forgive me, Emily," Walpole brightened, "things aren't that bad."

The Prime Minister's wife had never really forgiven her husband for allowing himself to be bullied into taking up residence at No 10, Downing Street, her least favourite address in Central London. Three decades ago her circle at Oxford, where she had been one of the brightest of all the footlights throughout her time at St John's College reading Modern Literature, Greek and French, had been astounded when she married the Honourable Hector Hamilton, the second son of Lord, then 4th Earl Maidenhead and Taplow. Opinion had been divided between those who were worried she might have suffered a psychotic episode of some kind or that she had been momentarily dazzled, blinded in fact, by the supposedly fabulous wealth of the son of the ringmaster of the 'Cliveden Set'.

Actually, her real friends soon realised that she had simply fallen head over heels in love with the quietly spoken, and in those days still relatively anonymous backbench Member of Parliament for Epping Forest. For most of their marriage it had been Emily, a published poet and erudite, acerbic columnist and sometimes features editor for a succession of daily national newspapers, and a popular ‘talking head’ on television current affairs and quiz programs, who had enjoyed by far the higher public profile – by a country mile – of the pair. That had all come to an end with Hector’s surprise promotion to the Cabinet in the post-assassination crisis which had brought King George V to the throne.

Nobody had been more surprised than Hector when it transpired that cometh the moment cometh the man!

Presently, Hector Hamilton was three-years and seven months into his second ‘sentence’ – as Emily put it succinctly – ‘in the jug at Downing Street with no hope of remission for good behaviour.’

Emily was the human face of the ‘family firm’ and everybody around her would forgive her anything. She was, after all, a national – nay – imperial treasure.

She took the Foreign and Colonial Secretary’s arm and led him into her husband’s ground floor office at the back of the great house. The Prime Minister’s personal Royal Marine bodyguard knocked lightly on the door, opened it and stepped, respectfully aside. Not the least of Emily’s, mainly whimsical complaints, was that she and Hector had to live in a goldfish bowl surrounded by heavily armed men!

However, after the carnage half-a-dozen dissident Fenians had wrought on the imperial establishment in the early 1960s the decision had been taken that *that* was never going to happen again. Cabinet ministers and the senior members of the Royal family never went anywhere without their police or armed services protection details; on balance, most ministers and, so far as George Walpole could tell, the consensus within the royal household was that being alive was a lot better than being dead or maimed, so the security and the constraints it placed on individuals just had to be tolerated.

“I don’t care how bad things are,” Emily Hamilton declared. “I don’t want you boys drinking all the whisky before dinner. I hate it when I’m the only voice of sobriety at the table!”

“Your word is our command, my dear,” her husband assured her, taking off his reading glasses as he rose to welcome Walpole. “I’ve called

the inner circle over this evening,” he said to his visitor when they were alone. “For obvious reasons, I wanted to hear your take on the latest developments first.”

The men took chairs by the cold hearth where a tea pot, a jug of milk and a pair of cups and saucers awaited them on a low table. They looked at each other.

“What the Devil are the Germans playing at, George?” The Prime Minister asked quietly.

“It’s not just the Germans,” his Foreign Secretary countered. “If it was, things might be explicable. In some sense, at least. Frankly, I’m not entirely convinced that the German Minister really knows what *his* Navy is up to in the Caribbean. It’s the old problem of the Army, the Navy and the Foreign Ministry each pursuing their own agendas. It does not help that the Kaiser seems to be a little do-lally some weeks... Goodness knows what the Crown Prince and the Tsar said to each other the other week; everybody knows they hate each other’s guts and have done since they were cadets...”

“Perhaps, they’ve finally agreed that they dislike us more than they loathe each other?”

Sir George Walpole shook his head, forced a grimace because they both knew that was not what this was all about. The German Navy, the *Kaiserliche Marine*, modelled itself on the Royal Navy, its officers were expected to be fluent English speakers and writers, and close, life-long and life-defining friendships between officers in the two navies were common. The relations between the *Deutsches Heer* and the British Army were less cordial, as was to be expected from the men of armies watching each other across the broad expanses of the upper Rhine.

But that was not the problem, the problem was that something unquantifiable had suddenly altered and the whole calculus of Anglo-German relations had somehow shifted, like continental tectonic plates grinding against each other, suddenly shifting without warning; and he had not seen it coming, so, perhaps it was not really that inexplicable that for the first time in his political career he was at a complete loss as to know what to do next.

The academic and the historian in him wanted to offer analysis, to dissect the runes uncovered by the not so subtly moving pieces on the geopolitical chessboard but the time for that had come and gone, possibly years ago.

He began to list the new, and old – unresolved – issues separating London and Berlin.

“While I am convinced that there would be no consensus within the circle around the Kaiser, or within his government, which would support any direct threat of armed aggression against our fundamental interests in Europe,” Walpole prefaced, cursing how ponderously his mind was turning of late, “German policies challenging our traditional hegemony around the world and encouraging allies and proxies to oppose our influence, essentially although not exclusively non-violently have led to conditions in some regions which have generated a momentum of their own. I do not know, nor can I claim to know, if this was the hope or the plan of my counterparts at the Wilhelmstrasse, or simply a concatenation of unseen or unforeseeable consequences.”

The Prime Minister’s eyes narrowed.

“An *accident*, you mean?”

“Perhaps, more likely an object lesson in the workings of the law of unintended consequences...”

“You do know that you start speaking like a professor of the old school when you are worried, George?”

Walpole forced a smile.

“Yes, sorry.”

Hector Hamilton rubbed his chin with his free hand before picking up his tea cup with the other. He raised the cup to his lips, thought better of it and replaced it on the table top.

“The Crown Prince has been talking about pulling out of the Submarine Treaty ever since the ink dried on it,” he reminded his friend. “The Germans have been complaining about our alleged interference in the development of their Caribbean oil refineries on Aruba, without cause, obviously, for almost as long. As for their army of so-called technical advisors on Cuba and in New Spain, well, we decided to turn a blind eye to that as part of the quid pro quo, or rather, the diplomatic scaffolding supporting the Submarine Treaty and its related sub clauses...”

“Lothar warned me that the Kaiser is on the verge of posting notice to quit from the Treaty,” Walpole informed Hamilton. “It is blatantly clear to me that the coup in Spain must have been instigated by a middle-ranking cadre of Army and Navy officers trained in Germany.”

The Foreign Secretary’s tone was suddenly harsh.

“The thing that worries me, scares me, if I’m being honest about it, Hector,” George Walpole continued glumly, “is the news that the Wilhelmstrasse, albeit apparently at the Kaiser’s command, has allowed the re-flagging of Admiral von Reuter’s squadron. It is unclear when exactly this occurred, probably sometime in the last fortnight but those ships are now under the operational control of the *Armada de las Americas*. Which means that this blasted ‘Triple Alliance’ that the Spanish colonies in the region have been talking about for years, now has the nucleus of a modern navy...”

“Surely, our German friends must realise that this risks temporarily altering the balance of naval power in the Caribbean,” Hector Hamilton remarked, cool as a cucumber. “Presumably, you explained this to Count Bismarck?”

“Yes,” his friend confirmed abruptly.

The Prime Minister remained relatively sanguine.

“With the Indomitable and her squadron at New Orleans and the Princess Royal and Task Force 5.1 of the Atlantic Fleet presently exercising within seven days’ steaming time of anywhere in the Gulf of Spain or the rest of the Caribbean, any advantage the Spanish, or their German mentors, might hope to gain from this ‘exercise’ would be short-lived, George.”

“Would it, Hector?” His old friend objected. “All we have down there right now is a single light cruiser, the Cassandra at Kingston Jamaica, and another, the Achilles on her way to join her in a few days’ time. We have negligible air forces on Jamaica, or for that matter on any of our other island territories in the eastern Caribbean. Goodness knows what potential havoc Admiral von Reuter’s ships could wreak down there *before* our capital ships caught up with them. *If they ever caught up with them, that is.* And what if we eventually capture or destroy those German-Spanish ships? There are already nascent independence movements on many of the islands under our control. There have been sporadic campaigns of civil disobedience on both Jamaica and Barbados, goodness, we had to send in the Marines to restore order in Trinidad two or three years back. What message will it send to the peoples of those far-flung islands if we cannot even defend them from a handful of bloody ‘Spanish’ cruisers?”

The Prime Minister digested this in silence, then, forsaking his tea went to the drinks cabinet and returned with a decanter of whisky and two crystal tumblers. He poured generous measures into each of the glasses.

The two men sipped, then as if by common consent, imbibed deep draughts of the restorative amber liquid as they mulled cause and effect, and ultimately, their failure.

Walpole knew that the King had talked his friend out of resigning in the aftermath of the Empire Day atrocities of two years ago, that personally, Hector had felt then, and ever since that he ought to have departed Downing Street back in July 1976, standing aside in favour of a younger, and perhaps, angrier and more decisive man to face the music.

People had been calling him 'the appeaser in chief'.

Until lately his detractors had had the courtesy to mutter it behind his back, out of his hearing so as not to upset Emily. Nowadays, there were frequent derogatory editorials in the papers, snide commentaries on the radio and television and Question Time in the Commons had come to resemble a bear pit.

Hector Hamilton had regarded his discomfiture as a small price to pay for the continuation of the European Peace, knowing full well that nobody would remember that it had been his government which had commenced the re-armament programs that were now, belatedly beginning to repair the damage his predecessors' neglect had wrought on the fighting power of the Empire's armed forces.

The new aircraft carriers coming into service with the Royal Navy, the high-performance propeller-driven monoplane scouts and bombers being delivered to the RAF in fast-increasing numbers, and soon, the first jet-powered 'interceptors' and 'attack' aircraft, the new generation of armoured land vehicles, ground cruisers and self-propelled artillery, the superb new infantry weapons, assault rifles, machine guns and a slew of short-range wire-guided munitions, were all the products of *his* administration's acknowledgement that until the armed forces had the weapons to do the job, *appeasement* was the *only* safe option...

Now, time had run out.

"One day I will apologise to Philip De L'Isle," the Prime Minister promised. "What he was afraid might happen has come to pass. The lesson of 1866 was that we, that is, the German and Russian Empires and every second and third-rate power left standing, should never fight a second general European war. Logically, therefore, all future wars would be fought elsewhere, imperial trials of strength directed by, and resourced from the old centres of empire." He grunted, drained his glass. "If I recollect, you

wrote a marvellously erudite book about all that twenty years ago. What did you call it?"

The interrogative was gently, and rhetorically posed.

"*The Imperial Crisis*," George Walpole groaned.

"Wasn't it your thesis that once the trouble in 'faraway places of which the man in the street in London, or Berlin or Philadelphia or Moscow, knows little and cares less' gains momentum, attaining a 'critical mass', that to all intents the 'contagion' would be unstoppable?"

"I was playing Devil's Advocate, Hector," Walpole retorted urbanely, contemplating his whisky glass.

If their fears materialised, they were going to have to claim that the catastrophe had come upon them unawares; that the pace of extraordinary events had overwhelmed the capacity of rational men, and that they had been the helpless victims of the tide of history: except none of that would be true.

Having known a storm was coming, a storm they could do very little about, they had appeased, compromised in the certain knowledge that the peoples of the Empire did not yet have the stomach for a war. At least, not the sort of war which might have plunged the globe into fiery chaos just to put a 'few Spanish colonies back in their cages' in the Americas, or to metaphorically clip the handlebars of the Kaiser's moustache.

"Thank God," George Walpole sighed, "we've got New England. Even the people around the Kaiser understand that the Empire, with New England at its heart, will always prevail."

The Prime Minister nodded grimly.

"Yes, nothing changes the 'facts on the ground', as they say. Still, it won't do any harm if we have a quiet word with our respective German 'friends' reminding them that if a single Deutsches Heer grenadier steps foot on French soil there will be Hell to pay."

Walpole hesitated.

"Actually, in the circumstances that 'reminder' might be better received in Berlin if the King could be persuaded to put a call through to Kaiser Wilhelm."

Hector Hamilton nodded.

"I shall speak to the Palace before dinner." He glanced to the clock on the wall over his desk. "I'll do it now, Emily will be incandescent if we don't all sit down at the appointed hour!"

Chapter 31

Tuesday 4th April

Hacienda de Cortés, Navalperal de Tormes, Avila

Albert Stanton tried not to look too worried when the two women were ushered— well, half-carried— into the long ground floor dining room of the old country house in the foothills of the Gredos Mountains. While he was confident that he still looked something of a ‘sight’, he was visibly on the mend but Melody Danson and Henrietta De L’Isle most closely resembled scarecrows!

They were thin, dirty, exhausted and their hair had been cut short as a boy’s might be, except with the inattention of a drunkard barber using garden shears. Both women were wearing what looked like wet-through British Army battledress, albeit not quite the right size for their privation-reduced frames.

They shivered as they were guided near to the fire burning fiercely in the hearth, where the Cortés family was methodically burning its papers.

Melody blinked acknowledgement to the *Manhattan Globe* man, while her companion stared at him blankly for some seconds before, in her exhaustion, giving up trying to work out who he was.

Blankets had been thrown around the women’s shoulders.

“This gentleman is Mr Albert Stanton of the *Globe*,” Melody told Henrietta.

“Oh, of course,” the younger woman apologised and despite the situation and her obvious physical state of near collapse, she held out her right hand to the stranger. “Sorry, I didn’t recognise you. I’m sure we must look a real sight!”

“Not at all,” the man lied valiantly. Thinking it best to change the subject he speculated: “I take it that you did not expect to encounter me here?”

Melody quirked a rueful half-smile.

“No,” the man decided, tight-lipped. “Nash is rather a ‘need to know’ fellow, what? Where is he by the way, Nash, I mean?”

Henrietta swayed and Melody grabbed for her elbow to steady her. The other women in the room took this as their cue to move in and as one to shepherd the Governor of New England's daughter safely to a chair.

"He said he had a 'couple of chores' to do before he came up to the hacienda," she reported. "I've been expecting to hear gunfire for the last couple of hours."

"Oh, yes. The chap seems to have a somewhat muscular approach to what he does, whatever that is..."

Melody too, had been led to a chair. Almost as the weight came off her aching legs and feet the arms of sleep reached out and attempted, seductively to embrace her.

"We had to abandon our supplies," she explained, feeling faint, "including what was left of our food and water, blankets and the dry socks Paul made us wear at night..." She must have blinked unconscious. Tried to remember where she had got to, and where she was. "That was a couple of nights ago, I think..."

She accepted a cup of water.

Then some tepid, exquisitely meaty broth which she could only sip at before her empty stomach cramped agonisingly.

Neither she nor Henrietta later remembered being escorted, half-carried upstairs and buried together beneath several layers of blankets, oblivious to the world from the moment their heads touched the pillow.

Contrary to Albert Stanton's expectation there was no gunfire in the night and to his immense irritation when Paul Nash made his belated appearance around midnight he seemed, mud-spattered fatigues apart, unmarked by the adventures he had been through since they had parted eleven days ago. In fact, the man gave every appearance of being maddeningly fit, fresh, ready for anything.

"What did I tell you about bending your knees and rolling when you hit the ground, Stanton?" He chortled, grinning crookedly.

"The ground 'hit' me first!"

"Never mind. So, it goes!"

"The ladies were in a state of near collapse," the New Englander said accusingly.

"Yes. I had no idea that they would be so plucky. I think they'd worked out that I wasn't going to let them fall into the Army or the Inquisition's

hands. Not under any circumstances. As I say, they are plucky ones. I think Ms Danson must have marked Lady Henrietta's card."

"What are you talking about, man?" Stanton demanded suspiciously.

"Ah, the man from the Manhattan Globe needs his card marked also," Nash whistled, his gaze suddenly hard. "There's no diplomatic way of saying this, I'm afraid. Trust me, you really, really do not want to fall into the hands of *those* people..."

"What are you talking about..."

The penny dropped.

Nonetheless, Paul Nash spelled it out.

Presumably, just so that Albert Stanton wrote it down accurately.

"There are people looking for us who would torture, torment more accurately, rape, I daresay, generally make the ladies' lives a living Hell, invent ludicrous confessions and have Ms Danson, and particularly, Lady Henrietta read those confessions out in court, in a show trial, you understand, before they°— the bad guys, and there are a lot of them out there°— eventually put them to death. The ladies would be very lucky if they were only hanged until dead by the neck in a public square in front of a baying mob. The way things are going it is more likely that they would be burned alive for witchcraft or heresy."

Albert Stanton felt as if all the blood in his body had drained into his feet.

"Seriously?" He asked. He switched on his brain the next second. "No, forget I said that..."

"You," the other man continued, "would certainly be almost as big a catch for *them* as Ms Danson, and no doubt treated similarly. I promised the ladies that if it came to it, I guaranteed them my best endeavours to ensure that they experienced as little pain and knowledge aforethought as I could manage, in what might be very trying circumstances. A man's word is his bond, what? Obviously, I don't want to get myself captured either. In that sense, we're all in exactly the same boat together."

"And eighty or ninety miles from the Portuguese border," Albert Stanton groaned.

"Nearer eighty than ninety, old man," Nash commiserated, grinning mischievously.

Don José entered the room and patted his back.

“You must have had many troubles along the way, old friend,” the Spaniard said wearily, showing his years now he no longer had to maintain the mask of assurance he had radiated to his family and retainers over the last week while they waited for news of Nash’s mission, preparing for flight at a moment’s notice.

“A few,” Nash conceded. “But nothing the ladies need to know about.” He glanced meaningfully at Stanton. “I’m not a great believer in inflicting the more sordid ephemera of my profession upon the womenfolk,” he said tersely.

The New Englander had no idea how to interpret this.

“I made sure that all the throat-cutting happened while the ladies were safely stashed away, out of sight, out of mind, what?”

“Oh, right, I see. That was very, er... Thoughtful of you...”

“No, it was professional of me. The ladies are in my care and it’s damned bad form to unnecessarily alarm a lady.”

Okay, if I blab to Melody Danson, I’ll be the next one to get his throat cut! It was always good to know exactly where one stood...

Stanton raised his hand.

“I understand.”

“Good. If the bad guys carry on being as inept as they’ve been so far,” Nash explained, pragmatically moving on past his warning to the reporter without a backward look— which Stanton guessed was the way he lived his life— and letting him in on the next part of the plan, “we shall be fine. We’ll rest up here until tomorrow night. If it comes on to rain, we’ll move out then, otherwise first thing the following morning. All of us, everybody.”

Stanton had already worked out that there was no future for the Cortés family or the members of its household in the new Spain rising from the ashes of the conflagrations in Madrid and the other big cities.

“You won’t see me tomorrow. Don José’s in charge now. In the event that anything untoward happens in my absence, he will decide if we run or fight.”

“Where will you be?” Stanton shook his head, raised his hand again, this time in apology. “Sorry, dumb question.”

“Not at all, old man. We’re in the middle of a particularly vicious, fast-spreading civil war and as in all such situations there is opportunity for those who know how to exploit them, and inevitably, an unusually large

number of people who urgently need to be dead,” he smiled wolfishly, “rather than alive and kicking.”

“A lot of people,” Don José growled like a bear with an itch that no matter how hard he tries, he cannot reach to scratch.

Chapter 32

Wednesday 5th April

HMS Achilles, Windward Passage, Caribbean

The ship had been piped to Air Defence Stations One an hour before dawn as the cruiser serenely glided south through the waters of the fifty-mile-wide channel between eastern Cuba and the island of Hispaniola – where Columbus had first set foot in the New World – which since the turn of the century had been known as, and latterly officially become the Spanish Crown Province of Santo Domingo. The strait itself had been formed in unimaginably remote geological times by movements along a major active fault line between the two islands. The same fault ran east through Santo Domingo all the way to the Mona Passage and the islands of the smallest and poorest of Spain's Caribbean colonies, the archipelago of the Estado Libre Asociado de Puerto Rico – the Free Associated State of Puerto Rico – which, largely neglected by Old Spain, had been loosely allied with its nearest neighbour for much of the last century until in modern times, the German Empire had acquired its now prosperous concession and wealthy watering hole around the port of San Juan.

The waters beneath the Achilles's keel were over five thousand feet deep and between the cruiser and its destination, still over two hundred miles to the south-south-west, Kingston, lay the abysmal deep of the eastern end of the Cayman Trench.

Piping the ship to ADS One was just the Old Man's way of letting everybody know that now they were heading south he wanted everybody to be on his toes.

'This is the Captain. We'll soon be clear of the northern reaches of the Windward Passage. We'll be letting the old girl,' the ship, 'have her head as soon as it is fully light. We'll make the breakwater at Kingston this evening and enter port tomorrow morning. At which point Achilles will assume command of the West Indies Squadron.'

The Old Man had been at his most fatherly.

'Whatever you have heard about the situation vis-à-vis Cuba and Santo Domingo and the rest of New Spain you will have noticed that nobody is

actually shooting at each other at the moment. Ideally, we'd like to keep things that way. We are sailing south to show the flag and to spread goodwill among the people of the islands blessed to live beneath the Union Jack...'

Shortly after the Old Man concluded his brief Tannoy address to the ship, word was passed for Surgeon-Lieutenant Abraham Lincoln and Sub-Lieutenant Edward Forrest to report to the Captain's stateroom.

'We've got at least one too many aircraft on board, gentlemen,' Captain the Honourable Francis Jackson proclaimed cheerfully. 'We can't even risk exercising the starboard three-inch auto-cannons without blowing away one of the bally things!'

Neither of the airmen attempted to gainsay this.

'I'm sending off the 'wheeled' Sea Fox at first light. I have a few despatches and the boffins have an attaché case full of papers they want sent back to Florida post-haste. I'm told the Sea Foxes have plenty of range for that sort of thing, especially the 'land' variant we've got sitting on the catapult right now.'

'Yes, sir,' Abe agreed respectfully. 'It's several hundred pounds lighter than the float planes and less robustly constructed so it can fly for at least another hour, say one hundred and thirty or forty miles, on the same tank of fuel.'

The Old Man nodded sagely.

'You and Forrest,' he went on, 'have the least time on the standard float plane Sea Fox. So,' he added apologetically, 'I have accepted your divisional commander's recommendation that you deliver despatches to Kingston, re-fuel and fly up to Florida via a fuelling stop on Grand Turk Island, with the initial reports and some of the raw data the electronic warfare chaps compiled while we were cruising off Santo Domingo. Rest assured, you'll be returned to the ship on the first vessel heading south in due course. Do you have any questions?'

Now, Abe and Ted Forrest were being shaken to bits as the engine ran up to maximum power with their Sea Fox firmly locked onto the catapult sledge.

To Abe's surprise the armourers had loaded a hundred pound, and two twenty-five pound high-explosive bombs into the racks under both wings of the aircraft. This weight had more than compensated for the seaplane's lack of big, heavy, dragging floats. Moreover, having expected the flight crew to

remove the observer's ring-mounted 0.303-inch calibre drum-fed machine gun, Ted had been pleasantly surprised to discover it still in place and two spare drums clipped into their rack near to hand. Likewise, the deck crew had re-mounted the aircraft's 0.5-inch forward-firing gun and filled its ammunition box.

Sitting in the wheeled Sea Fox's cockpit for the first time there were other, minor surprises. The controls were familiar, obviously, although waiting on the catapult they felt oddly strange; perhaps because the machine seemed to be brand new, everything spick and span. There was a small fire axe clipped to the inner fuselage by his right knee— in case there was a crash and he had to chop his way out of the wreckage, not normally a consideration at sea apparently, where it was presumed a trapped pilot would simply drown— and the first aid kit was in a larger, aluminium box stowed by his left ankle. There also seemed to be a thin metal bulkhead— in the float planes there was just a void— separating him from the navigator-gunner's position.

However, these were things he only gave fleeting consideration.

Not so the uncomfortable weight of the holstered service revolver, an old-fashioned Webley six-shooter on the belt around his waist. He and Ted Forest had stared at the gun and belt presented to each of them by the armourers as they waited to mount up.

'Captain's Day Orders, sirs,' they had been informed. 'All officers going ashore are to carry firearms at all times until further notice, sirs.'

There was no space in the aircraft for personal belongings; just as well because then it would really have felt as if they were deserting the ship at the precise moment the commission began in earnest. As it was, they could still convince themselves they would be back in a few days.

However bad the news, nobody believed the balloon was going to go up anytime soon. If the 'high ups' were really worried about the situation in the Caribbean, Achilles would be steaming south in the wake of a battleship, several much bigger cruisers and one of the giant new aircraft carriers. And as for the rumours about the German 'Vera Cruz' Squadron well, with the Indomitable already guarding the Mississippi Delta and the Gulf of Spain, the Germans— even if they were flying the flag of Nuevo Granada— were hardly in any position to cause mischief. If the Vera Cruz Squadron was intent on showing its new flag it was likely to cruise down to the Antilles and all those territories like Aruba in the south which Germany

had leased, or rather appropriated pretty much in perpetuity from their former Dutch owners, or to visit the Cayman Islands, another of the supposedly legitimate concessions granted to the Kaiser in the underbelly of the thirteen-year-old Submarine Treaty.

Both Abe and Ted Forrest's emotions had therefore, been mixed as they said their abbreviated farewells and mounted up in the pre-dawn darkness that morning, especially for the Sea Fox's pilot who had discovered the only way not to feel homesick was to bury himself in his duties to the threshold of exhaustion every day. If he allowed himself time to mope over Kate, of missing witnessing their son growing up day by day, his mood dipped and he became preoccupied, no use to man or beast on a fighting warship.

His chief, Surgeon Commander Michael Flynn had yet to get his head around the notion that Abe was a virtual teetotaller, so he put the younger man's moments of introspection down to his sobriety.

'Never met a woman who didn't drive me up the wall if we spent more than a couple of days in each other's company!' He had proudly confessed to the younger man.

Which had left Abe reflecting that although his superior no doubt had numerous excellent qualities, in some respects his appreciation of the human psyche was sadly deficient in a man who, like himself, had devoted his life to a profession which had as its precept *primum no nocere*: first do no harm.

The controller's torch flashed twice.

Abe braced himself

The next thing he knew the Sea Fox was airborne.

He heard Ted Forrest's cheerful tones in his headphones.

"I suggest we point the old jalopy at one-one-oh degrees magnetic on that round, compass-like thing in front of you, skipper!"

Abe suppressed a chuckle and held the aircraft in a slow climbing turn to the left, planning to circle Achilles a couple of times to get his heartbeat back down to a sensible pace before setting course to the south.

"That should take us to within sight of Navassa Island in about thirty-five minutes time," his navigator continued, "assuming we wobble along at what passes for a normal cruising speed for one of these dinosaurs."

Both Abe and Ted had had their heads turned by the 'demonstration' aircraft manufacturers had sent over to Virginia to persuade the Royal Navy

to submit large early orders for the next, and probably final variant of the Goshawk scout-interceptor and the latest incarnation of the Sea Eagle dual-purpose torpedo-dive bomber. The Goshawk Mark IV had a top speed in level flight closer to three than two times that of the ancient Sea Fox; the Sea Eagle Mark III could carry a ton-and-a-half of ordinance and was at least twice as fast. Both aircraft— already in service or coming into service with the Royal Naval Air Service— had service ceilings of over thirty thousand feet and a ferry range of about fourteen hundred miles. In comparison, referring to a Sea Fox as a ‘dinosaur’ was nothing but stating the fact, and if one was being picky, being a little unfair on that magnificent genus of long-extinct ancient reptiles.

As the aircraft flew to the south, climbing away from the Achilles the sky lightened to full day. It never ceased to amaze Abe that from altitude at this time of day one could very nearly see the new day racing to the west.

Suddenly, he blinked.

“Ted, put your glasses on two, maybe three ships at your eight o’clock.”

There was a delay of several seconds.

“I’ve got three ships, maybe a cruiser and two destroyers,” his friend reported.

“I can’t see a thing now,” Abe retorted in frustration.

“It’s a big hazy down there. They might be some of the old ships the Hispanics periodically recover from the scrap yard!”

Many Europeans called the Spanish on Santo Domingo ‘Hispanics’, New Englanders just called them ‘Dominicans’ or simply ‘Spaniards’... or worse. The farther north one went or the farther out into the interior of the North American continent, the generic appellation ‘Dagoes’ was in common usage, apparently a corruption, or a derivation, depending upon one’s conscience, of the Spanish name ‘Diego’.

The ‘old ships’ of the Santo Domingo Colonial Navy were in every respect, very old, a handful of ironclad cruisers with a miscellany of different calibre main battery armaments and powered by antiquated Spanish-made, inefficient— even when brand new— triple expansion reciprocating engines incapable of driving them through the waves faster than fifteen or sixteen knots. The ‘destroyers’ on the Dominican Navy List were better described as ‘torpedo boats’, sub-one thousand-ton greyhounds

in their prime but by modern standards, feebly armed and not best suited for oceanic operations. All of those ‘old’ ships had coal-fired boilers.

“I don’t think those ships can be that ancient, Abe,” Ted Forrest offered. “I’m not seeing clouds of black coal smoke.”

Between the haze and sun dazzle on the sea in the direction of the original sighting neither men could see a great deal for some minutes.

Abe checked the altimeter.

Five thousand feet.

He began to ease the Sea Fox lower, relishing the odd obedience of the ‘float-less’ sea plane. Not that the bombs slung under her wings and the fixed undercarriage offered an altogether negligible drag on the airflow streaming over the aircraft.

“What...” Abe grunted as the Sea Fox bucked like an angry mule.

Something hit the aircraft, rattling against the low windscreen in front of his face.

“Somebody’s bloody shooting at us!” Ted Forrest yelled over the intercom.

Two or three hundred feet above the aircraft and directly along the course Abe had been flying less than thirty seconds before, ugly balls of expanding grey smoke filled the sky.

Abe swung the Sea Fox around and dipped her nose into a shallow dive to the west. He had no intention of hanging around presenting an easy target for what probably had to be ELDAR-directed anti-aircraft fire.

“Ted,” he decided. “Break radio silence and report to Achilles that we have come under fire from as many as three unidentified warships. Send them our position. Tell the ship I plan to loiter hereabouts; hopefully, out of range.” He realised he was getting breathless. He took a couple of deliberately long, calming breaths. “You best ask them what they want us to do.”

His friend acknowledged this.

Then quipped: “I’m not going to remind Achilles we’ve got bombs on board. Those beggars have already made a couple of holes in the top wing and we were miles away at the time!”

Abe elected not to amend his orders.

The last time he had tried to ‘dive bomb’ a ship at sea he had nearly killed them both and on that occasion, nobody had actually been shooting at them!

Chapter 33

Wednesday 5th April

Hacienda de Cortés, Navalperal de Tormes, Avila

Melody Danson had awakened that morning to discover Henrietta De L'Isle keeping watch over her. Her lover was lying on her side, her gaze sleepily, contentedly amused. She kissed Melody, who reciprocated while attempting to suppress a giggle. The women hugged tight together and sank deeper into their nest of blankets.

Melody began to doze off to sleep again until the call of nature whose twinges had been what had roused her in the first place, reminded her it was a need which had, and was not about to go away. She groaned, began to disentangle herself.

It was only then that she realised that she hurt all over.

She was so stiff and sore, down to the marrow of her bones with every joint seemingly aching in mutual complaint, that she found it hard to sit up the first time she tried it. Her legs felt like wooden sticks even though – although she had no memory of it – her feet were bandaged and the stinging agony of yesterday's blisters was gone when eventually, she staggered upright.

She was wearing a long white cotton nightdress.

No, I don't remember putting that on either...

Fresh clothes were hanging on hooks by the bedroom door and folded over the back of chairs near the bed. Not the fancy court dresses they had been wearing right up to their desperate escape from Chinchón, no these were practically, crudely tailored workmen's or male below stairs household staff fatigues. That made sense, with their hair short and the way they had slewed off every last ounce of superfluous flesh in the last couple of weeks, they hardly looked like ladies of leisure anymore!

Somebody had had their walking boots cleaned and polished overnight.

And there was a tray on the floor near the bed with hard doorsteps of fresh bread – the smell gave it away – cheese, a jug of water and crystal glasses.

Briefly, the women forgot their pains and attacked 'breakfast'.

Under the window of their large, white-walled chamber there was a big bowl of tepid water, soap and towels which they employed in a vain attempt to make themselves look 'half-way presentable' before dressing and creeping down a wide staircase to the ground floor where they interrupted a conversation between Paul Nash, Albert Stanton— Melody had thought she had dreamed their meeting the previous evening — and a large, distinguished man in his sixties who introduced himself as Don José Cortés, Alcalde of Navalperal de Tormes.

All three men had side arms strapped to their hips.

Paul Nash had his grey automatic pistol, the others old-fashioned silvery revolvers of the type still, allegedly favoured by cowboys on the great ranches of the New England west, and all manner of ne'er-do-wells and 'free spirits' in the fast-shrinking wildernesses beyond the Mississippi.

The women became aware of the intense activity outside, the sound of horses, and of vehicle motors running up.

"We had hoped to let you ladies rest a while longer," Don José apologised, mortified that their restorative slumber had been prematurely disturbed. "Paul has told us of the privations of your journey and of your remarkable fortitude."

Melody smiled and thanked the old man and his family for 'taking us in'.

Don José beamed with pleasure.

"I had heard that you were both fluent speakers of our ancient language," he chortled in native Castilian.

"It has been our great joy to hear again the music in that language these last few months," Henrietta interjected with a girlish smile.

Melody had quickly accepted that the daughter of a Viscount was, as was to be expected, a lot better at social small talk than she was ever going to be, and wisely, since they had been in Spain she had often deferred to the younger woman in public settings.

Don José was instantly charmed to the point of distraction, his mind momentarily diverted from the troubles he and the other men had been discussing.

"We need to be on the road in the next couple of hours," Paul Nash declared, matter of factly.

The women waited for him to elaborate.

“There is an Army patrol in the next village,” Albert Stanton explained, throwing a frown at Nash. “We think the road to the west is still clear but the authorities seem to be getting their act together.”

Melody’s heart sank.

Don José and his people were about to become fugitives too.

The old man seemed to be reading her thoughts.

“Like my old friend Don Rafael, My Lord’s strong right arm, I and my family’s banner has been loyal to the Duke’s House since before the time of the Great War. His Grace has declared for the Queen and we are thus, condemned. We must flee, come what may because there is no place for us, or for any of our clan or mind in this new Spain.”

He spoke with stern, implacable gravitas as if there was no choice but to accept his fate.

Melody felt a tear trickle down her left cheek.

“No, no,” Don José murmured. “It is God’s will. My family is descended from that great butcher Hernán Cortés de Monroy y Pizarro Altamirano, Marquis of the Valley of Oaxaca, who died in debt, shunned and shamed by his own people. It matters more to *my household* that we live in honour rather than bend our knee to those who would betray Old Spain.”

Paul Nash coughed.

A starter motor fired, died, roared again in the yard outside.

He looked hard at Melody and Henrietta.

“Neither of you is fit to walk.” He shrugged. “Which rules out a slow, possibly safer trek over the mountains.” This said he grimaced: “Well, ‘safer’ being a bit of an oxymoron in this case.”

Albert Stanton opened his mouth to speak.

Nash cut him off.

“So, what we’re going to do is mount up in every available vehicle and make a headlong dash for the Portuguese border. Several of Don José’s most trusted men will go ahead of the main convoy. As a vanguard, or trail blazers, if you like. I will hang back in the rear guard. If all goes well, we shall meet up again on friendly territory in twenty-four to forty-eight hours’ time.”

Melody had always been a woman trying to compete with men in *their* world and in her experience, it was exactly *this* sort of macho, testosterone-

driven do or die crap which was responsible for most, if not all, of the World's troubles.

Infuriatingly, in this situation she could not think of a better idea. She knew that although there probably had to be one— a better idea, that was— she just could not think of it.

So, do-or-die it had to be...

Involuntarily, she put her hand to her neck where habitually she twirled her hair in moments of concentration. Her fingers encountered fresh air and she snapped back her hand, suddenly feeling very self-conscious.

Don José was viewing her with concern.

"It is nothing," she assured him quickly, with a tight-lipped smile. "Hen and I used to have long hair. Like I say, it is stupid..."

"Only two women of such fortitude and distinction could have survived the long walk out of the Sierra de Guadarrama. I did not think it was possible," the old man grimaced. "Your beauty is not in your hair, it shines from within your souls."

Melody blinked, tried not to start crying.

And I thought Alonso was a sweet-talking seducer...

This must have been the guy who taught him all he knows!

She heard what she took to be an engine backfiring in the distance. The men in the room were suddenly tense, listening hard.

"That sounded like one of those old *policía* carbines," Paul Nash suggested.

Don José nodded.

There was more shooting, albeit still distant.

The rattle of return fire, a ragged fusillade was not perhaps, as far away as they had all first imagined as it filtered into the room like the commotion of fireworks in the next valley.

Nash patted Don José's arm.

"That settles it," he decided. "I need to be somewhere else and you and the ladies need to be heading in the other direction!"

Chapter 34

Wednesday 5th April
Windward Passage, Caribbean

Knowing that they were too far away from the Achilles to communicate via scrambled VHF radio transmissions Abe climbed to rise, hopefully, high enough above the cruiser's line of sight horizon to establish secure voice communications. All the while Ted Forrest tried to raise the ship having been ordered not to broadcast in 'the clear' a second time.

"That's it!" He proclaimed triumphantly. "I've made contact again!"

The ships below had stopped shooting at the Sea Fox.

Either the range was too long, or they were flying too high. More likely the former than the latter, although their altitude was a perishingly cold nine thousand feet at present.

Abe had decided he was not going to miss the old-fashioned open cockpits of the Sea Fox when somebody offered him the chance to fly a more 'modern' aircraft.

"The other two kites are going to bomb those fellows!" The man in the aft cockpit reported. "We're to keep well out of the way and when it is all over, we're to report to Achilles and to beetle off down to Jamaica pronto!"

Abe did not think a Sea Fox could get anywhere near one of those ships down there without getting shot to pieces.

"Those ships almost knocked us down at a range of three or four miles," he reminded his friend. "They've got to have ELDAR-controlled gun directors on at least one of those boats. Our kites will be sitting ducks!"

"I'm just telling you what Achilles told me, skipper," Ted Forrest retorted tersely.

Abe realised that discussing it was not going to change anything.

"See if you can raise the other kites on the scrambler link, Ted."

"What do you want me to say to them?"

"Tell them we'll approach the targets from the west if they want to attack from other points, say north and east of the compass. That way, we'll at least split their fire and hopefully, make it impossible for their ELDAR directors to concentrate on a single aircraft."

Well, until the beggars have shot down the other two Sea Foxes...

“We were ordered to stay out of it, skipper?”

“Our friends will get themselves blown to bits if we don’t do something, Ted.”

“Okay, okay. But for goodness sake try not to fly down the funnel of the nearest ship this time!”

Abe began to bleed off height, seeking to get below the haze to find a clearer view of the enemy’s— people who fired at one were by definition ‘enemies’— vessels.

He blinked.

Whoever those ships belonged to the biggest of the three was no antiquated ironclad. To the contrary, just a fleeting glimpse of its three-quarters silhouette was enough to betray the purposeful lines of a modern cruiser, escorted by two big, very mean-looking fleet destroyers built on the... *German model*.

No, that was insane!

There were no big *Kaiserliche Marine* warships in the western Caribbean. The radio listening services in Florida and along the Gulf Coast all the way to the Mississippi Delta below New Orleans routinely triangulated all radio traffic in the region, identifying and locating— within a few miles— where every active unit of the Cuban and New Spanish navies were, day by day. Add to that the reports of ship sightings by the countless British and New England-flagged, not to mention friendly merchantmen plying these waters and a foreign vessel, especially a warship could not fire up a boiler without, within hours, appearing on the big situation board at Fleet Headquarters in Norfolk. Besides, all the German warships in the region were supposed to be down in Vera Cruz the best part of eighteen hundred miles away...

“The big ship looks like an Emden class cruiser. The destroyers with her look like C or D type ships.”

Ted Forrest was peering through binoculars.

“Yes, I’ll buy that!” Then: “What the Devil are they doing here, Abe?”

Emden class: launched between 1969 and 1972, ten thousand tons of menace armed with nine 5.9-inch guns in three triple turrets, two forward and one aft, and reputedly capable of thirty-three knots. By length and breadth, the Emdens were a few feet longer, and eight or nine wider in the

beam than Achilles and protected by well over twice the weight and thickness of armour.

The C and D type fleet destroyers were less than eight years old, two-an-a-half thousand tons of fast-moving trouble mounting either ten, in the case of the Cs, and eight in the slightly newer Ds, 4.1-inch dual-purpose high-angle cannons, a battery of up to sixteen 1.5-inch anti-aircraft autocannons in twin or quadruple mounts, in addition to at least eight 20-inch torpedo tubes.

Given that one, possibly all three of the ships cruising in and out of the haze now rapidly burning off the sea – which had just started shooting at the Sea Fox again – were clearly hostile it was not unreasonable to conclude that they had been lying in wait for the Achilles.

Abe banked away from the onrushing shells.

“I think that was only the nearest destroyer letting fly!” Ted Forrest speculated. “Oh, Achilles has just repeated the order for us to make ourselves scarce, Abe!”

Of all the things that were likely to happen in the next few hours the least plausible was that Captain Jackson would turn Achilles around and run away. Confronted with the big destroyers the cruiser might get the best of any battle; but not if the Emden class ship was in the mix too. Achilles was not built to slug it out, *that* cruiser was...

“Our two friends will be here in less than fifteen minutes,” his navigator informed Abe. “They plan to go in together, wingtip to wingtip.”

They both knew that was not going to work.

Without really thinking about it, Abe had turned back towards the enemy flotilla, intuitively flying long, lazy S’s to confuse the ELDAR-directed gun layers on the distant ships.

He had learned a brutally hard lesson that day he had nearly crashed into the Achilles in a spoof bombing run gone horribly wrong; and another unnerving one not long ago about never flying straight and level in a combat zone. He wondered if his crewmates and fellow airmen in the two approaching Sea Foxes were wiser men than he had been a fortnight ago.

“Warn our friends not to fly a constant course for more than thirty seconds at a time, Ted!”

Both the other pilots were vastly experienced naval aviators and had regarded Abe as very much the new boy on the block; the Flight’s part-timer, a ‘sprog’, still decidedly wet behind the ears. The oddity of Abe

being a Surgeon Lieutenant, albeit two to three years junior to the other pilots, had been a vexation to his fellow front seaters, who otherwise would have felt freer to throw their weight around in his presence. Not that Abe would have begrudged them their sport. He was a big boy now, he understood how the world turned and that the Navy had its traditions, one of which was to frequently remind one's juniors of their proper place in the order of things.

He had little doubt that the other men were better pilots than him: how could they not be with their hundreds of hours flying time on Sea Foxes? The question was: how quickly could they adapt to the kill or be killed rules of this deadly new game?

Those ships had opened fire on him when he was flying over international waters twenty plus miles outside the Dominican territorial limit.

They had clearly meant to kill *him*.

That was an unambiguous act of war.

In that moment everything had changed.

I ought to be afraid; instead, I feel... alive.

"Blue Section Leader is ordering us to disengage, skipper!"

"Acknowledge..."

"He says the reports we have on board are more important than a gaggle of hostiles."

Abe frowned and clicked his intercom switch.

"Put me on the scrambler circuit, Ted."

"Blue Three to Leader," Abe said tersely into his mask. "I am flying in and out of the enemy's effective envelope of fire to establish its limits. Presently, I estimate that to be around three nautical miles for the two smaller ships. I don't think the cruiser has fired a shot yet..."

"Blue Leader to Blue Three!" Retorted Achilles's senior pilot, cutting in angrily. "You were given a direct order to disengage. Do as you were bloody well told!"

Abe's thoughts were turning slowly, coldly.

"Very good," he drawled. "They're all your's, Blue Leader." Not waiting for the other man to confirm he had heard this he switched back to intercom mode. "Those fellows are going to barrel straight in on the cruiser."

He left unsaid the obvious corollary that: ‘And they are going to get themselves killed for nothing.’

“What are you thinking, Abe?” Ted Forest demanded.

Abe almost chuckled to himself.

His friend knew him too well already.

“I’m going to put us in the Sun to those fellows down there. They’ll be busy when Blue Leader and Blue Two get within range. This kite is a little slippier through the air than they are, she’ll be handier in the dive, too...”

“Our bombs will bounce off that cruiser, Abe.”

“Maybe,” Abe conceded. “But you wouldn’t want to be standing on the deck next to one of them when they go off!”

He was remembering the exquisite thrill of that day he had risked diving his aircraft down the Achilles’s funnel, the moment of terror when he had approached Albany field on his first solo landing, and that time he had had to land his misfiring Bristol VII on White Bear Lake in the darkness...

Perhaps, he was his father’s son after all.

The Hunter’s blood ran through his veins.

And those ships far below were his prey...

Chapter 35

Wednesday 5th April

Valley of the River Tormes, Avila

Sporadic bullets were whistling through the air, randomly thudding into walls and deflecting, dusting off the ground as the two women were bundled into the back of, all things, an ancient Bentley limousine of the vintage type only owned in the British Isles or New England by wealthy collectors and the most obsessive of historic car enthusiasts.

Something pinged off the bonnet bringing a scowl to Don José de Cortés's whole face for a moment as he unhurriedly deposited his large frame in the front passenger seat of the Bentley and touched the driver's shoulder, a man with a pugilist's broken, half-mended face, indicating for him to proceed. The car lurched forward, falling into convoy with the rusty, open-topped Land Rover in the lead. This vehicle was itself, perhaps thirty or forty years old, one of the original, very basic models so beloved of farmers and colonial administrators in far-flung rough country where simplicity and ruggedness – which even the earliest Land Rovers had always had in bucketfuls – were priceless assets.

Melody Danson and Henrietta De L'Isle had needed no encouragement to cower low on the crowded back seat with the patriarch's wife Señora Margarita – a slim, bird-like woman – and a wide-eyed boy, a skinny urchin with a mop of rebellious dark hair of no more than three or four years of age, who apparently, was the son of the man behind the wheel.

Picking up speed the car rocked and rolled on its rusty springs like a dinghy in a tideway, creaking and groaning as its wheels encountered potholes, dips and ridges in the barely maintained road along the foot of the northern side of the valley.

The sound of a huge explosion from somewhere near the Hacienda de Cortés reached the Bentley as it negotiated a sharp turn some minutes into the headlong flight to the west.

Don José turned and looked back at his passengers.

“Do not be alarmed. When I put it to Paul that I wished to leave nothing for the vultures to pick over when we departed, he suggested a use

for the blasting powder kept in the village store and for some of the ‘special stores’ that Señor Stanton brought with him.” He smiled grimly. “There will be further explosions,” he warned. “Please do not be alarmed.”

Don José was not a man who believed in ‘alarm’.

When the stray rifle rounds had started fizzing through the air he had stood, unconcerned, in the courtyard marshalling his people into the waiting vehicles, pausing here and there to pat a shoulder or to murmur a reassuring word. More than once he had cracked a wry, one-liner and guffawed, slapping his thigh as if today’s desperate escape was no more than the preparation for a family picnic in the hills.

The ‘further explosions’ were much smaller than the first but there were a lot of them.

Grenades, Melody guessed.

“The country is at its finest in the spring when the waters run strongly in the Tormes. Later in the year the sun beats down and the river becomes a stream,” Don José explained affably. “Some years the river dries up, although not so much of late; the winters have been harsh and the snow on the highest peaks does not melt until this time of the year. As a boy I fished in the Tormes, even this high in the hills. Not of late, though,” he reflected sadly. “Or, perhaps, ever again.”

His wife spoke for the first time since leaving her home.

“We have had forty good years together in this country,” she comforted her husband. “We shall have more to come. Just not in the land of our birth.”

The old woman’s stoicism made Melody a little ashamed of herself. Don José and his family had nothing to look forward to but exile; she and Henrietta might, although at the moment it seemed unlikely, get to go home at the end of this... nightmare.

It was this which made her sit up.

She was at least going to enjoy the view as the Bentley trundled to the west. Henrietta did likewise and gestured to the boy still crouched in the foot well to pop up on her lap.

“My name is Henrietta, what is your name?” She inquired maternally.

“Pedro,” the kid murmured.

Señora Margarita smiled fond indulgence.

“He’s not normally such a quiet one, that boy,” she said with a fond severity. “Sergio’s dear wife,” she nodded at the driver, “died when Pedro

was young. We had Polio and Diphtheria in the village that year, our precious monarch and his circle do not care to ‘waste’ their treasure on programs of inoculation of the type common in the rest of the civilised world.” She sighed in disgust. “Worse, they frown upon Alcaldes like my husband infringing upon their ‘prerogatives’ by doing the work they ought to be doing. Pedro was brought into our household as a baby.”

The old lady smiled.

Henrietta had hugged the boy to herself to stop him being thrown about by the unpredictable gyrations of the Bentley.

Melody gave her lover a look, unsurprised that the kid had brought out Henrietta’s mothering side. The younger woman looked back, shrugged imperceptibly, almost defiantly and clung onto the boy.

Behind them a battered Morris estate car— possibly less than twenty years old— and a slightly more modern, early 1960s battered Leyland lorry rumbled along in the Bentley’s wake. Despite the recent rains the vehicles were kicking up rooster tails of dust and loose stones.

Melody’s thoughts wandered.

Of course, Spain has no real automotive industry. A few factories made spare parts, albeit only for the relatively small number of imported cars and commercial vehicles— a business severely constrained by the Spanish government’s Draconian foreign exchange and currency rules— and several workshops produced hand-made, very expensive cars for wealthy customers, otherwise the country had no native ‘car industry’ in the sense understood by the citizens of the British Isles, Germany, New England— where approximately half the cars and six in every ten large lorries, that is, over five tons deadweight in the Empire were built— France, or elsewhere in the ‘first’, industrialised World. Even Russia produced several hundred thousand cars and trucks a year, and both Australia and India had their own thriving automotive industries. But not Old Spain whose industrial economy had scarcely progressed since the latter part of the nineteenth century.

Part of that was the legacy of the Great War, or that was the lie still parroted by the courtiers of the King-Emperor’s court, and by the organs of a Mother Church that was content to see Spain remain a bastion of medieval orthodoxy in all things...

Melody caught occasional glimpses of the Land Rover foraging far ahead of the rest of the convoy. The men riding precariously on its rusty,

bucking ribs were armed with rifles, looking for a fight. Problematically, in this sort of valley and mountain terrain, it was patently obvious that a single militiaman with a gun could stop the convoy in its tracks on this road.

Don José was ahead of her.

“In two or three miles we will go to the north, the rest of our journey will be through ‘bandit’ country which the *Army* and the *policía* fear to enter.”

He went on to answer Melody’s next, unspoken question.

“We shall drive through the night. At some stage we will have to halt to refuel the vehicles. We have several cans of petrol in the Leyland. With God’s providence, that will be sufficient to carry us to our destination.”

Chapter 36

Wednesday 5th April

Windward Passage, Caribbean

“I’m picking up a broadcast from Kingston!” Ted Forrest yelped. His voice rang with shocked disbelief. “They’re broadcasting in the clear and they say they are under attack. Cassandra has been hit and has gone aground in the harbour. Several ‘heavy units’ are shelling the naval base and the airfield...”

Abe was so insulated in his own intense little bubble of concentration that the words did not register for some seconds.

“Somebody’s shelling Kingston!” His navigator shouted into the intercom.

“I heard you the first time, Ted,” Abe retorted perfunctorily.

When you were in the woods the best hunter always focused on one thing at a time. Distraction was failure, a kill missed. He and Kate had gone off into the forests of the Mohawk country as kids trapping critters, wrangling snakes but that had got old, rattlers were not good eating. Thinking about it they rarely caught anything in those early years, nobody would let him have a gun until he was in his mid-teens. Then Tsiokwaris had loaned him a long Martini-Henry, a gun allegedly brought back by a man of the nation from the Border Wars, Kate had taught him how to be silent in the forests and he had begun to learn the ways of the hunter. Had he known then what he learned later he might have become a crack shot, not merely a journeyman with that gun but at the time the fun had been in the hunt, tracking, plotting, and of course, being alone in the woods with... Tekonwenaharake.

It was the oddest thing: right now, her spirit travelled with him through the wind as strongly as it had in those lost days of their childhood. It was as if a part of her was with him, looking over his shoulder, the angel of his better nature curbing the lust for blood that always lurked, demon-like, beneath his skin when he was like this, hunting his prey.

“It has to be the same people as the one’s down there!” Ted Forrest said, stating what was patently obvious before he knew what he was saying.

Abe had never taken his eyes off the distant ships.

He chopped back the throttle and the aircraft slowed, juddered on the point of a stall as its airspeed dropped to little more than sixty knots.

“What are we doing, skipper?” His navigator asked anxiously, still badly shaken by the radio broadcast in his earphones.

“Alex, my brother had a theory that the 5th Battle Squadron couldn’t dial back its rangefinders and fire-control directors to cope with the slow speed of the aircraft which attacked its ships on Empire Day,” Abe informed his friend, his tone didactic, unemotional. “That’s why *all* the attacking aircraft got through. My guess is that the fellows below assume that nobody would be so stupid as to mount an attack at their slowest, rather than their fastest speed.”

Ted Forrest was still listening to the broadcast from Kingston.

“Cassandra is confirmed as beached and on fire. The shelling has switched to the town... There are at least two enemy spotter planes circling the harbour... Two other floatplanes have strafed the airfield... The aviation spirit tanks are on fire... It sounds like bedlam down there, Abe!”

HMS Cassandra was a one-off, an experimental ‘anti-aircraft cruiser’ built on a similar hull to that of the Achilles. However, instead of eight 6-inch guns main battery in four twin turrets she mounted twelve 4.7 inch, long-barrelled— fifty-seven calibre— rifles in six twin gun houses capable of elevating their rifles to eighty degrees. An odd-looking ship even more lightly armoured than Achilles, she had clocked up nearly thirty-six knots in full-power trials shortly after her commissioning over twenty years ago. It was probably Cassandra’s ‘oddness’ which had consigned her to a so-called ‘guard ship’ career mostly spent in the Far East and here on the Caribbean Station, where she had been off and on, for the last five years based at Georgetown, Barbados.

Cassandra would be no match for that Emden class cruiser now beginning to grow larger in the ring-sight of the Fire Fox’s single forward-firing machine gun. Cassandra’s 4.7-inchers would barely tickle a ship like that...

The first salvo of anti-aircraft shells exploded well over half-a-mile ahead of Abe’s shallow windscreen.

“Achilles is now ordering us to fly straight up to the Turks and Caicos Islands, skipper!”

“Acknowledge that, Ted.”

Abe had to gun the throttle to stop the aircraft falling out of the sky; more airbursts blossomed several hundred yards ahead of the aircraft.

The cruiser was turning and from her broadening wake ‘opening all the taps’ and pouring on the power. The destroyers had raced past her, now they were having to heel into violent turns of their own to regain station.

Okay, that is interesting...

This is all new to them, too...

“Oh, God!” Ted Forrest cried excitedly.

One of the other Sea Foxes emerged from a cloud of shell bursts in pieces, tumbling end over end down towards the blue, glittering waters a mile below.

The other aircraft pressed on, diving now.

“Skipper, we’re supposed to be heading straight for Grand Turk Island or Cockburn Town on the way up to Florida!”

“Yes,” Abe agreed. He left his intercom switched to ‘transmit’. He needed to focus on that cruiser... and nothing else for the next minute or so.

The Sea Fox was less than a mile away, in a shallow dive with its engine throttle back so far that its propeller was virtually feathered when either Blue leader or Blue One, plummeted to its fiery death. For a moment Abe was unsure if it had hit the stern of the cruiser a glancing blow on its port side or just crashed into the sea. He was amazed the surviving Sea Fox had emerged more or less whole from the blizzard of small-calibre anti-aircraft fire thrown up in a seemingly impenetrable umbrella above the fast-moving ship.

Then there were three explosions.

Simultaneously, on the roof of the cruiser’s after triple turret, another right at the transom end of the quarterdeck and another, to the eye slightly delayed, from inside the ship bursting out of the deck planking in a splinter-filled mushroom of grey smoke shot through with crimson.

The Sea Fox had released its bombs in its death dive...

Abe decided, however unlikely it was, that his guess that the cruiser had stopped shooting at him, was correct. The reason why was of no consequence. Likewise, the reason why the ship which he had calculated to have been making at least twenty-five knots and had been picking up speed all the while just seconds ago had, although still turning hard to starboard, visibly slowed.

He pressed forward the throttle lever until it hit the stop bar.

Pushed the nose of the aircraft down.

He clasped the stick with his right hand as his left closed over the bomb release lever.

Instantly, the cruiser was filling his gunsight.

His thumb closed over the firing button.

He waited.

Pressed the button hard.

The Sea Fox shook as the slipstream roared past.

Chapter 37

Wednesday 5th April
El Barco de Ávila

Everything had gone to Hell in seconds.

There had been a blizzard of rifle and machine gun fire from up ahead, the Bentley had swerved off the road and very nearly overturned and men, women and children had spilled out of the following vehicles as the first bullets tore into the convoy and ricocheted off the road and the rocks to either side of it. It was bedlam with bodies falling, scythed down everywhere.

“If we stay here, we’re done for!” Albert Stanton shouted, blinking fiercely through the dusty lenses of his spectacles, as he dropped into the dirt where the women and the traumatised boy, Pedro, who had been dozing on Henrietta’s lap when the mayhem erupted, were sheltering.

The Bentley was fifty feet away, burning fiercely.

The driver, Don José and his wife, had been shot before they could move and Melody Danson did not have any idea how she, Henrietta and the boy had got out, scampered across open ground and fallen into the dry trench, some kind of drainage channel, without anything worse than a few grazes and scratches.

The man from the *Manhattan Globe* was hefting an old-fashioned sub-machine gun of the kind one saw German gangsters using in so many films these days...

“We have to get out of here!” He yelled.

He pressed a grey automatic pistol into Melody’s hands.

“The safety is off, there’s a bullet in the chamber. If you have to shoot anybody, grab it in both hands, point in the general direction of the target and keep pressing the trigger.”

“I don’t...”

“We have to get out of here,” the man repeated breathlessly. “NOW!”

He did not wait for a response.

Instead, he grabbed Melody’s arm and suddenly the two women, the boy, whom Henrietta in her terror had found the strength to sweep up in her

arms, were running bent double towards a nearby tree line above where the river Tormes in spring spate burred past the walls of a dusty village.

Others were running with them.

Bullets kicked up stones.

They hurdled a fallen body without thinking to stop.

They fell, tumbling into the trees.

They jumped up and ran again.

They halted under cover, listened to the water flowing nearby.

They could smell the river, an oasis in an otherwise dry, rocky landscape.

“Keep low,” Stanton directed, gasping for air. “If we got this far the plan was to meet up with ‘friends’ on the other side of the river. There was some talk of transferring to boats, the river isn’t navigable all the way to the Douro, which it joins at a place called Ambasaguas, but where it narrows or passes over natural outcrops or rocky sub-straits, I’m given to believe that it is just about passable if one is travelling in lightweight skiffs that can be manhandled over obstacles...”

Through the undergrowth Melody thought she glimpsed the shape of the arches of a stone bridge.

The intensity of the shooting had lessened.

“Well,” she decided. “I have no idea what’s happened to our ‘friends’ but I don’t think hanging around here any longer than we absolutely have to is going to be a very good idea!”

“I agree,” the man said. Although he was soaked in perspiration and trembling from the violent physical exertions of the last few minutes, he retained the presence of mind to nudge the muzzle of the gun gripped in Melody’s now cramping grasp away from his legs.

“Sorry,” she muttered.

“Don’t mention it,” he chuckled ruefully.

Henrietta was hugging Pedro to her breast.

“What do we do?” She asked, surreally calm in that moment.

“People are trying to kill us on this side of the river,” the man replied. “It can’t be any worse on the other side.”

Melody was tempted to disagree with this premise.

Every police officer, particularly every detective, took it as an article of faith that things could always get worse. However, in the circumstances she decided that it would have been less than helpful to belabour the point.

However, with bullets fizzing through the branches above them the simple act of steeling oneself to get to one's feet was going to be a near insuperable psychological obstacle.

That was, right up until the moment there were two small, ear-splitting detonations less than thirty yards from where they lay. After that they were on their feet in a flash and running along the eastern bank of the Tormes towards the bridge Melody had glimpsed through the trees a minute ago.

There were several men with rifles hunkered down behind sand bags and an overturned truck guarding the village end of the bridge. They saw Stanton and the women and waved the fugitives past.

"Date prisa los bastardos están llegando!"

HURRY, THE BASTARDS ARE COMING!

In reality, this incitement could not possibly have hastened their steps across the horribly exposed span of the medieval humped-back bridge. Nevertheless, with it ringing in their ears they ignored their pains and their terrors and sprinted as if they were possessed.

Chapter 38

Wednesday 5th April
Windward Passage, Caribbean

It was like a dream, a kaleidoscopic melange of impressions rather than a linear ‘real’ experience. Abe recollected the machine gun falling silent, its magazine boxes emptied, the cruiser’s funnel beckoning black and abysmal, the imagined tang of boiler exhaust in his face, the Sea Fox twitching and shaking, and something plucking at his left shoulder, the aircraft zooming away after the bombs dropped and Ted Forrest’s cockpit mounted 0.303 gun rattling angrily.

And then it was over.

“One of our eggs must have gone down her bally funnel!” Abe’s friend was yelling exuberantly. “She’s coming to a dead stop in the water! There’s a bloody big fire on her boat deck amidships! She’s venting steam from one of her boilers like nobody’s business! Even those little twenty-five pounders went off with a frightful bang when they hit her boat deck!”

Abe turned his head to snatch a look for himself.

Why aren’t the destroyers shooting at us?

Be thankful for small mercies, I suppose.

The aircraft felt a little heavy, he glanced to left and right trying to see what damage there was to the Sea Fox’s wings. He saw several uncomfortably large, fist-sized holes.

“Ted, what does the tail look like?”

“The rudder has got a bloody big hole in it, skipper!”

“What about you, are you okay, Ted?”

“Yeah, what about you?”

“Something clipped my shoulder but I’m fine.”

A fierce blaze had taken hold aft of the cruiser’s single, now somewhat abbreviated and re-profiled formerly elegant funnel and exhaust gases were pluming almost vertically above the wreckage. From the altitude Abe had released his bombs he knew none of them could have penetrated the two to three inches of Krupp cemented plate covering the cruiser’s vitals, so the

ship was not about to sink but on the other hand she was on fire and virtually stopped in the water.

“I think I read KARLSRUHE on that beggar’s aft superstructure, Skipper,” Ted Forrest reported.

“Report to Achilles that the *KARLSRUHE* is temporarily dead in the water and on fire. I’d guess her main battery is still intact, I don’t think that bomb that went off on her aft turret will have done anything more than concuss the gun crew.” He hesitated. “Did you see those great big Spanish-looking flags the Karlsruhe was flying from her forward yards and from her main mast, Ted?”

“Yes. But they weren’t Spanish. They look like the *Nuevo Granada* version of the Old Spanish *rag*.”

“Okay. Make sure you report that too, please.”

“I’m on it, skipper.”

Not that being at war with New Spain, or Nuevo Granada, and probably Cuba, Santo Domingo and God alone knew who else in this part of the World was better than being at war with Germany, leastways, from a New England perspective but none of that was Abe’s immediate concern.

Reporting exactly what they had observed was the main thing.

Abe circled, climbing back up to around four thousand feet, retreating out of the two destroyers’ anti-aircraft zone of engagement. One of the smaller ships had closed to hailing range of the Karlsruhe.

He checked the fuel gauges.

“Report to Achilles that we are disengaging. If we stooge around much longer, we won’t have any kind of reserve if we run into head winds on the way up to Cockburn Town.”

One last, long climbing circle and Abe pointed the Sea Fox to the north towards where he assumed Achilles was pounding south at her best speed.

“Achilles is engaging two heavies!”

Initially, Abe was a little afraid that all the excitement had proved a little too much for his friend.

“What was that, Ted?”

“Achilles reports she is engaging two heavy cruisers,” his friend said doggedly. “From what I’m hearing the hostiles must have come out of Guantanamo Bay, or the clutter of the land thereabouts, and suddenly popped up on Achille’s ELDAR plot at a range of only fourteen miles...”

Abe did the math: the 8-inch guns of the latest generation of *Kaiserliche Marine* heavy cruisers had a range of around twenty miles. Fourteen miles was well within the killing envelope of those guns and at the absolute outer effective range limit of Achilles's 50-calibre 6-inch Mark XXIs. More pertinently the German ships were shooting two hundred and seventy-pound projectiles against Achilles's one hundred and twelve pounders. Even taking into account that Achilles could probably throw two broadsides to the bigger ships' one that still meant her eight guns could only put one thousand seven hundred and ninety-two pounds of metal in the air per minute, against the four thousand three hundred and twenty pounds of her two much bigger, heavily armoured foes. Worse, especially at long-range, plunging fire from the German ships would tear through Achilles's thin skin and parsimoniously light armoured protection like a hot knife through butter, while her own rounds would simply crumple up or bounce off the three or four inches of plate protecting the enemy's machinery and magazine spaces.

"It was always a trap, Ted," Abe said blankly. "If Achilles managed to outrun the heavies coming out of Guantanamo Bay the Karlsruhe and those two destroyers were positioned to block her way south. With other ships shelling Kingston this has to be practically the whole of the Vera Cruz Squadron mounting a pre-emptive operation against us in this part of the Caribbean!"

His friend was silent for some seconds.

"If the Old Man pulls out all the stops, I bet Achilles can show those big beggars a clean pair of heels," Ted Forrest speculated.

But they both knew that the Old Man was not going to run away from anybody.

The Royal Navy had not become the globe's premier navy by running away. It was hammered into all inductees at every naval college in the Empire that 'no captain can do wrong if he lays his ship against his enemy'. Three hundred years of indefatigable tradition and the honour of the service dictated that whatever the odds no Royal Navy ship declined battle on the piffling grounds that it was massively out-gunned.

As to how a captain was expected to react to a supposedly 'hopeless' situation, that was simple: one fought until one could fight no more, and then one fought on regardless...

Chapter 39

Wednesday 5th April
Puente de Congosto, River Tormes

In the darkness the lights of the village seemed unnaturally bright as the two boats, little more than what New Englanders would regard as ‘punts’ and the locals called ‘skiffs’, drifted slowly beneath the arches of yet another very old stone bridge.

Had Melody Danson not been exhausted— it seemed as if they, Albert Stanton, she and Henrietta De L’Isle and the grim-faced Spanish teenagers steering the two boats had spent longer manhandling the wooden punts over two or three inch deep stone-fields and through muddy shallows than actually afloat— she might have recognised that she was travelling through an antique landscape, surrounded by the immutable evidence of the suffocating stasis which had gripped this once great nation. It was as if time had stood still in this country; away from the big cities the majority of the population lived more or less as they had done in the seventeenth century everyday viewing bucolic rural vistas and living in communities which might have been recognisable to the Roman, Visigothic and Moorish-ruled inhabitants of those places in long-gone past ages.

Henrietta only let go of Pedro when she took a corner of the frail vessel that she and Melody shared, to help lift it over obstructions. The second they were back on the water again she squeezed the child, who was near catatonic, to her bosom and resumed whispering, cooing words of comfort.

They had eaten the stale bread and mouldy cheese which had been thrown to them as they cast off downstream from Barco de Avila that afternoon, scooping water from the river to slake their thirst under a cruelly searing spring sun until evening finally allowed them a merciful relief.

“The river widens soon,” the young Spaniard in the stern of the punt whispered. The two boats were roped together to prevent them becoming separated. The water had only been a few feet deep beneath them thus far, so the risk of drowning was the least of their problems whereas, separation,

would have been a disaster given how many people had already probably died since Don José's motley party had departed Navalperal de Tormes.

'Before he left us,' Albert Stanton had confided to the women, 'Paul Nash told me he did not think anybody knew that you were being sheltered in Don José's household. It might be that the sort of people who are looking for us, the *bad guys* still have no idea where we are. And,' he had remarked, 'now that I've travelled through this country the lack of basic services like telephones, motorised transport, anything that you or I would consider as the pre-requisites for a modern civil society, mains electricity, for example, must make it incredibly hard for anybody to mount, let alone co-ordinate a man, or a woman hunt, in this country. It is as if the countryside is a different, alien Spain to the worlds of Madrid and the cities. The twentieth century has just not happened out here.'

Melody had wordlessly agreed,

Living in Madrid these last few months and visiting Toledo and Segovia, and on their one extended foray to the south, Cordoba and Seville, had been to explore places that were sufficiently modern, familiar to her eyes and senses despite their ancient architectural wonders. Even their stay in Chinchón had hardly been any kind of culture shock—until the night of the coup, obviously—because up in the mountains the town had been a little bit of oldy-world Spain that was still very much connected to the milieu of Madrid. However, walking in the mountains, passing through and around villages that still sat on the footprint of pre-Roman, possibly Neolithic settlements in which nothing had changed since before the time of the Great War, and twentieth century sanitation or medicine had certainly not yet arrived, had been a rude introduction to the realities of life for the majority of the population of Old Spain.

Now, of course, that dislocation from the modern world was their friend, their one ally in an otherwise wholly hostile land. Moreover, while they might still think themselves in some way superior, or exotic they all looked grubby, weary, and their clothes were ragged just from the adventures and traumas of the last twenty-four hours.

'A lot of people will see us on the river,' Albert Stanton had explained. 'The guides,' he nodded to the two teenage boys, "tell me nobody will give us a second look. Everybody will assume we are a family going down river searching for work in the upper reaches of the Douro Valley. Pedro, they

will assume is our child, likewise the youngsters steering the boats, other adolescent family members...'

Melody had asked the man how far they were from the Portuguese border.

'I have absolutely no idea,' he had confessed sheepishly. "Further downstream the river runs through several larger towns, and Salamanca before it flows into the Douro somewhere quite close or opposite the border. I don't know which. I don't know how far we will be able to get by boat. Farther downstream the river is dammed and we can't risk crossing those waters in these punts. We'll have to start walking again or ideally, find somewhere to hole up for a while until we've all got our strength back...'

Melody thought that was woolly thinking.

Every day they remained in Spain they were in deadly peril.

'The Douro marks the border between Spain and Portugal at one point,' she had offered, trying to be helpful.

'Oh, right. I didn't know that.'

Wisely, the man had taken back the gun he had given Melody before she inadvertently wounded or killed somebody, and kept his submachine gun hidden beneath a blanket in the bottom of his punt. Strangers carrying expensive-looking modern foreign-made guns was a sure-fire way of attracting unhealthy attention on these upper navigable reaches of the Tormes.

'We'll have to find serious boats if we're still on the river in a couple of days,' Stanton had cautioned Melody, very confidentially, seemingly contradicting his previous thoughts on the subject. 'Or maybe, before, depending on how fast the stream is flowing.'

Normally, Melody would have asked what she could do to help, or even tried to take charge of the situation. Tonight, she was too tired and actually, notwithstanding Albert Stanton was primarily a very good journalist, and probably not a natural warrior-type, she was pretty sure he was a lot better at using a gun than she was and right now, that was what actually mattered the most if she and Henrietta, not to mention little Pedro, were going to get through this alive.

The lights of the village slowly receded into the gloom.

High above their heads the stars were coming out, twinkling like diamonds in the infinite firmament. Hungry, a little faint and aching all over Melody guessed that this was one of those moments when it would have

been good to have been religious, except that was a horse which had bolted years ago. God had not been with her when she still believed, or when she had needed *Him* most. She had trusted *Him* then and he had not been there for her, or actually, there at all, if she was going to be rigorously forensic about it.

As it was, she elected to wonder at the marvels of the natural universe because if she reflected on the day just passed, its deaths and its terrors, she suspected she was going to break down and her friends needed her to be strong. They all needed to be strong for each other: they were alone, truly strangers in a strange land who might have been drifting on a boundless sea as upon a river in the heart of Spain...

Chapter 40

*Wednesday 5th April
Little Inagua Island*

Abe had abandoned all hope of reaching the safety of either Cockburn Town or Grand Turk Island after the first very German-looking, low-wing monoplane seaplane wearing garish Spanish roundels and dazzle camouflage had rocketed past his elderly stead blazing away with its wing root-mounted machine guns.

That had not been a good moment.

Neither he— or Ted Forrest— who had gone silent and was presently slumped unconscious, or dead, his head lolling forward in the rear cockpit had seen the bastards coming.

If either of the enemy aircraft had been flown by men who knew what they were doing, or perhaps, those men had been slightly less over-excited by the prospect of shooting up the Sea Fox — a sitting duck by any standard— Abe was under no illusion he would be dead by now.

The slipstream was ripping through the gashes in the cockpit around Abe. The contents of the first aid kit beneath his chair seemed to have been scattered around his feet, the fire axe had disappeared, it too was probably skittering around the bottom of the fuselage, or had fallen out.

As it was, even if the aircraft had not been trying to fall out of the sky and his flying controls felt as if they had been shot to pieces, he would have been looking for somewhere, anywhere other than Cuban or Dominican territory to put down on.

Inevitably, without Ted Forest's guidance he had got lost, ended up flying far too far to the east. Or at least, that was his best guess assuming that the featureless, low-lying island in the haze directly ahead of him was in fact Little Inagua. Somewhere to the south, relatively nearby, there ought to be a much bigger, inhabited land mass but that was immaterial because the Sea Fox was not going to stay in the air long enough to crash anywhere other than the island in front of him. And it was a moot point if the aircraft would hold together long enough to reach that!

Had Abe had the time or the spare mental capacity he might have decided that this was the worst day of his life. True, he had had a few tough, 'hairy' scrapes: that first time he landed a Bristol VII on White Bear Lake had been terrifying at the time; being separated from Kate and his son, handcuffed and beaten up crossing the border to re-enter New York had not been much fun; nor, in retrospect had that stunt nearly diving down the Achilles's funnel been his finest hour. However, all in all, nothing really compared to the fix he was in now.

He was afraid Ted was dead; refused to think about it overlong.

The priority was to survive the coming crash and to do what he could for his friend...

Then, without warning, the engine seized.

Okay, that's just one more damned thing!

Nothing I can do about it...

The sight of the Achilles nearly stopped in the water haemorrhaging bunker oil as fires consumed her after superstructure, boat deck and catapult amidst a constant rain of huge shell splashes was indelibly imprinted on his psyche. The forward main battery guns of the dying cruiser belched defiance still, her starboard twin 3-inch auto-cannons blasted away at her tormentors regardless of the reality that its projectiles would bounce off the armoured hides of the two big°— both were twice Achilles's size°— German cruisers prowling between three and four miles from their doomed prey.

Somehow, Achilles's battle flag still streamed, torn and ripped by splinters, singed by the fires raging on the deck below, from her main mast stays.

Do your worst; this ship will never surrender...

Abe had watched as yet another salvo bracketed Achilles, and another, this time accompanied by a sickening crimson flash among the massive waterspouts as an 8-inch round scythed into the cruiser's vitals beneath the funnel.

Shortly afterwards, they had flown over two big destroyers, just like the killers screening the Karlsruhe fifty miles to the south east. They were obviously closing in to administer the coup de grace with torpedoes and there was nothing, absolutely nothing Abe could do about it. His frustration had been physically agonising in those seconds before the first of those German seaplanes flashed past with their guns blazing.

It was only the ridiculously fast closing speed of those Stettin Wasserflugzeug Funktioniert (Stettin Seaplane Works) – SWF – Model 157s, licenced copies of the successful BMK 57F scout with their retractable undercarriages removed and replaced with fixed floats, which had saved the lumbering Sea Fox. The enemy aircraft had come in at such a rate of knots they had barrelled past their quarry within two, or at most, three seconds of coming into the effective range of their 0.31-inch Krupp Kleinwaffenfabrik (Krupp Small Arms Factory) machine guns.

Abe had lost control of the aircraft and it had dived into the persistent haze long enough for the two BMK 157s to resume their combat air patrol above the big ships ruthlessly pounding the Achilles to death at what, for their big naval rifles, was practically point-blank range.

The Sea Fox's intercom was lifeless and fluid from – only Abe's smashed-up instruments, he fervently hoped – had spotted his goggles and flying jacket. Fortuitously, since instrumentation was fairly basic on a Sea Fox, most pilots were thoroughly accustomed to flying the type by the seat of their pants anyway.

Abe knew the engine had seized – not died of fuel starvation – because the two-bladed propeller was static, un-feathered and adding further drag to the powerless machine, accelerating its descent.

The Sea Fox wobbled over one white-capped reef, then another and was suddenly skimming the surface of the lagoon with the grey-brown, green-tinged land still horribly distant. Resisting every instinct to pull the stick back Abe pushed it gently forward, hoping against hope that the sea plane did not just dive straight into the water.

He sensed a fleeting moment of response through the stick.

The ground fast approaching seemed rough, rocky, patchily covered with scrub and arid bushes, Flamingos burst from somewhere to his left and... was that a donkey, no, a small herd of donkeys over to the right?

It would have ended very badly – or rather, even more badly than it actually did – if unknown to Abe the two BMK 157s had shot away most of the Sea Fox's relatively flimsy fixed undercarriage. One of the reasons the aircraft was wallowing about was that one strut and wheel was completely gone and the other was flapping about in the slipstream, and it was this which tore off the instant the aircraft hit the ground about twenty yards beyond the jagged coral of the beach.

Abe had had to piece the sequence of events together later.

At the time all he had been aware of was the rending, cracking sound of the starboard wing and several feet of the rear fuselage detaching from the rest of the airframe, as the wreck skidded sideways and the air filled with dust, and lumps of airframe and pulverised stones.

Briefly, he had been knocked out.

He had come too with the stench of petrol in his face hanging half out of his cockpit. The aircraft had come to rest on its right-hand side and in a second, he had fallen out onto the bone-hard ground, picked himself up and like an automaton started dragging Ted Forrest out of his seat.

His friend had obviously been thrown forward into the mount for the 0.303 machine gun but there was too much blood to be explained away by a mere broken nose.

Laying the unconscious man in the shadow of the wreck Abe tried not to panic. Ted Forrest had a nasty-looking, gory scalp wound; he could see the yellow-white of the exposed skull through the shredded fabric of his leather flying helmet. That might have been what knocked him out thirty or forty minutes ago. Abe had lost track of time, that was what happened when you were surviving minute by minute.

No, no, no...

He made no attempt to remove his friend's helmet.

For all he knew it might be all that was holding an undisplaced skull fracture in place.

There was blood in Ted's flying suit, soaking the left side of his furs. Almost as an afterthought, Abe realised his friend's left calf was broken.

That would have to wait.

His friend was still breathing.

Pulse okay...

He looked awfully pale though...

He scrabbled in the chaos of the rear cockpit to retrieve the second small emergency medical kit. He would check what was left of the pilot's med kit later but did not entertain high hopes of salvaging anything useful.

Checking that the second kit was correctly stowed was the navigator-observer-gunner's job...

He found it, dislodged from its broken bracket it was wedged beneath the attaché case carrying the Old Man's despatches, and the boffins' reports from the spying cruise north of Santo Domingo last week.

Abe injected the contents of the first of the three intact ampoules of morphine into his friend's thigh – he prayed at least one or two of the ampoules in the broken front cockpit kit had survived – and started to peel off his jacket, ignoring for the moment the still angrily weeping head wound. In the scale of things that injury was possibly, superficial.

He unbuckled the injured man's pistol belt, pausing to divest himself of his own gun before he explored beneath his friend's shirt, his hands coming away bloody.

A through and through: entry below the rib cage and exit above Ted's right hip.

His friend groaned, blinked at him uncomprehendingly.

"What..."

"We crashed," Abe said tersely.

"Oh, right..."

"You're a little bit bust up but it's nothing I can't fix."

Ted Forrest's stare was a little glazed.

"What happened to your shoulder, Abe?"

Bizarrely, it was not until then that Abe recollected feeling something 'pluck' or more accurately, 'kick' at his left shoulder when those 157s roared past...

Or had that happened in the attack on the Karlsruhe?

It did not matter, he would figure it out later...

Some of the blood he had assumed was Ted's was actually his, dripping persistently down his left arm.

Even though he knew it was a really bad idea he gingerly flexed his injured shoulder. Everything seemed to work, albeit stiffly. No bones broken, maybe he had got lucky.

"They just winged me, old man," he assured his friend. "I'll give the wound a good wash in the sea when I've looked after you."

Abe used all the sulphonamide powder in the emergency kit packing the neat entry wound and not quite so discrete exit wound above his friend's hip, tore up his vest and tied a makeshift binding around the inadequate sterile bandages. Next, he carefully eased off Ted Forrest's helmet, breathing a heartfelt sigh of relief when he discovered that the gash was nowhere near as lengthy, nor deep apart from a one-inch section of the wound, as he had feared.

Ted hardly winced as he clumsily sewed up the scalp wound.

Abe was exhausted, somewhat knocked about himself and as he had been repeatedly reminded during his studies at the Queen Eleanor Medical Centre in Albany, by much wiser practitioners than he suspected he was going to be any time soon, it was always much harder psychologically, tending to a badly injured patient whom one knew, or was close to. He had only known Ted for a few weeks but they had lived intensely in those weeks and ‘clicked’ from day one, become like brothers and after today, would forever be linked by their mutual travails.

Eventually he examined his friend’s broken left leg.

He returned to the wreck and salvaged three lengths of detached wing-struts, hacking at them with the small hand-fire axe which he had discovered embedded in the side of the fuselage roughly rib-high, or snapping them over his knee to get them to approximately the right length, and recovered several lengths of wire— previously, stressing the wings— and knelt beside the semi-conscious man on the ground.

He put the axe aside.

That would come in handy later if they lived long enough to worry about butchering meat, or gutting fish to eat.

“I’m sorry, Ted,” he apologised, choking on the words. “We’ve only got two more shots of morphine and you’re going to need both of those to get through the next twenty-four hours. Your left calf is broken, there’s no skin break or so far as I can see major soft-tissue trauma, certainly nothing we need to worry about now,” he paused, “but I have to pull you about something rotten if I’m going to set the bone before the leg has a chance to go bad on us.”

He had placed a wadge of doped canvas torn from the shredded right wing between his friend’s teeth: Ted Forrest’s scream would haunt him forever.

Afterwards, Abe must have passed out because when he regained consciousness, he was lying close to his friend, whom he had obviously made as comfortable as possible at some stage.

‘Comfort’ being a relative thing in their circumstances.

The other thing he had done but had no memory of doing was to recover the signalling flare gun and three cartridges from the rear cockpit, both water bottles from the wreck— discovering that one had a large hole in it— and the attaché case stuffed full of documents, which in lieu of another suitable pillow he had placed under Ted’s head.

Abe shivered despite the warmth of the late afternoon.

That would be shock settling in...

The sun was setting, and a breeze picking up from the west.

Abe had spread his own flying jacket over his friend to try to keep him warm.

He crawled over to him.

The other man blinked at him.

“This is a bit of a pickle,” Ted Forrest decided feebly. “What’s the plan, skipper?”

Abe drew immense strength from the fleeting suggestion of a grin on the badly injured man’s drawn features.

He checked his friend’s pulse.

Steady...

Tested his brow for feverishness.

Cool to the touch.

Keeping Ted warm tonight was going to be a problem because he had probably lost a lot of blood before the crash...

First things first!

“I need to clean myself up, old man. Re-charge our water canteen, that sort of thing.”

He doubted if there were any natural springs on the island.

Praying for rain holes was the best he could hope for.

Abe’s left shoulder pulsed with pain and every time he moved, needles of fire lanced down his arm. He nearly fainted more than once as he went down to the water and tried to clean the wound. Eventually, he simply immersed himself in the shallow water and allowed the brine to soak the through and through holes, miraculously just above the level of his clavicle. Half-an-inch lower and the bullet would have shattered his collar bone, which would not have been good news...

He lay in the water until the cold started to get into his bones, staggered ashore, stood awhile dripping.

Suddenly, he was desperately tired.

He just wanted to lay down and sleep...

No...

Where did I put that gun?

There were two forms in the gathering darkness close to the wreck of the Sea Fox, and nearer still to where Ted lay.

‘What the...’

Then the moment of panic passed.

One of the dark shapes shook its head and... brayed.

I did see donkeys just before the crash!

EPILOGUE

Chapter 41

17:45 (London Time)

Sunday 10th April

Cabinet Room, Downing Street, London

Emily Hamilton fussed around her husband, fending off the pestering make-up girl and basically, enforcing what amounted to a six to ten feet wide cordon sanitaire around the poor man. The camera crew had completed their 'set-up', everything was ready and the Prime Minister – whom she knew to be anything but the staid, grey man, or the cold fish so many people who ought to know better painted him to be – needed a little bit of space while he composed himself to make his career-defining, and likely, career-ending speech to the Empire in the next five minutes.

She patted his shoulder and on impulse, bent and kissed the top of his balding pate. Her husband looked up and quirked a forced grimace of undiluted affection.

This was undoubtedly the worst day of his life.

In due course His Majesty the King would address the Empire but today somebody had to take responsibility for the political and diplomatic failures of the last twenty years which had brought them all to this sad pass.

The Prime Minister and his wife had breakfasted with the King and Queen at St James's Palace that morning: it had been a sombre meal while the old friends discussed the feasibility of the various damage limitation plans – most of which were wish lists rather than plausible schemes – which had been discussed in Cabinet in recent days, not to mention during the course of long, exhausting nights.

The King had read the speech Hector Hamilton had drafted and without comment, initialled it.

His Prime Minister had warned his Monarch that there were calls from his back-benchers, and mutterings from members of his government demanding the removal of the incumbent in Government House in Philadelphia, Philip De L'Isle.

'Over my dead body,' the King had retorted tersely.

‘Mine too!’ Queen Eleanor had added with a frown. ‘Goodness, at a time like this, Philip and Diana must be frantic with worry over Henrietta!’

If the crisis escaped from the confines of the Gulf of Spain and the Caribbean, for over a century a crucible of Catholic fundamentalism and nascent nationalistic agendas in the Americas the consequences would be incalculable. The last thing anybody in their right mind ought to be contemplating was dismissing the one man who had single-handedly kept the lid on the situation after the outrageous Spanish-inspired Empire Day ‘provocations’ of two years’ ago.

The Prime Minister began to read his speech.

One last time before the BBC’s Imperial Cable Network links went ‘live’.

Yesterday, His Majesty’s Consul-Generals in Mexico City, Havana, Port-au-Prince and Porto Rico handed the Spanish Imperial Governors of those crown colonies of the Empire of New Spain final notes stating that unless we heard from them by eleven o’clock this morning, Greenwich Mean Time, that they were prepared at once to cease naval operations in the Gulf of Spain and the whole Caribbean region and to withdraw their troops from Jamaica, where fighting is in progress as I speak, a state of war would exist between us and those crown colonies of the Empire of Spain.

He sighed regretfully.

I have to tell you now that no such undertaking has been received, and that consequently this country is now at war with Nuevo Granada, the Kingdom of Havana and the Catholic Protectorate of Santo Domingo, also known as Hispaniola, the Colony of Porto Rico and its neighbouring concession, Anguilla.

He planned to pause to allow each paragraph to speak for itself before he proceeded to the next. It was like hammering one nail after another into the coffin of the post-Great War World order.

Peace died by another breath every time the hammer fell.

You can imagine what a bitter blow it is to me that all my long struggle to maintain the peace has failed. Yet I cannot believe that there is anything more or anything different that I could have done or that would have been more successful.

Even after the abomination of the Empire Day outrages which we now know to have been perpetrated under the oversight of and facilitated by elements within the Intelligence Service of the Spanish Empire, I still hoped

that reason would prevail. I regret with all my heart that our best efforts have come to nought.

It is my firm conviction that up to the very last it would have been possible to have arranged a peaceful and an honourable settlement with the Emperor Ferdinand and those parties in the Americas bent on abandoning the norms and accepted standards of international conduct. Unfortunately, the King-Emperor, although still nominally on the ancient royal throne of the Spanish is now the puppet of the unholy cabal of Colonels and Cardinals who have seized power in Madrid and who are at this time methodically spreading their web of terror across the whole of that part of the Iberian Peninsula under their control.

Behind the scenes strenuous efforts were made to seek honourable settlements to the border question between New England and New Granada, to address the questions of freedom of navigation and issues such as the equitable distribution of mineral rights across the Caribbean but in the end our entreaties were rejected. Rejected not in quiet rooms where reason might prevail but by dint of the aggression of the so-called Triple Alliance of New Granada, Cuba and Santo Domingo, who have elected to settle their territorial, trade and other disputes with New England and this country by resorting to violence. We put forward reasonable proposals to peacefully settle all the outstanding issues; the Spanish authorities in the region rejected our proposals.

Regrettably, the actions of the members of the Triple Alliance, possibly acting as proxies for other parties...

The Kaiser and his ministers could interpret that back-handed 'swipe' any way they wanted!

...Now leaves us no option but to honour our imperial commitments to the colonies, dominions and protectorates who look to us for succour and their defence, and in the final resort, to meet force with force. Sadly, tyranny, we learned long ago can only be stopped by force.

Last Wednesday German warships re-flagged to serve in the Armada de las Americas, the Navy of New Granada, mounted a series of unprovoked, aggressive— frankly, murderous— operations against Jamaica and Royal Navy units in the Caribbean. During these actions two of our cruisers, the Cassandra and the Achilles and several smaller vessels engaged and were defeated, by a force of at least five modern German cruisers and eight fleet destroyers.

HMS Cassandra was attacked while in harbour at Kingston, severely damaged and forced aground to prevent her total loss while simultaneously Spanish and Cuban troops made landings at Montego Bay on the north west coast, and units of the Dominican San Lorenzo Commando came ashore at St Margaret's Bay in the north east. Heavy fighting is still going on between garrison troops and a brigade hastily formed from the survivors of HMS Cassandra and other naval shore detachments in and around the capital of the colony, Kingston. The situation is desperate as more enemy ships arrive to land more invaders and to intensify the bombardment of our positions.

Simultaneously, HMS Achilles was ambushed in the Windward Passage by the former German heavy cruisers SMS Lutzen and SMS Breitenfeld in company with at least two large fleet destroyers. Achilles's sea planes had previously valiantly attacked and disabled a third cruiser, the former SMS Karlsruhe. However, confronted by two modern cruisers with hugely superior firepower whose armoured sides her own, much smaller guns could not hope to penetrate, Achilles fought like a lion at bay to the very end, until overwhelmed by her attackers she sank with the loss, we fear, of over four hundred lives.

I must emphasise again that these were unprovoked, sneak attacks mounted in flagrant contravention of the accepted rules of war and those responsible for them will be held accountable.

The Empire will go to the aid of Jamaica.

The Empire will remember the men who have died this week.

The Empire will remember brave Achilles!

Today, in fulfilment of our solemn imperial obligation we shall meet force with force. We have a clear conscience. We have done all that any country could do to keep the peace.

People will ask why we have not declared war on Spain itself. Had not that sad country descended into madness in recent weeks that might have been a consideration which sorely tried my government. Nobody should be under any illusion that if 'Old Spain' threatens or in any way instigates military aggression against our ally, Portugal, or against our colony at Gibraltar or in any way seeks to impede traffic in international waters the consequences will be immediate, and severe. As always, we stand by our Treaty of Paris commitments to guard in perpetuity the historic northern border between Spain and France.

For the moment we are content to sever normal diplomatic relations and all trading links with 'Old Spain'. At some point in the near future we will raise as a matter of urgency the disgraceful treatment of our diplomatic personnel and property in Madrid and elsewhere. Rest assured that we will demand justice for our murdered people and continue to pursue the prompt return, unharmed of members of the Empire and international community still unaccounted for in Spain.

Hector Hamilton well understood that the neo-barbarians currently consolidating their power in Madrid would claim the burning of the British Embassy was the work of a mob, and that this and other excesses of the enraged crowds were the very things they had mounted their coup to put an end to... And in the meantime, death squads roamed the country settling old scores and quietly liquidating what little survived of Queen Sophia's faction's influence outside the big cities. There had already been two botched attempts on that courageous lady's life in the few short days she had been in exile in Lisbon.

Now may God bless you all. May He defend the right. It is the evil things that we shall be fighting against— brutish force, bad faith, injustice, oppression and religious persecution— and against them I am certain that the right will prevail.

It is my fervent hope that the military actions initiated by my government to quickly snuff out the real and present threats posed to our cousins in New England by the so-called Triple Alliance to their south, will soon restore sanity to the region.

That was no lie.

In the meantime, I say to New England, trust in God and remember brave Achilles!

Chapter 42

*12:55 (New England Time)
Sunday 10th April
Anson Road, Norfolk, Virginia*

Everybody in the married quarters estates surrounding the great naval base and dockyards, and across Hampton Roads in the settlements around Newport knew that something awful had happened last week in the seas of the Gulf of Spain and the northern Caribbean. Something so bad that the Royal Navy had rigorously enforced a previously unheard of – certainly in recent times – complete news blackout about all its operations in the Americas. In effect, the whole of the base had been ‘locked down’ and all normal communications with the families of men currently on active service at sea had been ‘temporarily suspended for operational reasons.’

Notwithstanding, under the informal leadership of the wife of HMS Achilles’s Executive officer, the redoubtable Melanie Cowdrey-Singh, the cruiser’s ‘wardroom wives’ had rallied together, attempting to include every member of the Achilles family in a series of impromptu gatherings both large and small. The older wives had appointed themselves ‘comforters in chief’ and done what they could to keep up spirits and basically, to inculcate a ‘never say die’ attitude towards what they all tacitly expected was not going to be good news, when eventually, they learned what had befallen their menfolk.

Inevitably, dark, horrible rumours were rabidly stalking the neat, superficially calm streets of the married quarters estates fuelled by the reckless abandon of many of the East Coast’s bestselling newspapers and the inability, because of censorship, of the television stations, led by the New England Broadcasting Corporation, and the majority of the radio broadcasters to cast any meaningful light on the subject.

Literally, people did not know what to believe.

At one end of the spectrum some commentators said the whole Caribbean was on fire, the British and German Empires were about to go to war with each other. And as for Spain and its dastardly colonies around the World, what on earth was going on? There was civil war in Old Spain,

frenzied sabre-rattling in New Granada, Havana and among those religious fanatics on Santo Domingo...

The one voice that was getting drowned out by the media background noise, was that of calm.

Kate Lincoln had promised herself that she would wait to hear 'real' news before she panicked. This despite some of the other wives, including her next-door neighbours on both sides, being already in mourning: in her tradition mourning was a thing one did in memory of loss, not in the anticipation of it. Rumours and gossip were not facts. If the worst came to the worst her husband still lived in, and would for ever more, in her heart and her thoughts and in their son's blood and in the veins of their unborn child, and she would always remember the joy of her life with Abe.

Nevertheless, just before one o'clock that afternoon she carried Tom, a chubby, precocious toddler, into the apartment's small lounge and turned on the small, black and white, television in the corner of the room. She bounced her happily gurgling son in her lap as the TV set warmed up.

The other wives all seemed to have larger, colour TV sets. She and Abe hardly watched the set, preferring to listen to the radio and besides, her husband was a voracious reader, not a slavish watcher. Modest living was a virtue in her culture, a thing Abe had embraced from boyhood. They had each other – and Tom – and no need to surround themselves with 'things' they neither needed, or remotely cared about just days after they had acquired them.

"The Prime Minister, the Honourable Sir Hector Hamilton, MP, KCB, will now address the Empire," the stentorian tones of the announcer warned viewers. "For the first time he is speaking directly from the Cabinet Room in Downing Street via the BBC's newly commissioned transatlantic link to the Imperial Cable Network."

Abe had spoken to her about how recent scientific advances were on the verge of completely 'revolutionising international telecommunications' and, that in the next few years 'anybody who wants to will be able to quickly and easily communicate with anybody else anywhere in the world, instantaneously, at the touch of a button.'

That the Prime Minister was able to speak to a housewife in her own living room on the opposite side of the Atlantic Ocean was proof positive that the times were changing.

Abe called it 'the second industrial revolution'.

She loved it when he talked to her about the wide world even though— and she knew he knew it— much of what he said went straight over her head!

The doorbell chimed musically just as the Prime Minister of England's— she had never got her head around the distinction between England, the United Kingdom, Great Britain, or the British Isles— grim face filled the small, grainy monochrome screen of the Lincoln family TV set.

Kate sighed, hefted Tom in her arms and went to answer the door.

“Mrs Lincoln?” A grave-faced man with the two-and-a-half ‘wavy navy’ rings of a lieutenant-Commander in the Volunteer Reserve who wore a base staff badge on his upper right arm, asked very gently.

The man was accompanied by a woman in sober civilian attire of about Kate's own age, sporting a tab above her left breast identifying her as Second Officer— lieutenant— A.D. Brigham, in the Women's Royal Naval Service, more popularly known as the *WRENS*.

“I'm Simon Wakeley, Ma'am,” her older, male partner explained.

Kate read the look in the other woman's eyes and the tone of Lieutenant-Commander Wakeley's voice and she... just knew.

They had come to tell her that Abe was dead...

<i>[The End]</i>

Author's Endnote

'Travels Through The Wind' is the third book in the *New England Series* set in an alternative America, two hundred years after the rebellion of the American colonies was crushed in 1776 when the Continental Army was destroyed at the battle of Long Island and its commander, George Washington was killed.

I hope you enjoyed it— or if you did not, sorry— but either way, thank you for reading and helping to keep the printed word alive.

Remember, civilization depends on people like you.

Oh, please bear in mind that:

Inevitably, in writing an alternative history this book has referenced, attributed motives, actions and put words in the mouths of real, historical characters.

No motive, action or word attributed to a real person after 28th August 1776 actually happened or was said.

Whereas, to the best of my knowledge everything in this book which occurred before 28th August 1776 actually happened!

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Coming later in 2019

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The Cloud Walkers
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The Painter
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Details of all James Philip's published books and forthcoming publications can be found on his website www.jamesphilip.co.uk

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